

CONTEMPORARY WORLD HISTORY SINCE 1945



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JEFFREY W. JONES

ROUTLEDGE

Contemporary World History Since 1945

This book introduces readers to the historical roots of the key events, issues, and themes in the post-World War II period since 1945.

Organized by region—Europe, Asia, the Middle East, Africa, and Latin America—it uses case studies to emphasize common themes and patterns. The book argues that the colonial period largely shaped the primary global relationships that still hold in the world today. During and after de-colonization, the Cold War emerged as the dominant global paradigm, but following the collapse of communism, a neo-liberal capitalist agenda prevailed in much of the world, although that has in turn shifted because of the global financial crisis of the late 2000s/early 2010s. The book explores these themes as well as terrorism and the environmental degradation of the planet which are major features of the post-Cold War world, along with racial/ethnic/religious diversity and conflict, democracy, human rights, nationalism, and gender relations.

This volume is an essential resource for students of Contemporary World History, the World Since 1945, and the World in the Twentieth Century more broadly.

Jeffrey W. Jones is a Professor of Russian/Soviet and Contemporary World History at the University of North Carolina at Greensboro. He is the author of several articles and two monographs, including *Smoke, Mirrors, and Memories: Legacies of the Soviet-Afghan War* (2025).



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Contemporary World History Since 1945

Jeffrey W. Jones

Designed cover image: 1930s UK Empire Marketing Board Trade Poster.
Retro AdArchives / Alamy Stock Photo.

First published 2026
by Routledge
4 Park Square, Milton Park, Abingdon, Oxon OX14 4RN

and by Routledge
605 Third Avenue, New York, NY 10158

Routledge is an imprint of the Taylor & Francis Group, an informa business

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British Library Cataloguing-in-Publication Data

A catalogue record for this book is available from the British Library

ISBN: 978-1-032-06821-3 (hbk)

ISBN: 978-1-032-06817-6 (pbk)

ISBN: 978-1-003-20400-8 (ebk)

DOI: 10.4324/9781003204008

Typeset in Sabon
by Newgen Publishing UK

To my beloved son Andrew.



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Acknowledgments

I am grateful to several people whose support and assistance made this book possible, none more so than Eve Setch and Sneha Shiralagi, editors extraordinaire at Routledge Press. Without their valuable feedback, patience, and gentle guidance this book would not have seen the light of day. I also want to thank the anonymous readers, whose feedback and suggestions allowed me to produce a better manuscript than would have otherwise been the case.

Numerous friends and relatives over many years have provided me with tremendous support, encouragement, and kindness: Dan Acker, Susan Acker, Irma Alacron, Vince Alventosa, Jill Alventosa, Nathan Basik, Jim Crawford, Bob Dermer, Mark Elliott, Tony Greene, Beverly Hardy, Rich Hite, Ernest Hooker, Watson Jennison, Lisa Levenstein, Loy Newby, Connie Newby, Tim Reed, and Mark Schulz.

Finally, I owe a boundless gratitude to my beloved son, Andrew for all that he has done for me and meant to me over the years. He has truly enriched my life in ways he could not even possibly realize.

Abbreviations

ACS	American Colonization Society (Liberia and Sierra Leone)
ADF	Allied Democratic Forces (Democratic Republic of Congo)
APC	All People's Congress (Sierra Leone)
AIOC	Anglo-Iranian Oil Company
ANC	African National Congress (South Africa)
AQI	Al-Qaeda in Iraq
BBC	British Broadcasting Corporation
BCE	Before the Common Era
BJP	Bharatiya Janata Party (India)
bn	billion, i.e., 1bn = 1 billion
CBL	Central Bank of Libya
CCP	Chinese Communist Party
CE	Common Era
CIA	Central Intelligence Agency (US Spy Agency)
CPA	Comprehensive Peace Agreement (Sudan)
CPP	Convention People's Party (Ghana)
DPK	Democratic Party of Kenya
DR	Dominican Republic
DRA	Democratic Republic of Afghanistan
DRC	Democratic Republic of Congo
EU	European Union
FIS	Islamic Salvation Front (Algeria)
FJP	Freedom and Justice Party (Egypt)
FLN	National Liberation Front (Algeria)
FSA	Free Syrian Army
FSLN	Sandinista National Liberation Front (Nicaragua)
GNU	Government of National Unity (Libya)
GNS	Government of National Stability (Libya)
GLF	Great Leap Forward (China, 1958-62)
HTS	<i>Hayat Tabrir al-Sham</i> (Life of Liberation for al-Sham or Greater Syria)
IDF	Israeli Defense Forces

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IDPs	Internally Displaced Persons
IFP	Inkatha Freedom Party (South Africa Zulu-dominated)
IMF	International Monetary Fund
ISI	Import Substitution Industrialization (South America)
ISI	Inter-Services Intelligence (Pakistani Spy Agency)
ISI	Islamic State of Iraq
ISIL	Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant (Jordan, Syria, Lebanon, Israel and Palestine)
ISIS	Islamic State of Iraq and Syria
ISIS-K	Islamic State of Iraq and Syria-Khorasan
IT&T	International Telephone & Telegraph
JEM	Justice and Equality Movement (Sudan/Darfur)
JNF	Jewish National Fund (Europe/Palestine)
KADU	Kenya Africa Democratic Union
KANU	Kenya Africa National Union
KGB	<i>Komitet Gosudarstvennoy Bezopasnosti</i> (Committee of State Security, Soviet Spy Agency)
KhAD	<i>Khadamat-i Ittila'at-i Daulati</i> (State Information Services, Afghan Spy Agency)
KMT/NP	Kuomintang/Nationalist Party (China)
LDP	Liberal Democratic Party (Japan)
LNA	Libyan National Army
LURD	Liberians United for Reconciliation and Democracy
M23	March 23 Movement (rebels in the Democratic Republic of Congo)
MDC	Movement for Democratic Change (Zimbabwe)
MIAs	(Soldiers) Missing in Action
MITI	Ministry of International Trade and Industry (Japan)
mn	million, i.e., 1mn = one million
MODEL	Movement for Democracy in Liberia
MOIS	<i>Vezerat-e Ettela'at Jomhuri-ye Eslami-ye Iran</i> (Ministry of Intelligence and Security, Iranian Spy Agency after the 1979 Revolution)
MOSOP	Movement for the Solidarity of the Ogoni People (Nigeria)
MRND	National Revolutionary Movement for Development (Rwanda)
NAM	Non-Aligned Movement (of countries during the Cold War not wanting to be allied with either the US or the USSR during the conflict)
NATO	North Atlantic Treaty Organization
NDC	New Democratic Congress (Ghana)
NLF	National Liberation Front/Vietcong (communist movement of South Vietnam)
NPLF	National Patriotic Front of Liberia
NP	National Party (South African Afrikaner-dominated)
NPP	New Patriotic Party (Ghana)

NSA	National Security Agency (US State Security Agency)
NVA	North Vietnamese Army
OAS	Organization of American States
OAU	Organization of African Unity
OPEC	Organization of Petroleum Exporting Countries
OSS	Office of Strategic Services (US Spy Agency prior to the CIA)
PDPA	People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan
PDVSA	<i>Petróleos de Venezuela S.A.</i> (State-owned oil company)
PKI	Indonesian Communist Party
PLA	People's Liberation Army (China)
PLO	Palestinian Liberation Organization
pmt	per metric ton
PNA	Pakistan National Alliance
POW	Prisoners of War
PPP	Pakistan People's Party
PPP	People Power Party (South Korea)
PRC	People's Republic of China
PTI	Pakistan Movement for Justice (initials in Urdu)
RCTV	Radio Caracas Televisión (Venezuelan Radio and Television Station)
RPF	Rwandese Patriotic Front
RSF	Rapid Support Forces (Sudan)
RUF	Revolutionary United Front (Sierra Leone)
SAF	Sudanese Armed Forces
SAVAK	<i>Sâzmân-e Ettelâ'ât va Amniyyat-e Kešvar</i> (Intelligence and Security Organization of the Country, Iranian Spy Agency prior to the 1979 Revolution)
SDM	Somali Democratic Movement
SLA	Sudanese Liberation Army
SLPP	Sierra Leone People's Party
SNM	Somali National Movement
SPLA	Sudanese People's Liberation Army
SRC	Supreme Revolutionary Council
SSDF	Somali Salvation Democratic Front
SYL	Somali Youth League
TNA	Transitional National Assembly (Somalia)
TRC	Truth and Reconciliation Commission (South Africa; Sierra Leone; Guatemala; and elsewhere)
UDI	Unilateral Declaration of Independence (Rhodesia/Zimbabwe)
UFCo	United Fruit Company (US-owned enterprise in Central America; now Chiquita)
UIA	Ukrainian Insurgent Army (World War II)
UAR	United Arab Republic (Egypt and Syria, 1958-61)
UK	United Kingdom/Britain/Great Britain/England
UN	United Nations

xiv *List of Abbreviations*

UNMIL	United Nations Mission in Liberia
US	United States
USC	United Somali Congress
USSR	Union of Soviet Socialist Republics/Soviet Union
WB	World Bank
WMDs	Weapons of Mass Destruction



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Map I.1 World Map.

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Introduction

The study of history is the interpretation of the past. Historians use primary source material, anything produced at the time being studied—dusty old documents and newspapers, films, songs, stories, jokes, posters, pamphlets and so on—to *interpret* the past. Different historians emphasize different aspects of the past or emphasize one cause of a specific event over other causes, and that is what the study of history is all about. The published research of historians, or secondary sources—monographs, anthologies, journal articles, etc.—in which they reveal their interpretations is the historiography of a field, the body of literature of how different historians have interpreted the history of that particular subject.

This book introduces readers to the historical roots of the key events, issues, and themes in contemporary world history, focusing mainly on the post-World War II period since 1945. The book examines the world by region—Europe, Asia, the Middle East, Africa, and Latin America—with a number of themes (dealt with to varying degrees) in mind: colonialism/de-colonization; the Cold War; racial/ethnic/religious diversity and conflict; democracy; the rise and fall of communism; human rights; nationalism; the rise of terrorism; gender relations; genocide; the international economy; and the environmental degradation of the planet. A couple of these themes are defined in the text itself but most are defined at the end of this Introduction.

This book argues that the colonial period largely shaped the primary global relationships that still hold, with the European colonial powers (and also the US, Canada, and a few other highly-developed modern countries such as Japan and, increasingly, China that were not themselves major colonial powers) as the main extractors and benefactors of resources from the former colonies (now de-colonized independent countries). Colonialism usually involved the introduction of cash crops to the colonies, opening the formerly subsistence-based economies of peasant villages in the colonized territories (to varying degrees) to the forces of a global market economy, a profound and impactful transformation. Colonialism also played a pivotal and mostly negative role by imposing largely artificial boundaries on the globe, especially in Africa but also to some degree in Asia and the Middle East, often carving

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out colonies that clumped together diverse groups of people in terms of their racial, ethno-linguistic, and religious identities. Following de-colonization in (mostly) the 1950s–60s in which these colonies gained their independence—often but not always through violent struggle—the stark differences within many of them contributed to instability owing to ethnic rivalries, conflicts over resource allocation, the rise of dictatorial one-party states of varying ideological persuasions, and other problems.

The Cold War that arose following World War II, while primarily a political, economic, and ideological struggle between the US and USSR, involved most of the rest of the world, including the de-colonized countries, replacing colonialism as the dominant geopolitical paradigm for roughly four decades. The subsequent collapse of communism and end of the Cold War in the late 1980s/early 1990s gave rise to a neo-liberal economic agenda throughout much of the world that prevailed until the economic global downturn and financial crisis of the late 2000s/early 2010s. Since then (and even beforehand to some degree) an “Asian model” of state planning and intervention mixed with private investment emerged as a significant alternative to the neo-liberal capitalist model of economic development. Attacks like the one on the US on September 11, 2001 (and others) as well as the rise of such groups as the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS) and Hamas show the significance of terrorism in the post-Cold War world. Environmental degradation of the planet threatens to surpass all other issues and problems as the main cause of global concern, while the rise of ultranationalist authoritarian governments that imperil democratic rule around the world presents an alarming trend.

The approach of this work is to examine case studies in the various regions of the world with an emphasis on common patterns and themes. It does not cover the entire world, a nearly impossible undertaking, nor does it include a chapter focusing on US history since World War II (or directly on US history at all). This is partly because of the limitations of the author as a non-Americanist historian and partly to the fact that there is a plethora of existent works that cover this subject material for interested readers. That said, the impact of the US through its foreign policies on the rest of the world, which varies from place to place and time period but is particularly strong for Latin America, Asia, and the Middle East during and after the Cold War, is a major point of emphasis in the book. Western Europe itself is likewise not a primary focus of the book other than through the tremendous impact it had on the rest of the world, North and Latin America from 1500–1800 but also Asia and Africa in the late nineteenth and twentieth centuries, through its colonial conquest and domination (or sometimes semi-colonial control) thereof.

World War II

Historians refer to World War II as a *watershed*, an event so profound in its significance that it forms a natural break between what came before it and what came afterward. The book does not deal in depth with World War

II, although its significance as a backdrop, as well as that of World War I over two decades earlier, are apparent. World War II in Europe began on September 1, 1939, when Germany invaded Poland, and as an example of differing interpretations of history let us examine the debate over the war's causes. Some historians trace the roots of World War II to the end of World War I in 1919 and the Treaty of Versailles that ended that conflict. According to this interpretation the victorious allies dealt with Germany too harshly at the end of World War I and that was the main root cause of the Second World War. The Treaty of Versailles imposed heavy reparations on Germany that its economy could not handle, and the harsh penalties incurred at Versailles also injured German sensibilities, creating a nationalistic backlash embodied in Adolph Hitler and the rise of his fascist Nazi Party in the early 1930s. In his infamous tract *Mein Kampf* (My Struggle), written while briefly imprisoned in the mid-1920s, Hitler argued that Germany lost World War I because the Jews betrayed the country and complained that the Treaty of Versailles was a national humiliation for Germany. Historians use that source to support this argument.

Other historians focus not on the end of World War I nor the Versailles Peace Conference but on the global economic crisis of the 1930s, the Great Depression. According to this interpretation, by the end of the 1920s Germany had finally begun to recover from its major economic problems (especially inflation) following World War I, but then the Great Depression struck and led to widespread unemployment, causing discontent and leading to the Nazi's rise to power. Hitler gained popularity by addressing this problem and putting people back to work. Germany had an estimated 5.5mn unemployed at the time of Hitler's ascent to power in early 1933, which was down to 2mn two years later, less than 1mn by 1937, and a mere 30,000 (a full-employment economy) by the outbreak of World War II in 1939. Hitler put people to work making weapons (ignoring restrictions placed on German rearmament by the Versailles Treaty) and with large public works projects such as the construction of the Autobahn, Germany's highway system. Industrial production more than doubled in Germany between 1933–39, and armament production increased by a factor of six between 1935–39.

Another debate on the origins of World War II centers on attempts to form an anti-German alliance in the 1930s. Many Western historians point to the Nazi-Soviet Non-Aggression Pact of 1939 as a major contributing factor leading to the war. In that pact, Hitler and Soviet leader Joseph Stalin divided Eastern Europe among themselves and agreed not to attack each other, which gave Hitler a green light to do whatever he wished in Europe without fear of Soviet retaliation. Russian historians, however, tend to look at this issue from a different point of view, arguing that the Western powers, specifically Britain and France, rebuffed Soviet efforts to form an anti-Hitler alliance in the mid-1930s. When those same Western powers appeased Hitler at the infamous Munich Conference in the fall of 1938, allowing German forces to take over

part of Czechoslovakia, the Soviet Union had no choice, they argue, but to enter the pact with Germany to protect its own interests.

Hitler broke the Non-Aggression Pact by invading the Soviet Union in June 1941, forcing the Soviets into a tenuous alliance of necessity with the Western powers—Britain, the French resistance, and eventually the US following the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor on December 7, 1941, that brought the US into the war. To better understand the war and postwar Europe, we need to look at two closely related strategic issues: the “soft underbelly” approach of the US and Britain versus the issue of a “second front” posed by the USSR. British leader Winston Churchill proposed the “soft underbelly” strategy, a plan to attack the Nazis at their weakest point in North Africa and move up into Europe through Italy from there. The USSR, conversely, pressed its allies (Britain and the US) to open a second front in Western Europe to take some of the pressure off Soviet forces fighting against the Nazis on the eastern front. As of early 1944 there were sixty-one German divisions on the Western front, as well as more than twenty-five German and four Italian divisions in Italy, a total of ninety; by contrast there were 199 German divisions in Russia and an additional sixty-three German divisions in Eastern Europe, a total of 262.

An estimated 27mn Soviet citizens died during World War II compared to a total of 2mn US, British, and French deaths combined (both estimates include civilian and military deaths). The Soviets took *by far* the heaviest losses in the fighting against Nazi Germany, which is why Stalin wanted his Western allies, US President Franklin Roosevelt and British leader Churchill, to open a second front against Germany in the West and take some pressure off the eastern front. The Western allies finally did so in June 1944 with D-Day, the invasion of the beaches of Normandy in France, which was undoubtedly a vital part of the Allied victory. Over-concentrating on Normandy and over-emphasizing the US role in the European war, however, leaves out a great deal—blowing the importance of D-Day out of proportion distorts the whole picture. The Soviet Union bore the brunt of the fighting and devastation in Europe and did far more to defeat Hitler than the other allies combined. At the same time, it is important to note that the US and Britain were engaged in a two-front war as they also fought against Japan in Asia, whereas the Soviets did not.

In Europe, however, it was a different story; Churchill openly stated in 1941 that the best-case scenario for the Western powers was for the German fascists and Russian Communists to kill each other off. Harry Truman said basically the same thing in August 1941 (before he was vice-president or president) in the US Congress: “If we see that Germany is winning we should help Russia and if Russia is winning we ought to help Germany and that way we let them kill as many as possible, although I don’t want to see Hitler victorious under any circumstances.” The Western allies shaped the “soft underbelly” strategy with political objectives in mind, directly opposing it to the Soviet demand for a second front, which was a major sore point between the

allies during the war. In the US, emphasis on the victory over Nazi Germany in World War II is often placed on D-Day, but in Russia more attention is paid to that country's tremendous sacrifice in the war and to the late opening of a second front.

Another important issue concerns the long-term implications of Churchill's "soft underbelly" strategy. Some historians assert that this strategy during the war led directly to the Soviet occupation of Eastern Europe afterward. Had the Western allies opened a second front earlier, they argue, and pushed the Germans back from the West, they may have been the liberators of Eastern Europe. However, since they attacked instead from Northern Africa through Italy, leaving the Soviets to bear the brunt of the fighting, the Soviet army pushed the Germans back from the east, "liberated" Eastern Europe from Nazi occupation, and then settled in to occupy the region themselves in the postwar period. Thus, in this interpretation of the war and its aftermath the price of the "soft underbelly" strategy during World War II was the occupation of Eastern Europe by Soviet troops after the war.

Truman and the Bomb

Yet another crucial issue of historical debate regarding World War II brings us into the Asian theater of the war, the decision by US President Harry Truman to deploy two atomic bombs against Japan in August 1945. US scientists successfully tested the first atomic bomb in the New Mexico desert in mid-July while Truman was meeting with the victorious Allied leaders at the Potsdam Conference. At the end of the conference the allies issued the Potsdam Declaration calling on Japan to surrender or suffer "the utter devastation of the Japanese homeland" and concluding with a call for the Japanese government "to proclaim now the unconditional surrender of all Japanese armed forces." This reiterated the demand for Japan's "unconditional surrender" first issued in 1943. Truman ordered the US Air Force to use the bomb as soon as possible after August 3. The first bomb was dropped on Hiroshima on August 6, the Soviets declared war on Japan on August 8, and a second bomb was dropped on Nagasaki on August 9. Japan notified the US of its intention to surrender on August 10, initial papers were signed on August 15, and the formal surrender ceremony took place on September 2. Even after the bombs were dropped the allies did not obtain "unconditional surrender" because they granted an amnesty to the Japanese emperor from war crimes and allowed him to maintain his throne, the main issue of concern for the Japanese.

Truman justified his decision to use the bombs on the grounds that doing so "saved American lives" that would have been lost in a possible invasion of the Japanese mainland, which the bombs made unnecessary. He claimed that the decision saved as many as 500,000 lives of American troops projected to have been lost in such an invasion. However, people at the time and since have harshly criticized Truman's decision to deploy the bombs, citing

evidence that the Japanese would have surrendered without either an invasion or the bombs if they had been assured that their emperor could retain his position after the war, which did in fact turn out to be the case. Howard Zinn, for example, argues that the main reason Truman made this fateful decision was not to save lives, but to keep the Russians out of Japan. At the Yalta Conference in February 1945 the Soviet Union agreed to enter the war against Japan no later than three months after the end of the war in Europe. The war in Europe ended May 9, 1945, and the US dropped the first bomb on August 6, according to Zinn, because they wanted to end the war before the Soviets invaded Japan and possibly occupied part of the island nation. In that scenario, the US would have to share the postwar occupation of Japan with the Soviet Union, as in Germany and Korea, a situation Truman clearly wanted to avoid. Zinn has been criticized for this interpretation on the grounds that there is no documented proof of this assertion.

Defining Our Themes

Finally, it is always important for scholars to define their terms. Accordingly, here are the working definitions (aside from those defined in the text) of the main themes for the book—dealt with to varying degrees therein—described above:

- Colonialism/de-colonization: colonialism is the system of political and economic domination imposed militarily by the countries of Europe first between 1500–1820 on the “New World” (North and Latin America) and also India, and later in a second “wave” of colonialism in the mid-nineteenth to early twentieth centuries on Asia and Africa. De-colonization refers to the process of those Asian and African colonies achieving their independence, often though not always through armed conflict, mostly in the 1950s–60s.
- The Cold War: a term coined by George Orwell in 1945; it came to define a key global conflict in the post-World War II era, one that we discuss and define in greater detail in the first chapter.
- Racial/ethnic/religious diversity and conflict: most of the countries discussed in this book have a variety of different racial and/or ethnic groups (as defined primarily by language) as well as different religious groups, a combination that unfortunately often leads to conflict within those countries.
- Democracy: as we will see, “democracy” is a relative term that means different things to different people. The *Merriam-Webster Dictionary* defines “democracy” as a form of “government in which the supreme power is vested in the people and exercised by them directly or indirectly through a system of representation usually involving periodically held free elections.”

- The rise and fall of communism: “communism” is also a relative term that means different things to different people. We will see, for example, that there were key differences between the communist systems of the USSR and China, as well as those of other self-proclaimed communist countries in the twentieth century. The *Merriam-Webster Dictionary* defines “communism” as “a) a system in which goods are owned in common and available to all as needed; and b) a theory advocating [the] elimination of private property.” The fall of communism was the collapse of (most) of those systems in the late 1980s and early 1990s.
- Human Rights: a concept born of the Enlightenment in early modern European history and tied to the rise of democracy that promotes inalienable rights believed to belong justifiably to every person.
- Nationalism: a phenomenon of modern history originating during the French Revolution (the term was first used in print in 1789 by the French priest Augustin Barruel) and linked to the concept of “citizenship” that emerges with democracy. Much has been written by way of defining the concept of “nationalism,” and by no means is there a consensus on the subject, but for our purposes the working definition of nationalism is that of people within the same geographic borders sharing the discerned common identity (most often in cultural, religious, and linguistic terms) of a broadly understood “community,” especially vis-à-vis or in comparison with those of other national identities.
- The rise of terrorism: we discuss and define this crucial theme in contemporary world history in the text.
- Gender relations: broadly speaking this theme is meant to encompass the concept of *patriarchy* or *male domination of society*, a key theme in the history of the world as reflected in the relationship between men and women (and non-binary identities); gender relations are the ways in which a culture or society defines the rights, responsibilities and identities of men and women in relation to one another.
- Genocide: a term stemming from the Holocaust during World War II and first used in an official capacity in 1944 by Polish lawyer Raphael Lemkin. From the Greek word *genos*, meaning “family, clan, tribe, race, or kin,” and the Latin *cide*, meaning “killing.” In 1948 the UN defined genocide as “acts committed with intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnic, racial or religious group.”
- International economy: broadly speaking the international economy refers to the patterns and consequences of transactions and interactions between the inhabitants of different countries, including trade, investment, and transactions among other things. We examine this theme largely through the role of global capitalist lending agencies such as the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and World Bank (WB), but also the involvement of cartels such as the Organization of Oil and Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) as well as through other institutions.

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- Environmental degradation of the planet: the deterioration of the environment through the depletion of resources such as air, water, and soil; the destruction of ecosystems and the extinction of wildlife in large part due to human-driven actions contributing to habitat destruction and climate change.

Sit back and buckle up as we begin our journey through time to different parts of the globe with these various themes in mind, starting with Cold War Europe.

Part I

Europe



Map 1.1 Map of Europe.

Source: Created with mapchart.net. CC BY-SA 4.0.

1 Europe and the Origins of the Cold War

Before Europe could put itself back together and rebuild after World War II the continent found itself in the midst of another conflict, the Cold War. Different people define this term differently and its meaning is open to interpretation, but we can describe it roughly as a conflict primarily between two of the victorious “allies,” the US and the USSR, two postwar “superpowers” who divided the world into “spheres of influence” and competed with each other on ideological, economic, and political grounds.

It was never a “hot war” because there was no direct fighting between US and Soviet troops (though there were several “proxy” wars, or wars by substitution, such as in Korea, Vietnam and Afghanistan). There was always an underlying threat of direct military hostility, leading both sides to maintain strong military forces, create alliances, and build up nuclear arsenals (arms race). The beginning of the nuclear era was one of the main consequences of the war. The bomb literally ushered in a new period in history in technological terms with the introduction of a new weapon of destruction on a scale never before seen.

World War II, which was fueled by nationalist aspirations, had some major consequences for Europe and the world, including a decrease in power internationally for Europe, whose economic dominance was weakened due to the two world wars of the first half of the twentieth century. In ideological terms Europe’s prestige was greatly undermined. The ideology of colonialism stressed Europe’s role in bringing “civilization” to the “savages” or “primitive” peoples around the globe (the so-called “white man’s burden”). The two barbarous world wars that ravaged Europe as well as the Holocaust brought the ideological claims of colonialism very much into question.

A related aspect and consequence of the war was an increased impetus for independence movements (de-colonization) in Europe’s colonies, and the empowerment of women and racial minorities (especially in the US) who participated in the war effort. The war empowered the “underdogs” in society, whose role historically had been downplayed or ignored. World War II was a victory over Hitler’s racist ideology of fascism, which had obvious implications for people of color around the world struggling for

independence and equal rights. World War II, more than any other conflict in history, was a “total war” involving the mobilization and participation of almost all segments of society, which in turn led to increasing demands for equal rights and political representation among oppressed groups around the world.

Shaping the Postwar World

The leaders of the three major allied countries in World War II—the US, Britain, and the Soviet Union—decided the makeup of the postwar world at a series of conferences toward the end of the war when it became clear that victory over Germany was imminent. The Yalta Conference was a major wartime meeting held in Crimea in the Soviet Union in February 1945. At Yalta the so-called “big three” met, the leaders of the soon-to-be-victorious allied nations—Winston Churchill of Britain, Franklin Roosevelt of the US, and Joseph Stalin of the Soviet Union. Major issues of discussion at the conference included Soviet entry in the war vs. Japan, which as we saw Stalin agreed to do three months after the end of the war against Germany; the fate of Poland, where it was agreed that Communists and democrats would form a coalition government based on “free and unfettered elections as soon as possible;” the formation of an international organization, the UN, which stemmed from the experience of the Versailles Peace Treaty at the end of World War I and the formation of the League of Nations; and the division of Germany into zones of occupation and the imposition of reparations.

Reparations was one of the first issues over which the US and Soviet Union disagreed. The US argued strongly against imposing heavy reparations against Germany for two reasons: reparations imposed in the Versailles Peace Treaty at the end of World War I were seen as a root cause of World War II, and the US wanted to rebuild Germany quickly to offset what it increasingly viewed as the threat of Soviet aggression and expansion in Eastern Europe. The USSR, however, wanted to impose heavy reparations against Germany because of the destruction of its economy and infrastructure during the war.

The next conference to shape the postwar world was the Potsdam Conference (July-August 1945) with some major changes since Yalta: Truman replaced Roosevelt, who died in April, from the US; also, while Churchill was present early in the conference, he lost an election during the conference and Clement Attlee replaced him as leader of Great Britain. So, of the original “big three” from Yalta, only Stalin of the Soviet Union remained. The major issue discussed at Potsdam was the growing diplomatic crisis over Poland, where Soviet-occupying troops did not allow the Polish government-in-exile in London to return to power. The conference happened at the same time the US successfully tested the atomic bomb in the New Mexico desert, which had considerable diplomatic significance. Potsdam ended in a stalemate, with Stalin refusing to move the Soviet army out of Eastern Europe.

Soviet Hegemony in Eastern Europe

Potsdam signaled the end of the wartime alliance. The USSR and US were allied against Germany during the war, albeit in a tenuous alliance laden with tensions, and at the end of the war there was no reason to think that the alliance would end and turn into conflict. However, tensions arose because of Soviet hegemony or domination of Eastern Europe after the war, characterized by the famous phrase the “iron curtain” first coined by Churchill in a 1946 speech. Soviet control of Eastern Europe took hold after World War II, greatly contributing to the beginning of the Cold War. As noted, during the war the Soviet army pushed German Nazi forces west, liberating Eastern Europe, but then Soviet troops remained as an occupying force in these countries after the war ended. Thus, they had “boots on the ground,” which gave them the upper hand in determining the postwar fate of the region.

There are several ways of explaining the subsequent “Sovietization” of Eastern Europe. The “strategic force” interpretation emphasizes the imposition of communism in Eastern Europe behind the power of the Soviet army. There were few communist party members in the countries of Eastern Europe after the war: Bulgaria had about 15,000 communist party members; Poland several thousand; and Romania around 900. In elections held in Hungary in November 1945, communists received only 17% of the vote; in Romania, 28%; in Czechoslovakia, 38%. Poland did not have elections until 1947, and when it did they were far from truly “fair and unfettered” (despite Stalin’s promise to Churchill and Roosevelt at Yalta).

The Soviet Union wanted to secure communist control over these countries in the postwar period as a “buffer zone” between it and the West. There was an influx of new members in the communist parties of Eastern Europe after the war, but they still represented a small minority of the population in each country. Furthermore, these small communist parties faced challenges by much larger political parties that had ruled these countries prior to the war. Thus, according to this interpretation, the Soviets took control of these countries gradually, through police tactics, building up communist control of the army, the police, and the bureaucracy. They also nationalized (took over ownership for the state) key industries and collectivized agriculture (imposing state control over the land), disempowering the mostly anti-communist landowners and the business class. Gradually, backed by the occupying forces of the Soviet army, the communist parties of each Eastern European country took over the state and economy. Subsequent coups or unfair elections brought the communist parties to power throughout Eastern Europe by 1948, and each of them (with the notable exception of Yugoslavia) became puppet states of the Soviet Union.

Other historians look at this issue from an entirely different point of view, arguing that the number of communist party members was not important because the parties were banned in most of inter-war Eastern Europe (with the exception of Czechoslovakia), while communists in the region had wide

popularity because of their role in the underground resistance against fascism during the war. Also, the former ruling parties were widely discredited because of either collaborating with or losing to the Nazis. Finally, according to this point of view, the Nazi-occupying governments had already nationalized key industries, so the transition to communist control was very easy and natural. This interpretation stresses that the duality of local communists and the Soviet army characterized the imposition of communist control in Eastern Europe, though the balance between the two varied from country to country.

US Containment Policy

Whether one subscribes to the strategic force theory or the duality theory, it is clear that Soviet rule was established throughout Eastern Europe, and US policymakers were determined to counter what they saw as Soviet aggression and expansionism. The US policy of “containment,” of stopping the expansion of Soviet-led communism, began almost immediately after the war. A leading American analyst in Moscow, George Kennan, originated the policy in a “Long Telegram” to the US State Department later published anonymously. He argued that the Soviet Union was inherently expansionist, comparing it to Hitler’s Germany while pointing out that the Soviet Union was much more subtle, working behind the scenes instead of directly attacking countries. It would try to take advantage of power vacuums around the world stemming from the war, to “fill every nook and cranny available to it in the basin of world power.” Thus, in Kennan’s view, the best way to stop the Soviet Union was to be forceful and not give in to or appease Soviet demands as the European powers had done in the case of Hitler at the 1938 Munich Conference. The policy of containment spelled out by Kennan would eventually become embodied in three major postwar policies initiated under the US Truman administration: the Truman Doctrine; the Marshall Plan; and the formation of NATO.

The Truman Doctrine

The Truman Doctrine (March 1947) promised US support to countries facing the threat of communist takeover. Issued two months after unfair elections in Poland, it made the concept of containment outlined by Kennan official US policy. The Truman Doctrine stemmed from crises in Greece, where civil war raged after World War II, and Turkey. Communist insurgents were struggling to take power over the postwar monarchical government of Greece, while Turkey, a secular republic, was under strong pressure from the USSR to cede territory in the east and permit the establishment of Soviet bases on the strategic straits on the Black Sea. The US assumed that the Soviet Union was supporting the Greek Communists as well as nursing designs on Turkey; however, assistance for the Greek insurgents came not from the USSR, but from Yugoslavia and its communist leader, Marshal Josip Tito. US President

Truman ignored this because he knew his new doctrine would have a greater chance passing through the US Congress if he played up the Soviet communist menace. Faced with a long-standing tradition of American isolationism, Truman quipped that he would have “to scare the hell out of the American people” to get his policy passed. The US Congress overwhelmingly voted for the measure.

The Marshall Plan

A second major aspect of the containment policy was the Marshall Plan (June 1947), authored by Secretary of State George Marshall. President Truman called the Marshall Plan “the other half of the same walnut” along with the Truman Doctrine. The Marshall Plan granted loans to Europe for postwar reconstruction. Two years after the war, Europe was still in shambles, its economies suffering from low production, weak currencies, and high inflation. As a result, the war-torn countries of Europe were unable to produce anything for export to raise the funds they needed to import materials like cement, steel, bricks and machinery that they desperately needed to rebuild their economies, a problem referred to as the “dollar shortage.” Europe needed massive amounts of aid, and the Marshall Plan aimed to provide it. Like the Truman Doctrine, the Marshall Plan was intended to stop the spread (or the perceived threat of the spread) of communism. Unlike in Eastern Europe, communist parties tended to be strong in several of the West European countries, especially France and Italy, but also in the Western-occupied zone of Germany. US policymakers realized that if they did not help rebuild Western Europe, the possibility of communist takeovers in those countries was very real. That was one of the main rationales behind the Marshall Plan.

Another important rationale behind the Marshall Plan was to help the US economy. The countries of Western Europe had been the main US trading partners prior to (and during) the war, so as long as they suffered it negatively affected the US economy as well. The US recognized the need to rebuild its European trading partners in order to strengthen its own economy. The US offered the Marshall Plan loans to the countries of both Western and Eastern Europe, even to the Soviet Union itself. However, there were so many strings attached that the Soviets would have to turn it down. Stalin hoped for US aid money to rebuild the devastated Soviet economy; he continued to refer to the US and Britain as “allies” in public statements until the Marshall Plan, when it became clear that aid money from the US would not be forthcoming.

The anti-communist bent of the policy is seen by the fact that before the Marshall Plan was announced the US clarified that any aid program would be contingent on banning communists from governing cabinets. In a move that critics compare to unfair Soviet practices in the East, France and Italy expelled members of their respective communist parties from ruling coalitions to open the way for economic assistance from the Marshall Plan. There were a couple of important stipulations in the Marshall Plan:

1. Recipient countries had to use the loans to purchase goods made (mostly) in the US (a bit from Canada, which also contributed funds to the program). So, in effect, the Marshall Plan was a huge subsidy to US business: American taxpayer money went to Europe in the form of loans, then returned to the US to buy goods from US companies. This greatly helped the US economy at a time when people were unsure what was going to happen. Prior to World War II, the US and the rest of the world were bogged down in the Great Depression, so most feared, even assumed, that with the end of the war and the return of millions of soldiers, unemployment would go up again and economic depression return. Immediately after the war, in 1946–47, there was a wave of labor unrest and strikes in the US because wartime price controls were lifted and the cost of living dramatically increased ahead of wages. The Marshall Plan helped stabilize the US economy and avoid a return to depression.
2. Recipient countries had to open their economies to free trade. This too stemmed from fears of economic depression, as it was understood that one of the main causes of the Great Depression was protectionism, the maintenance of high tariffs to keep competitive imports out and protect the domestic industry. The US wanted to guarantee that the borders of Europe remained open to its exports, which was the main reason behind this stipulation of the Marshall Plan.

All of this meant that, as the US expected and intended, the Soviet Union refused the offer. The last thing the Soviets wanted was open trade with the US, especially in Eastern Europe, because this would strengthen the business class of those countries, precisely the element of society the Soviets were trying to disempower.

NATO

A third and final aspect of containment was the formation of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO)—the one part that is still with us—in 1949. The formation of NATO stemmed from a conflict over Germany, the country defeated in World War II and occupied by the victorious allies after the war. The allies discussed the postwar occupation of Germany at the Yalta Conference in February 1945, deciding to divide it into four zones of occupation, one for each of the victorious countries: the US, Britain, France, and the USSR. After the war, the US, Britain, and France combined their zones into one, completing the division of Germany into East and West. There was, however, one glaring problem for the Soviets and their communist allies in East Germany: the Yalta agreement also divided the German capital, Berlin, located deep inside the Soviet-controlled east, into occupied zones. This meant that the western half of Berlin was an island of Western power in the midst of the Soviet-occupied Eastern zone, a situation that did not appeal to the Soviets nor the East German communist government.

Stalin thus wanted to take over all of Berlin. In June 1948, the Soviets blockaded Berlin from the west, not allowing goods in through the eastern zone. In response the US and Great Britain organized a highly successful airlift, flying thousands of planes into West Berlin around the clock with supplies for the population of West Berlin. The airlift worked and after about six months the Soviet Union ended the blockade. Afterward the Western powers formed NATO as a military alliance to counter the threat of Soviet expansion, especially the large Soviet troop advantage in Europe, as well as to quell threats of domestic (pro-communist) disturbances in the countries of Western Europe.

Originally consisting of the US, Canada, Britain, France, Belgium, Denmark, Iceland, Italy, Norway, Portugal, and the Netherlands, NATO expanded in 1952 to include Greece and Turkey, and in 1955 added West Germany. Members agreed to come to each other's aid should any of them be attacked (Article Five), although NATO itself could not commit any nation to go to war and left the final decision up to individual member countries. NATO's formation solidified the Cold War configuration of two opposed "blocs" or "spheres," and the Soviet Union eventually responded by forming the Warsaw Pact in 1955 (composed of Albania, Bulgaria, Czechoslovakia, East Germany, Hungary, Poland, Romania, and the USSR). The Warsaw Pact disbanded in 1989, but NATO remains intact. In 1999, it expanded again to include Poland, Hungary, and the Czech Republic. In 2004 NATO added Slovenia, Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, Bulgaria, Romania, and Slovakia. Albania and Croatia joined in 2009, Montenegro in 2017, North Macedonia in 2020, Finland in 2023, and Sweden in 2024. NATO expansion into Eastern Europe is a huge sore point in US-Russian relations and Russian President Vladimir Putin cited it as one of the reasons for his invasion of Ukraine on February 24, 2022, a topic we return to in the next chapter.



Map 2.1 Map of Former Soviet Union and East-Central Europe.

2 The Soviet Union, Post-Soviet Russia, Post-Soviet Ukraine, and Eastern Europe

The Soviet Union

The Soviet Union with its capital in Moscow was about two-and-half times larger than the US, but even without the other former fourteen republics of the USSR (Armenia, Azerbaijan, Belarus, Estonia, Georgia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Latvia, Lithuania, Moldova, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, Ukraine, and Uzbekistan), now independent countries that surround post-Soviet Russia on all sides, Russia, which has a population of around 146mn as of 2025, is still by far the largest country in the world. There are no physical impediments, mountains, seas, or even major rivers forming Russia's borders, which historically has made it vulnerable to invasion. Russia has been invaded three times from the west since 1800, by Napoleon in the early nineteenth century, Kaiser Wilhelm and the Germans in the early twentieth century during World War I, and by Hitler's German Nazi troops in the mid-twentieth century during World War II.

Russia's open borders also make it easier for the country to expand, which explains how it became the world's largest country. Russia expanded gradually over the course of the fifteenth to the nineteenth centuries to become a major colonial power with control over numerous contiguous neighboring areas—and the many different people therein—from the Baltics to the Caucuses to Central Asia, creating the world's largest colonial empire (comprised of the former Soviet Republics along with much of Finland and eastern Poland as well). At its territorial height the Russian Empire extended into Alaska and down the coast of Western Canada into Northern California! The vast Russian Empire collapsed in the aftermath of World War I and the 1917 Bolshevik Revolution inspired by Marxist-Leninist ideology and led by Vladimir Lenin, who managed afterward to piece most of the defunct empire back together in the form of the newly created Soviet Union (USSR).

Marxism-Leninism

The ideas of Marxism-Leninism emerged in Russia in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries and became the dominant ideology of the Soviet

Union after the Bolshevik Revolution in the fall of 1917. Karl Marx, who was from a German Jewish background, and Friedrich Engels, who was British, both lived in England in the 1800s and based their observations on that country's process of industrialization. Their focus was on socioeconomic class, one's consciousness of one's position and interests in society in economic, cultural, and political terms, as defined against the interests of other class(es). Marx and Engels believed that history developed through class struggle, that each phase in history is based on social conflict between two main classes pitted against one another: slaveowner vs. slave in the early societies of ancient Greece and Rome; nobleman vs. peasant in the feudal societies of medieval and early modern Europe and Asia; and, subsequently, the bourgeoisie vs. the proletariat in modern capitalist society. The bourgeoisie are the owners of the means of production (factories, the machines therein, and the raw materials needed for production), and the proletariat are the workers, "with nothing to lose but their chains," in Marx's famous phrase from the 1848 *Communist Manifesto*.

Marx and Engels argued that as society gradually industrialized on the English model, conditions would continue to worsen for workers and they would eventually realize their power numerically since they are the overwhelming majority of society and rise up to overthrow the factory owners (bourgeoisie). Then ownership of the factories would go to the workers, or to society as a whole, which for Marx and Engels was the key distinction between capitalism and socialism: capitalism is based on the private ownership of the means of production, socialism on social (society as a whole) ownership of the means of production.

Marx assumed that socialist revolutions would occur first in the most heavily industrialized countries. That was a very basic and obvious assumption for him because to have a socialist revolution you need a strong working class, and to have a strong working class required a high degree of industrialization. Marx, therefore, was talking primarily about the highly industrialized countries of Western Europe, especially England, but also France and Germany. He definitely was not talking about the primarily agrarian country of Russia, which by the late nineteenth century had only begun to industrialize and lagged behind the other countries of Europe and the US.

This issue posed a problem to Russian socialists and their main leader in the early twentieth century, Lenin. He was forced to deal with the challenge of developing socialism based on the working class in a country with a relatively small working class. Lenin adapted Marxism to fit Russia's unique conditions. In *What is to be Done?* (1903), Lenin argued that Russian socialists needed to form a closed, tightly-knit, highly disciplined political party, which he called the "vanguard of the proletariat," vanguard meaning the leading element or forefront. He therefore added a political component to Marx's theory because Lenin believed that without such a political party to lead it the working class would never overthrow the bourgeoisie.

Lenin and his followers won the revolutionary power struggle in Russia near the end of World War I, which brought utter chaos to the Russian Empire. Offering “land” to the peasants, “bread” to the masses, and “peace” to the soldiers, Lenin’s Bolshevik Party assumed power in October 1917. Lenin and the Bolsheviks withdrew the country from World War I, fought off an invasion by a coalition of European powers (which also included Japan and the US) at the end of the war in 1918, and defeated their political opponents in a civil war, consolidating power in 1921. At the end of the civil war Lenin proclaimed the formation of the Soviet Union, comprised of fifteen republics with hundreds of different ethnic groups and two main religions, Eastern Orthodox Christianity in the European Slavic states (Belarus, Moldova, Ukraine, and Russia) and Caucasus (Armenia and Georgia) and Islam in the other main Caucasus state, Azerbaijan, and in Central Asia (Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan). The three Baltic states, Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania, independent states between the wars but illegally occupied by the USSR during and after World War II until the collapse of the Soviet Union in late 1991, are a mix of Christian denominations, Eastern Orthodox, Catholic, and Protestant. Officially the Soviet Union, which remained under Lenin’s leadership until his death in 1924, was an atheist state.

Stalinism

Lenin’s death sparked a struggle for power in the young Soviet Union that was eventually won by Joseph Stalin against Lenin’s wishes. Lenin wrote in his “Last Testament” that Stalin was “too rude” to lead the party and should be removed from his post as General Secretary of the communist party. But the testament did not become public until decades later, and meanwhile Stalin began to climb the ladder to power, eliminating his political opponents one by one, and forcing his main foe, Leon Trotsky, into exile in 1928.

Once in power, Stalin had to deal with Russia’s age-old problem of catching up with the West, as well as the new problem of creating a working class in an alleged “workers’ state.” Russia was not very industrialized at the time of its revolution, and the (mostly foreign-owned) industry it did have was devastated during World War I, the revolution, and the civil war that ravaged the country for seven years. Only by 1928 did Russia reach its 1913 (pre-World War I) level of industrial production, after which it became necessary to create new industry in the Soviet Union. This was a step toward socialism that Marx himself would have never even fathomed—for him industrialization was a necessary prerequisite or requirement for socialism and a socialist revolution.

The Stalin Revolution (1928–33) comprises two main campaigns: collectivization of agriculture and rapid industrialization. Stalin at the time announced that through these two policies the Soviet Union would make up for a hundred years difference in industrialization with the West in just ten

years. Stalin seized the resources necessary to industrialize the country from the countryside, from the peasants. In 1928 he reneged on the Bolshevik promise of land to the peasants and carried out collectivization, forcing peasants to live on large, state-owned collective or communal farms. There was a great deal of opposition to this policy, which was carried out very brutally and set agricultural production in the country back decades. Many peasants killed their livestock or sold farm implements rather than turn them over to the state, and the policy led to widespread famine in the Ukraine, the area in the USSR with the best agricultural land, and elsewhere such as Kazakhstan.

The Soviet state labeled peasants opposed to collectivization kulaks, or rich peasants, rounding up and exiling many of them to Siberian prison camps. Many more died of starvation, especially, as noted, in Ukraine in what most historians agree was a state created genocide, the *Holodomor* (death by hunger), which took an estimated 4mn lives, mostly Ukrainian peasants. But from Stalin's point of view the policy of collectivization provided the resources necessary to industrialize the country, and therefore was a success. In the 1930s, when the West was mired in economic depression, the Soviet Union had the most rapidly expanding economy in the world.

Stalinism was based on a state-controlled, planned economy with state ownership of property and an emphasis on large-scale production, all of which led to a huge bureaucracy and bred corruption. Politically, it was based on dictatorship, terror, and repression of "class enemies" (political opponents). Stalin is perhaps most infamous for his purges of the party's ranks, the most significant of which was in 1937–38, when hundreds of thousands of commoners, local party cadre, and military leaders were arrested and exiled or executed. As we have seen, during World War II the USSR bore the brunt of the fighting against Nazi Germany and the Soviet economy was devastated, but victory in the war validated the Stalinist system in the eyes of its leaders.

Stalin's policies had a very significant socioeconomic impact on the country, gradually transforming the Soviet Union from a primarily agrarian country to an industrialized one. Stalin ruled the country for twenty-five years (1928–53) and became the leader of an empire when the Soviet Union expanded its control over Eastern Europe following World War II as we have seen. Many worshipped him as an idol; however, the victims of Stalin's repression and their families had a much more negative view of him.

Despite the system's political oppression, Soviet leaders believed their society to be the most democratic system in the world. "Democracy" is a relative concept—different people define it differently. For Soviet leaders, democracy includes not just political rights, but also economic rights—they argued that you could not possibly have political democracy based on economic inequality as in a capitalist system. They referred to the elected parliamentary governments of the west as a form of "capitalist democracy," a system distinct from and, from their point of view, inferior to their own

“socialist democracy.” Very little about the Soviet Stalinist system was truly democratic in *any* sense of the term as it was riddled with corruption and, as noted, highly oppressive.

Post-Stalin USSR

Stalin died in March 1953, leaving a major political legacy for his successors to cope with. The first leader to deal with Stalin’s legacy was Nikita Khrushchev, an ethnic Russian from Ukraine who emerged as leader of the country in 1956 when he delivered his famous “secret speech” to communist party leaders. The speech denounced Stalin for creating a personality cult and for his “crimes against socialist legality,” as Khrushchev dubbed them, committed during his repressive rule, especially the brutal purges of the late 1930s. Transcripts of the speech were read to all communist party members and leaked to the West, where it appeared in the *New York Times* shortly after it was given, so in reality it was not very secret.

Khrushchev’s speech was the beginning of reform, de-Stalinization, a relative loosening of the system. His rule was referred to as the “thaw” because he allowed greater freedom in the arts and literature. The speech also had significant ramifications beyond the Soviet Union’s borders. It led to anti-Soviet uprisings in Eastern Europe, especially Hungary in 1956, and caused a rift in the Soviet Union’s relationship with communist China, contributing to the Sino-Soviet split, which we discuss in greater detail in a later chapter.

On the one hand, Khrushchev denounced Stalin and liberalized the system slightly, but on the other hand he ruled like a Stalinist, as a dictator. He went far enough to gain some political support but not far enough to maintain that support. Thus, when his economic policies proved disastrous, a majority vote of the Communist Party Central Committee replaced him in 1964, the only time power shifted hands in the Soviet political system without the death of the incumbent leader. Khrushchev lived in quiet retirement on the outskirts of Moscow until his death in 1971. However, the fact that Khrushchev rose to power on a platform of de-Stalinization shows that there was an anti-Stalinist opposition within the Soviet communist party, a reformist tendency in the country. Stalin had carried out severe policies of repression, which naturally created a good deal of opposition, and Khrushchev was able to tap into that opposition for a while.

Leonid Brezhnev, who like Khrushchev was from Ukraine, emerged as the country’s ruler for almost the next two decades. He pursued a policy of neo-Stalinism, ending the brief period of liberalization Khrushchev had begun, and his reign included renewed political repression, which had never completely gone away in any case. From the mid-1970s until the mid-1980s the USSR sputtered through a period of “stagnation” as the economy began to show signs of serious trouble. The Brezhnev regime invaded Afghanistan in late 1979, a move that would prove to be very unpopular over time. Soviet troops became bogged down in a bloody guerrilla conflict. The invasion of

Afghanistan heightened tensions between the US and the USSR, deepening Cold War hostilities in the early 1980s. In addition, the drop in the price of oil on the international market in the 1980s compounded the Soviet Union's economic decline, showing the extent to which its economy was linked to the capitalist-dominated international economy.

After a couple of older leaders succeeded Brezhnev and ruled briefly in the early 1980s, Mikhail Gorbachev became leader in 1985, gradually introducing two major reforms to revitalize the Soviet economy and society: glasnost and perestroika. Glasnost means "openness" and was the political side of Gorbachev's reform. He felt that unless the country was democratized, opened up to varying political views, Soviet society would never overcome its problems. Perestroika, which means "restructuring," was the economic side of the reform program, Gorbachev's attempt to decentralize the economy and open it up to market forces. It was not an attempt to create capitalism but to create a form of mixed socialism, an economic system with elements of both a market economy and a socialist economy.

Gorbachev's efforts to reform communism failed, however, and the system collapsed, first throughout Eastern Europe in the late 1980s, and then in the Soviet Union itself in late 1991. Several reasons explain the failure of Gorbachev's reforms: they did not produce economic prosperity, which is really the underlying test of any policy; the reforms did not go far enough politically as Gorbachev tried to maintain the power of the Communist Party, which had become bankrupt with most Soviet people; Gorbachev did not have a specific plan for reform, a blueprint to lead the way as he lacked any real foresight; Gorbachev never adequately dealt with the nationalities issue as many of the republics of the Soviet Union were clamoring for independence and nationalism was on the rise; finally, Gorbachev tried to walk the middle ground between two political extremes, the reformists and the Stalinists—he tried to please both and ended up pleasing neither, which explains why he lost popular support. In August 1991, hardline Stalinists within the Soviet political leadership attempted a coup to overthrow Gorbachev. The coup failed and led instead to the collapse of the Soviet Union itself by the end of that year.

Post-Soviet Russia

Boris Yeltsin took over as president of Russia, winning the country's first non-communist elections in 1992 in a landslide. However, owing to a very difficult transition to capitalism overseen by his government, Yeltsin lost much of his initial popularity. Market reforms or "shock therapy" cut social spending, privatized industry (which contributed to widespread unemployment), and eliminated state-imposed price controls, all of which led to a dramatic decline in living standards and widespread corruption. The reforms also led to a growing gap between rich and poor in the country and contributed to the rise of Russian nationalism. In addition, a military conflict with the small

breakaway Caucasus Republic of Chechnya ended in defeat for Russia in the First Russo-Chechen War (1994–96).

Russia's first post-Soviet transition in leadership took place peacefully as Yeltsin surprisingly resigned and handed power to his handpicked successor, Vladimir Putin, with the new year 2000. Putin was popular because of his handling of the Second Chechen War (1999–2009), in which Russia prevailed, and he won elections in March 2000. In addition, Russia's economic situation improved markedly in the first decade under Putin (Russia paid back in full the massive IMF loans it had taken out in the 1990s) due mainly to the high price of oil, Russia's main export, on the international market.

Conflict erupted between Russia and Ukraine in early 2014 following the overthrow of Ukraine's pro-Russian president, Viktor Yanukovich. Russia responded by seizing the Crimea while pro-Russian separatists in the southeastern Ukrainian region of the Donbas began fighting with support from and the direct intervention of Russian troops. Over the next seven-and-a-half years fighting in Donbas continued off and on between the Ukrainian army and pro-Russian militias. Russia greatly escalated the conflict by invading Ukraine proper in late February 2022. Putin did not achieve his expected quick and easy victory as Ukrainian forces, with support from the West, put up fierce resistance. As of early 2025 Russia occupies roughly 20% of Ukrainian territory (including Crimea), and the course of the war remains to be seen.

Post-Soviet Ukraine

Since its independence from the USSR in late 1991, Ukraine, with its capital at Kyiv and a population of around 41mn as of 2024, has been caught between stronger neighbors, “the West”—the EU/US on one side, and Russia on the other side. Ukraine is the second largest country in Europe (to Russia); it borders Russia to its east, Belarus to its north, Poland to its northwest, Slovakia and Hungary to its southwest, and Romania and Moldova to its south. A large part of southern Ukraine borders the strategically important Black Sea. One of Ukraine's greatest assets is its land, especially the central/southern “black earth” region widely considered to be some of the best agricultural land in the world. Ukraine is divided between its more Western-looking, Ukrainian-speaking provinces in the center and west of the country and its more Russian-speaking provinces in the east/southeast. While the country's leaders have tried to strike a balance between east and west since independence, they have been defined mostly by whether they were more pro-European (i.e., the first post-Soviet President Leonid Kravchuk), or more pro-Russian (i.e., his successor, Leonid Kuchma).

In the early 2000s Kuchma became embroiled in a scandal (dubbed “Kuchmagate”) sparked by one of his bodyguards surreptitiously taping a conversation in the president's office in which Kuchma appeared to be calling for the murder of a controversial journalist who strongly criticized the

corruption inherent in Ukraine's "privatization" process during Kuchma's first term as president. It was not entirely clear from the tape if Kuchma was ordering the journalist's death or saying he would not mind seeing it, but the journalist in question, Heorhii Gongadze, was found beheaded in the woods outside Kyiv shortly after the tape was made!

Kuchma weathered the storm of the scandal but could not run in the 2005 Ukrainian elections because of term limits. The *very* divided 2005 elections (the most divided in Ukrainian history up to that point) were a key turning point; the elections pitted a pro-Western candidate (Viktor Yushchenko, with his campaign team full of US advisors and assistants) against a pro-Russian/Putin candidate (Viktor Yanukovych, strongly supported by Russia). The pro-Western candidate (Yushchenko) suffered a mysterious poisoning during the campaign; the poison was identified as a strain of dioxin only manufactured in a few countries, including Russia but *not* Ukraine. Thankfully Yushchenko recovered and stayed in the race, but more political turmoil was in store for him and the country. Exit polls in the November 2005 elections showed the pro-EU candidate Yushchenko getting 53% of the vote to the pro-Russia candidate Yanukovych's 44%.

Surprisingly, when the government-controlled electoral commission announced the results, Yanukovych allegedly won with 49.5% of the vote to Yushchenko's 46.9%. However, telephone intercepts of discussions between members of Yanukovych's campaign staff showed that they had tampered with the server of the electoral commission to falsify the election results submitted to Kyiv. Massive peaceful protests flooded the streets of Kyiv and *Maidan* or Independence Square in the "Orange Revolution" (after the official color of Yushchenko's campaign). The country's Constitutional Court annulled the results as fraudulent and called for another election, which was held in December with the pro-Western candidate Yushchenko winning 52% to Yanukovych's 44% of the vote.

Unfortunately, Yushchenko proved to be a huge disappointment as president. He failed to reign in corruption and by some accounts was corrupt himself; he feuded with his own Prime Minister, Yulia Tymoshenko, and failed to alleviate the country's pressing economic problems. He alienated Russia (and many Russians in Ukraine) by playing up to Ukrainian nationalism, promoting the memory of the horrible famine or Holodomor of 1932–33 that, as noted, many see as a genocide against the Ukrainian people carried out by Stalin and Russia. Yushchenko's most controversial move was to celebrate the memory of the Ukrainian Insurgent Army (UIA), which had fought against the Soviets during World War II and after but also collaborated with the Nazis, massacring Jews and Poles in Ukraine. Yushchenko posthumously granted the UIA's founder Stepan Bandera a "Hero of Ukraine" award. These moves catered to the most extreme elements of Ukrainian nationalism and divided the country along ethnic lines without adding to Yushchenko's popularity. As the incumbent candidate he won a mere 5.5% of the vote in the first round of his re-election bid in 2010!

In those 2010 elections, the two main candidates in the second round of voting were, again, the pro-Russian candidate Viktor Yanukovych, who had lost out in the Orange Revolution five years earlier, and the pro-EU candidate Yulia Tymoshenko, who had served as Yushchenko's Prime Minister. Yanukovych won a close election with strong support from the predominantly Russian-speaking areas of Ukraine in the east/southeast (he is from the Donbas region) and this time his victory was not disputed.

The Russo-Ukrainian War (2014–?)

Yanukovych's 2010 election and pro-Russian tendencies opened the way to war. The issues directly leading to the war started a few years later, in November 2013, when Yanukovych backed out of a trade deal with the EU and decided instead to accept a trade deal and aid from Russia. As a result of that decision, protesters gathered in Kyiv to support the rejected pact with the EU. These protests in Kyiv's Independence Square grew, especially after Yanukovych ordered riot police to crack down brutally against them. In late February 2014 an estimated 100 protesters were killed in Independence Square and Yanukovych was forced to flee as his government collapsed in a coup (as the Russians called it) or a popular uprising (as the US/West called it). Ukrainians call this event the "Revolution of Dignity" and refer to the 100 protesters killed as the "heavenly hundred."

As noted, Russia responded by seizing Crimea, which at the time had a Russian-speaking majority of about 60% and is also the location of Russia's main Black Sea Naval Base at Sevastopol (rented from Ukraine since the collapse of the USSR). They held a referendum in March "confirming" Russian control. Meanwhile, fighting began in the Donbas region (the break-away, self-proclaimed "People's Republics" of Luhansk and Donetsk) and continued for the next eight years, with the UN estimating 14,000 deaths as a result of the conflict *before* Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022.

In May 2014 Ukrainians elected Petro Poroshenko, a candy magnate and one of the country's wealthy oligarchs, as president. He signed a deal with the IMF to implement a program of reform that gave Ukraine billions of dollars (\$17bn promised in total) in exchange for austerity measures like raising the price of natural gas by 50%, significantly increasing taxes and raising the cost of public transportation. This hurt common people who were already barely making it and eroded support for Poroshenko, whose government, like so many before it, was mired in corruption. Poroshenko was bound by Ukrainian law to give up his candy business when he became president, which he claimed he had done, but in fact he kept it and hid it under different ownership. His name was revealed by the 2016 release of the Panama Papers as among those with offshore accounts hiding millions of dollars.

So not surprisingly in the country's 2019 elections, Poroshenko lost badly to Volodymyr Zelensky, a popular Jewish comedian who received 73% of the

vote *and* was supported by most of the country unlike the divided east/west electoral results of the past. When Russia invaded Ukraine in late February 2022, contrary to Putin's expectations Zelensky did not flee, staying and rallying his people and the world against the Russian invaders.

Russia did not achieve its clear initial objective, which was regime change—taking Kyiv, getting rid of Zelensky, and installing a pro-Russian puppet ruler. So, Putin pulled back and started what he calls Phase Two of the “special military operation,” the objective of which is to secure Russia's hold on the east/southeast areas, including control of the key port on the Sea of Azov, Mariupol, a major industrial center and steel-producing city, and create a land bridge connecting Russia to Crimea. Putin's current goal seems to be to secure a “peace” agreement that allows him to keep at least nominal control of this territory, and in February 2025 newly elected US President Donald Trump voiced his support of Russia in this regard. So far, however, Ukraine seems determined to resist such an outcome and regain control of its sovereign territory.

Stalinism in Eastern Europe

As noted, the Soviet Union gradually imposed communist rule in the countries of Eastern Europe following World War II despite the small number of communist party members in those countries. Once this was accomplished, the Soviet Union basically transposed the Stalinist system onto Eastern Europe. To varying degrees and with some local differences, East Germany, Poland, Czechoslovakia, Hungary, Romania, Albania, and Bulgaria all carried out policies of collectivization and industrialization in the 1940s–50s, just as the USSR itself had done earlier. As a result, just as in the case of the Soviet Union, these countries went through a dramatic social transformation under communist control with increased urbanization and industrialization.

Also, just as in the Soviet Union itself, the Stalinist systems of Eastern Europe were repressive and based on terror (all the more so because they were occupied by Soviet troops). In the wake of Stalin's death in 1953, there were major uprisings in both Poland and East Germany that communist leaders in those countries repressed with tanks. After Khrushchev's “secret speech” in 1956, a major reform movement in Hungary emerged led by Imre Nagy, who began to press for more radical reforms than those proposed by the Soviet leader, calling for open elections involving non-communist parties. Unfortunately, from the point of view of Khrushchev and the Soviet leadership, that was going too far, and in the fall of 1956 the Soviets sent in the tanks to remove Nagy from power. He was executed two years later. Clearly there were limits to Khrushchev's de-Stalinization reforms and he did not intend to give up Soviet control over Eastern Europe.

Berlin also remained a trouble spot after the 1948–49 blockade and airlift. East Germans came to Berlin to escape to the West for political asylum, so in 1961 East German leaders began building a wall to keep people from fleeing

to the West. The Berlin Wall became the ultimate symbol of the Cold War division between East and West. More cracks in the iron curtain appeared over the years as well, the most prominent being in Czechoslovakia. In 1968 the country's reformist communist leader, Alexander Dubček, pressed for economic and political reforms. Seeking to create "socialism with a human face," Dubček liberalized the system, introduced elements of a market economy, gave peasants greater freedom to choose what crops they could grow, and proposed allowing non-communists to participate in the elections, the same proposal Nagy made in Hungary twelve years earlier. Dubček's efforts to reform the Czechoslovak communist system became known as the "Prague Spring." He emphasized that he was not rejecting socialism; he was rejecting the Stalinist form of socialism imposed on his country by the USSR. His reforms met with the same end as Nagy's as in the summer of 1968 Soviet leaders sent in tanks to put down the uprising.

Eastern Europe's fate depended on Moscow, and it would be Gorbachev who, in the late 1980s, finally let the countries of Eastern Europe go their own way. In a speech in early November 1989 denouncing the Soviet interventions in Hungary and Czechoslovakia, Gorbachev announced that Soviet troops would never again intervene in the internal affairs of the Eastern European countries. Within weeks of his speech communism had been wiped out in Eastern Europe, starting first with Germany and the collapse of the Berlin Wall. By the end of 1989 the Soviet sphere of influence in Eastern Europe that it had occupied since the end of World War II was gone, and as we saw two years later in 1991 the Soviet Union itself disintegrated. In the decades since, Central and Eastern Europe have increasingly merged with the countries of Western Europe economically and politically by joining the European Union (EU) and, also as we saw, NATO as well.



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Part II

Asia



Map 3.1 Map of Asia.
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Map 3.2 Map of South Asia.

3 South Asia and Southwest Asia

India, Pakistan, and Afghanistan

India

The Indian or South Asian subcontinent historically comprised the countries that are today India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Myanmar (formerly Burma), and the island nation Sri Lanka. India, with its capital at New Delhi, is now the world's most populous country at over 1.4bn as of 2023. The subcontinent's two large river systems, the Indus (from which India takes its name) in the west (now mostly in Pakistan), and the Ganges in the east are historically very important as early areas of settled populations based on agricultural production. The agriculturally rich region of the Ganges River plain lies south of the massive Himalayan Mountain chain that divides India and China. Historically, the majority of the population inhabited that area, the coasts, and the Indus River valley in the west, whereas the central part of India, the hilly, dry Deccan highlands, are relatively sparsely populated.

The Indian subcontinent is surrounded by water (the Indian Ocean and the Bay of Bengal) and protected by the highest mountains in the world, the Himalayas, in the northeast. However, the region is susceptible to invasion from the northwest through passes in the Hindu Kush mountains that now separate Pakistan and Afghanistan. This has been an avenue for incursions throughout the subcontinent's history, which has been shaped in part by invasions. Descendants of the Mongols invaded and conquered India in the early sixteenth century, forming the Moghul dynasty of the last Indian (Moghul) Empire in 1525. A legacy of its history of invasions is the prominence of ethnic and religious diversity on the subcontinent. There are three main religions, Hinduism, Islam, and Sikhism. Based on ancient Sanskrit texts, Hinduism is one of the oldest religions in the world. Islam, which is the second major religion in the area, originated in the seventh century CE and gradually spread into the subcontinent between the eighth and eleventh centuries and to some degree afterward as well. Sikhism, which combines elements of both Islam and Hinduism, originated in the Punjab region of Northwestern India in the late fifteenth century. There are also small Christian, Buddhist, and Parsee (former Zoroastrians from Persia) minorities in India as well. There are countless ethnic groups (over 100) on the Indian

subcontinent and a number of different languages and dialects, but religion is the most important defining characteristic. Hindi is India's official language.

British Colonial Rule, Mohandas Gandhi, and the Struggle for Independence

India is our first case study showing the impact of European colonialism, which took root in the vast South Asian subcontinent gradually starting in the coastal regions from the early sixteenth to the eighteenth centuries. Great Britain eventually colonized the region, but at first other European powers (the Portuguese, Dutch, and the French) were also involved in settling and trading in the subcontinent. The British gained the upper hand over the course of the eighteenth century, particularly following their defeat of France in the Seven-Years War (1756–63), due largely to their naval advancements but also their rise as the world's first industrial power by the late eighteenth/early nineteenth centuries. In the early nineteenth century fighting between Muslims and Hindus weakened India's Moghul Empire; the British took advantage of India's weakened state by playing one side against the other, a strategy, as we will see, they would employ until the very end of their rule, resulting in the partition of India.

Britain controlled India and most of its other colonies indirectly, meaning that they relied heavily on local elites to govern for them (India was much larger than Britain itself). The British trained an army of Indians, called sepoys, to rule the colony for them and bought off local ruling Indian elites, allowing them a share of the country's wealth in exchange for maintaining control over the population. The British in the 1850s introduced a new type of weapon to the native Indian sepoy troops that required them to grease the bullet with hog and beef fat. The Hindus objected because for them cows are sacred, and the Muslims objected because pork and pork fat are taboo. The event sparked a riot, revealing broad discontent with British rule that eventually became a full-scale rebellion. The 1857 Sepoy Rebellion points to the rise of opposition to British colonialism in India.

The British pursued a number of policies that bolstered their own economy at the expense of India. For example, they banned Indian cloth exports from their own home market in Britain while allowing English-produced clothing to enter India tariff-free, meaning with no import taxes, which greatly damaged India's traditional textiles industry, historically a very important part of its economy (a Spinning Wheel is in the middle of India's flag, indicating the long-term significance the traditional textiles industry had for India).

In the agricultural sector the British carried out land reform in India, leading to the consolidation of land holdings, and introduced cash crops or commercial crops, usually inedible crops grown for export on the world market rather than for internal consumption, i.e., cotton, tobacco, tea, coffee, cocoa, or (from India), peanuts, sugarcane, indigo (which is used to make dye for clothing), and even opium as we see in our discussion of China. Prior to

British rule, Indian peasants produced their own food for their own consumption or subsistence, paying rent and taxes in kind, meaning with part of their harvest. After the British commercialized India's agricultural economy, however, peasants began producing crops for export in exchange for cash and paying their rents and taxes in cash. The British, in short, introduced a cash economy into India and opened the country's economy up to the international market economy.

One notorious aspect of British rule in nineteenth century India was the occurrence of famine in different time periods and different parts of the country. Localized droughts, crop failures, and famines had always occurred as part of the natural agricultural cycle in India at a regularity of around once every forty years in various regions of the country prior to British colonization. However, after the British takeover the occurrence of famine increased significantly, with an estimated 15mn Indians dying in twenty-four famines between 1850–99. The introduction of cash crops was a contributing factor, as much of the cash earned from this transition went to those at the top, local landowners and the British themselves, leaving peasants without sufficient means to purchase the foodstuffs they needed for survival. The main problem in these localized famines was not the lack of food but rather the poor distribution of food and/or the money needed to purchase food items. Poor transportation, inadequate infrastructure, and badly organized, undemocratic local governments during British colonial rule compounded these problems and made famines worse than they otherwise would have been.

India's Independence Movement

The struggle for India's independence nominally began in 1885 with the formation of the India Congress Party (or Indian National Congress), which was joined in 1906 in a coalition by the newly formed Muslim League. India's independence movement gained a great deal of moral legitimacy around the world in 1919 when a British commander ordered his troops to fire on a crowd of unarmed, nonviolent protesters in the Amritsar massacre, killing several hundred of them.

Mohandas K. Gandhi (dubbed “Mahatma” or “Great Soul” for the first time in 1914) took his place rather late in the struggle after about a twenty-five-year stay in South Africa. Studying law in Britain as a young man, Gandhi initially strove to be like the British, taking dancing lessons and learning how to play British sports. Like most Indians in his milieu, Gandhi initially dressed in a Western style. However, his attitude toward dress and many other things changed dramatically over time. Experiencing discrimination at the hands of the British and the racist attitudes of whites in South Africa, Gandhi began to search for his own Indian roots and study the classics of Hinduism, where he discovered the concept of satyagraha, the force of truth and love, of change through peaceful means, which became the basis of his philosophy of non-violent resistance to the injustice of colonial rule.

In the 1920s Gandhi launched the Spinning-Wheel Movement as a reaction against Britain's unfair trading practices in textiles. Gandhi called on Indians to refuse to purchase cloth imported from Britain and to return to their traditional techniques of spinning their own cloth. The campaign worked very successfully for a while, but then several demonstrations against British textiles turned violent and Gandhi stopped the campaign by going on a fast.

In 1930 Gandhi led the Salt March, the strategy of which was twofold: to break the hold of the British monopoly on salt (no one could sell salt without a permit from the British colonial administration, which required them to pay a hefty tax for that right), and to empower the Indian people by showing them the path to self-reliance. Gandhi led a march of 240 miles to the sea and upon arrival boiled a pot of water and made his own salt. Afterward, people throughout the country began to make their own salt, breaking the British monopoly. In many ways, this highly symbolic campaign represents all that Gandhi stood for: in an entirely peaceful, nonviolent way he broke the long-held British monopoly on salt in India, striking at the economic heart of British colonial power, simply by boiling a pot of water.

As a political campaign, however, the Salt March was not simple at all—it was one of the most calculated and successful political campaigns Gandhi carried out. On the march Gandhi and his followers stopped in every village along the way to talk to peasants. He spoke against not only British colonialism but also against traditional Indian social abuses such as child marriage, the mistreatment of women, and taboos against the “untouchables.” Gandhi's movement was more than just a return to traditional Indian culture, it was a transformation of that culture, with Western ideas influencing Gandhi's outlook.

Independence and Partition in 1947

Indians split over the question of their country's role in World War II. Gandhi and the Indian Congress Party refused to support the British during the war (he had done so in World War I) and in 1942 began the “Quit India” campaign demanding independence. As leader of the Muslim League, Mohamad Ali Jinnah, conversely, supported the British war cause in exchange for a promised independent Muslim state after the war. This agreement between the Muslim League and the British left a legacy of conflict and political instability in South Asia. In 1947, two years after the end of World War II, the British granted India independence, but split the country into predominantly Hindu India and the separate Muslim states of East and West Pakistan. Jinnah became president of Pakistan and Jawaharlal Nehru the first prime minister of India.

Independence had been achieved, but at the price of unity. British colonialism created borders in South Asia where previously there had been none, creating rival nation-states out of its former colonial possession. After the

agreement was reached, a mass migration of 13mn people began, with Hindus fleeing the new state of Pakistan for India, and Muslims fleeing India for Pakistan. Fighting broke out between the two sides in 1947 and lasted for about six months, causing an estimated 1mn deaths.

The worst violence was in the northwestern corner between the two countries, in the princely states of Punjab and Kashmir where there is a great deal of religious diversity. In Punjab (bordering Pakistan and China), for example, a large majority of the population is Sikh, with Hinduism the other religion in the region, the only major Indian province with a Sikh majority and a Hindu minority. Another major trouble spot was Kashmir further north. According to the agreement with the British, the princely rulers of border states would decide which country to enter, and the Hindu prince of Kashmir chose to become part of India despite a Muslim majority in the province. This created a dispute that still exists between India and Pakistan over control of the region.

India Since 1947

In January 1948 a Hindu extremist assassinated Gandhi, part of a group that criticized him for meeting with Muslim leaders, accusing him of collaborating with Muslims even though Gandhi vehemently opposed partition. Despite Gandhi's legacy of nonviolent resistance to oppression, violence has certainly played a major role in the post-World War II history of India and the region, as in so many other parts of the world. India and Pakistan have gone to war over Kashmir several times since 1947 and tensions in the region have been very high on other occasions as well. Conflict within India between the Hindu majority and Muslim minority has also been very pronounced at times. In late 1992 a large crowd of Hindu nationalists in Ayodhya destroyed the Babri Mosque, believed by them to have been built by early leaders of the Mughal Empire on the site of a former temple at the birthplace of the Hindu God Rama. A decade later, in February 2002 Muslim extremists attacked a trainload of Hindus returning from the disputed temple/mosque site in Ayodhya, killing fifty-eight. The attack sparked large-scale anti-Muslim riots and many, many more deaths (an estimated 600 people, most of them Muslims, were killed in the several days of rioting that followed). Violence continued through the spring and into summer.

Economic change and social reform have also been key for India since 1947. The Nehrus (Jawaharlal, who ruled until his death in 1964, and his daughter Indira Gandhi—no relation to Mahatma Gandhi—who ruled for most of the period from 1964 until her assassination in 1984) sought with mixed success to modernize India and reduce poverty. India abolished the legal category of Dalit (or "Untouchable"), instituting affirmative action programs to benefit that historically disadvantaged segment of society and passing legislation guaranteeing women's equal rights. India and Pakistan had very little industry when the British left in 1947 (owing to British

policies discouraging the export of industrial technology to its colonies), but by imposing a great deal of state control over their economies, heavily taxing the agricultural sector, and utilizing foreign aid, both countries have industrialized (India more so than Pakistan). Indira Gandhi in the 1960s–70s pursued a policy of “mixed capitalism”: state-owned factories plus private industry and foreign investment.

Indira Gandhi promoted the “Green Revolution” in India in the 1960s–70s. This entailed the modernization of India’s agricultural sector of the economy with the introduction of new, high-yield seeds (from Taiwan and the Philippines) for growing rice, wheat (from Mexico), and other crops. The government granted farmers low-interest loans to purchase tractors, combines, and harvesters as well as to improve and modernize irrigation techniques and begin using fertilizers and pesticides. These changes led to significant increases in yields, much needed to feed the subcontinent’s ever-growing population and fund other government-sponsored modernization projects. In the twenty-first century India’s large well-educated, English-speaking urban population has put it in a strong position to flourish amid globalization in technology and telecommunications industries among others. The country’s economy has grown moderately in recent decades with the wealth generated very unevenly distributed as the gap between rich and poor in the country remains wide. In early 2023 India passed China to become the world’s most populous country.

In the post-World War II geopolitical realm India benefited from its relative neutrality in the Cold War because it traded with and received aid from both sides in the conflict. In the early 1980s, when the Cold War was at a new high point, India’s main trading partners were, in this order, the USSR, the US, and Britain, making it one of only a few countries to get money from both sides of the Cold War at the same time. However, investment by Western corporations in India at times led to problems. One of the most controversial events in US corporate history occurred in the Indian city Bhopal in 1984 when, because of an industrial accident, a chemical plant owned by the US-company Union Carbide suddenly released a cloud of toxic gas over the city, killing an estimated 3,000 people in the immediate aftermath of the incident and as many as 25,000 over time. Union Carbide settled with survivors and the family of survivors years later for a mere \$500 per family. After decades of high incidences of cancer and birth defects in the region the Indian government in a highly publicized move in early 2025, over forty years after the incident, removed an estimated 337mn tons of contaminated waste from the site, unfortunately a small percentage of the remaining contaminants in Bhopal.

India has certainly had its share of internal political turmoil and violence. In the mid-1970s Indira Gandhi’s political opponents accused her of voter fraud, a claim held up by the courts, effectively removing her as Prime Minister. However, to stay on as leader in 1975 Gandhi responded by declaring a State of Emergency, effectively suspending India’s democracy

by ordering the arrest of political opponents, heightened surveillance and censorship of the media, and increased police powers to deal with political opposition. Two years later Gandhi called for elections that she hoped would vindicate her rule. However, a broad coalition of opposing parties trounced Gandhi's Congress Party in the 1977 elections, as a result of which she lost the position as Prime Minister she had held for over a decade. Three years of political chaos and economic turmoil followed, as a result of which Indira Gandhi swept back into power in 1980 elections following the collapse of the government.

In 1984 two of her bodyguards, political opponents among the country's Sikh minority population who had infiltrated her security team, assassinated Indira Gandhi. Anti-Sikh riots erupted leading to the deaths of as many as 8,000 people across the country. Indira Gandhi's son Rajiv succeeded her as Prime Minister; at forty he was the youngest Prime Minister to rule India (before or since). Rajiv Gandhi ruled for one term, his government accused of widespread corruption, before being voted out in 1989. Thereafter he led the parliamentary opposition until he too was assassinated by a suicide bomber in May 1991. The bomber was opposed to Rajiv Gandhi's support of the Sri Lankan government in its ongoing, brutal civil war against the "Tamil Tigers," as the rebels were known, who fought for an independent Tamil state in northeastern Sri Lanka.

In recent decades India has shed the "Nehru-Gandhi Dynasty" that dominated the country politically for most of its first forty years after independence. Shri Atal Bihari Vajpayee, head of the National Democratic Alliance government and specifically of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), ruled from 1998–2004 during the period of some of the worst aforementioned violence between Hindus and Muslims in the country. Vajpayee publicly decried the outbreak of violence and the revenge attacks of Hindus against Muslims in the 2002 riots that engulfed parts of the country. However, critics pointed out that the government did very little to protect Muslims against the riotous attacks, and that Vajpayee's political allies fanned the flames of anti-Muslim sentiment for their own political gain. In part because of the instability Vajpayee was voted out of office in 2004, replaced by India's first Sikh Prime Minister, Manmohan Singh, who served from 2004–14.

In 2014 India elected Narendra Modi Prime Minister, a position he maintains over a decade later. Modi has been a controversial ruler of the country as a member of the BJP party allied with extreme Hindu nationalists. He is India's longest ruling Prime Minister outside of the Congress Party, and many are concerned about his increasingly authoritarian tendencies. In 2021 the Indian government passed the controversial Citizenship Amendment Act, which eases the path to Indian citizenship for immigrants from several religious minority groups, including Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists, and Christians, which Modi's government says faced persecution in Pakistan, Bangladesh, and Afghanistan. Critics note that this is a highly exclusionary law (Muslims

persecuted in those countries, for example Shia minorities, are *not* included in the law) that violates secular principles enshrined in India's Constitution by linking one's faith to citizenship status in the country. The law was initially passed in 2019 but put on hold amid massive protests that saw the deaths of numerous protesters and the arrest of many others.

These legal changes, the government's tightening grip on the media, an increase in the surveillance of the population, and growing Islamophobia in the country have led many Indians to question whether it can still call itself, as it has proudly since 1947, "the world's largest democracy." Islamophobia manifests itself in subtle and not-so-subtle ways; in 2020, as an example of the latter, Muslims were falsely (ridiculously) accused of spreading the Corona virus to carry out a so-called "*Coronajihad*." India, in short, is a country with tremendous promise and potential but also one with a difficult and violent history, the future of which remains uncertain.

The Birth of Pakistan

We cannot divorce Pakistan—the idea and the reality—from India, with which as we have seen it was historically linked for many centuries. Aside from, as noted, the high mountains ringing the subcontinent in the north, the key defining geographical features of Pakistan (and also Bangladesh) are its river systems, the Indus River system in the west and the Ganges River system in the east. Pakistan's current ethnic composition includes considerable diversity, with several main groups making up the largest part of its population: the Punjabi (about 45%), Pashtun (nearly 15%), Sindhi (around 14%), Saraiki (related to the majority Punjabi, 8%), Muhajirs (7%), and several other small groups making up the rest. The main language in Pakistan is Urdu, which is closely related to Hindi; as in India many Pakistanis also speak English.

The Islamic Republic of Pakistan, with its capital at Islamabad and a population of almost 254mn as of 2025, is also defined by its religious makeup: over 96% of the population is Muslim, split between a majority Sunni (85–90%) and minority Shia (10–15%), the two largest branches of Islam that split gradually over the course of the seventh century following the Prophet Muhammad's death in 632 over the question of who should be his successor or Caliph. Small minorities of Hindus and Christians make up the rest of Pakistan's population. Islam spread into the Indus River valley by the eighth century, roughly a century-and-a-half after the rise of Islam on the Arabian Peninsula, especially after Islamic armies of the Umayyad Caliph based in Damascus, Syria, conquered the Sindh people in the Indus River valley around 700. Islam expanded gradually from there largely through conversion by Suffi missionaries, trade, and to some degree also conquest such that by the middle of the thirteenth century the eastern coast of South Asia in the Bay of Bengal (the area of today's Bangladesh) was also predominantly Muslim.

By 1500 Islam had made significant inroads throughout India, as some Dalits and lower caste Hindus converted, although Hinduism remained by far the majority religion in the South Asian heartland. The significance of Islam in the South Asian subcontinent increased with its aforementioned 1525 conquest by the Mughals, descendants of the Mongols who had long since converted to Islam. For the most part Mughal rulers showed great tolerance to the majority Hindu population, but nonetheless (and not surprisingly) some people in India converted from Hinduism to Islam under Mughal rule. The numbers in India are about 80% Hindu and 20% Muslim for most of the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, although with its large population that means that India has the second—to Indonesia—largest Muslim population in the world.

The concept of a “Pakistan” separate from India arose only in the 1930s from among leaders of the Muslim League. Originally the Muslim League, which formed in 1906 to promote the interests of the Muslim minority in India, did not question British rule, but in 1923 it allied more closely with the Indian National Congress in support of Gandhi’s call for independence from the British. In a speech to the Muslim League in 1930, Muhammad Iqbal, a prominent poet, philosopher, and political leader, articulated the idea of forming a separate, independent Muslim state out of India, although he did not give it a specific name. In a 1933 pamphlet Choudhry Rahmat Ali, another key Muslim leader, called for the creation of a separate Muslim state in India called “Pakstan” (without the “i”) formed from the first letters of four of the major regions with large Muslim populations and the ending of another: *P*unjab, the *A*fghan Province (or Northwest Frontier Province), *K*ashmir, *S*indh, and *B*aluchistan (the Persian suffix “stan” means “where one stands” or “place of”). Thus, the idea of Pakistan as a separate Muslim state in India was born.

As we saw, the creation of Pakistan as a separate Muslim state came out of the deal struck during World War II between the British and Muhammad Ali Jinnah, leader of the Muslim League, who supported the British war cause in exchange for a promised independent Muslim state after the war. Jinnah had worked closely with the Indian National Congress, including Gandhi and Nehru, for most of his political career. He had not promoted the idea of a separate Muslim state in India, i.e., Pakistan, until the late 1930s when, he said, the arguments and ideas of Muhammad Iqbal and Choudhry Rahmat Ali inspired him and won him over to the cause.

Pakistan gained its independence on August 14, 1947, with Jinnah as President; India followed the next day (both Sri Lanka and Burma, now Myanmar, became independent in January 1948). Originally Pakistan included two component parts, West Pakistan comprised of the areas making up the country’s name (although only part of Kashmir), and East Pakistan in the predominantly Muslim region of the Bay of Bengal and the Bengali ethnic group that makes up the majority of that area. Jinnah died in 1948; Liaquat Ali Khan, replaced him and ruled until his assassination three years later.

The wartime agreement and partition of the subcontinent led to war between India and Pakistan (the first of several) over control of the disputed region Kashmir, where the vast Indus River system originates, in 1948. Kashmir's ruling Hindu prince decided to join India in accordance with the agreement authored by the British despite the fact that the region had a two-thirds Muslim majority. The newly formed UN intervened and reached a ceasefire resolution in the conflict with control of the region divided between Pakistan and India. The UN called for a plebiscite of the population of Kashmir to decide which country the region should belong to, but the vote has never been held owing to Indian opposition. India claims that it cannot ensure a legitimate voting process because of Pakistani interference. China complicated matters by invading and illegally occupying a small part of Kashmir in 1962, which it has controlled ever since.

Pakistan Since 1947

Since independence Pakistan has mostly been ruled by military dictatorships, with intervals of elected civilian governments in the 1970s, 1980s, 1990s, and again for most of the twenty-first century (since 2008). Relations between India and Pakistan have remained tense. In addition to the war over Kashmir in 1948, a conflict that ended mostly unresolved, subsequent wars between the two neighboring countries (mostly over control of Kashmir) occurred in 1965, 1970–71, and very nearly several times since (including a small-scale war in 2001–02 and border skirmishes as recently as 2015). In 1998 Pakistan reported successfully testing a nuclear device, which India had done in 1974, adding a potentially frightening element to this conflict.

Pakistan promulgated its first constitution in 1956, but two years later General Mohammad Ayub Khan overthrew the government in a military coup, declared martial law, and ruled until 1969, when he stepped down for another military leader largely because of Pakistan's poor showing in the 1965 War with India over control of Kashmir. In the 1960s East Pakistan, home primarily to the Bengali ethnic group, which felt discriminated against by the groups ruling in the West (especially the majority Punjabi), began an independence movement against West Pakistan. East Pakistan produced a larger percentage of the country's export crops but was much poorer than West Pakistan and not benefiting as much from economic development. With the support of India, which sought to weaken its archrival Pakistan by facilitating the breakaway of its eastern province, separatists in the East defeated West Pakistan in 1971 and East Pakistan became Bangladesh.

Two years later, after losing Bangladesh, the military government, led at that point by General Yahya Khan, who had succeeded Mohammad Ayub Khan, stepped down, returning the country to civilian rule. A key civilian leader defining much of the Pakistani political landscape in the 1970s was Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, a member of the Sindhi minority and part of the country's traditional elite (he was educated at Oxford and Berkeley).

In 1967 he founded the Pakistan People's Party (PPP), an Islamic-Socialist party, which won Pakistan's national elections in 1970. However, due in part to growing economic problems, by the mid-1970s Bhutto's popularity began to wane. He had nationalized the country's leading banks and industries and carried out an extensive land reform program, and by the mid-1970s these policies, implemented rather chaotically, led to inflation and an economic slowdown.

Thus, when Bhutto and the PPP won re-election by a wide margin in March 1977, the opposition Pakistan National Alliance (PNA) claimed it was owing to vote rigging. They began a countrywide policy of protest based on civil disobedience (in the style of Gandhi), and Bhutto responded by declaring martial law. This was a mistake, however, because imposing martial law necessitated leaning on the military, and in July General Muhammad Zia-ul-Haq overthrew Bhutto in a military coup. Zia arrested Bhutto and jailed him for two years before executing him in 1979, thereby ushering in another prolonged period of military rule in Pakistan. During his decade-long rule Zia affirmed Pakistan as an Islamic country, ignoring calls for the secularization of the country, an idea he adamantly opposed.

Zia-ul-Haq's regime found itself in an interesting position when the USSR invaded Afghanistan in late 1979. Pakistan became the main conduit of weapons and aid to the Afghan mujahideen rebels fighting against Soviet troops, which greatly boosted the power of Zia-ul-Haq's regime. However, in August 1988 Zia-ul-Haq died in a plane crash under mysterious circumstances. Several other key Pakistani leaders also died in the crash, as did the US Ambassador to Pakistan, Arnold Lewis Raphael.

Since Zia's death Pakistan has seen a revolving door of military and civilian leaders, often the same civilian leaders. Benazir Bhutto of the PPP, daughter of Zulfikar, ruled between 1988–1990, becoming the first woman leader of a predominantly Muslim country, and again between 1993–1997, her governments collapsing both times amid allegations of corruption. Nawaz Sharif, leader of a re-formed Pakistan Muslim League and Bhutto's main political rival, ruled between 1990–1993 and 1997–1999, but he too was removed in both cases because of allegations of corruption, clearly a key ingredient of the Pakistani political scene.

General Pervez Musharaff overthrew Sharif's civilian government in 1999, returning Pakistan once again to military rule, largely because the country had not fared well in the Kargil Conflict, a brief war with India over Kashmir. The US Clinton and Bush Jr. administrations were weary of Musharaff because Pakistan was one of only three countries to recognize the harsh Taliban government of Afghanistan that came to power in 1996 (the other two being Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates). The US relationship with Musharaf's military regime turned abruptly with the terrorist attacks on the US on September 11, 2001, at which time the US Bush Jr. administration gave Musharaf a choice: side with the Taliban in Afghanistan (and by extension al-Qaeda) or assist the US in its attempt to overthrow the Taliban

and round up Osama bin Laden and his supporters. Musharraf denounced the Taliban and agreed to assist the US in its war in Afghanistan.

The Pakistani Taliban, a group related and allied to but separate from the Afghan Taliban, which we discuss in the next section, originated in the mid-2000s out of the conflict between the Pakistani military and Muslim extremists in the country. An umbrella group of Muslim extremists mostly from the northwestern tribal regions bordering Afghanistan and (like the Afghan Taliban) predominantly from the Pashtun ethnic group, the Pakistani Taliban's main goal is to overthrow the country's secular government. They were reportedly responsible for the assassination of Benazir Bhutto as she campaigned in December 2007. Five years later they forced a fifteen-year-old girl off of a school bus and shot her for her outspoken support of girls' right to education. Malala Yousafzai, who survived the attack, went on to become the youngest recipient ever of the Nobel Prize for Peace, which she won in 2014 at age seventeen.

Musharaff ruled until 2008 before stepping aside for civilian rule. Asif Ali Zardari, Benazir Bhutto's widower and also of the PPP, ran for and won the presidency. He ruled until 2013, when Nawaz Sharif once again won elections to rule for another term that ended in 2017. The following year a popular former cricket star for the Pakistani national team, Imran Khan, founder of the populist Pakistan Movement for Justice (PTI in its Urdu initials) won the elections. He ruled as Prime Minister until 2022 when a scandal involving the US, dubbed "Lettergate," led to his ouster.

Imran Khan claimed that the US was pushing for his removal because of his failure to support Ukraine following the Russian invasion of that country in late February 2022. Criticizing US interference in Pakistan's foreign affairs, Imran Khan, who visited Moscow shortly after the invasion, claimed to have documented proof of the allegations. In April he became the first Pakistani Prime Minister ever removed by a parliamentary vote of no confidence (as opposed to a military coup). Six months later he survived an assassination attempt, but then in May 2023 the Pakistani authorities arrested him on corruption charges. In prison ever since, he argues that the accusations against him are unfounded and politically motivated. Asif Ali Zardari of the PPP won the country's most recent elections and assumed power once again in early 2024.

In late November 2024 thousands of Imran Khan's supporters, led by his wife Bushra Bibi, herself only recently released from jail, marched to a center square in Islamabad demanding Khan's release from prison. There were reports of several deaths in the police crackdown against the protesters that followed. Pakistan's political future, in short, remains under a cloud of uncertainty.

Afghanistan: A History of Turmoil

Because of its location between the Persian Gulf, Central Asia, and the Indian subcontinent, Afghanistan, with its capital at Kabul and a population of

roughly 41.4mn as of 2023, has historically been an important entity in this region of the world, including along the once prominent Silk Road trade route that linked the Middle East and Far East. Afghanistan is a landlocked country in which communication and transportation have been impeded historically by its mountainous terrain, and as a result integration on a national level has been difficult. Thus, Afghanistan has been characterized throughout most of its history by regionalism and conflict and weak central governments.

Modern Afghanistan is a very ethnically diverse country. The majority Pashtun comprise about 42% of the total population; Tajiks about 27%; Hazara, who are predominantly Shia Muslims, about 9%, roughly the same as the Uzbeks; Aimaqs are about 4%, and several small groups, including the Turkmen and Baloch among others, make up the rest. Inter-marriage between the various groups is common. The population is overwhelmingly Muslim with a Sunni majority of around 80% and Shia minority of roughly 19%. The main languages of Afghanistan are Dari, which is a dialect of Farsi spoken in neighboring Iran, and Pashto, although there are estimated to be some twenty different languages and dialects in the country.

The modern Afghan state was born in 1747. Tribal chieftains assembled a *loya jirga* or tribal council, which elected Ahmad Khan Durrani as leader of Afghanistan, at the time a loosely assembled entity of Pashtun tribal chiefs. Afghanistan for centuries before this had been divided between the two main Islamic empires in the region, the Persian/Iranian Safavid Empire and the Indian Mughal Empire. The formation of modern Afghanistan was owing to the relative weakening of these two neighboring empires. By the mid-eighteenth century they were on the decline and Ahmad Khan was able to conquer territory between both empires among the Pashtun tribes.

In the colonial period of the nineteenth century Afghanistan was caught in the “Great Game,” a phrase coined by British author Rudyard Kipling to refer to the diplomatic machinations between Russia and Great Britain. Neither of these two European powers actually conquered or colonized Afghanistan outright, but the British controlled Afghanistan’s foreign policy for several decades following the Second Anglo-Afghan War (1878–80). Britain’s primary concern was to keep Russian influence at bay in Afghanistan because they feared the possibility of Russian expansion interfering with Britain’s control of India, the “jewel” of their empire. They had no intention of colonizing Afghanistan but wanted to keep the Russians from doing so as well. A British mission headed by Sir Mortimer Durand established the border between Afghanistan and British India, dividing the region’s majority Pashtun population on both sides of the new border.

Amanullah Khan’s Reforms

Amanullah Khan replaced his father Habibullah as Afghan monarch after the latter’s assassination in 1919. He immediately sent a letter to the British Viceroy of India, Lord Chelmsford, declaring that henceforth Afghanistan

would control its own foreign policy and demanding that the Durand Line be redrawn to bring the Pashtun tribes in the east under Afghan control. The Viceroy responded by dispatching British troops to Afghanistan, sparking the Third Anglo-Afghan War (1919), which ended with the Durand Line still intact but with Afghanistan in control of its own foreign affairs for the first time in over forty years, a victory for Amanullah.

Amanullah sought to implement Westernizing, secularizing reforms like those Kemal Atatürk was carrying out in Turkey in the 1920s. He wrote a constitution creating a secular basis of rule for Afghanistan's monarchical government and a secular legal system that bypassed traditional Islamic courts. He also allowed girls to go to school for the first time and guaranteed the legal rights of women. After returning from a "Grand Tour" abroad (mostly to Europe) with his wife, Queen Soroya, in the late 1920s Amanullah tried to deepen the reforms, proposing that monogamy be enforced for all government employees; that a minimum age limit be set for marriage; that women be allowed to pursue higher education; and that only Western attire be worn in public in Kabul. These proposals sparked outrage among the country's conservative religious clerics and others, outrage compounded by (untrue) rumors that Amanullah had converted to Catholicism while on his trip abroad. Afghan newspapers published pictures of his wife, Queen Soroya, unveiled in public while traveling abroad, which led to further condemnation of Amanullah. The precise events that triggered Amanullah's fall are unclear, but a series of revolts forced his abdication in January 1929. He fled to exile in Italy, where he would live for the remaining thirty years of his life.

Muhammad Zahir Shah and Muhammad Daoud

After a brief nine-month period in which the country was ruled by a Tajik bandit leader, four brothers from the country's Pashtun royal family (distant cousins of Amanullah) seized power. They rescinded Amanullah's reforms, continuing on a path of Westernization and modernization, but at a much slower pace. Nineteen-year-old Zahir Shah became monarch in 1933 following the assassination of his father. With the outbreak of World War II in Europe in 1939, the Afghan government decided to remain neutral. In October 1941 the British and Russians, who were by then allied against Nazi Germany, demanded that the Afghan government kick out about 200 German and Italian citizens (mostly engineers) in Afghanistan. The Afghan government resented this demand but had to comply, especially given that similar problems just a few months prior had led to the ouster by a joint Russian and British invasion of the ruling Reza Shah Pahlavi in neighboring Iran for being too pro-German.

A key figure in the Afghan government at this time was Muhammad Daoud, cousin, friend, and brother-in-law to the ruler Zahir Shah. As Minister of Defense in the late 1940s, Daoud asked the US for military

assistance, which, to his annoyance, the US denied (the US simply did not consider Afghanistan important enough strategically and the Truman administration feared that weapons provided to Afghanistan could just as easily be used against Pakistan). Daoud thereafter looked to the USSR for weapons and trade, and Afghanistan gravitated toward the Soviet side in the Cold War (in 1956 the Soviets built the Bagram Air Base north of Kabul).

In 1953 Zahir Shah named Daoud Prime Minister. Six years later Daoud's wives and daughters as well as other women in the royal family appeared unveiled at the annual *Jeshn* ceremony marking Afghanistan's independence on August 19, 1919. Daoud was promoting women's rights just as Amanullah had in the 1920s, although he did not pass any laws regarding this matter, choosing instead to lead by example. Nonetheless, this caused quite a bit of controversy and leading mullahs were outraged.

Daoud also strongly supported the idea of a united Pashtunistan, bringing the Pashtun people in western Pakistan together with those of Afghanistan (presumably, of course, under Afghan rule). In the early 1960s Daoud began actively instigating rebellion among Pashtun rebels across the border in Pakistan, whose military ruler at the time, Ayub Khan, was Pashtun. Pakistan responded by closing off the border, greatly damaging the flow of goods into and out of Afghanistan, which negatively impacted the Afghan economy. In March 1963 Daoud resigned amid growing economic problems, concern among members of the royal family of the country's growing dependence on the USSR, and also dissatisfaction with Daoud's increasingly autocratic form of rule.

A decade later in the early 1970s a drought—a problem Afghanistan is very susceptible to and has experienced periodically throughout its history—caused severe hardship in the country and weakened support for Zahir Shah, whose government was accused of widespread corruption. Daoud, who as former Minister of Defense remained influential within the military, seized power in a nearly bloodless military coup in 1973 while Zahir Shah was on a visit to Italy, where he then remained in exile for almost thirty years before returning to Afghanistan in 2002. Although a member of the royal family, Daoud declared the country a Republic, thereby ending its monarchical government after more than 200 years.

The Rise of the PDPA and the Mujahideen

Beneath the surface political turmoil was brewing in society at large. In 1965 Nur Muhammad Taraki and thirty colleagues formed the People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan (PDPA), the country's first communist party, at a meeting at his house. Aside from Taraki, who was elected General Secretary of the party, another key leader of the PDPA was Babrak Karmal, and a third was Hafizullah Amin. It seems quite likely that they were on the Soviet/KGB payroll for their activities as communist activists. Taraki, for instance, was paid "royalties" for his translations of Russian theoretical

works, and this money financed the organizing efforts of the PDPA from the outset of that organization's birth.

Factionalism plagued the communist movement in Afghanistan from its inception. In 1967 the PDPA split into two factions: the more radical *Khalq* ("masses"), led by Taraki, and the more moderate *Parcham* ("flag" or "banner"), led by Karmal. Parcham called for working for change within the system, expressing loyalty to the king, recruiting among government officials, etc., whereas Khalq emphasized a purer ideological approach of class struggle. Karmal's Parcham faction was more multi-ethnic, attracting supporters from a variety of ethnic groups, whereas Taraki's Khalq was more exclusively Pashtun in its composition. Amin remained loyal to Taraki and became the second-leading figure of the Khalq faction.

While the communist factions emerged, Islamic groups that would later form the core of the mujahideen ("holy warriors"), the rebel groups that would fight against the Afghan communist regime and its Soviet supporters in the 1980s, were also taking shape. Gholam Muhammad Niazi, a professor of religious studies at Kabul University who inspired several future mujahideen leaders, played a pivotal role in this development. Niazi's supporters often clashed with communists at rallies on campus in the late 1960s and early 1970s. In 1972 Niazi formed *Jamiat-e-Islami* (the Islamic Society), which included a Muslim Youth wing led by several future mujahideen leaders, Burhanuddin Rabbani, Ahmed Shah Masood, Abdul-Rab al-Rasul Sayyaf, and Gulbuddin Hekmatyar, the latter allegedly overseeing a group of extremists who splashed acid in the faces of unveiled women on campus.

In 1974 the Daoud government cracked down on Islamic extremists, arresting Niazi and 200 of his more ardent followers. However, several supporters, including Rabbani, Masood, Sayyaf, and Hekmatyar, found out about the raid in time to escape to Pakistan. Rabbani eventually emerged as successor to Niazi, killed in prison by the communist regime in 1978, to lead *Jamiat-e-Islami* (along with Masood), a predominantly Tajik faction of the mujahideen, whereas Hekmatyar broke with them to form the more radical and mostly Pashtun faction *Hezb-i-Islami* (Islamic Party). Thus, the two sides of Afghanistan's internal struggle to come, the communists and the Islamicists, or Islamic extremists, both divided between more radical and more moderate elements, gradually emerged at the same time in the late 1960s and early 1970s.

The Communist Coup (April 1978) and Soviet Intervention

The Parcham faction of the PDPA supported Daoud's seizure of power in the 1973 coup. Once in power, Daoud initially returned to the close relationship with the USSR he had cultivated in the 1950s. However, over the course of the 1970s Daoud's government expanded its external relations, seeking aid from neighboring Iran, whose Shah (until his overthrow in 1979) was a close US ally, and also normalizing relations with Pakistan (there was no return to the rhetoric of Pashtunistan that Daoud had pushed earlier) and China,

both enemies of the USSR. One of Daoud's assistants later indicated that while visiting Moscow in 1977, Soviet leader Leonid Brezhnev reportedly took Daoud to task for allowing so many foreign experts into Afghanistan, to which Daoud responded angrily that his country would employ whom it pleased and would not allow the USSR or anyone else to dictate to them how they should act. Daoud walked out of the room and broke off the ongoing talks with the Soviet leadership, an act some say sealed his doom the following year.

Unhappy with Daoud, in 1977 the USSR pressured the Khalq and Parcham factions of the PDPA to form a united front, which they did, and a year later they seized power in a communist takeover. In April 1978 someone murdered Mir Akbar Khyber, a prominent member of Parcham. It remains unclear who did it, possibly either Daoud's secret police or someone representing the Khalq faction. Large demonstrations packed the streets of Kabul, the country's capital, on the day of Khyber's funeral, and Daoud was alarmed at the apparent level of support for the PDPA, so on April 25/26 he ordered the arrest of most of their leaders. This, however, prompted communist leaders not in jail to act and with the support of a few hundred men and about forty to fifty tanks they seized power in a military coup. Daoud, most of the members of his government, and many members of his family died in the attack on the Presidential Palace that led to an estimated 2,000 deaths (the communist PDPA commemorated this event as the Saur—meaning “April” or “Spring”—Revolution, but it was clearly a military takeover or coup).

Taraki declared the country the Democratic Republic of Afghanistan (DRA). Soon the differences between Khalq and Parcham resurfaced as the former, led by Taraki and Amin, wanted an immediate and far-reaching social and economic revolution to completely overhaul Afghan society; the more moderate Parcham faction led by Karmal, on the other hand, wanted a gradual approach to revolutionary change. The Khalq faction had the upper hand, in large part because Amin was head of the secret police apparatus (KhAD), and soon began purging Parcham members. In August KhAD began to arrest and execute leading Parcham figures. By the end of summer 1978 Amin was the most powerful figure—second to Taraki in name only—of a government now controlled largely by the Khalq faction. The regime decreed a radical land reform program placing strict limits on land holdings and redistributing land to poor and landless peasants. They also issued a marriage decree that set an age limit for marriage (sixteen), something Amanullah had tried unsuccessfully to do in the 1920s, established freedom of choice in marriage (replacing arranged marriages), and began a literacy campaign aimed at establishing universal literacy and equal education for Afghan boys and girls.

The reforms faced widespread and deep-seated resistance and opposition at every turn. Part of the problem was their focus on land—it was not just a question of land ownership because Afghan peasants also often relied on landowners for seed, fertilizer, water rights, and draught animals to work the land. The government gave some of landless peasants land, thereby angering

the landowners who withheld out of spite these other necessary materials, making the land itself effectively worthless because the government did not make the necessary arrangements to supply peasants with the other things needed to farm the land. There was also a key religious issue involved: most rural Afghans believed it unjust and un-Islamic to accept property that had been taken from someone else, so the land reform policy of the Khalq-led government was not widely embraced by Afghan peasants. The changes in marriage practice and education were also largely resented by people in the countryside, and by late 1978/early 1979 the new communist regime faced the armed opposition of rebels, mujahideen, in mostly rural areas throughout the country.

By the fall of 1979 the Soviet leadership worried that Afghanistan's Khalq-led regime was on the brink of collapse. The Soviets saw Amin's radical policies as the root of the problem and thus wanted to get rid of him and compel Taraki to work with Karmal in a moderate coalition communist government. However, Amin found out about a secret meeting in Moscow between Taraki and Karmal (probably from the Foreign Minister, a supporter of Amin who was on the trip) and struck first, killing Taraki in an attack on the Presidential Palace and taking over control of the government in September 1979. This led to the Soviet invasion three months later in December. A Special KGB corps killed Amin and Karmal took over the government. Within a few days 50,000 Soviet troops were occupying Afghanistan's main urban centers as well as controlling roads and mountain passes into and out of the country. Within a few weeks that force had grown to 85,000 and would eventually swell to well over 100,000.

The US supplied weapons and finances to the mujahideen as early as July 1979, while Jimmy Carter was still US President, several months prior to the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, and continued to provide tremendous monetary support and weapons to the mujahideen throughout the conflict under the administration of US President Ronald Reagan in the last major Cold War proxy war. There were at least seven separate factions within the mujahideen led by some of the aforementioned students of Niazi at Kabul University in the late 1960s/early 1970s, such as the mostly Pashtun faction of Hekmatyar, probably the most radical and uncompromising faction of all, which received the bulk of the US CIA-supplied weapons smuggled covertly into the country via Pakistan's secret service agency (ISI—Inter-Services Intelligence). Another key group was the mostly Tajik faction led by Rabbani and Masood in the northeastern Panjshir valley, widely seen as the most effective fighting force against the Soviets. And there was a mostly Pashtun and Arab faction led by al-Rasul Sayyaf, the Islamic Union for the Freedom of Afghanistan, which received support from Saudi Arabia and the US and recruited volunteers from the Arab world, including, most notably, Osama bin Laden. There were a number of other factions as well, most of them divided by ethnic identity (there were three separate Hazara factions for example who mostly fought among themselves during the 1980s).

The Soviet-Afghan War (1979–1989)

The Soviet strategy in the war was to occupy major population centers, strategic sites such as bases and mountain passes, and provide weaponry, support, and training to the communist government's Afghan forces to fight it themselves. The Soviets did not intend to stay long—they wanted to build up the strength of the Afghan forces and get out in a few months. However, it quickly became apparent that the Soviets would have to fight this war, or at least the bulk of it, because of the weakness and unreliability of the Afghan communist government troops, many of whom defected to the mujahideen. The Soviet-Afghan War was fought overwhelmingly in rural areas, where a large majority of the Afghan population (about 75%) resided. The Soviets tried to depopulate the countryside by brutally attacking villages, employing a “scorched earth” policy of destroying buildings, crops and livestock to undermine support for the mujahadeen. This type of warfare led to a massive flow of refugees out of the Afghan countryside into the cities, Pakistan (mostly), and Iran. By 1984 there were 3.5mn Afghan refugees in Pakistan, 1.5mn in Iran, and an estimated 1.5–2mn Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs). Many of these refugees (especially in Pakistan) were recruited into the various factions of the mujahideen.

In November 1986, at Soviet leader Gorbachev's urging, Muhammad Najibullah, former head of the Afghan secret police for most of the early 1980s, replaced Karmal as president of Afghanistan. Karmal went into quiet exile in the Soviet Union, where he would live (witnessing the collapse of the USSR) for another decade until his death by natural causes (unique for an Afghan leader in this era) in 1996. Gorbachev saw a stable and peaceful international situation as essential to his reformist goals. In February 1986 he famously referred to Afghanistan as a “bleeding wound”; talks for the withdrawal of the Soviet army began later that year. The USSR announced in February 1988 that Soviet troops would begin withdrawing in May and be completely out of Afghanistan by February 1989, thereby leaving Najibullah's communist government in power in Kabul without Soviet troops to support it. Najibullah's government survived for three years following the Soviet withdrawal, mainly because of massive Soviet military support and also because of continued divisions and infighting within the mujahadeen. Finally, in April 1992 mujahadeen forces advanced on Kabul and took control of the city. Najibullah sought refuge along with his brother and their families at the UN compound in Kabul.

The Rise of the Taliban

As soon as the Afghan communist government fell conflict began between the various mujahideen factions over who would rule the country. The mostly Tajik forces of Rabbani and Masood held nominal power between 1992–1996 but faced fierce opposition from Hekmatyar's Pashtun faction; there

was a constant shift in alliances with other key factions as well. Hekmatyar's forces constantly bombed the capital Kabul in a period of utter chaos and brutality that Afghans call "the Kabul Wars" (other cities were involved too, just not to the same degree). Under these conditions the Taliban, which had emerged as a small faction of the mujahideen during the Soviet War of the 1980s, took root and grew. The term "Talib" means "religious student," so "Taliban" means "student movement" or "religious student movement." The core membership of the Taliban as it drove to power comprised Afghan students from refugee camps in Pakistan.

The Pakistani government supported Hekmatyar's forces against first the Soviets and then the other mujahideen groups in the civil war of the early 1990s. However, the Pakistanis became disillusioned with Hekmatyar and switched their support to the Taliban in 1994, arming the group and allowing them to train at camps in Pakistan. Under Pakistan's tutelage, Taliban forces grew to about 20,000 within six months in 1994. Some of the Taliban's members were ethnic Pashtuns from Pakistan. With this support, the Taliban captured the major Afghan southern city of Kandahar in 1994 where they ended factional fighting but imposed a very harsh regime, including forbidding women to work and girls to attend school, forcing women to wear the burqa and people to pray at the appointed times (five times a day), banning music, television, kite flying, etc.

In September 1996 the Taliban captured Kabul. Two years later they seized Mazar-i-Sharif, the major city in the north, and carried out a brutal massacre, killing an estimated 6,000 Hazaras, presumably in retaliation for a massacre of some 2,000 Taliban fighters by Hazara and Uzbek forces the previous year. Meanwhile, Rabbani and Masood, still the internationally recognized leaders of the country and now calling themselves the Northern Alliance, controlled the northeast corner of the country and fighting continued there, but by the end of 1998 the Taliban controlled two-thirds of the country. Despite their control over most of the country, as noted only three countries in the world officially recognized the Taliban government of Afghanistan: Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates.

By the end of the 1990s/beginning of the 2000s Afghanistan was the world's largest producer of opium, responsible for about three-fourths of total global production. The Taliban took steps to eradicate opium production, as a result of which it dropped sharply in 2001. The US pledged \$43mn to the Taliban in support of its efforts to eliminate opium production in May 2001; however, the terrorist attacks on the US on September 11, 2001, changed everything. The US linked the attacks to Osama bin Laden, a Saudi terrorist who had fought against the Soviets (with US support) in the 1980s and had returned to take refuge in Afghanistan under Taliban rule. As a result, US-led NATO forces invaded Afghanistan in October 2001—the only time to date that Article Five of the NATO agreement was evoked—and forced the Taliban out of power.

The US/NATO War in Afghanistan

As the Taliban was losing its grip on power a conference was held in Bonn, Germany in early December 2001 to decide the fate of Afghanistan. A group of prominent Afghan leaders chose Hamid Karzai to lead a six-month transitional government. Karzai had spent most of the years of the Soviet-Afghan War in the 1980s in neighboring Pakistan. He initially supported the Taliban when it began consolidating power in the mid-1990s; however, he became disillusioned with the Taliban and returned to exile in Pakistan, where he began working for the Northern Alliance led by Masood and Rabbani. A *loya jirga* (tribal council) in July 2002 chose Karzai as head of a two-year transitional government of the Islamic Republic of Afghanistan, and then he won elections for a five-year term as president in October 2004.

A Taliban insurgency formed in the countryside and by 2005 violence in the country was on the rise. By 2008 the situation had deteriorated significantly. Corruption, linked to the production of opium, once again on the rise in the country, undermined the legitimacy of the Karzai government. A December 2009 report by *Transparency International*, which tracks corruption problems in the world's governments, listed Afghanistan as the second most corrupt country in the world (behind only Somalia, which as we discuss in a later chapter did not even have a functioning central government). Karzai's vice-president (one of several), former Defense Minister Mohammad Qasim Fahim, was widely believed to be involved in drug smuggling, along with several others in positions of leadership, including Karzai's half-brother, Ahmad Wali Karzai, Provincial Governor of Kandahar Province until his assassination in 2011.

Hamid Karzai was re-elected in 2009 amid accusations of election fraud. Meanwhile the Taliban insurgency continued and gradually strengthened amid ongoing corruption problems for the US/NATO-supported Afghan government. Karzai could not run for a third term in 2014, when elections were won (once again amid allegations of fraud) by Ashraf Ghani, an economist who had worked for the World Bank from 1991–2001 and briefly as Minister of Finance in post-Taliban Afghanistan in the early 2000s. Like his predecessor, Ghani proved unable to bring stability to the country either by curbing corruption, which remained a huge problem under his rule, or controlling the insurgency of the Taliban. His re-election in 2019 did not lead to improvements in the country and his tenure as president ended with the Taliban's takeover of power (again).

In August 2021 the Taliban seized the capital Kabul and returned to power after twenty years. US and remaining NATO forces left the country in a chaotic retreat, ending the longest war in US history in defeat. Since reclaiming power, the Taliban has gradually imposed many of its harsh policies from its earlier tenure, restricting young women's access to education (banning secondary school for girls) and greatly limiting their public employment

possibilities and forcing women to wear the burqa in public. The economy was on the brink of collapse after the withdrawal of US/NATO forces and international aid agencies but has stabilized somewhat (albeit at a very low level) since. On the one hand, Afghanistan is now finally at peace, but on the other hand Afghans must once again endure the harsh rule of the Taliban.



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Map 4.1 Map of China, Japan, and South Korea.

4 East Asia

China, Japan, Korea, and the Pacific Rim Countries

China

China, with its capital at Beijing and now the world's second largest population (behind India) at a little over 1.4bn, is the world's third largest country territorially (behind Russia and Canada) with a great deal of geographic variation, from the highest mountains in the world, the Himalayas (more correctly in Tibet, a disputed area under Chinese control since 1954), to one of the largest deserts in the world, the Gobi Desert in the North. One of the world's earliest settled agricultural societies, China's civilization from its beginning has been centered along the eastern coastal region in the rich river valleys (Yellow, Yangtze, Xi) suitable for rice production, which is where the vast majority of the country's population lives, making China's eastern seaboard one of the most densely populated areas of the world.

While China is shielded by the Himalayas and the Gobi Desert, in the north Manchuria and (farther north) Mongolia sit on flat grassland, making China open to invasion by outside forces from that direction. The grassland has historically been home to semi-nomadic herding peoples; many of history's greatest conquerors hailed from there (Atilla the Hun and Genghis Khan among others). The problem of outside invaders from the north was so pronounced that early Chinese emperors constructed a Great Wall with slave labor to block invaders from the north, considered one of history's greatest architectural achievements. The wall, however, did not keep invading armies at bay forever, and China's modern history was shaped to a significant degree by invasion from the north, specifically Manchuria—China's final dynasty in the modern era was formed in the mid-seventeenth century by the conquering Manchus. Owing to a history of invasion (as well as migration) by neighboring peoples there is some ethnic diversity in the country; the majority group (ethnic Hans—native Mandarin speakers, including its various dialects) make up about 91% of the population, but there are significant minority groups like the predominantly Muslim Uyghurs and Kazakhs in the west as well as Tibetans in the Southwest; Manchus, Mongols and Koreans in the north; and various smaller groups like the Manchu, Li, Yi, Dong and several others as well.

Modern communist China is officially an atheist state, but historically Buddhism was the dominant religion. The emperor ruled with a “Mandate from Heaven” believed to ensure the balance between Heaven and Earth. When that balance was disrupted, chaos ensued—rebellions, the rise of regional warlords and civil wars, until eventually the ruling dynasty crumbled and a new dynasty formed to take its place. Chinese political history functioned this way for thousands of years into the early twentieth century. Chinese society has historically been based on a peasant economy with rice, which is very labor intensive, as the main food crop. The overwhelming majority of the population worked as peasants in the agricultural economy to sustain a non-laboring elite comprised of a gentry of rural landowners/moneylenders, and a very small ruling elite of extremely wealthy landowners and the royal family. A small urban segment of merchants, moneylenders, and artisans made up the rest of the population.

Peasants are people residing in rural villages and engaging in agricultural production. There is tremendous differentiation *within* China’s vast peasant majority with rich peasants (those with enough land that they needed to hire laborers to work it), middle peasants (those with just enough land to sustain themselves), and poor peasants (those with either no land or so little land that they had to hire themselves out as laborers on other’s lands). There were also significant regional differences—in the south where the land is better peasants tended to own less of it whereas in the north where the land is not as good peasants owned more land but had to take loans at very high rates of interest (usury) from local gentry/merchants/moneylenders to farm it year-to-year. China’s peasants historically lived communally (typical for peasant societies around the world), in mostly closed, self-sufficient villages with a built-in safety net that kept poor peasants from falling below a level of basic subsistence because villages needed the labor of the collective as a whole (there were exceptions to this during crises/famines).

China and the West

The decline of China and its final dynasty, the Qing (Manchu) dynasty, coincided with the rise of Europe, especially after 1800 with the onset of industrialization in the West. Europeans had long been eager to trade in China, and began doing so on a small scale in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries; however, there was no demand in China for European goods and as a result Europeans could not raise the money they needed in China to buy the silks, porcelain, tea, and other Chinese items that were in *very* high demand back in Europe. The Europeans needed something they could supply to China that would boost their trading position.

The British fell upon that “something” finally at the end of the eighteenth century—opium! In the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries the British began growing opium as a cash crop on a large scale in India and selling it as a narcotic in China, where previously it had been used for

medicinal purposes. By the early nineteenth century opium smoking had become an epidemic in China along the southern coastal regions in most direct contact with the British/Europeans, causing major social problems. The British interpreted the opium trade in purely business terms, whereas Chinese officials, seeing the impact that the opium epidemic was having in China, saw the issue in *moral* terms; thus, it was difficult for the Chinese and the British to see eye-to-eye on this matter.

In 1838 the Chinese Emperor banned the sale and use of opium in China. The British went to war (First Opium War, 1839–1840; Second Opium War 1856, which also included the French) to guarantee their right to sell it in China—all under a claim to the right to “free trade.” The Europeans won easily and forced the Chinese to sign a series of treaties legalizing opium and giving the British control over several port cities, including Hong Kong. The Opium Wars illustrate China’s decline vis-à-vis the West. Based on a series of these so-called “unequal treaties,” China became a “semi-colony” of the West (mainly Britain); it was not colonized (in contrast to India, Southeast Asia, and much of the rest of the world), but Europeans controlled China’s major seaports and thereby gained a political foothold as well. The West’s impact did not greatly alter the traditional forms of Chinese agriculture as it had in India with the large-scale introduction of cash crops. There was an increase in the production and export of certain cash crops, especially tea. But this did not entail a transformation of traditional Chinese agriculture as it had for India because tea had already been grown in China for a long time and because it was still grown on a relatively small scale (it did not significantly displace the cultivation of rice or other food crops).

Over the latter half of the nineteenth century China continued to decline, suffering a major military defeat at the end of the century to another, much smaller Asian nation, Japan. China’s loss in the Sino-Japanese War (1894–95), which we return to in greater detail later in the chapter, illustrated how far China had weakened while showing how far Japan had risen because of its willingness to adopt Westernizing reforms. By the turn of the century the Western powers (including the US) forced an “open door” policy on China, trade on whatever terms the European countries dictated, and the Chinese were in no position to resist another blow to their sovereignty. China was changing very dramatically in the early twentieth century, but for the country’s age-old dynastic system it proved to be too little too late: China’s final dynasty, the Manchu Qing dynasty, collapsed in the Revolution of 1912, led by Sun Yat-sen, a Western (US)-educated doctor who tried to introduce parliamentary democracy in China. The attempt failed and plunged the country into decades of chaos, civil war, and eventually revolution.

Warlordism, the KMT, and the CCP

The collapse of the Manchu Qing dynasty in 1912 ushered in an era of regionally based “warlordism” with the lack of a strong centralized government in

China and local strongmen commanding militias to rule small fiefdoms at the provincial level. China's two most important political parties also formed at the time, and Sun Yat-sen was at the center of those developments. Sun was not a communist; he always held to his original belief in Western parliamentary democracy. But he accepted the need for relative economic equality and a strong government role in redistributing land and wealth, and he was impressed by what he saw taking place in Russia with its 1917 Bolshevik Revolution led by Lenin. Sun Yat-sen liked Lenin's concept of a tightly-knit, highly disciplined vanguard party organization. In 1918 he formed the Kuomintang (KMT) or Nationalist Party (NP); when he died in 1925 leadership of the party passed to his son-in-law, Chiang Kai-shek.

Meanwhile, two Chinese intellectuals and a Soviet agent formed the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) in 1921; the KMT and CCP initially formed a coalition or alliance (First United Front) in the 1920s because they both wanted to oust the various warlords and re-establish a strong centralized government. However, this First United Front did not last; in 1927 the KMT and CCP succeeded in consolidating central control of China by either defeating (or buying off) all of the regional warlords. Chiang Kai-shek's forces held the upper hand as China basically fell under his control at the time. Afterward Chiang Kai-shek turned against his erstwhile "allies" within the CCP and, looking upon them as his main political rival now that the warlords had been defeated, carried out a massacre of communists throughout the country in 1928 but especially in Shanghai where their numbers were strongest. Chiang Kai-shek's KMT forces massacred thousands of communists in what became known as the "White Terror."

The CCP was surprised by the attack and felt betrayed; also, while it was a small party to begin with, their numbers were greatly reduced by the attack. Chiang evidently intended to eliminate the CCP all at once and thereby get rid of a potential opposition force. The "White Terror" marked the end of the First United Front and the beginning of civil war between the CCP and KMT. It also led to the CCP's shift away from the cities and toward the countryside. A young communist party leader in the 1920s, Mao Zedong, promoted this shift. Mao was from a peasant background in Hunan province. He argued that China's communist movement should be based on the rural peasantry, not urban industrial workers. After all, the vast majority of China's population were rural peasants, *not* urban workers, whose numbers were tiny overall. Mao did not exclude workers from his revolutionary picture; he saw them as an important urban base for revolution, but the industrial working class was clearly of secondary importance for Mao compared to the peasantry. The peasants were going to rise up against their exploiters in any case, Mao argued, and it would be better for the CCP to be at the front of that movement, as the "vanguard" of the revolutionary peasantry, rather than following behind.

Thus, Mao adapted Marxist thought to fit the needs of China by looking for support among the peasants, and this is by far his most important

ideological legacy. As we have seen, Marxism is a theory based on the rise of the industrial working class; Marx saw peasants as ignorant, backward, and politically reactionary—the class of the past—and believed that they would be transformed during the process of industrialization as they migrated to the cities to become workers. Mao's strategy to seek support for a communist movement among the peasantry is completely alien to anything Marx had ever fathomed. In 1931 Mao and the CCP declared the first "Soviet," a Russian term that literally means "council" or "people's committee," though in the Chinese context it meant "liberated area"; it was a sizable rural area in Southeastern China that the CCP controlled, winning the support of the poor peasants there by carrying out land reform. Chiang responded by sending KMT forces to attack CCP supporters, thereby initiating civil war between the KMT and CCP. In September 1931, the Japanese invaded and occupied Manchuria in the North, but Chiang decided to concentrate his military efforts against the CCP, leaving the Japanese mostly with a free hand in Manchuria.

KMT forces defeated the CCP in the South, forcing the communists in 1934–35 to flee thousands of miles to the North on the "Long March." The CCP fought KMT and Japanese troops along the way and lost thousands of followers. When they began there were 100,000 CCP members and supporters on the march; when they arrived at their destination at Yen'an in the Northern area of Shensi Province fifteen months later there were 30,000. They left people in villages along the way to organize and propagate the CCP's ideas, but most of the loss was due to hunger, disease, and fighting. Once they arrived in the north Mao and his supporters formed a new Soviet and vowed to continue their struggle against Chiang and the KMT. The long march is highly significant in the political lore of communist China and was a *major* formative experience for the country's future political leadership. Soon thereafter the KMT and CCP allied again in the Second United Front to fight against Japan, which invaded Northern and Central China in 1937 and carried out a number of atrocities, including the infamous "Rape of Nanking" in the city that had been Chiang Kai-shek's capital.

World War II and Civil War

When global war broke out in 1939 and the US was drawn into the Pacific theater (after the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor in December 1941), the US supported the CCP with weapons and other materials. US State Department documents from the time indicate that the CCP was a far better fighting force than the KMT in the war with Japan. Mao's Red Army forces were looked upon as a valuable ally in the war against Japan (similar as we will see to Ho Chi Minh's Viet Minh in neighboring Vietnam). As Chiang Kai-shek had feared, the Second United Front and the war against Japan greatly helped the cause of Mao and the communists as membership in the CCP increased from an estimated 10,000 in 1937 to over 800,000 in 1945. World War II

strengthened the CCP while weakening the KMT because the communists were seen as the defenders of the poor, while the KMT's base of support came mostly from landlords, wealthy merchants, and the country's few industrialists. The CCP also won the support of nationalistic gentry youth (the elite) by fighting more ardently against the Japanese. Chiang Kai-shek's KMT, on the other hand, was seen as too inept, corrupt, and bureaucratic to effectively fight the Japanese. Many KMT supporters even collaborated with the Japanese during occupation, which also worsened their image among the population.

So, when World War II ended in 1945 the CCP was stronger than ever. By early 1946 the Second United Front was over and fighting between the two sides, the CCP and KMT, began again in a renewed round of civil war between the two. Despite strong US support, Chiang's KMT forces lost; mainland China was in the hands of the CCP and Mao Zedong, who proclaimed it the People's Republic of China on October 1, 1949. Chiang Kai-shek and his KMT forces fled to Taiwan (formerly Formosa). The ethnic Chinese (Han) coming to the island under Chiang's command massacred thousands in Formosa in the late 1940s and early 1950s. The 1949 Chinese Revolution also had major reverberations back in the US, as it was widely believed that the US had "lost" China to the communists, contributing to the rise of the "Red Scare" (McCarthyism) of the early 1950s.

The 1949 Revolution—*Fanshen*

The term the Chinese often used to describe the revolutionary changes in their country, especially the land reform in the countryside, was "*fanshen*," which means "turning over." In the Land Reform Campaign (1949–52), more than one-third of the land changed hands. However, the categories imposed on the countryside in the Land Reform Campaign—landlord; rich, middle, and poor peasant—did not always correspond to circumstances in the villages; it was often difficult to tell if someone was a landlord or rich peasant, a rich or middle peasant, and so on. The campaign led to brutality and repression, especially for those labeled landlords (tens of thousands were killed). It amounted to a complete overturn of the old system and social order; land ownership had always been at the heart of power in old, feudal Chinese society, so by redistributing land the new communist regime was redistributing political power.

Almost as soon as the CCP solidified its control of the Chinese mainland it faced a major foreign policy challenge—the Korean War. The war, which we examine more closely in the section on Korea, began in June 1950 when troops from the communist, pro-Soviet North Korea invaded the pro-US South Korea, sparking the first major Cold War proxy war. The two Koreas formally divided in 1948 as Cold War tensions between the former allies, the US and USSR, grew. The UN sent an "international police force" to help South Korea, with US troops playing the main role therein. The Korean War,

which ended in a stalemate in 1953, was the first major international geopolitical challenge for communist China, whose intervention in the war played a decisive role, and the conflict marked communist China's emergence as a formidable military power in Asia. The conflict also had strong domestic implications for China, leading to a hardening of domestic policies.

Constant Revolution

Hundred Flowers Campaign (1956)

As the Korean War was underway Chinese society was changing dramatically. The centralization of the economy under a planned, command economic structure produced social side effects and political problems, creating a large, cumbersome bureaucratic apparatus and a managerial, party elite based mostly in the cities. Reflecting this social development, the CCP in the 1950s split into two factions: the Maoists, under Mao's leadership, which continued to look to the countryside and the peasants as their base of support, including the People's Liberation Army (PLA) comprised mostly of peasants; and the "Modernists," led by Liu Shaoqi and Deng Xiaoping, whose support came from urban-based intellectuals and the bureaucratic party elite. Although Mao was the revered and uncontested leader for most people in China, this political divide is at the root of China's struggles in the years to come.

After the revolution Mao wrote about post-revolutionary "contradictions" in Chinese society, contradictions between the bureaucratic party elite and the peasant masses, between the countryside and cities, between manual and mental labor. These contradictions, Mao argued, threatened to undermine China's path to socialism and set the country on a revisionist, capitalist course. The contradictions had to be "nipped in the bud," Mao argued, or they threatened to undermine the new country's efforts to build socialism. Thus, Mao's rule was guided by the concept of "Constant Revolution," his belief that Chinese society had to be constantly "shaken up" or jolted by the leadership to overcome the post-Revolutionary contradictions threatening to undermine China's path to socialism and set the country on a revisionist, capitalist course.

Mao also believed in the power of humanity to alter even the natural environment, a direct negation of Confucian-Buddhist thought on the need for harmony between humanity and nature. A shining example of a Maoist campaign with often misplaced enthusiasm was the "Kill a sparrow campaign" of the mid-1950s: Mao argued that grain harvests would be much higher if not for those pesky sparrows eating up all the grain, so he launched this campaign to kill sparrows (along with other "pests"). Children, party administrators, everyone killed birds with rifles or slingshots. Unfortunately, however, because there were fewer sparrows that year there were far more worms than usual and they wound up eating a much larger percentage of the grain in storage.

Another Maoist campaign was the “Hundred Flowers Campaign,” which began in 1956. The name came from an ancient Confucian saying, “Let a hundred flowers blossom, let a hundred schools of thought contend.” Mao invited party members and others in this campaign to criticize party leaders, to “Let a Hundred Flowers Bloom” by openly stating their problems with party rule and then helping to correct those problems. The political intent was to focus criticism on the “modernist” faction in the party bureaucracy, the group that Mao felt threatened China’s peasant revolution and his own political standing. He expected the complaints to be directed at his political rivals but was surprised to receive much more far-reaching criticisms. When people called the communist party’s leadership into question, Mao made an abrupt policy shift and turned against those he had encouraged to openly criticize the regime. He repressed many who had spoken up as the Hundred Flowers Campaign morphed into the Anti-Rightist Campaign.

Great Leap Forward (1958–62)

Soon after the dust settled on the Hundred Flowers/Anti-Rightest Campaigns, Mao unleashed one of his most adventurous and, as it turned out, extremely disastrous campaigns: the Great Leap Forward (GLF, 1958–62). Mao instigated this ambitious campaign to completely collectivize agriculture (the process of collectivization, which began just a few years after the Land Reform, had been very slow prior to this) and to industrialize the vast Chinese countryside with small “backyard furnaces” for steel production. The policy was officially adopted at Mao’s insistence at the Party Congress in May 1958. Within months almost all peasants in China were organized into collective farms, which included communal meals and communal childcare. The program was based on the idea of using local resources and developing agriculture and industry simultaneously; it was also based on a relatively low-tech, labor-intensive approach, rather than the high-tech, capital-intensive approach to economic development favored by the “modernist” faction. Mao felt China had a large pool of labor to draw from—its great advantage as he saw it—but very little wealth and few developed resources. China’s population problems in the decades since are in part rooted in Mao’s policies at this time and later: Mao encouraged population growth because he believed that a large pool of labor could overcome China’s relative technological backwardness.

The decision to introduce the GLF had major geopolitical implications, specifically regarding China’s relations with its major communist ally since the 1949 Revolution, the USSR. Mao began the GLF in part because of his increasing dissatisfaction with the Soviet model of economic development; he wanted to pursue a unique path to industrialization. A split had been slowly brewing between the PRC and USSR since 1956 when Stalin’s successor Khrushchev made his “secret speech” denouncing Stalin. Mao showed deference to Stalin as the leader of international communism but he apparently despised Khrushchev. Mao argued that Khrushchev was leading

the USSR toward capitalist “revisionism,” which was exactly what he said about his own internal political opponents, the “modernists” Liu and Deng. The GLF finalized the split between the PRC and the USSR because it was a direct rejection of the urban-based Soviet model of industrialization. The Soviets thought the policy foolhardy and in 1960 pulled their technical staff out of China and ended all material assistance, leaving some factories half-built. The two countries remained enemies thereafter, with the world’s most militarized border being between them during the Cold War.

The GLF had successful aspects to it, mainly in service-oriented, “light” or consumer industry: food processing, manufacturing and textiles. Overall, however, it was an economic failure—even a disaster for China—mostly because of peasant resistance and because small-scale production for most goods proved highly inefficient. Peasants set up thousands of small steel-producing furnaces in villages all over the country. Untrained to do such work, they spent a lot of time working in the “backyard steel furnaces” and neglected agricultural production. People melted down anything and everything they had for the steel furnaces, including their cooking woks. The steel produced proved to be of poor quality—much of it was unusable. The campaign culminated in a famine that led to an estimated 20–30mn deaths, still considered the worst famine in human history; the famine was due to the fact that the state based its rate of taxation (i.e., seizure of food) from the collective farms on exaggerated production sums, confiscating most of what the peasants had produced, thereby leaving them with very little to eat and/or plant the following year. The disaster was further compounded by a drought that struck Eurasia at the time.

As a result of this disastrous program Mao resigned as Chairman of the People’s Republic, though he maintained the more important post of CCP chairman. Thus, Mao’s political fortunes decreased, while those of Liu and Deng, the leaders of the “modernist” faction and Mao’s main internal political rivals and opponents, increased, and in the early 1960s there was a relative return to “normalcy.” Mao, however, continued to promote his concept of “constant revolution” against the threat of “revisionism” and a return to capitalism (by the modernists, he argued) in China. A cult of Mao began forming in communist China symbolized by the Little Red Book of Mao’s sayings published in early 1964 by the PLA, led by Mao’s close ally Lin Biao.

The Cultural Revolution

The rise of the cult of Mao set the stage for another disastrous Maoist campaign, the Cultural Revolution. After the failure of the GLF, Liu and Deng resumed a centralized approach to economic production and restored economic growth to the country. However, the wealth generated in that economic growth was unevenly distributed, and therein, for Mao, lay the problem. He began to argue again that the “modernizers” were leading China back to capitalism, with the party bureaucracy forming a new elite or bourgeoisie.

Mao sought support for an attack on the party bureaucracy among the army, comprised mostly of peasants from the countryside. With the support of the army, led by his ally Lin Biao, Mao began purging the party leadership in August 1966. Violence broke out around the country as Mao's supporters attacked party bureaucrats. In addition to the army and the peasants, Mao sought support from the country's youth, especially urban youth because that is where the support base of his political enemies was centered, in the cities, and he needed someone to crush that power base. Maoists formed "Red Guard" units of high school and university students to carry out attacks on their teachers and professors and local party bureaucrats. They found support in some cases even among the children of the people under attack as the Cultural Revolution broke up families in China.

The Cultural Revolution was a political conflict played out on a social level between Mao with his support base (peasants, army, youth) and Liu with his support base (party administrators). In one of the many bizarre aspects of the Cultural Revolution, the situation in Beijing and Shanghai in 1967 reached such absurd proportions that Red Guards forced the traffic administrations to reverse the meaning of stop lights: red, they argued, should not mean "stop," since as the color of communism it should be associated with movement and progress. Thus, for a brief time in these two cities red lights meant "go" and green lights meant "stop," but the policy was quickly reversed because it led to too many traffic accidents! In 1967 the Red Guards split into factions, each claiming to be more loyal to Mao and more truly revolutionary, and fighting broke out between different Red Guard units. The fractionalization among the Red Guard units was partly because at first they were comprised mostly of the sons and daughters of high party officials, the very segment Mao was attacking. But as the Cultural Revolution deepened, these early Red Guards were labeled too conservative because many of them were hesitant to denounce their own parents, and thus a more radical phase began led by the sons and daughters of lower party officials or non-party figures.

In the fall of 1967 Mao carried out the most thorough purge of the communist party apparatus in China to date. The main leaders of the modernist faction, Liu Shaoqi and Deng Xiaoping, had already been removed from positions of power, but the party apparatus still had a large number of people within the modernist camp to deal with. Thousands of party officials were exiled to rural re-education/manual labor camps, where Mao believed bureaucrats and intellectuals would be purified of "bourgeois" thoughts if they worked alongside peasants. This purge had a very disruptive effect because of the rapid turnover of experienced personnel in positions of responsibility. New people (many of them with either PLA or Red Guard experience) were put in charge of important positions in the administration of the economy and their inexperience contributed to mounting problems in production brought about by the Cultural Revolution. Consequently, most of the party officials "sent-down" to the countryside were quickly rehabilitated and brought back into the party bureaucracy; except for extreme cases,

officials spent anywhere from six months to two years in the camps before being rehabilitated. By the end of 1970 an estimated 95% were restored to good standing.

In short, like the Hundred Flowers Campaign and the GLF, the Cultural Revolution went farther than Mao intended, and in 1969 with China near the brink of civil war due to fighting between rival Red Guard units Mao had to call upon the PLA to restore order. China's leaders were worried about the steady buildup of Soviet troops along the border and did not like the precedent set by Soviet intervention to put down Czechoslovakia's "Prague Spring" in the summer of 1968. In March 1969 Chinese and Soviet troops clashed on an island in the disputed Ussuri River border area, which illustrated the need for domestic stability. Thus, Mao's retreat from the radical phase of the Cultural Revolution was due at least partly to the perceived threat of the USSR, which, as we will see, eventually turns Mao toward the US.

By 1969 the Red Guards units, which Mao had *created* in order to carry out his political will, were spreading chaos in China's major urban areas. Mao ordered them to turn in all their weapons and disband. Millions of these youths from the Red Guards were subsequently sent to rural areas as part of the next phase in Mao's Cultural Revolution—"making revolution in the countryside." Shipping youth to the countryside solved the problem of bringing them under control—Mao thereby broke the power of the youth he had used to attack the party bureaucracy.

The Cultural Revolution, in sum, was very chaotic, and many victims and victims' families are still very bitter about it. Estimates are that between 1966–69 there were somewhere between 2–7mn deaths. But despite all the instability and turbulence the Cultural Revolution had positive aspects for Mao politically: he had broken the power of his main political rivals, Liu and Deng. Liu died in house arrest in the late 1960s and Deng was sent to a rural re-education camp along with millions of other party administrators. The worst of the violence of the Cultural Revolution was under control by 1970.

In the early 1970s there were still two clearly discernable factions within the party's leadership, the more radical faction or "Maoists" headed by Mao and his allies and a more moderate faction, the "modernists," led by Zhou Enlai. The moderates gradually gained the upper hand, as evident in a major foreign policy move promoted by Zhou: the PRC's normalization of relations with the US driven largely by China's perception of the USSR as a major threat. China looked to the US at this time to balance its position against the USSR. In 1973 the US under President Nixon finally agreed to allow the mainland communist government to take over China's seat on the UN Security Council, which since 1949 had been held by Taiwan. However, China and the US did not officially begin diplomatic relations until the Taiwan Relations Act (1979) under the administration of US President Jimmy Carter and Chinese leader Deng Xiaoping, which clarified the question of US-Taiwanese relations by expressing that US involvement in China would continue along with US friendship with Taiwan.

In 1973 Deng Xiaoping began to reappear in Chinese leadership circles. The semi-retirement of Mao and the support of Zhou Enlai facilitated the rehabilitation of Deng, who had been close friends with Zhou since the 1920s when they studied together in Paris. With Zhou's support Deng was re-elected to the Politburo in 1975. Zhou was dying of cancer and he wanted a pragmatist like Deng Xiaoping in a position of leadership to counter the expected power play of the radical faction after his and Mao's death; Zhou was setting Deng up as his successor and, he hoped, as China's next leader.

Deng Xiaoping's Reforms

Zhou Enlai's hopes came true as Deng eventually emerged in the power struggle following Mao's death in 1976 (Zhou had died a few months earlier) to lead China on a dramatic reform program. In the late 1970s there was a general loosening of Chinese society as even disco became popular. People were encouraged to talk about their victimization during the Cultural Revolution and a wave of so-called "wound" or "scar" literature was published about people's experiences and suffering during Mao's reign, especially the Cultural Revolution. Deng's political outlook was one of pragmatism—the belief that economics was more important than ideology. Deng's economic policies can be summed up in his famous saying: "It doesn't matter if a cat is black or white, as long as it catches mice." In other words, it does not matter if you call the Chinese economic system "socialist" or "capitalist" as long as it works and produces prosperity. Deng himself said his goal was to create "Chinese socialism," but his policies implemented a form of "mixed socialism" or "mixed economy"—private ownership mixed with a strong state sector. Deng began his rule by enacting gradual economic reforms, but he never opened China's political system, maintaining the CCP's dictatorship in the country (his reign, drawing an analogy with the Soviet Union, has been called *perestroika* without *glasnost*).

Once he consolidated political power, Deng set about reforming China's economy and society in very fundamental ways. His most significant reforms were in the economic realm and he began by carrying out sweeping changes in the agricultural sector. Instead of working the fields collectively, families and households could sign contracts to cultivate a portion of land as if it were their own; initially contracts for land were handed out on a short-term, one-to-three-year basis. According to the contracts, peasant households agreed to meet a specified quota or tax set by the government (based on how much land they received, which depended on the number of laborers within the household and other factors). Anything the peasants produced above that set quota could be sold at the marketplace. In the early 1980s the government increased the contractual period for land to fifteen years and the program began to develop rapidly. This and other related reforms contributed to increased agricultural production in the 1980s; one estimate for the early

stages of the reform puts the increase in agricultural production at 36% between 1978–83.

In industry China's reformers decentralized decision-making power and allowed the opening of small privately-owned businesses, mostly in the service sector at first such as inns, restaurants, tailor's shops, barber shops, repair shops—all sorts of shop sprang up. Gradually these took hold within small industries such as textile manufacturing plants as well. The number of private businesses in China grew from 1mn in 1981 to 3.4mn in 1984. In 1981 the state announced the end of guaranteed employment for workers, which had been one of the basic features of the socialist state since 1949 (the "iron rice bowl"). The state closed unprofitable businesses and factories that could not be converted to profitable semi-private ownership, which increased unemployment in the country in the 1980s.

In 1980 the Chinese government created the country's first Special Economic Zone (SEZs), Shenzhen near Hong Kong, to entice foreign investment and promote exports by allowing production with little government regulation (given the old unfair treaty-port system with the colonial powers in the days of semi-colonialism this was a sensitive issue). Foreign companies investing in China had to enter joint-ownership agreements with the government (which maintained a majority 51% control of these businesses) and had to agree to abide by Chinese law. As a result of all these changes, China became more closely linked to the world economy throughout the 1980s, and its trade with the US increased dramatically—from \$1.1mn in 1978 to \$4.5mn in 1983. China's trade with Japan, Taiwan, and Western Europe increased at a similar pace.

Deng's reforms also affected Chinese society in very direct ways, aside from these economic factors. For example, he imposed a one-child policy on Chinese families, which was particularly difficult to enforce in rural areas. If a couple's first child was a daughter, they were likely to try again for a son; true too if their second, third, and fourth births were daughters. Sons are vitally important in Chinese culture because they carry the family name and thus "open the door," as the Chinese say, to future generations of the family line. Sons were also important because of the labor power they provide on the newly minted farms granted to peasants by the agricultural reforms, so in some sense these major reform efforts contradicted one another. In some cases in rural areas (especially) parents who had a daughter would abandon her with a family they knew to be childless. The Chinese government ended its one-child policy in 2016.

Tiananmen Square Protests (1989)

Politically Deng's government faced a huge challenge in the 1989 Tiananmen Square Protests that began April 15. The funeral of a popular leader, Hu Yaobang, who had openly supported student protests for democratic reform

three years earlier, sparked the protests. They started mainly among the student population but soon involved workers as well, posing a serious threat to the CCP's rule. A week into the protests a major workers' union made a statement criticizing the government and announcing its support for the students' demands. In late April Soviet reformist leader Gorbachev visited China and protesters enthusiastically chanted "Gorbie! Gorbie!" In May student leaders began a hunger strike.

The government's crackdown on the protests began June 3. The regime called on troops from outlying regions brought into Beijing in recent days, *not* the troops who had been garrisoned in the city (and thus courted by the protesters) during the demonstrations. The troops brutally crushed the demonstrations. The government admitted a few deaths, whereas protesters estimated the numbers at between 200 and 4,000. Those numbers are still in dispute, and we will never know for sure how many protesters died that horrid night. The government followed up by arresting countless students, workers, and other participants. It drew up a list of the twenty-one most active leaders and called for their arrest. To round up participants the government utilized US-made surveillance equipment placed all over Tiananmen Square after student protests three years earlier in 1986. In the West it was widely perceived that the Tiananmen Square protests were for "democracy," and while that was basically true, it bears noting again that "democracy" is a relative concept defined differently by different people. Student demonstrators at Tiananmen Square did not necessarily have Western-style democracy in mind. The protesters mixed ideas of social and economic equality with ideas of political freedom, i.e., the concept of "socialist democracy."

The economic reforms of the 1980s created some major problems, leading to inflation, unemployment, corruption, and a noticeable and growing gap between rich and poor. Corruption was a major theme of criticism for protesters. Party officials and their friends and relatives had access to the documents necessary to start import/export businesses; in the system created by Deng's reforms this meant people with the right connections could buy goods at low, fixed state prices and resale them at much higher prices either as exports abroad or domestically on the flourishing market economy. In this sense the state subsidized the party elite as it grew even wealthier at the expense of workers and others. Thus, protesters defined "democracy" in economic as well as political terms. They were responding to the West, for example with posters and signs written in English. But what they called "democracy"—political rights mixed with economic rights and concerns—does not necessarily correspond to the Western idea of democracy, at least not exactly.

Lurking over the protests was a huge portrait of Mao hanging prominently in Tiananmen Square. At face value (and from a Western point of view) you might expect Chinese students demanding "democracy" to have opposed Mao's legacy, and perhaps even to have damaged his picture, in much the same way protesters in Russia destroyed statues of Soviet leaders two years

later in 1991. In one incident some protesters tried to damage the painting of Mao by splattering red paint on it, but others in the square intervened and stopped them and formed a unit of students to guard Mao's portrait. The complaints of the protesters were in many ways comparable to what Mao himself had said—their criticisms aimed at corrupt, elitist party bureaucrats are very reminiscent of Mao's rhetoric. Thus, many of the protesters were as much in line with Maoism as with Western democracy.

In the years following the Tiananmen Square incident China's leaders reached a sort of informal agreement with society: economic prosperity in exchange for no more protests or demands for political change/democratization. And, indeed, the next three decades brought tremendous economic growth and development to China. Deng Xiaoping died in March 1997, and was replaced by Jiang Zemin, who maintained the course of economic reform and political dictatorship. A Chinese Party Congress in 2002 confirmed another shift in the country's leadership, with Jiang Zemin stepping aside in favor of the younger Hu Jintao. Xi Jinping took over as China's leader in 2012. The course of market reforms and modernization has continued (the "Modernizers" have clearly won), creating tremendous economic growth and development.

Reflecting the increase in trade between the US and China, which grew significantly in the 1980s and exploded in the 1990s and after, by 2004 Walmart, the largest private employer in the US at the time representing 2% of its overall GDP, bought 80% of its goods from Chinese suppliers. In 2004 IBM announced the sale of its personal computer business to Lenovo, a Chinese company, marking an important shift in China's economic development toward increasingly high-tech industries (as opposed to low-tech manufacturing sectors). Lenovo today is the world's largest producer of laptop computers. Another key turning point was the 2008 Summer Olympics in Beijing, widely seen as China's arrival on the world scene. This was soon followed in late 2008/early 2009 by the global financial crisis/Great Recession, which changed how Chinese leaders saw the US—no longer as a model to be emulated, but rather as an example to be avoided. China decided that the best course of action was to double down on its mixed economy—market forces (now 90% of the country's jobs are within the private sector) combined with strong elements of state control over land, energy resources, the financial system, and other key sectors of the economy, especially given that its economy was the only major economy in the world to continue economic growth—albeit at a lower level—throughout the entire crisis.

In 2010 China surpassed Japan to become the world's second largest economy behind only the US. China's decision to shift from low-tech manufacturing to high-tech economic development puts it on a course to compete directly with the US, sparking increasing tensions. Low-tech manufacturing continues in China and remains its economic bread-and-butter as the trade deficit between the US and China has continued to grow over the years, despite efforts (especially during US President Trump's first term) to curtail it.

The trade deficit between the US and China declined from its peak in 2018 but remains high. China's middle class is now bigger than the entire US population and the country's economy is growing twice as fast, making it a very attractive market for US companies. China's population is more than four times bigger than that of the US, and overall it is becoming more affluent as the country's economy grows.

Thus, the US trade relationship with China started out more or less mutually beneficial—in the 1980s–90s China benefited from jobs and economic growth and development by exporting inexpensive goods to the US, keeping prices in the US down and inflation at bay, while in return US investors received cheap labor and access to a massive Chinese market and profited greatly from it, albeit at the cost of US manufacturing jobs. That relationship, however, is changing to see which country, China, the US, or possibly someone else (Japan) will lead the way technologically in the twenty-first century. China's Belt and Road Initiative, launched in 2014, provides investments for development (and, of course, influence and benefits for China) in more than 120 countries around the world. China is also still developing its own internal frontier with completion in 2012 of the Three Gorges Dam, which produces huge amounts of energy and promises to open a sparsely populated part of the country to further development.

A negative aspect of China's economic development, much of which has been powered by cheap coal, is its awful environmental impact. There have been improvements in this regard in recent years (the country is importing more natural gas, producing electric cars and building up mass transit), but air pollution is still consistently well above levels considered safe for breathing in major cities and industrial centers. Finally (last but not least), another issue is China's continued repression of political dissidents of various stripes, including ethnic minorities, especially the Muslim Uyghurs in Western China, who have resisted Chinese control in various ways—including some who resort to violence—since at least the 1990s. In recent years the Chinese government has rounded up Uyghurs and resettled them in indoctrination camps that, among other things, force feed them pork, taboo for Muslims for religious reasons. In addition, China has faced challenges in recent years in Hong Kong and the possibility of a revived democracy movement always looms beneath the surface. There is little doubt that China will be one of the most powerful and important countries of the twenty-first century.

Korea: A Nation Divided

Korea is located at a crucial crossroads next to China, which greatly influenced its history from very early on. Japan is also close by, but despite its proximity the Pacific island nation did *not* play a pivotal role in Korean history—the Korean straits between the two is infamously difficult to navigate—until the modern era, from the late nineteenth-early twentieth centuries, when Japan dominated the course of Korean history (in the late sixteenth century a

Japanese leader tried to invade Korea but Korean forces soundly defeated the Japanese invaders as they came ashore). Russia was also a crucial part of the mix in the modern era (it shares an eleven-mile border with North Korea) as it spread east across Asia in the area of the Korean Peninsula.

The physical geography of the Korean Peninsula consists mostly of hills and mountains separated by deep, narrow valleys, with coastal plains in the east and west serving as the main areas of rice cultivation historically. The major mountain ranges include the Nangnim Mountains in the north-central part of North Korea, which run down the spine of the Peninsula in a north-south direction, making communication between the eastern and western parts of the country difficult historically. The Kangnam Range, which runs along the North Korean-Chinese border, offers some defense from Chinese attack (though without blocking Chinese influence). As a result of the Peninsula's mountainous terrain most of the population inhabits the lowlands on either side of the main mountain ranges, making population density in those areas quite high, especially around Seoul, the capital of South Korea (the country has a total population of around 51mn as of 2025), and Pyongyang, the capital of North Korea (the country has a total population of around 26.5mn).

The populations of both North and South Korea are largely homogenous ethnically as the vast majority of both countries are Korean with small minorities of Chinese and Japanese. The Korean spoken language is distantly related to Japanese and unrelated to Chinese. Most of East Asia adopted the Chinese system of writing based on symbols rather than an alphabet, which facilitated the spread of Chinese culture throughout East Asia. The vast majority of the Korean Peninsula's population are Buddhists, again reflecting Chinese influence as it spread from there, but in the modern era Christian missionaries have converted about one-fourth of the population to Christianity, mostly Protestant denominations. In communist North Korea today people are officially atheist and do not ascribe openly to any particular faith.

In the late nineteenth/early twentieth centuries there was a battle for control of Korea, which found itself caught between more powerful neighbors, primarily Russia and, in particular, Japan, and, to a much lesser degree China. The latter as we saw was weakened and reeling from the impact of the West, internal divisions, and its own gradual decline. As noted earlier in this chapter the first of two major wars over Korea, the Sino-Japanese War (1894–95), pitted China against Japan but was fought almost entirely on Korean soil. Although an independent kingdom, Korea had been a tributary state of China, meaning that its leaders paid an annual tribute tax—extracted from the population of course—to China for centuries and the Japanese wanted to seize control of Korea (and also the island Formosa, modern-day Taiwan).

In the final decades of the nineteenth century Japan concentrated on modernizing its military forces, especially its navy, which gave it a great advantage over the Chinese when war for control of Korea erupted between the two. The Japanese scored early victories in the south before routing the retreating

Chinese forces at Pyongyang, assuring victory for Japan. After a little over six months of fighting (July 1894 to February 1895) China sued for peace, regaining its own lost territory from the war while granting Japan control of both Korea and Formosa. This was a truly remarkable outcome and a great surprise to many, including observers in the West, who had assumed that China would defeat the much smaller Japan in the war. Japan's victory was the result of its two decades of modernization and industrialization, and it marked the first step in Japan's rise as a major imperial power in its own right alongside the European powers. It came at the expense of Korea, which was now under Japanese control.

Japan's control of Korea would, however, soon be challenged by another regional power—Russia. Japan and Russia were on a collision course in the Far East because of their conflicting aims toward Manchuria in northern China (not Korea this time, although right next to it), a mineral-rich region. Japan offered to acknowledge Russia's control over Manchuria (at least at that time) *if* Russia acknowledged Japan's claims to Korea, which Russia refused to do because it wanted control of northern Korea as a buffer between Japan and Manchuria. Japan, however, refused to grant Russia control of northern Korea and the impasse led to the Russo-Japanese War of 1904–05. Using its newly acquired territory in Korea as a base of operations, the Japanese Navy dealt the Russian Pacific fleet a devastating blow in October 1904 at the Battle of Port Arthur. Both Russia and Japan took huge losses in the fighting, but Russia lost as the Japanese lay siege to Port Arthur for six months (June 1904–January 1905), forcing a humiliating defeat on Russia, the first time in the modern era that an Asian nation defeated one of the European powers. Time was on the side of the Russians, which had a much larger population and far greater resources to draw on; however, the Japanese got the quick and decisive victory they needed, the devastation of the Russian fleet at Port Arthur, and that was all it took (the Japanese would dust off this old strategic plan and try/hope to do the same to the US thirty-seven years later with the attack on Pearl Harbor in December 1941, but in that case of course it did not work out in the long run).

Japan's victory in the Russo-Japanese War cemented its emergence as a major world power. In 1910 Japan officially annexed Korea, now considering it to be part of Japan. Tens of thousands of Japanese moved to Korea as businessmen, farmers, merchants, and moneylenders, a process that began to some extent even before Japan's annexation of Korea but continued rapidly thereafter. The number of Japanese citizens in Korea increased from 20,000 in 1897 to 170,000 in 1910 to 336,812 by the end of World War I in 1919 and continued to rise thereafter. The Japanese carried out “modernizing” reforms in Korea, some of which sought to crush or annihilate Korean culture (the Japanese, for example, tried banning the Korean language, at least in government usage and schools—newspapers were not allowed to publish in Korean—and forced Koreans to take Japanese names). The Korean economy was reorganized to be almost completely subservient

to the demands of Japan, especially the export of rice from Korea to Japan, which increased multifold during this period and brought tremendous suffering to the Korean people. The Japanese brutally crushed all resistance to their rule over the next three decades, including killing an estimated 7,000 Korean demonstrators who took part in a 1919 independence movement inspired by US President Woodrow Wilson's post-World War I call for the self-determination of nations as part of the negotiations of the Versailles Peace Treaty ending the war.

Japanese occupation and oppression gave rise to an acute sense of Korean nationalism during this period and led by the 1930s to a strong underground resistance movement against Japanese rule in Korea. The onset of World War II in Asia with Japan's invasion of China in 1937 brought even greater suffering to Korea, as Japan heightened the exploitation of the Korean population to support its war effort. Japan forcibly conscripted tens of thousands of Korean men to fight for it, and in an extremely ugly chapter of the war an estimated 200,000 women and girls from Korea (mostly), China, the Philippines, Indonesia and other countries were forced into sexual slavery, dubbed "comfort women," for Japanese soldiers. The fate of Korea shifted sharply at the end of World War II. As we know, at the Yalta Conference in February 1945 the Soviets agreed to enter the war against Japan, and in accordance with that agreement the USSR declared war on Japan in early August and landed in Korea (in the north) to prepare for that war. But, of course, as we also know in the wake of the two atomic bombs dropped on it by the US (August 6 and 9), Japan surrendered. As a result, the Japanese withdrew from Korea, leaving a vacuum of power.

Within Korea pro-communist forces organized into People's Committees throughout the country gained the upper hand, carrying out land reform to redistribute land vacated by the Japanese, many of whom had been settling in Korea and taking over land since it was annexed in 1910, and/or owned by large Korean landowners. This policy was very popular with most of Korea's population in both the north and the south. However, when US troops occupied Korea south of the 38th parallel they reversed the land reform carried out by the People's Committees and repressed these organizations (as well as labor unions). The division of Korea was intended to be temporary, but as Cold War tensions heightened in the late 1940s it became long-term (permanent?)

The Korean War (1950–53)

The modern-day division of Korea took root at the end of World War II. By 1948 the split between North and South Korea was solidified by the formation of separate governments confirmed by unfair elections in both the north and the south. In South Korea (the Republic of Korea) a pro-US authoritarian regime under Syngman Rhee took power. Rhee studied and lived in the US for some time (he was very pro-American) and was active in the anti-Japanese movement in his country. In North Korea (the Democratic Republic

of Korea) a pro-Soviet communist regime emerged under the leadership of Kim Il-sung, who had also been involved in the anti-Japanese resistance.

Amid ever-heightening tensions between the US and USSR, Korea became the site of the first major Cold War “proxy war” or war by substitution. In June 1950 North Korean troops invaded South Korea, with explicit approval from Stalin to do so, prompting the Korean War; the UN voted to intervene on behalf of the South as a “police action” against the aggression of the North. At the time the USSR was boycotting the UN, where it held one of four Security Council seats with veto power, because the US refused to allow the new communist government of China (as of 1949) to occupy China’s seat on the UN’s Security Council, insisting instead that that seat should remain in the hands of Chiang Kai-shek’s regime in Taiwan. This was the one and only time that the USSR boycotted the UN. Thus, this was not an officially declared war by the US Congress—it was a UN “Police Action.”

US General Douglas MacArthur, who was in charge of the ongoing US occupation of postwar Japan, intervened at the famed Battle of Inchon in Korea in September 1950 from bases in Japan and Pusan in the far South of Korea. MacArthur took US forces onto the Chinese side of the Yellow Sea and also against the very turbulent waters of the Tsushima Strait and wedged in between North Korean forces, splitting them in two. After that the US-led UN coalition force began gradually pushing North Korean troops back up into North. In fact, they pushed these forces all the way up to the Chinese border, possibly even crossing the Yalu River into Chinese territory, although that remains disputed and unclear.

When US/UN forces pushed North Korean troops to the border with China about 250,000 Chinese “volunteers” intervened and pushed US/UN forces back to the 38th parallel. Chinese intervention led to the most disorderly retreat in modern US military history and gave rise to the phrase “bugging out,” meaning to get the heck out of somewhere. The conflict spilled over into US domestic politics when MacArthur made it clear publicly that he wanted to chase the new Chinese communist regime out of power and called for the use of nuclear weapons against Mao Zedong’s new communist regime in China. In April 1951 US President Truman dismissed MacArthur and brought him home rather unceremoniously for overstepping his power. After three years of fighting and around 3mn deaths (40,000 US deaths with over 100,000 wounded), the Korean War ended in a stalemate, with the country still divided at the de-militarized zone (the 38th parallel, as it remains to this day) between the communist pro-Soviet North and the pro-US South.

The Korean War was highly significant for a number of reasons: it was the first major test of the US Cold War policy of “containment” outside Europe; it marked communist China’s emergence as a formidable military power in Asia (the Korean War proved that the Chinese were major players on the international scene, so it is very important for the early PRC in international terms); and, along with the 1949 Chinese Revolution, it marked the emergence of Japan as the main US Cold War ally in post-World War II Asia. The

war also served as a huge economic boost for Japan, still recovering from its shock and the devastation of defeat in World War II.

Cold War and Post-Cold War Korea

South Korea

The ardently anti-communist, pro-US Syngman Rhee established an authoritarian regime in the South. His rule ended in 1960 and the following year General Park Chung-hee seized power in a military coup. He established a brutal dictatorship with an emphasis on economic modernization and development, leading by the 1970s–80s to what observers called an economic “miracle” of rapid growth, albeit with few benefits shared by the bulk of the population and *no* political freedoms. Park ruled for eighteen years until in 1979 the head of his own security team assassinated him (he survived an earlier assassination attempt in 1974 though his wife was killed in that attack).

Opposition to military rule in South Korea culminated in labor strikes and massive protests in the mid-late 1980s and finally in 1988 to a transition to free elections and a more democratic form of government. Economic improvements thereafter greatly enhanced the lives of many South Koreans as relative (but uneven) economic prosperity prevailed in the 1990s and after (albeit with a few hiccups, as in the so-called “Asian flu,” a sharp economic downturn that swept the region, leading to a major devaluation of currencies that devastated people’s savings in 1997 and after). In South Korea these economic developments led to labor strikes in the late 1990s and afterward. On the whole, however, the country has maintained its developed economy and a (mostly) stable democratic system since the late 1980s.

In early December 2024 South Korea’s democracy faced a major crisis. President Yoon Suk Yeol of the conservative People Power Party (PPP), elected in 2022 by the slimmest margin in the country’s history of elections, declared martial law, accusing the opposition of engaging in “anti-state” activities in alignment with North Korea. Yoon’s popularity rating had dipped below 20% amid a scandal involving his wife accepting an expensive gift, an act caught on camera. Earlier in the year the ruling PPP suffered a crushing defeat in parliamentary elections. He was also facing a major strike by doctors and staff in the medical sector and a stalemate with the opposition in parliament over a pending budget bill. The martial law decree, signed by an army general, would, among other things, restrict the country’s media, force striking medical workers back to work, and reportedly even arrest of some of Yoon’s political opponents and outspoken critics, although Yoon vehemently denies that accusation. The decree lasted a mere six hours: protesters marched on parliament, where opposition figures and PPP members all voted (190–0) to withdraw the declaration of martial law. Yoon conceded and rescinded his decree for martial law. In mid-December the South Korean Parliament

voted to impeach Yoon, and in January 2025 a Seoul court ordered Yoon's arrest for starting an insurrection and abusing his power. In early April the country's constitutional court upheld Yoon's impeachment, ruling that he had "committed a grave betrayal of the trust of the people" with his declaration of martial law in December.

North Korea

In the North the situation has been very, very different. North Korea has maintained a rigid, repressive communist economic and political system; after his death in 1994, Kim Il-sung's son Kim Jong-il took power. Kim Jong-il's son, Kim Jong-un, took power after his father's death in 2011. Thus, communist North Korea is a family dynasty; it is probably the most closed and isolated country in the world today, and its population suffers periodically from famine in part due to its relative isolation in the global economy. Aside from a close trading relationship with China, North Korea does not engage with any other countries in any significant way economically or otherwise. It began a project to acquire nuclear weapons in the 1990s and this remains a huge cause of concern with the US and the broader international community.

Japan: Land of the Rising Sun

Japan is an island nation in the Pacific Ocean separated from the Asian mainland, primarily Korea in the south and Russia in the north, by the Sea of Japan. It is a very densely populated country, especially the largest island, Honshu, home to the capital Tokyo, the largest city in the world in terms of population (Japan as a whole has a population of around 123.5mn as of 2025), and other major cities such as Osaka, Kobe, and Kyoto to name a few. Historically Japan was relatively isolated from the Asian mainland by a difficult sea passage, the Straits of Tushima that separate Japan from Korea. As with the Koreans, the origins of the present-day Japanese people are traced to migrants from northeast Asia or Siberia who entered Japan sometime between 300 BCE–200 CE. The migrants intermarried and intermixed with groups already inhabiting the Japanese islands while pushing smaller minority groups, such as the Ainu people, to the north, where many of them still live. Japanese make up over 97% of the country's population. The cultivation of wet rice seems to have spread to Japan from China sometime around 250 BCE.

The first centralized Japanese state began to take shape by the late fifth century CE around the same time that Buddhism entered the country from China and Korea, emerging alongside the traditional religion of Shintoism (in modern Japan the two are roughly split with a small Christian minority). Buddhism required the construction of temples, which in turn required the role of a somewhat centralized state apparatus to extract the resources and

mobilize the labor necessary to carry out such an act. Over time the Japanese state became more centralized with a divine emperor atop the social structure and a strict hierarchical caste system similar to that of Medieval Europe.

The Impact of the West on Japan

Western missionaries, primarily the Portuguese and Dutch, arrived in Japan in the mid-sixteenth century and encountered some success winning converts to Christianity, which alarmed the island's rulers. In the early seventeenth century the emperor banished foreigners from Japan and closed the country off from outside influences to a significant degree. After this Japan remained very isolated for over two centuries until US Commodore Matthew Perry arrived with armed vessels off the coast in 1853 and essentially forced Japan under threat of attack to open the country up to foreign trade. The Western powers did not colonize Japan, but in the decades following Perry's mission Japan began exporting tea and silk in exchange for Western manufactured goods. By the 1870s Japan had begun its own policies of railroad construction, industrialization, and the modernization of its military, particularly its navy, in an attempt to catch up with the Western powers. As we saw, they did a remarkably good job of it and managed by the end of the nineteenth/beginning of the twentieth centuries to defeat China (Sino-Japanese War), and Russia (Russo-Japanese War), thereby becoming the major Asian power.

Japan remained out of the fighting during World War I but took the opportunity while the European powers were bogged down in their own bloody conflict to seize more territory in China. Japan's economy grew during the war because it supplied some of the combatant nations, mostly Britain, with materials needed for the war effort. Its territorial gains in East Asia during the war years were acknowledged by the Western powers in the Versailles Peace Treaty that ended World War I. Politically Japan had all the trappings of a parliamentary democracy during the 1920s and seemed to be evolving along that path, although its government was extremely unstable (between 1918–32 three of Japan's Prime Ministers were assassinated while in office). The country's economy expanded considerably in Japan's own version of the "roaring twenties," but that all came to a screeching halt with the beginning of the global Great Depression in late 1929, after which Japan's exports fell by half in just two years, unemployment rose dramatically, and real wages plummeted. A sharp fall in the price of rice devastated Japan's peasants and a poor harvest in 1930 led to widespread starvation in the countryside.

Suddenly the Western model of "democracy" no longer looked so appealing and as the decade progressed—and the economic woes continued—Japanese political leaders and theoreticians began looking to fascist Italy and Germany as potential models instead of the Western democracies. Fascism is a dictatorial, ultra-nationalistic/racist, militaristic, and imperialist (expansionist) form of government based on private property and strong popular

support (or at least indifference) to varying degrees. Fascism arose in Japan in 1932 following yet another assassination of yet another Prime Minister, who had opposed the military's invasion and occupation of Manchuria in China (renamed Manchukuo by the Japanese) the previous year. Japanese nationalists assassinated him in May 1932 and General Tojo Hideki advanced to a leading position within a coalition of military leaders. As elsewhere the rise of fascism and military rule in Japan was accompanied by strict controls over personal freedoms as well as a strengthening of the country's military power. Japan forged a military alliance with Nazi Germany and fascist Italy in 1936 and began to look upon its neighbors, several of which it occupied (such as Korea and Formosa, as we have seen) or greatly influenced economically as part of a "Greater East Asia Co-Prosperity Sphere" with the Japanese, of course, in control thereof. World War II began in Asia with Japan's invasion of China in 1937.

Between 1937–41 Japan occupied most of East and Southeast Asia—northern China, Korea, Vietnam, Cambodia, Laos, the Philippines, Indonesia, Thailand and Myanmar. On December 7, 1941, Japan attacked the US in Pearl Harbor, Hawaii, prompting US entry into the war and greatly widening the scope of the conflict. However, time was not on Japan's side as it had few resources to survive a lengthy war, especially as the US and Britain began pushing back Japanese occupation of the Asian mainland and the Pacific islands in a very successful "island hopping" campaign in 1944–45. In February–March 1945 the US/British defeated Japan in the Battle for Iwo Jima with both sides taking very heavy casualties. The Battle of Okinawa in April–June 1945 was the largest amphibious invasion in history again with huge casualties on both sides ending in an allied victory.

The US and British began bombing the Japanese mainland, especially Tokyo. In March 1945 an allied firebombing campaign of Tokyo killed an estimated 100,000 Japanese—more than would perish in the initial atomic bombing of Hiroshima or Nagasaki—and destroyed roughly half of the city. As the war continued into the summer months it was becoming increasingly difficult for the resource-poor Japanese islands to keep up the fight, yet they refused to surrender in part because the allied call for "unconditional surrender" left the status of the Japan's emperor unclear. The Japanese cabinet was split over the war, and peace overtures were made to the US via Moscow, but a slight majority of the country's leadership favored continuing the conflict no matter what. One indication of Japan's lack of resources was the creation of the infamous Kamikaze suicide pilots in late 1944, because of the country's lack of oil and skilled pilots. This way relatively inexperienced, unskilled pilots could wreak much more damage on the enemy and use only half as much fuel. As discussed in the Introduction, the war ended following the decision of US President Truman to drop two atomic bombs on Japan, one on Hiroshima on August 6, 1945, and the other on Nagasaki three days later.

Post-World War II/Cold War Japan

In looking at the post-World War II/Cold War history of Japan a key theme is its role and position within the international economy. We have noted the various approaches to economic development within communist countries, and the postwar history of Japan shows that there were variations in economic development within the capitalist bloc as well. Under the broad rubric of “capitalism” there are a number of ways to organize and operate an economic system, and the model of capitalism developed in Japan as well as other countries is quite different from that of the US. The key to Japan’s economic success—Japan’s postwar “miracle”—was its model of economic development. The first ingredient of that success was imposed upon Japan by the US, which occupied the country for seven years (1945–52) following World War II.

The US found itself in a bit of a Cold War dilemma with regard to Japan: having defeated Japan in the war the US sought to maintain stability by not dramatically altering the defeated country’s social order, fearing that instability could lead to a communist takeover. This meant working with some of the very people the US had just spent four years fighting against, including Emperor Hirohito, who was allowed to remain on the throne but with his role reduced to that of a figurehead during US occupation. General MacArthur led the US occupying force; he made changes, but he largely maintained the status quo. The US occupying force did not break up Japan’s major economic cartels such as Mitsubishi, despite their prominent role in leading Japan into war. In 1947 the US wrote Japan’s Constitution, which included Article 9 renouncing war forever. Over the long term this proved to be very important and beneficial to Japan because it allowed the country to concentrate on rebuilding and further developing its economy, rather than focusing on military spending. The key role in the Cold War in Japan was apparent in two events we have already noted: the Chinese Revolution in 1949, which made that former US ally a communist nation and left Japan as *the* major US ally in East Asia; and the outbreak of the Korean War soon thereafter, which led to an early economic boom in Japan as a major supplier for the US/UN forces in Korea, especially since Japan could not fight in the war because of Article 9 of its constitution.

Postwar Japanese society was very divided and economic problems were prominent. Unemployment was high and wages low throughout the 1950s giving rise to a strong labor movement and a significant socialist opposition. The party that has dominated Japan’s post-World War II political history is the Liberal Democratic Party (LDP), a conservative (despite the name) party that has maintained power by relying on business, the bureaucracy, and farmers. The LDP has at times defied the rules of democracy to maintain its control; in 1960, for example, representatives of the LDP in the Japanese Diet (Parliament) passed a controversial security treaty with the US

increasing the American military presence on the island nation. Police forces removed opposition socialist deputies from the Diet chamber and in their absence LDP representatives pushed through treaty approval without any opposition despite major anti-treaty protests throughout the country. These developments revealed the political divisions in Japanese society between the socialists, the conservative LDP, and the ultra-nationalistic far right, which, though defeated in the war, was still a political force in the country. Japan in 1960 was not the model of political stability and economic prowess it would later become, and the socialist opposition mounted a serious (though unsuccessful) challenge to LDP control at the time.

The LDP remained in power and continued to pursue policies of economic rebuilding. An important player in Japan's economic future was its Ministry of International Trade and Industry (MITI), part of the country's powerful bureaucracy. Emerging after the war as a bureaucratic body to regulate and direct individual Japanese industries for the good of the country MITI has played a very active role in the economy. MITI's role contrasts with the US-style "free market" or neo-liberal capitalism that seeks to minimize the government's participation in the economy. Using its power over capital through the financial system, MITI phases out industries in which Japan is no longer competitive and encourages new branches of industry that will give the country an edge. MITI also protects domestic industries with high tariffs (taxes on imported goods) and subsidizes research and investment for Japanese firms and global exports.

Japan's economic success in the postwar period is based largely on the government restricting access by foreign competitors to Japan's home market, allowing Japanese firms to sell their exports very cheaply, "dumping" or flooding foreign markets, while selling goods on the Japanese market at high prices and for large profits (which they could do because there was limited foreign competition) to make up for the loss. MITI guided this strategy, which transformed Japan's economy from a base in textiles to steel and electronics and cars in the 1960s to computer industries thereafter and to robotics and other high-tech industries in recent decades. It proved to be a successful model of capitalist development, but one that, with its heavy involvement of a government agency like MITI, is very different from capitalism as practiced in the US.

Stemming from labor disputes in the 1950s–60s, MITI's strategy afterward was to stress social stability as an important part of economic development, which meant providing higher wages and better working conditions for Japan's workforce. MITI urged economic managers to share the country's prosperity with workers, leading to greater social stability. Japan's relatively equal distribution of wealth led in the 1970s–90s to a high level of savings among the Japanese public (the average Japanese citizen at the time bought very little on credit, saving the amount needed to buy something and paying in cash instead). Consequently, there was a large pool of capital available, and the government offers business cheap, subsidized capital for investment

at very low interest rates—a large part of the reason for Japan’s economic success in those decades.

The “Asian Flu” and the Pacific Rim Countries

However, in the mid-1990s, Japan’s once powerful economy slowed significantly and became mired in economic stagnation. The financial crisis or “Asian Flu” that began in Thailand in 1997 and spread from there compounded Japan’s earlier economic woes even more, although Japan managed to keep the worst effects of this development in check, in large part owing to government intervention. The global economic downturn of the late 2000s presented another major threat to Japan’s economy and thus to the wellbeing of the country’s population. A huge challenge for Japan since the 1990s is the country’s aging population, which means that there is an ever-larger share of the population receiving retirement benefits while not actually working. Compounding this situation is the fact that Japan allows very minimal immigration, so it is unable to resupply the workforce with younger workers to mitigate this problem of an aging population.

The “Pacific Rim” countries include Japan as well as South Korea, which we have already examined, and also Taiwan, Thailand, Malaysia, Singapore, the Philippines, and Indonesia, the latter of which we examine more closely in the next chapter. Beginning in the 1960s these countries began to apply Japan’s model of economic development with some variations, and they too have been very successful for the most part. The main difference from most of these countries and Japan is that the others relied more on “free-trade zones,” offering low wages and tax breaks to foreign investors (especially Japanese investors), and backing up their economic program with strong authoritarian centralized governments. As in the case of Japan, the result was rapid economic growth, though the wealth generated in these countries was less equally distributed than in Japan, leading to greater social instability in several of those countries in the form of labor disputes.

Known as the “Asian tigers” in the West because of their rapid economic growth in the 1980s–90s, the Pacific Rim countries achieved a significant degree of economic success and prosperity by pursuing a very different capitalistic model than that promoted in the US. However, in the late 1990s the export-driven policies promoted in these countries by international lending agencies, mainly the International Monetary Fund (IMF), led to a crisis, the aforementioned “Asian Flu,” caused mainly by oversupply and speculative investment practices. The crisis began in Thailand in March 1997 with the collapse of that country’s stock market and the sharp devaluation of its currency. Speculation in the real estate market, an increasing debt problem, unsound fiscal policies, and lagging demand for export items combined to cause the crash. From Thailand it spread quickly throughout the region. South Korea, Taiwan, Singapore, Malaysia, and Indonesia all experienced

sharp falls in their stock markets and all devalued their currencies. In 1998 the crisis spread to Russia as well.

In short, just as with the communist countries around the world we have examined so far, there is a great deal of variation in the economies of the capitalist countries as well, and the policies pursued therein have their successes as well as their potential pitfalls. Japan has fallen in its once lofty economic status (as noted, China passed it as the second largest economy in the world in 2010 amid the global economic crisis), but it as well as the Pacific Rim countries have managed to persevere as mostly stable democracies with relatively strong economies coming out of the “Asian Flu” of the 1990s as well as the global crisis of the late 2000s/early 2010s.



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Map 5.1 Map of Southeast Asia.

5 Southeast Asia

Vietnam, Cambodia, and Indonesia

Vietnam

Vietnam is located on the archipelago of Southeast Asia with its tropical rain forests, river plains, and mountains. With a population of a little over 100mn as of 2024, Vietnam is one of the world's most densely populated countries, especially in the areas of its two largest cities, Hanoi, the capital, in the north and Ho Chi Minh City (formerly Saigon) in the south. Its two major river systems are the Red River in the north and the Mekong River in the south. The earliest settlers of the Red River region dating back some 3,000 years ago are believed to be the first to cultivate rice, which spread from there throughout East Asia. The Vietnamese language is most closely related to Cambodian (Khmer) in the region but has Thai and Chinese influences as well. The southern tip of the country (and Southeastern Cambodia) has historically been relatively sparsely inhabited because the Mekong River delta is very swampy. Vietnamese society, therefore, was centered mostly in the northern and central parts of the country until recently—the Mekong region in the south, mostly inhabited by small fishing societies, represented a frontier for settlement in the seventeenth-nineteenth centuries as Vietnamese increasingly migrated there in part because of the incursion of French colonialists.

Modern-day Vietnam has a largely homogenous population with the majority Kinh or Viet people making up about 85% of the country's total population, although there are a number of other smaller groups (Thai, Muong, and Khmer) spread throughout the country as well, mostly in the mountains to the west and along the border with Cambodia and Laos. Historically most of East Asia Vietnam was a Buddhist country, although the communist regime does not encourage religious observance and it is unclear how many Vietnamese today are practicing Buddhists. A key characteristic of this region is the importance of outside influences in shaping its history, which is apparent in the phrase often used to describe the area: French Indochina. Southeast Asia was heavily influenced early in its history by India, China, and eventually France, which colonized the region in the late nineteenth century. China had the greatest influence in Vietnam as it was subjected to about 1,000 years of direct Chinese rule, leading to a great deal of resistance by

the Vietnamese. Consequently, the Vietnamese developed a strong sense of national identity atypical of a predominantly peasant society at that stage of economic development.

French Colonialism in Southeast Asia

Traditional Vietnamese society underwent dramatic changes owing to the impact of French colonialism. The first Europeans to arrive in Southeast Asia were French missionaries, who came to the region in the early 1800s. Reports of vast natural resources, especially teak, a type of wood ideal for boat construction, subsequently attracted the attention of French colonialists. By the 1860s French troops were fighting to control Vietnam, and by the 1880s they had conquered all of Southeast Asia. The French colonized Vietnam in pieces between 1859–83; they ruled earlier and more directly in and had a stronger influence over the South. The Vietnamese resisted but the modern firepower of the French was too overwhelming. A significant minority of Vietnamese (about 10%) converted to Catholicism under French influence, most of them in the South. The French built up Saigon, the largest city in the South, as its main administrative center, and it became a very European city (“Paris on the Mekong”).

The French drained the marshy swamplands of the Mekong River Delta and, with the use of modern irrigation technology, opened the area to cultivation and habitation. As a result, a sizable area that had previously been sparsely inhabited was settled, in part by French landowners, and used for agricultural production and rubber tree plantations. Thus, the South was in many ways unique and distinct from the rest of Vietnam. French colonial practices mirrored those of their European counterparts: they imposed very high taxes on practically everything (the Vietnamese joked that soon the French would tax their bowel movements because they had already taxed everything else!). The French also imposed “monopolies” on crucial items, such as salt (like the British in India), a crucial aspect of the average diet and necessary for food preservation, and alcohol (an important part of Vietnamese ancestry rituals). Also like the British, the French imposed monopoly control over the sale of opium, the use of which they encouraged in Vietnam.

French rule strengthened Vietnam’s already acute sense of nationalism and anti-Western sentiments grew among the elite during French colonial rule. The person in Vietnamese history who best embodies these anti-French sentiments is Ho Chi Minh, whose name means “He who Enlightens.” Ho’s father hated the French and instilled a strong sense of patriotism and pride in Vietnamese traditions and culture in his young son. Ho converted to communism after the 1917 Bolshevik Revolution in Russia but for Ho the road to communism was paved first and foremost with nationalistic intentions.

Ho Chi Minh was a student in France in 1919 when the world’s powers met for the Versailles Peace Conference to officially end World War I. He

appealed to meet with US President Woodrow Wilson with a petition for the self-determination of the Vietnamese people, but his request was not acknowledged. Ho's efforts nonetheless won him widespread support among Vietnamese nationalists back home. He was a founding member of the French Communist Party and Vietnam's first communist party as well a bit later, but his main goal was to end French colonial rule in Vietnam and throughout Southeast Asia.

Initially it would not be the Vietnamese communists, but rather the Japanese who would finally break France's hold on Southeast Asia. As part of their expansion, the Japanese occupied Vietnam and Cambodia in 1941. At first they kept the French colonial rulers in place, only now the French were ruling for and collecting taxes on behalf of the Japanese. Ho Chi Minh was as determined to fight against Japanese rule in his country as against French rule, and he formed the Viet Minh, a coalition of communists and nationalists opposed to both Japanese occupation and French colonialism. This movement was led and dominated by communists, but it was not limited to communists: anyone opposed to foreign rule was allowed into the Viet Minh.

The Viet Minh became a very effective fighting force, using Maoist guerrilla warfare tactics against the Japanese. The US State Department considered the Viet Minh a major asset in the war against Japan in Southeast Asia, providing them with weapons through supply routes in China. The Viet Minh gained wide popularity among the common people because they led attacks on rice supplies during a horrible famine in 1944–45, distributing the rice to the population. Nonetheless, an estimated 2mn Vietnamese died during the famine while food supplies, which were plentiful, were used to feed Japanese soldiers and/or exported to Japan.

The Japanese ousted the French in March 1945 and took over direct control of Vietnam, but they surrendered soon thereafter in August after the two atomic bombs were dropped on Japan. The ouster of the French and subsequent defeat of the Japanese raised the question of who would rule Vietnam. The only viable political force in the country was the Viet Minh with its leader, Ho Chi Minh, so when Japanese troops left in August 1945 Ho proclaimed Vietnamese independence. He read the Declaration of Independence in Hanoi's main square, starting with "All men are created equal. They are endowed by their Creator with certain inalienable rights, among them are Life, Liberty, and the pursuit of Happiness." Ho had always been a strong admirer of the US, seeing Americans as freedom-loving people who had defeated British imperialism in much the same way he hoped to defeat the French. Ho Chi Minh visited the US (New York and Boston) several times as a cook or waiter on a luxury French cruise liner. He also lived for a while in Moscow in the 1920s–30s and in China as well in rural villages with Mao's forces—he was a very well-traveled person.

Declaring Vietnamese independence was one thing; maintaining it, however, would not be easy. After World War II ended the French returned,

arriving in the south and pushing their way north, sparking the French Indochina War (1946–54). The fighting was centered mostly in the north, where the Viet Minh were strongest and the French weakest, and the Viet Minh employed guerrilla tactics against the French just as they had against Japan. The war became a major drain on French resources and devastated much of Vietnamese society. The US began supporting the French effort financially; by the early 1950s the US was paying for roughly 80% of the French war effort in Vietnam, which marks the beginning of US involvement in the region. US financial support, however, did not turn the tide of the war, which went badly for the French. The decisive blow was struck in 1954, when Ho Chi Minh's Viet Minh troops surrounded a French outpost and supply center located in a very isolated region along the northern border with Laos at Dien Bien Phu. After a siege lasting fifty-five days the French were forced to surrender. The battle was a major victory for the Viet Minh, as at long last they had defeated the French and put an end to French colonial rule in Vietnam and throughout Southeast Asia.

Prelude to the US-Vietnam War (1954–64)

The Geneva Conference (1954)

During the Battle of Dien Bien Phu, representatives of the world powers met in Geneva to discuss global issues, including the situation in Vietnam. The agreement reached at Geneva was to temporarily divide Vietnam along the 17th parallel, with Ho Chi Minh and the Viet Minh forming the government in the North, where their support was strongest. In the South initially a government was set up under Emperor Bao Dai, the Vietnamese monarch and puppet ruler the French had put in place during the French Indochina War. He had no legitimacy among the majority of the Vietnamese people, and almost as soon as the Geneva Conference ended leadership in the South passed to Ngo Dinh Diem, who was from an elite Vietnamese Catholic family and was the choice of the US. The US did not officially participate in the conference—a US representative was present but silent throughout the proceedings—and did not sign the agreement mainly because the Eisenhower administration did not want to see any territory lost to the communists, especially the fertile Red River valley in the North. The US was, however, a key behind-the-scenes actor at the conference.

The 1954 Geneva Agreement included a period of safe passage for anyone wanting to move from one part of Vietnam to the other, which set in motion a mass migration in both directions, although mostly from North to South as Catholics in the North, an estimated 850–900,000 of them, felt unsafe in the new communist-controlled Democratic Republic of Vietnam established by Ho Chi Minh's Viet Minh in the North. A much smaller number of communists and ardent nationalists (around 80–90,000 Viet Minh supporters) in the South migrated North to train under Ho Chi Minh's communist government.

This migration had the effect of further accentuating the differences between North and South in Vietnam.

The division of Vietnam created at Geneva in 1954 was *not* intended to be permanent. The agreement called for the country to be reunited with a nationwide election in two years. Ho Chi Minh saw the agreement as a temporary setback but was confident of reunifying the country through the elections in 1956 (they lobbied for holding the elections immediately but failed to get an agreement on this). The North-South division became long-term, however, when, with US support, Diem, the handpicked pro-US leader in the South, broke the agreement and backed out of the planned elections. Diem canceled the elections because if held it was obvious to everyone that Ho Chi Minh would win in a landslide. Despite some early mistakes by the communist regime in the north, Ho Chi Minh was the great patriot who had ousted the French, had already gained something of a legendary character, and was widely popular throughout the country. Diem, on the other hand, was neither well known nor particularly popular; his government was corrupt and repressive, and his Catholicism alienated a lot of Vietnamese Buddhists.

The reasons Diem and his US supporters (namely Secretary of State John Foster Dulles) gave for canceling the elections were that they had not signed the Geneva Agreement and thus were not bound by the agreement (the US, as noted, had not signed the agreement and Diem was not put into power until *after* the agreement). They asserted that free and fair elections could not be held in the communist north under Ho Chi Minh's control, a point that may have held a grain of truth but was mostly just a smokescreen—a justification for canceling the planned elections. Diem would *not* have won an election, which is why he canceled it, and in that decision as much as any other we find the roots of the US-Vietnam War. A 1954 US State Department document notes that “current intelligence leads the Joint Chiefs of Staff to the belief that a settlement based upon free elections would be attended by almost certain loss of the Associated States to Communist control,” or, in other words, that an election would be won by Ho Chi Minh. US leaders had decided to back Diem in Vietnam and support him in a process of state building that would keep communism contained in the north.

Although the Viet Minh had clearly won the French Indochina War with their decisive victory at Dien Bien Phu, at the Geneva Conference Ho Chi Minh had to accept a temporarily divided country partly because his communist allies, the Soviet Union and communist China, pressured him to do so. This was just one year after the end of the Korean War, and neither the Soviets nor the Chinese were eager for another major fight with the West—and certainly not a military confrontation—over Vietnam. Stalin died in 1953 so the USSR was still in the midst of a transition in leadership (Khrushchev had not quite emerged as Stalin's clear-cut successor); China, meanwhile, was rebuilding after decades of civil war, Japanese occupation, civil war again, its 1949 Revolution, and then the Korean War. Ho Chi Minh's communist allies were clearly in no mood for a fight.

The Cold War factored heavily into the US calculus on Vietnam as well. Direct US military involvement in Vietnam began under Eisenhower, who sent members of military intelligence in 1954 and military advisors in 1955. US policymakers saw this conflict in terms of the “Domino Theory,” the idea that if Vietnam fell all of Southeast Asia would fall to communism, so the US had to hold up the “weakest link” in the chain of dominoes. The “Domino Theory” was just another way of stating the Cold War policy of containment put in place at the end of World War II; the main flaw of the theory is that it gave precedent to external factors in determining the course of events in a country’s history over internal factors within that country. Thus, although a defining feature of US Cold War ideology, the domino theory held very little validity at all.

Cold War ideology is also the key to understanding why the US decided to follow France into this disastrous Southeast Asian quagmire: although the US supported France in the French Indochina War, they saw that battle as a struggle to maintain colonial rule over a subjugated people. US leaders, conversely, saw their own mission in Vietnam ideologically in Cold War terms of supporting the “freedom” and “liberation” of the Vietnamese people—Eisenhower, Kennedy, and Johnson all used this rhetoric regularly—against the threat of communist aggression, which is a very different perspective.

Civil War in the South (1959–64)

Once in power in the north the new communist regime immediately carried out a brutal collectivization program on the model of the Soviet Union, leading to famine as Ho Chi Minh’s forces imposed a very repressive regime. Meanwhile in the south, Diem’s policies undermined his credibility and ultimately aided his communist foes. Many of those returning to the south in 1954 were former landlords whose land had been seized and redistributed to landless peasants by the Viet Minh during the French Indochina War.

When it became clear that the elections agreed to at the Geneva Conference would not be held, many of the Southern communists who had migrated North in 1954 began to gradually return home to the South. These communists *from the South* would become known as the Vietcong, a derogatory term coined by Diem’s supporters meaning Southern communists (they called themselves the National Liberation Front—NLF, an umbrella organization of southern communists and nationalists based on the model of the Viet Minh). So the Viet Minh was the broad coalition of communists and nationalists that fought the Japanese during World War II and then the French, forming the government in the North after 1954; the NLF/Vietcong were Southern communist/nationalist forces supported by the North but initially with a great deal of independence in decision-making from the North.

Most Americans saw the Vietnam War as the result of an invasion by the north against the south, but this conflict was *not* a clear-cut case of invasion as in Korea. Documents captured by the US military during the conflict in the

early 1960s reveal that Ho Chi Minh initially tried to convince the NLF to be cautious and not provoke the Diem government into an all-out, full-scale war. The NLF, however, responded that if they did not fight back and react to Diem's repression they were in danger of being crushed by Diem's forces in the south, so acting largely on their initiative the NLF began to attack government troops in the South. Thus, by the late 1950s/early 1960s South Vietnam was engulfed in a civil war between the communist NLF, independent of but supported by the communist government in the north, and the non-communist Republican government of Diem supported by the US. The war initially at least was *not* a clear-cut battle between North and South Vietnam so much as a battle between different groups in the south, especially in its early stages (it becomes more northern dominated later as we will see).

By the early 1960s the war was on and despite assistance from US advisers it did not go well for Diem, whose government was very corrupt, unpopular, and repressive of Buddhists. To protest the Diem government's repressive policies in 1963 several Buddhist monks burned themselves alive, which made a very strong impression back in the US. Diem's backers in the US began to pull away from him because of his dictatorial policies; his wife Madame Diem did not help matters when she referred to these incidents as "Buddhist barbecues" in an American television interview.

As Diem's government became increasingly unpopular in Vietnam and abroad, US policymakers decided he had become a liability. In late 1963 several Vietnamese army generals planned a coup, their plans supported by US Ambassador to South Vietnam Henry Cabot Lodge. US President John Kennedy, who had studied with and befriended Diem at Harvard University many years earlier, reluctantly agreed but insisted that Diem not be killed. The latter wish was not upheld, however, as the coup leaders removed Diem from power and killed both he and his brother only three weeks before Kennedy himself would be assassinated in Dallas. Diem's removal did not bring political stability and democracy to South Vietnam: over the next twelve years (1963–75) the South Vietnamese government was controlled by eleven different military regimes, including one general who listed Hitler as the figure in history he most admired. Members of the US State Department joked that the South Vietnamese government's coat of arms should be a turnstile. This situation was apparently very frustrating for US President Lyndon Johnson who told an advisor in the mid-1960s that he was "sick of this coup shit" and desperately hoped for stability in South Vietnam. The non-communist government in the south was definitely *not* a democracy.

The Gulf of Tonkin Incident (1964)

The major incident that led to an escalation of the US-Vietnam War was the Gulf of Tonkin Incident. Two US ships were conducting "unspecified" activities in disputed territory off the coast of North Vietnam—the North Vietnamese claimed it was in their territory, whereas the US claimed it was

in international waters. Three North Vietnamese warships attacked the US ships and then supposedly attacked one of them again two days later in what were undeniably international waters. The second incident is particularly unclear. The US ship received blips on its radar screen that were either caused by torpedoes or by a storm at sea.

A 2002 US National Security Agency (NSA) report states that the second incident “most likely did not occur,” adding though that it was not a deliberate provocation but rather a failure of intelligence. The NSA report demonstrates “that not only is it not true, as Secretary of Defense Robert McNamara told Congress, that the evidence of a *second* attack was ‘unimpeachable,’ but that to the contrary, a review of the classified signals intelligence proves that ‘no attack happened that night.’” Nonetheless it was this second event that President Johnson used to pass the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution, which only two members of the US Congress voted against. The Resolution allowed the President to dispatch troops to Vietnam without an official declaration of war, which is why the US never officially declared war on Vietnam—the Resolution made it unnecessary to do so.

The US-Vietnam War

After this US involvement in Vietnam greatly escalated. There were a little over 16,000 US troops in Vietnam in 1963 but that number soon escalated dramatically following the Gulf of Tonkin Incident/Resolution and throughout the late 1960s, reaching a peak of over 500,000 US troops in 1969. In all, a total of around 2.5mn US troops served in Vietnam and about 58,000 of them died there along with well over 1mn Vietnamese (some estimates put that number as high as 3mn). When the war was in full swing in the mid-1960s, it was widely perceived that the US was winning and that it was just a matter of time before victory. In a taped phone conversation in 1965 between President Lyndon Johnson and Secretary of Defense Robert McNamara, Johnson compared the war to a football game, saying that we were winning big (78–0) but that we needed to hang on and finish up all four quarters.

However, strategically on the battlefield the US was not able to overcome a far less technologically advanced enemy. In the war the NLF relied mostly on guerrilla warfare, as the Viet Minh had done before them in its wars against the Japanese and the French. The NLF built an extensive network of tunnels, fighting much of the war from underground. The communists fought a war of attrition: they were not trying to win or hold territory they were just trying to make the war too costly for the enemy so that they would pull out. Also, the NLF definitely had the home field advantage in this war: they spoke the same language as the peasant villagers and were fed and housed by peasants.

North Vietnam supplied the NLF with Soviet and Chinese-made weapons along the Ho Chi Minh Trail, which ran through neighboring Laos and Cambodia. As we see in the next section, the ruler of Cambodia, Prince Norodom Sihanouk, allowed the communists to do this, which upset US

military leaders. In 1970 the US supported the overthrow of Sihanouk by Cambodian General Lon Nol and the Nixon administration also secretly bombed Cambodia. Despite these efforts of US military strategists to stop or even ebb the flow of supplies and, increasingly, North Vietnamese Army (NVA) troops south along the Ho Chi Minh Trail they were unable to do so.

US strategists knew that the strength of the NLF was its reliance on the support of rural peasants and sought strategies to undermine that support. Chinese Communist leader Mao Zedong had explained the success of guerrilla armies by comparing them to “fish in water,” the fish being the guerrillas, the water being the countryside and the peasant villages. US strategists reasoned that the best way to kill the “fish” was to drain the “water,” or the jungle terrain that the guerrillas lived and hid in. They therefore began to use defoliants like Napalm and Agent Orange to expose the guerrillas in their jungle terrain and to kill the crops of the peasants supporting the guerrillas. One result of this has been a high rate of cancer and other problems among US Veterans of the war as well as among the Vietnamese exposed to these chemicals.

In conducting the war the US relied heavily on its superior air power in both the North and the South. For example, the US instigated “Operation Rolling Thunder” (March 1965–October 1968), an intense bombing campaign intended to attack and limit North Vietnam’s capacity to support the war effort in the South. The US dropped more tonnage of bombs on Vietnam than was dropped in all of World War I and World War II combined. President Johnson worried that expanding the war might bring the Soviet Union or China more directly into it (like the Chinese “volunteers” who swept across the border in Korea). As it was, the Soviets and Chinese aided the communist forces with weapons and supplies but their forces (mostly) stayed out of the fight.

For US ground troops it was often difficult to identify the enemy. Consequently, anyone among the Vietnamese could be the enemy and the tendency was to see everyone in that light, justifiably or not, which led to atrocities by US troops. Another issue was the weakness of the US ally in the war, the Republican forces of South Vietnam, not known for their willingness or ability to fight. As the US escalated its involvement in the conflict and troop numbers in the mid-1960s, the communist regime of North Vietnam responded in kind and the war became more and more a battle fought by and led by forces in and from the North. From the perspective of many Vietnamese peasants the American troops were there to destroy and kill them, and the Americans did not always distinguish between simple villagers and actual NLF rebels (everyone was perceived as the enemy).

The Tet Offensive (February 1968)

US General William Westmoreland, who was in charge of the military side of the US war in Vietnam between 1964–68, gave a speech in November

1967 in which he said that the US military was entering the final stage of the war, a sentiment President Johnson reiterated in his own speech a few weeks later. However, despite such constant rhetoric from the country's leaders and the American public's expectations of victory, US strategies in Vietnam produced few positive military results and the war kept going on and on with no end in sight. Consequently, opposition to the war in the US began to grow in the late 1960s and would ultimately play a pivotal role in bringing it to an end.

The anti-war movement in the US was boosted in February 1968 by a major offensive undertaken in South Vietnam by the NLF, proving that they were not, after all, on the verge of defeat. This was the Tet Offensive, a surprise offensive named after the Buddhist New Year, traditionally a period of truce during the war. Prior to the offensive beginning communist forces created a diversion at Khe Sanh, an outlying US military outpost, to get Westmoreland to draw US troops and resources away from the major cities in the south to defend Khe Sanh, which observers at the time compared to Dien Bien Phu.

This was part of the Tet Offensive, an attempt by the NLF to seize the major cities of the south, spark a popular rebellion in their favor and bring the war to an end with a communist victory. However, the offensive did not spark the hoped-for popular rebellion and the communists were eventually chased out of all the cities they attacked. Militarily, the offensive failed; the communist forces took part of Saigon briefly, including the grounds of the US Embassy, and took and held the ancient city Hué, just south of the 17th parallel, for several weeks. Hué became the perfect illustration of the old adage that they (US forces) had to destroy it in order to save it—very little of the city was left when the battle was over. In their short period of control over Hué the communist forces rounded up anyone suspected of working for or supporting the government of South Vietnam; in all they massacred an estimated 2,800 people at Hué during Tet, as became clear a year or two later when one of the communists involved defected and revealed the site of the mass grave.

The NLF took very heavy casualties during Tet, which led to an increased role for northern troops in the war. It was at this point, in the aftermath of Tet, that the north really took control of the war. Nonetheless, in another sense, the Tet Offensive was a huge success for the communists: it showed their strength to the American public, proving that they were not, in fact, on the verge of defeat and thus that, contrary to the words of Westmoreland and Johnson, the US was not really in a position to win the war in the near future, if at all. It was a public relations victory for the communists and ultimately that proved to be more important than the military defeat. After Tet a growing number of figures within President Johnson's administration decided that the war was not a good idea, including Clark Gifford, who had replaced Robert McNamara as Secretary of Defense.

My Lai Massacre (March 1968)

US troops carried out a number of atrocities in the war, none more nefarious than the March 1968 My Lai massacre, which happened soon after the end of the Tet Offensive. The incident was covered up for about a year-and-a-half and the US public did not find out about it until late 1969, but when it became known it too gave a major boost to the anti-war movement in the US. On March 16, 1968, a US commander, Lieutenant William Calley, ordered the execution of hundreds of Vietnamese villagers (mostly women and children; the US military investigation put the death toll at 507), for their suspected support of the NLF. Word of the event leaked to the public, first by a journalist friendly with soldiers in Charlie Company, which had carried out the massacre, and then definitively when the military photographer at the incident released his harrowing photos of it to the *Cleveland Plain Dealer*. Lieutenant Calley stood trial for his part in the massacre and was found guilty and sentenced to life in prison, though US President Richard Nixon quickly commuted his sentence and pardoned him in 1974 after he had served only four months in a military prison.

The My Lai massacre could have been much worse except for the heroic intervention of two US pilots who stopped the violence. Hugh Thompson and Lawrence Colburn even loaded Vietnamese civilians onto their helicopter to take them to safety away from the approaching troops of Charlie Company and threatened to shoot the US soldiers carrying out the massacre if they did not stop. They also evacuated a young boy who was wounded but still alive to a nearby hospital, saving the boy's life. They were belatedly awarded the Soldier's Medal for their actions in 1998.

When the My Lai massacre became known in late 1969 it reduced support for the war further among the American public. Nixon won a close 1968 presidential election over incumbent Democratic Vice-President Hubert Humphrey (Lyndon Johnson, as incumbent, chose not to run for re-election) partly because of Nixon's promise to end the war with honor. However, evidence unearthed in 2017 suggests that Nixon's campaign worked with sympathizers in South Vietnam to sabotage peace talks led by the Johnson administration early in the 1968 campaign. In May 1970 the Ohio National Guard shot and killed four student protesters at Kent State University, which led to boycotts of classes and major protests at universities across the country. Ten days later two student protesters were killed during protests at Jackson State University in Mississippi. Demands for an end to the war were growing in the US.

"Vietnamization" of the War (1969–73)

Faced with increasing domestic opposition to the war, President Nixon began a "Vietnamization policy," which meant strengthening the government and

military of South Vietnam and letting them handle the war themselves while pulling US troops out of the country. With the gradual withdrawal of US troops in the early 1970s the economy of South Vietnam began to suffer because it had become so dependent on the presence of US troops. As a result, support for the communist opposition increased in the south owing to a sagging economy. Also, as part of this policy the US did a lot to bolster the South Vietnamese military, which in the early 1970s had the fourth largest Air Force in the world.

Talks with the North Vietnamese in Paris that had begun under Johnson in 1968 continued, though with several breakdowns in negotiations. The North Vietnamese launched another major offensive in late March 1972 dubbed the Easter Offensive by the US. An all-out direct invasion with tanks and military personnel pouring across the border (the 17th parallel) into the south, initially it looked as though the offensive might succeed as the Republican troops of South Vietnam on the border retreated quickly and the communist forces picked up substantial ground. After these initial gains by North Vietnam, however, the US responded by mining the Haiphong Harbor in the north and unleashing one of the most intense bombing campaigns against the north in the entire war, stalling the offensive and leading to a resumption of peace talks in Paris. The goal of the 1972 Offensive (like Tet four years earlier) was a complete communist victory and reunification of the country, but again it failed.

After several more vacillations, including an extremely intense bombing campaign against North Vietnam ordered by Nixon in December 1972 (dubbed the Christmas bombings) the warring sides finally signed the Paris Peace Accords on January 27, 1973, days after the death of former President Johnson, ending US involvement in Vietnam. The agreement declared Vietnam to be one country with two governments; called for the release of all US Prisoners of War (POWs) being held by North Vietnam and help accounting for soldiers Missing in Action (MIAs); called for the complete withdrawal of all US troops in South Vietnam; and promised aid and reparations to North Vietnam from the US. The South Vietnamese government had refused to sign essentially the same agreement several months earlier before the Christmas bombing of the north by the US, which extended the fighting and the peace talks by four more brutal months (the north had agreed to the same terms in October). In January the South Vietnamese government still hated the agreement but Nixon pressured them to sign it this time and they did.

War and Peace in Southeast Asia: Reunification and Vietnam Since 1975

Neither side held to the 1973 Paris Peace Accords. The Nixon administration soon became embroiled in the Watergate scandal and the US refused to pay reparations to Vietnam because of the MIA/POW issue as US leaders believed that North Vietnam was still holding POWs. The North Vietnamese did not hold to the agreement permanently dividing the country; in April 1975 the

Vietnamese communists began a final offensive that ended with their victory and the reunification of Vietnam under communist control. US personnel and thousands of South Vietnamese were hastily evacuated in helicopters from the grounds of the US Embassy in Saigon in yet another iconic (and chaotic) moment in the war. After reunification, Saigon was renamed Ho Chi Minh City in honor of the leader of the Vietnamese communist movement who had died in 1969. The bloodbath in the south that many anticipated with a communist takeover did not occur, although thousands of suspected supporters and sympathizers of the South Vietnamese government were sent to “re-education” camps where they endured horrible conditions. Many escaped and fled the country (as well as Laos and Cambodia, both of which along with Vietnam also experienced communist takeovers within weeks of each other in April 1975). Between 1975–79 an estimated 1.5mn Southeast Asians fled, most of them Vietnamese.

Vietnam remained a close ally of the Soviet Union but found itself at odds with communist China, an issue we return to in the next section on Cambodia. Southeast Asia after 1975 was no longer caught up in the Cold War, which was less important there after the US withdrew, as in the conflict between China and the Soviet Union—after 1975 the Sino-Soviet split was the most important external factor defining relations in Southeast Asia. As a close ally of the Soviet Union, Vietnam followed a course similar to that of Moscow. In 1986, one year after Gorbachev rose to power in the USSR, Vietnam embarked on its own course of economic reform similar to Gorbachev’s “perestroika” (they were not, in other words, following China’s path of economic reform, which had begun several years earlier in 1980). Calling the reform movement in their country “renovation,” the communists invited foreign investors into Vietnam, decentralized economic decision-making, introduced greater profit-incentive factors into the economy, and allowed a market economy to exist alongside the official state sector.

In 1990 the reforms were broadened to allow peasants long-term ownership rights over their land, and Vietnam created its first “Free Economic Zone.” US companies such as Nike for example began to invest heavily in Vietnam to take advantage of cheap labor in the country. These policies led to increased production in Vietnam, although the wealth generated was unevenly divided and corruption was a major problem. Also, unlike Gorbachev and the USSR, Vietnam has not introduced political reform (in this Vietnam can be compared to China under Deng Xiaoping in that they implemented perestroika without glasnost). The Communist Party maintains a political dictatorship in the country.

The US normalized direct trade relations with Vietnam in 1996 under the administration of US President Bill Clinton. Full diplomatic relations were restored in 1998 (the first US ambassador to Vietnam was a former POW), and business has been booming between the two countries ever since. Vietnam today remains nominally a “communist” country; it is a political dictatorship with strong elements of both state control over the economy

and market forces. Vietnam has had a growing economy for years, but it is also plagued by problems such as corruption, “sweat-shop” industries, and growing economic disparities between rich and poor.

Some within the Vietnamese Communist Party criticize the current leaders for these problems, wondering why Vietnam fought so long and hard if its leaders were simply going to lead it back to capitalism after all the fighting was over. A nationalistic element remains in Vietnamese society, with many opposed to the increasing presence of foreign corporations and particularly a US presence in the country. Yet for the most part US-Vietnamese relations have been positive in recent decades, perhaps in part because of the perceived threat of Chinese expansion. In a 2016 visit to Vietnam US President Barack Obama agreed to allow US weapons to go to Vietnam because of the threat of China in the region. Vietnam, moreover, was a major benefactor of the US trade war with China during the first administration of President Trump as US trade with Vietnam increased significantly as a result. That may prove to be the case again with Trump now in power for a second term.

Cambodia: The Kingdom of Wonder

Cambodia, with its capital at Phnom Penh and a population of around 17.3mn as of 2025, has no mountain chains running North-South; hills in the North run along the border with Vietnam, but these pose no barrier to outside invaders and Cambodia’s history has been largely shaped by invasion and migration from outside. The defining feature of Cambodia’s physical geography are its river systems: in the north the Tonle Sap, which unfortunately suffers from a great deal of environmental damage over the years, and the Mekong River and its delta in the east and south. In the monsoon season that lasts from May to November much of Cambodia is under water and peasant huts are built accordingly on stilts; as with other societies Cambodia’s agricultural economy is tied to the control of water as peasants store water in small ponds for irrigation for the cultivation of rice, the main crop for Cambodia as throughout East Asia.

The earliest evidence of habitation in Cambodia dates from a cave in the northwestern corner of the country from 4,200 years ago. These early inhabitants mixed over time with waves of newcomers from Thailand and Vietnam. In contrast to Vietnam, which was heavily influenced by China, India’s influence prevailed in Cambodia; the Khmer language, the largest in Cambodia, is closer to languages in India than to Chinese (it is part of the Mon-Khmer family of languages scattered throughout Southeast Asia and parts of India). One indication of Indian influence is that the Khmer people ate with spoons, rather than chopsticks as in China and Vietnam. Beginning in the ninth century, Cambodians built one of the most splendid and mysterious of all pre-modern civilizations, Angkor Wat, with temples dotting the countryside today.

The majority of Cambodia's population are ethnic Khmers, who have made up 90% or more of the population for decades. There was, however, an ethnic Chinese minority of around 5%, a mixed Sino-Khmer population, and a small Vietnamese minority and others—mostly Muslims—from the islands of Southeast Asia. Genocide is one of the main themes of this book, one that we touched on briefly with reference to the Holodomor in Ukraine in the early 1930s (we return to this theme in detail in the chapter on Rwanda). Unfortunately, the modern history of Cambodia allows us to explore that ugly theme as it became the site of a terrible genocide in the late 1970s that has shaped the country's demographic makeup since. The Chinese and Vietnamese populations in Cambodia grew during the nineteenth-twentieth centuries but were targeted during the genocide of the late 1970s, so their numbers have fluctuated greatly. There is a strong Buddhist majority in the country of around 97%, with a Muslim minority of about 2% and a very small Christian minority as well.

Crucial changes took place in Cambodia with the onset of French colonial rule in 1863 (as in neighboring Vietnam and Laos). Historically only ethnic Khmers owned land; almost all of Cambodia's peasants were ethnic Khmers who owned their own land, usually small plots of land on which they grew subsistence crops. One of the most important changes with the onset of French colonialism was the introduction of cash crops grown not for subsistence but for export on the global market, which, as we saw in the unit on India, is an important aspect of colonialism. As in neighboring Vietnam and Laos, in the late nineteenth century the French introduced rubber plants and began to grow rice and corn in large quantities for export, especially on large plantations in the northwestern part of Cambodia. Thus, French rule led to a shift to a cash-based economy, as taxes (still paid to Cambodian officials, but now routed to French colonial administrators) were paid in cash instead of in kind or as part of the harvest.

This shift to a cash-based economy had tremendous implications for Cambodia and its population of Khmer peasants. While Khmer peasants paid taxes and grew crops for subsistence, they increasingly had to take loans at very high interest rates from mostly ethnic Chinese merchants and moneylenders in surrounding towns and cities to pay for important rites such as weddings, funerals, and religious services, or just to tide them over in lean years. Thus, ethnicity and economics became closely interrelated in Cambodia with different ethnic groups defined by their economic activity. As a result, wide disparities in wealth developed between the cities and the countryside and also along ethnic lines, with Khmer peasants indebted to Chinese moneylenders and merchants engaged almost solely in trade and business. This development was not entirely due to French colonial rule, but French rule greatly compounded and exacerbated the issue, particularly the shift to a cash-based economy geared around the export of cash crops.

By 1930 about 90% of the Chinese in Cambodia were involved in commerce; around 95% of all merchants in Cambodia were Chinese, and

roughly 86% of the Khmer population were peasants living and working the land in the countryside. Thus, a clear ethnic divide developed between rural Khmer peasants and urban/semi-urban Chinese merchants and moneylenders (a trade network tied rural Chinese to urban areas). By the mid-twentieth century French rule in Cambodia facilitated the growth of commerce dominated by a Chinese minority and fueled in large part by the taxation and exploitation of the Khmer peasant majority.

The construction of railway and road transportation allowed for goods bound for export to be more easily shipped to the coast and, from there, out of the country. French colonialists and Chinese merchants benefited from these developments at the expense of the majority, rural-based Khmer population. There was a steady increase in the Chinese minority population of Cambodia, from 170,000 in 1905 to 300,000 by 1940. Owing to migration into the country but also because of natural population growth, improved health care, and other factors, the overall population of Cambodia increased from about 1mn in 1850 to more than 4mn in 1950 and to 5.7mn by 1962. This steady population growth, especially in the countryside, increased economic pressures in the country because more and more people vied for control of the land.

Prince Norodom Sihanouk

During World War II one of the most influential figures in modern Cambodian history emerged; Prince Norodom Sihanouk, who became ruler of Cambodia in 1941 at age nineteen. Sihanouk was a popular and nationalistic ruler. Roughly two months before he was crowned the new monarch about 8,000 Japanese troops moved into Cambodia. As with Vietnam, for most of World War II the Japanese allowed French colonial administrators to stay in power and rule for them (this was partly because the French never declared war on Japan; also, as we noted earlier with respect to Vietnam the tax revenue generated in Cambodia was sent to Japan rather than France). In March 1945 the Japanese arrested French colonial administrators and took over direct control of Cambodia (again, just as in Vietnam). However, as we know, the Japanese were on the brink of defeat and surrendered after the two atomic bombs were dropped on their country in August 1945, and Prince Sihanouk promoted Cambodian independence. But the French were determined to re-impose their control on their colonies in Southeast Asia.

Opposed to French colonial rule in Cambodia, Sihanouk supported the Viet Minh in the French Indochina War, which was fought mostly in Vietnam. With the French bogged down in the war in Vietnam, Sihanouk badgered them for Cambodian independence, at one point dramatically offering his life in exchange for Cambodia's independence. Not wanting to extend the war beyond Vietnam, the French decided in November 1953 to grant the kingdom authority over Cambodia's armed forces, judiciary, and foreign affairs—although, notably, France's economic hold remained intact and it is

unclear if the French intended this to be total independence for Cambodia. Nonetheless, it was enough for Sihanouk to triumphantly declare and celebrate the country's independence on November 9, 1953.

Cambodia benefited from the Viet Minh's defeat of the French at Dien Bien Phu and from the Geneva Conference of 1954 that brought an end to French rule in Southeast Asia. During the 1950s–60s Sihanouk tried to isolate Cambodia as much as possible from Cold War hostilities. He was not a communist, but neither was he staunchly anti-communist. Sihanouk was a key figure in the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM), which formed in 1961 among countries not wanting to be aligned with either side in the Cold War, along with world leaders like Egypt's Abdul Nasser, India's Jawaharlal Nehru, Ghana's Kwame Nkrumah, Indonesia's Sukarno, Yugoslavia's Josip Broz Tito, and others.

However, as the US escalated its involvement in Vietnam, Cambodia and Sihanouk were inevitably drawn into the conflict. The earliest US involvement beyond the borders of Vietnam was in Laos, where the communist Pathet Lao movement gained strength in the late 1950s with direct support from North Vietnam. In 1961 the CIA under US President Kennedy began organizing the mountain Mong (and other) peoples along the border between Laos and Vietnam to ebb the flow of goods along the Ho Chi Minh Trail. When that did not work, beginning under President Johnson in March 1964, several months prior to the Gulf of Tonkin Incident, the US began a secret and illegal bombing campaign in Laos. Between 1964–73 the US dropped an estimated 2.5mn tons of bombs on Laos, a country with which it was not at war. Once again, however, this attempt to stop the flow of goods along the Ho Chi Minh Trail proved unsuccessful.

In neighboring Cambodia, as noted earlier, during the US-Vietnam War, Sihanouk allowed the communists to run supplies through Cambodia along the Ho Chi Minh Trail, which upset US military leaders. The US wanted Sihanouk to close off the supply route, but he refused to do so and decided instead to help the NLF. The US resented Sihanouk's tacit support for the NLF and his refusal to stop the flow of military supplies along the Trail. In 1969 the US began a secret (and illegal) bombing campaign in Cambodia but was unable to stop the flow of goods along the Trail. US military leaders decided that to cut off the supply route along the Ho Chi Minh Trail they would need to remove Sihanouk from power. In 1970, about eight months after the US started bombing the country, US military advisors in Cambodia encouraged General Lon Nol to overthrow Sihanouk while the latter was abroad in Beijing, where he remained after his ouster.

The Rise of the Khmer Rouge

After the coup and invasion Lon Nol faced trouble almost immediately. He lacked the popularity of Sihanouk and, most importantly for the Cambodian people, he lacked the religious sanction to be ruler of the country. He

faced heightened opposition from the outset of his rule, largely from the first uniquely Cambodian Communist Party, which had formed in 1951, the Khmer People's Revolutionary Party, based mostly on the support of intellectuals. A Maoist party that sought support from peasants in the countryside, in 1967, now dubbed the Khmer Rouge ("Red Khmers") and assisted by the communist regime of Ho Chi Minh in North Vietnam, it began a peasant-based armed movement against the Sihanouk government. By that time most of its members were Khmer peasants from the countryside.

After Lon Nol's coup support for the Khmer Rouge increased and the civil war in Cambodia intensified. In 1968 the Khmer Rouge was a relatively small and mostly ineffective group with only about 5,000 members. However, several factors contributed to the rapid growth of the Khmer Rouge between 1968–75: US bombing of the Cambodian countryside, which greatly disrupted the rural economy and actually increased support for the communists (which is ironic because the bombing was intended to defeat the communist rebels and strengthen Lon Nol's regime); the US-sponsored coup that overthrew Sihanouk, whose popularity and religiously-sanctioned leadership had kept the Khmer Rouge at least somewhat at bay, and the installation of the corrupt and unpopular Lon Nol regime in his place; a 1970 invasion of Cambodia by US and South Vietnamese forces (20,000 US troops and 40,000 South Vietnamese forces), which further disrupted Cambodia's rural society, thereby leading to still more support for the Khmer Rouge; and, finally, after being overthrown, Prince Sihanouk, now exiled in China, boosted support for the Khmer Rouge in 1970 by joining them in an anti-Lon Nol alliance.

The Khmer Rouge grew from 5,000 members in 1968 to 70,000 by 1973. With the civil war in the Cambodian countryside heating up in the early 1970s, millions of Internally Displaced People (IDPs) who did not want to fight for either side fled to the cities, especially Phnom Penh. The city's population grew from 600,000 in 1969 to 3mn in 1975 because of the influx of refugees. The war went badly for the US-supported government of Lon Nol. The Khmer Rouge mounted an offensive in 1973 and laid siege to Phnom Penh, leading to famine and disease for the city's swollen population. US planes flew in bags of rice, fuel, and weapons for Lon Nol's dwindling army, but it was too little too late. On April 17, 1975, two weeks before the fall of Saigon, the communist Khmer Rouge marched into Phnom Penh and overthrew Lon Nol's government. Neighboring Laos fell to the communist Pathet Lao the same month.

Once the Khmer Rouge gained control of the country it began a reign of terror. Pol Pot (Saloth Sar) was a very secretive figure who led the Khmer Rouge and thus Cambodia's communist government between 1975–79, overseeing one of history's most brutal genocides. Symbolic of the dramatic changes Pol Pot and the Khmer Rouge introduced, they changed the country's name: Cambodia, they argued, was a European term, a foreign designation that did not accurately reflect their country's identity or its history, so they changed the name to Kampuchea based on the (mythical)

first inhabitants of the region, the Kambujas, who had supposedly migrated from India.

The Khmer Rouge carried out a mass evacuation of the country's cities in April 1975. As noted, the population of Phnom Penh had swelled to around 3mn by the time of the communist takeover. Four years later, in 1979, the population was a mere 200,000, one third of what it had been before the civil war began, and this was after some people had returned to the city. Khmer Rouge leaders justified the decision to evacuate the cities as necessary to move people to rice stockpiled in the countryside because the war had destroyed roads and railroads into the cities. However, the Khmer Rouge carried out this mass evacuation mostly to attack its political enemies, the Chinese and Sino-Khmer merchants, moneylenders, and administrators of the Lon Nol regime, and break their power base in the cities. Millions of Cambodians (including those evacuated out of the cities when the Khmer Rouge seized power) had to live and work in rural labor and "re-education" camps on starvation rations.

The extreme violence of the Khmer Rouge was in part a consequence of the unique interaction of economics and ethnicity and the great disparity between city and countryside noted earlier, as the regime targeted ethnic Chinese and Sino-Khmer city dwellers for repression. The Khmer peasants brutally exacted their revenge for what they saw as decades of exploitation. Pol Pot proclaimed 1975 the year zero, the beginning of history. The Khmer Rouge called its new government "Angkar," or "the organization," and banned money, markets, schools, universities, watches, clocks, music, dancing, and televisions (much like the Taliban regime in Afghanistan twenty years later, though for *very* different reasons). The Khmer Rouge imposed egalitarianism based on severe poverty. They collectivized agriculture; banned religion and destroyed temples and forbid observance of New Year celebrations; abolished all private property; blew up banks and other "capitalist" organizations; and sought to break up the family unit, forcing children to denounce their parents as "bourgeois" traitors.

The "Killing Fields" and Beyond

In Pol Pot's four-year reign an estimated 1.5–2mn Cambodians died out of a total population of 8.5mn (many because of starvation, many executed by the Khmer Rouge). A disproportionate number of the victims were ethnic Chinese or Sino-Khmer and also intellectuals; the Khmer Rouge targeted and killed those who wore glasses because that was a sign of their intellectual and elite status. In rural workcamps people were literally being worked to death while fed meager rations. The Khmer Rouge dumped the bodies of the deceased in mass graves—often craters left behind by US bombings—that now dot the countryside.

Their own brutality against the population and infighting within the Khmer Rouge proved their undoing. There were two main Khmer Rouge factions

vying for power: Pol Pot's pro-Chinese faction, and a pro-Vietnamese/Soviet faction led by Hun Sen. Pol Pot's faction ordered the arrest and execution of any party member suspected of being pro-Vietnam/Soviet. As noted in the section on post-1975 Vietnam, in this period the Sino-Soviet split was the most important external factor defining relations in Southeast Asia. This split was reflected within the Khmer Rouge itself, leading to war when Vietnam invaded Cambodia in January 1979. The Pol Pot regime had been bombing Vietnam across the border throughout 1978, prompting Vietnam to invade. The much more heavily armed Vietnamese (who had inherited the military hardware in South Vietnam left behind by the US) easily defeated Pol Pot's faction of the Khmer Rouge, especially since there was a pro-Vietnamese faction within the Khmer Rouge itself and also because Pol Pot had not exactly been a widely popular ruler.

Pol Pot and his supporters fled to the mountainous region of the country adjacent to Thailand. The Vietnamese set up an occupying force and a pro-Vietnamese/Soviet communist government under Hun Sen in Cambodia, after which the genocide came to an end. However, conflict continued in Cambodia; Pol Pot and his faction of the Khmer Rouge remained a highly armed guerrilla force and fought against the Vietnamese occupying troops and the pro-Vietnamese/Soviet communist faction now ruling Cambodia.

The situation in Cambodia in the 1980s takes on bizarre proportions when analyzed in terms of the Sino-Soviet split and the US position within that: Vietnam was a close ally of the USSR, and the US was of course a bitter enemy of both the USSR and communist Vietnam. Pol Pot's faction of the Khmer Rouge, conversely, was allied with communist China, with which the US was on good terms by the 1980s. Consequently, the US during the 1980s sided with Pol Pot's faction of the Khmer Rouge against Hun Sen's pro-Vietnamese faction. At the insistence of the US a representative of Pol Pot's forces continued to occupy Cambodia's seat on the UN rather than a representative of the Vietnamese-controlled Hun Sen government in Phnom Penh (similar to the situation between China and Taiwan between 1949–73). Tacit support for Pol Pot's faction of the Khmer Rouge by the US finally ceased in the late 1980s/early 1990s with the end of the Cold War and the dramatic re-alignment of international forces that event brought with it.

Cambodia's civil war continued but diminished in the late 1980s, and the Vietnamese withdrew their occupying forces from the country in 1989 as UN peacekeeping forces entered to keep the warring sides at bay. A 1993 agreement brought the country's first real political stability in a long time, including restoring the monarchy (it is now once again the Kingdom of Cambodia) and returning a familiar face to (at least symbolic) power in a remarkable comeback: Prince Norodom Sihanouk! Meanwhile, in the jungle somewhere near Thailand, Pol Pot, who had been removed as leader of the Khmer Rouge only a short time beforehand, died in April 1998 and the remaining elements of his Khmer Rouge faction surrendered in 1999. Sihanouk abdicated in 2004 to his son, Prince Norodom Sihamoni; Sihanouk

died in 2012. Hun Sen ruled as the country's prime minister from 1985 until stepping aside in August 2023 as his son, Hun Manet, took over.

Some surviving Khmer Rouge leaders were belatedly tried for crimes against humanity by a hybrid UN-Cambodian tribunal supported by international assistance. Nuon Chea, Pol Pot's number two man for much of his rule and Khieu Samphan, another highly placed Khmer Rouge official, were convicted and sentenced to life imprisonment in 2014 for their respective roles in Cambodia's genocide of the late 1970s. Nuon Chea died in 2019 at age 93 but Khieu Samphan is still alive (age 93) as of this writing in early 2025.

Economically Cambodia has experienced strong growth since 2000, with the country's GDP growing at an average rate of over 8% between 2000 and 2010 and, even amid the global financial crisis, at a 7% rate since 2011. Steady growth continued until a recession hit the country in 2020, partly due to the impact of Covid, though Cambodia's economy began to recover thereafter. The bulk of the country's economic growth is in tourism, low-wage garment manufacturing, construction, real estate, and agriculture, which still employs most of the population. One can only hope for a bright future for this long-suffering country.

Cold War Conflict and Genocide in Indonesia

Indonesia, with its capital at Jakarta, is a large and ethnically diverse Southeast Asian nation made up of many separate islands in the South China Sea/Pacific Ocean. With over 277.5mn people as of 2023 it is the world's fourth most populous country, and the majority of the population is Muslim, roughly 87%, making it the largest Muslim country in the world in terms of population. There are numerous ethnic groups spread throughout Indonesia's many islands, the largest being the Javanese (45%) and Sundanese (14%). As in Cambodia (and elsewhere), there is also an ethnic Chinese minority (5%) in Indonesia.

The Netherlands colonized the "East Indies" piecemeal beginning in the seventeenth century, gaining control over all of modern-day Indonesia by the late eighteenth century. Indonesia gained its independence after World War II, due in part to Japan's occupation (1942–45) and subsequent withdrawal at the end of the war, a common theme in Southeast Asia as we have seen. Sukarno (born Koesno Sosrodihardjo) led Indonesia's independence movement and declared independence when the Japanese withdrew in 1945. Like the French in Vietnam, however, the Dutch fought to keep its colony, so full independence was not achieved until 1949. Much like Sihanouk in Cambodia, Sukarno was not a communist, but neither was he anti-communist; he defined himself first and foremost as a nationalist as for him Indonesian independence from Dutch rule was always the main issue.

At a key moment in the post-World War II struggle for independence, September 1948, the Indonesian Communist Party (PKI) made a play for power against Sukarno's nationalist forces and failed, and after taking power

Sukarno's nationalists repressed the PKI in response. For most of his early years as President of Indonesia in the late 1940s and early 1950s Sukarno tried to strike a middle path between right-wing militarists and communists, both powerful political groups in Indonesia. On the international scene he was a founding member of NAM—countries that as we saw tried to steer a neutral course in the Cold War. The first meeting was held in Bandung, Indonesia in 1955, although at that time it was the “Asia-Africa Conference” (NAM was not formed until six years later).

Facing economic strains and political instability, Sukarno became increasingly autocratic in the late 1950s—in 1957 he strengthened executive power in a policy he dubbed “guided democracy”—and began rounding up political opponents, targeting especially Islamic political groups, many of whom were linked to Indonesia's military, which increasingly put Sukarno at odds with his own military. To counter this perceived threat, in the early 1960s Sukarno took a clear turn to the left and began relying on the communist PKI for support against the military.

In 1963 the Indonesian Parliament, elected a few years earlier after changes that assured strong support for Sukarno, named him “President for life.” By 1965 the PKI had 3mn members and stood as the strongest political entity in the country. Communist leaders in the Parliament initiated a land-reform program that alienated wealthy landowners, many of whom were Islamic clerics and/or military leaders. On the twentieth anniversary of Indonesian Independence in August 1965 Sukarno committed to an “anti-imperialist alliance”—loaded language in the context of the growing US war in nearby Vietnam—with China and other communist countries, and he also announced a policy of arming and training a peasant and worker militia, which clearly threatened the military's position in the country.

In September 1965 a group of radical young officers in the Indonesian military with ties to the PKI arrested and executed six generals in the army for, they alleged, plotting to overthrow Sukarno. However, the leaders of this counter coup, dubbed the “September 30th Movement,” were unable to establish their control over the entire country, presumably on Sukarno's behalf, although he refused to offer his support for their actions. This in turn opened the door for surviving right-wing members of the military led by General Muhammad Suharto to strike back; Suharto rallied anti-communist Islamic and nationalist allies, blamed the country's political turmoil on the PKI (Suharto claimed that the young officers themselves had initiated a failed communist coup, although that was not the case), and used it as an excuse to put Sukarno under house arrest and round up communists and their supporters throughout the country. Suharto's supporters within the military began arresting students, teachers, labor union activists, and anyone suspected of supporting the communists—a disproportionate number of whom were part of the country's Chinese minority—and executing them.

The Indonesian military organized citizens' militias of their own that killed an estimated 500,000 people over several months in 1965–66 in

another unfortunate example of genocide. A November 1965 CIA memo advocated US covert support for the Indonesian army's efforts to exterminate communists "in a manner which will not embarrass them or embarrass our [the US] government." Muslims played an active role in this process as declassified materials from the US Embassy in Jakarta, the country's capital, indicate. A December 1965 report from the US Consulate in Medan, Indonesia to the US Embassy in Jakarta states that, according to a Muslim source, imams in mosques are telling their congregations that "all who consciously joined PKI must be killed. 'Conscious' PKI members are classified as the lowest order of infidel; the shedding of whose blood is comparable to killing a chicken." American officials monitored the killings as the US provided the Indonesia military with money, equipment, and lists of communists to target.

Sukarno was not informed about the violence unfolding around him. While still nominal head of the country, he essentially had no power and was forced to resign in 1967 as Suharto became dictator. The US strongly supported Suharto as a staunch anti-communist ally until the end of the Cold War. Suharto promoted his "new order" based on economic growth and progress, but it was coupled with political oppression, widespread corruption, and nepotism. Suharto managed to survive the end of the Cold War in the late 1980s/early 1990s, but not for long. By the late 1990s Suharto and his extended family, especially his two sons, had become infamous for their incredible greed and corruption. In 1997 *Forbes* magazine estimated Suharto's wealth at \$16bn, making him the fourth wealthiest person in the world at the time (the CIA estimated his family's wealth at \$35bn!)

The "Asian Flu" and the end of Suharto's Dictatorship

The aforementioned "Asian Flu," the economic crisis in Asia in the late 1990s, struck Indonesia in the summer of 1997, not long after it began in Thailand, and finally led to the fall of Suharto's long reign. The downturn caused the crash of a speculative real estate market and a sharp devaluation of Indonesia's currency, the rupiah, which lost as much as 80% of its value at one point. This led to a dramatic rise in prices and a severe drop in living standards for most of the population. Capital flight from foreign investors and an overall decline in investment stemming from the crisis contributed to rising unemployment, while the gap between rich and poor in the country widened even further. Widespread government corruption compounded these basic economic problems, and the country's middle class that had grown over the previous decades of relative economic prosperity declined sharply.

Suharto was hesitant to accept the terms of a massive IMF bailout of Indonesia's economy because it required "austerity measures" such as cuts in social spending and the elimination of price controls. Suharto feared these measures would lead to social unrest—and, in fact, that is exactly what happened. Riots and protests in the streets of Jakarta led to Suharto's

resignation in May 1998 after over three decades of rule. One cause of the anti-Suharto riots was the dramatic rise in gas prices in April and May 1998, the direct result of the IMF's plan to abandon government price subsidies.

After his resignation, Suharto was replaced initially by his close friend and ally, Bacharuddin Habibie. He faced a major challenge in the secessionist movement of East Timor, which occupies the eastern half of the island of Timor and was a Portuguese colony until 1975. The mostly Catholic inhabitants of the island, illegally occupied by Indonesia since 1975, voted for their independence in a 1999 referendum. However, pro-Indonesian militia groups on East Timor refused to acknowledge the results of the referendum and initiated a violent attack against the East Timorese with the support of the Indonesian government. The UN intervened in the conflict in autumn 1999 to end the violence. The East Timorese subsequently voted for and received their independence in 2002, this time without interference from the Indonesian government and pro-Indonesian militias.

Sukarno's daughter, Megawati Sukarnoputri, won Indonesia's 2001 elections and became the country's new president (Sukarno had died under house arrest in 1970). In the country's 2004 elections retired General Susilo Bambang Yudhoyono soundly defeated the incumbent Sukarnoputri, whose indecisiveness as president had led to a sharp decrease in her popularity. However, Sukarnoputri's rule strengthened Indonesia's nascent democracy, in part by implementing reforms that balanced the powers of the presidency with those of the country's parliament, decreasing the likelihood of a return to a Suharto-style dictatorship. President Joko Widodo, popularly known as Jokowi, a member of Sukarnoputri's party, ruled Indonesia between 2014–24. Unable to run in February 2024 elections owing to term limits he stepped aside for his defense minister Prabowo Subianto, with Jokowi's son Gibran Rakabuming Raka running as his Vice-President. They won a decisive victory over their two main challengers and assumed office following a transition period in October 2024. Economically, although poverty, high unemployment rates—especially for the country's youth—and other problems remain, in the early 2020s Indonesia has had one of the fastest growing economies in the world and is the largest economy in Southeast Asia, so hopefully the trajectory for its future is strong.

Part III

The Middle East



Map 6.1 Map of Iran.

6 Modern Iran

From Secularism to the Islamic Republic

Iran, known for much of its history as Persia, has a huge coastline, 1,400 miles, along the Caspian Sea, the Persian Gulf, and the Gulf of Oman. With its modern capital at Tehran it has a population of over 92mn as of 2025. Mountains and desert predominate in Iran, making up about half of its terrain. The high Zagros and Elburz Mountains form a large part of the country's borders, and in between are desert valleys, with large bodies of water (the Caspian Sea in the north and the Persian Gulf in the south) on the fringes.

Iran is located between the steppes of Asia and the fertile crescent (Mesopotamia) in modern Iraq, and its position has lured many traders but also invaders throughout history, mainly from the steppe region to the north-east but also notably Arab invaders from the southwest who brought Islam to Iran in the seventh century. As a result, Iran evolved as a very diverse country in ethno-linguistic terms. The largest group in Iran today are the Farsi (or Persian), who make up about 61% of the population. Descendants of invaders from Central Asia who settled the Iranian Plateau 800BCE, they made the transition to settled agricultural societies in the sixth century BCE. The largest minority group at roughly 16% are the Azerbaijani, who speak a Turkish language. The Kurds, who speak a language related to Farsi, make up about 10% of Iran's population. They too trace their origins to the original settlers of the Iranian Plateau from Central Asia, but they settled in the mountains and claim to have remained more ethnically "pure" than the settlers of the lowlands. There are a number of smaller groups as well; Arabs make up 2–3% of the population. Iran is separated from the other countries in the region by its mountainous borders as well as by ethnic, linguistic, and religious differences.

The dominant pre-Islamic religion of Persia was Zoroastrianism, which survives in small pockets today. As noted Islamic invaders from the Arabian Peninsula conquered Persia in the seventh century CE, an opportune time because the previous centuries had seen almost constant warfare between the Persian Empire and its Christian Byzantine neighbor, which exhausted and

weakened both. It was under the leadership of the second and third Caliphs, or successors to the Prophet Muhammad, Umar and Uthman, mainly between 640–651, that Islam spread east into Persia through conquest and conversion, which came easily to the Persians because Islam included aspects of their own pre-Islamic beliefs: monotheism; the fear of evil; the existence of angels; and the acceptance of a Judgment Day.

Beginning around 1500 Persia had to cope with the ascendance of a major emerging (Sunni) Islamic power in the region—the Ottoman Empire. Persia became the center of another, rival Islamic Empire, the Safavid Empire founded by Ismail, who was of Kurdish origin. Starting from a base in what is today Azerbaijan, Ismail consolidated his control of Eastern Iran by 1510, capturing the city Tabriz in 1501 and continuing to expand his territorial control from there. The most important legacy of Ismail's rule was that he adopted the minority branch within Islam, Shiism, as the official religion of Safavid domains in 1501 and made conversion compulsory. He dissolved brotherhoods of the majority Sunni branch of Islam and ordered the execution of all who refused to accept Shiism. Under Ismail and his successors Shiism became firmly embedded as the religion of the vast majority of the Persian population.

Russian and British Influence in Persia

The Safavid Empire fell into a stage of decline characterized by decentralized tribal warlordism for much of the seventeenth-eighteenth centuries. By the late eighteenth century and into the nineteenth century European influences were growing in the region. In 1813 Persia lost territory in the Caucasus to an expansionary Russian Empire, and in 1828 Russia seized areas bordering the Caspian Sea to the north as well. By the eve of the twentieth century Russia controlled areas in the north of Persia while Britain controlled much of the south. Persia, its monarchical government ruled since 1796 by the Qajar dynasty, was never colonized, but it was subjected to strong British and Russian influence.

In their specific spheres, the foreign powers demanded tariff concessions, meaning that British and Russian factory-made goods were sold in Persia without import taxes, allowing them to undersell the native handicrafts industry, which caused a great deal of economic dislocation and tremendous disenchantment among Persian merchants or *bazaari*, historically an important segment of society. The British and Russians also exacted special “commodity concessions” that gave them monopolies over the production, sale, and export of specific commodities (timber, mineral resources, even the rights to the country's water were signed away to British or Russian investors by Qajar rulers for the right price). As we have seen, these are common practices of colonial rule, although, again, Persia, was not colonized outright. The most important commodity monopolized during this time was the country's oil resources, which was done before anyone even knew for

sure there was oil. One of the Qajar Shahs granted monopoly control (for a payoff of course) to a British entrepreneur in 1901, granting him the right to explore for oil in the southern part of Iran along the Persian Gulf. This eventually paid off handsomely after oil was discovered in large quantities in the southern British-controlled sphere in 1908.

In the early twentieth century economic problems in Iran led to a series of protests combining economic grievances with religious themes in the capital Tehran as protesters increasingly demanded limits on the Shah's power. In August 1906 the ailing ruler Shah Mozaffar ad-Din succumbed to the pressure of a general strike and street protests and signed an order creating a national assembly, or Majlis, which convened for the first time in October 1906 and immediately set about writing a constitution, the Fundamental Laws. This first phase of the "Constitutional Revolution," as it became known, was achieved peacefully and led to an upsurge in political activity throughout the country. However, the new ruler, Mohammad Ali Shah, the young son of Mozaffar ad-Din Shah, sought to undermine the new Majlis. In June 1908 he ordered troops loyal to the monarch to attack the Majlis, forcing its closure (many of its leaders were arrested and executed). However, Majlis supporters still controlled several Persian cities and managed, with the assistance of disenchanted tribal leaders in the provinces, to retake control of Tehran and oust the Shah, who fled to exile in Russia in July 1909. This saved the country's new Constitutional Monarchy, but at the cost of considerable bloodshed.

Meanwhile, the British and Russians, erstwhile rivals who increasingly recognized Germany as a rising threat, took advantage of Persia's period of weakness and turmoil to sign the Anglo-Russian Agreement (1907) that formally divided Iran into spheres of influence, with Russia controlling the north, Britain the south, and a "neutral zone" in between the two. Rivalry between Russia and Britain for influence and control in Iran continued, but the agreement held.

World War I and Reza Shah Pahlavi

When World War I began in 1914 the Persian monarch, Ahmad Shah Qajar, who had replaced his father the ousted Mohammad Ali Shah, declared the country's strict neutrality. There was, however, a great deal of pro-German sentiment in the country because of resentment toward the British and the Russians. Also, although neutral, northern Iran was the site of intense fighting between Russian and Ottoman forces and the conflict took a devastating toll on the country. Several years of drought led to food shortages and owing to the lack of an effectively functioning centralized government in the country, Persia could not import the grain it needed to feed its population; forced requisitioning by occupying armies (the British in the south, Russians and Ottomans in the north) compounded matters and led to widespread famine in Persia by 1917.

Persia's history took a sharp turn following World War I when Colonel Reza Khan Pahlavi, who served as Minister of War, seized power in a bloodless coup in February 1921 as Ahmad Shah Qajar fled to exile in Europe. In 1924 following the path of Kemal Atatürk in neighboring Turkey (created out of the ashes of what was left of the Ottoman Empire), Pahlavi tried to declare Persia a Republic, but he quickly abandoned the effort and instead declared himself the new monarch, or Shah, of a newly founded Pahlavi dynasty. The Majlis officially deposed the former Shah, Ahmad Shah Qajar, bringing an end to that dynasty and crowned Reza as the new Shah in early 1926. Reza Shah Pahlavi was a reformist, Westernizing ruler who wanted to turn Persia, a country at that time of roughly 12mn people, the majority of whom were illiterate peasants in the countryside, into a highly-developed, modern state with a strong army. In 1925 he began reforms intended to undermine the power of the Islamic clergy, introducing a Western-style law code to replace Sharia (Islamic law), requiring men to wear Western clothing, and forcing women to renounce the veil.

Reza Shah Pahlavi also demanded that the Anglo-Iranian Oil Company (AIOC), founded at the beginning of the century with the oil concession given to the British, grant Iran a greater share than the 16% of the profits they originally agreed upon. The company increased Iran's share of the payout to 20%, still rather small when you consider the company's tremendous profitability by that time. In a mostly symbolic (but nonetheless important) move, in 1935 Reza Shah Pahlavi ordered foreign governments to stop calling the country "Persia" in all official communications and instead use the name "Iran" ("land of the Aryans"), the ancient name mostly used by Iranians themselves. The change linked the country to its pre-Islamic (and thus pre-Arabic conquest) past; the Shah asserted that Persia was the name given to the country by the Greeks and others, i.e., Alexander the Great, who conquered it, but that Cyrus, Darius and the other great early indigenous rulers had called their country "Iran."

Iran During and After World War II

Officially underscoring that the name of the country is "land of the Aryans" in 1935 had broader geopolitical implications in the context of the times. Reza Shah Pahlavi was flirting with Nazi Germany, although he seems to have had no love for either fascism or communism, the two extremes of European politics. In 1937 he arrested several pro-fascist students and also a group of Marxist students. The Shah was a nationalist who did not want any foreign power controlling his country, be it Britain, Russia, or Germany. After Nazi Germany invaded the USSR in June 1941, thereby bringing it into the war on the side of Great Britain, in August Britain and the USSR demanded that Reza Shah Pahlavi expel all German nationals from Iran (several German engineers and specialists moved to Iran in the 1930s). The allies did not want Iran's vast oil resources to fall into Hitler's hands. Weeks

earlier the British had occupied Iraq following a German-inspired and assisted anti-British uprising in that country. The Iranian Shah refused to comply with the allies' order, however, so British and Soviet forces invaded Iran and, facing minimal resistance, took over Tehran in mid-September. Reza Shah Pahlavi abdicated the throne in favor of his son, Muhammad Reza Pahlavi, in his early twenties at the time, and left for South Africa, where he died in 1944.

Iran remained a Constitutional Monarchy, but the young Shah, educated in Europe and a staunch supporter of the allied war effort (unlike his deposed father) allowed free speech and political activity, releasing political prisoners from jail. As during the Constitutional Revolution of the early twentieth century, newspapers flourished and new political parties formed, most of which were secularist in outlook. The Tudeh ("the masses"), Iran's main Communist Party, formed in 1941, grew significantly during the 1940s and early 1950s. In 1949 the Shah blamed the Tudeh for an unsuccessful attempt to assassinate him, although the would-be assassin was almost certainly a religious extremist, and banned the party, though it continued to play a major underground role.

As the war raged allied forces (including US troops beginning in 1942) occupied Iran. Iran hosted one of the major wartime conferences, the Tehran Conference, in late 1943 with the "big three" allied leaders (Stalin, Churchill, and Roosevelt; the young shah's role was minimal). At the conference allied leaders agreed to withdraw all forces from Iran within six months of the war's end. However, the Soviets initially refused to comply with this provision of the agreement, creating the first Cold War challenge to the wartime alliance. The war against Japan ended August/September 1945, and by January 1946 British and US troops had withdrawn from Iran but, citing "security concerns" for the USSR and attacks against the pro-communist Tudeh Party, Stalin initially refused to do so. He also fanned the flames of secessionist, pro-communist movements in northwest Iran adjacent to the USSR, mainly the Iranian provinces of East and West Azerbaijan, which bordered the Soviet Republic of the same name. Eventually pressure from Britain and the US convinced the Soviets to withdraw their forces, and they did so in May 1946, thereby securing Iran's territorial sovereignty in the first early Cold War test.

Muhammad Mosaddegh

A key figure in the Iranian Parliament was Muhammad Mosaddegh. In his early sixties, he was a secular nationalist (he was a Muslim but Islam was secondary for him to Iran's national sovereignty) from a wealthy background. He had proven himself at a young age to be a great scholar (educated largely in Europe) as well as an incorruptible government administrator at the local level. Mosaddegh had spent two decades in semi-retirement because of disagreements with Reza Shah Khan, but he was set to make a tremendous

comeback, being named leader of a broad coalition of Iranian nationalists, the National Front, in the mid-1940s, which set the stage for his ultimate showdown with the Shah in the years to come.

Mosaddegh's disdain for the AIOC and, eventually, his call to nationalize (or take over for Iran) the country's oil reserves won him widespread popularity in the country. He became a threat to the Shah's power, emerging as the country's dominant political figure. Mosaddegh was very anti-British and hated the AIOC, which he and other nationalists saw as a symbol of British power and influence. The company had definitely profited from its position in Iran, which by 1950 was among the world's largest producers of oil. According to a 1952 World Bank (WB) study, between 1914-June 1951 the AIOC earned an estimated \$3.64bn in profits (after taxes). The company paid an estimated \$1.5bn in taxes to the British government (including an oil subsidy to the British Navy). Over that same period, the AIOC compensated the Iranian government \$50mn for the oil extracted from its land.

The WB study, moreover, estimated the amount paid to Iran to be \$1.2bn less than what was owed to it. Given such a scenario, nationalistic parliamentary leaders in Mosaddegh's National Front as well as members of the Tudeh regularly denounced the company. By 1950 practically everyone in Iran was calling for the nationalization of the country's oil, which put the Shah, still young and unproven, in a bind. He and his pliant Prime Minister at the time, Ali Razmara, tried to resist pressures to nationalize the country's oil, which made them very unpopular, especially Razmara, who took the brunt of the criticism because he was in the public eye.

In March 1951 a religious extremist assassinated Razmara, and afterward the Majlis forced the Shah's hand by nominating the popular Mosaddegh to be Prime Minister. The Shah was in no position to refuse. Mosaddegh agreed to accept the position on one condition: that the country's oil resources be nationalized! In 1951 both houses of the Majlis voted *unanimously* to nationalize Iran's oil. The Shah signed the Parliament's nationalization decree despite his close relationship over the years with the British and the oil company. This set the stage for a major showdown between the AIOC and the British government, on the one hand, and Mosaddegh and the Iranian government on the other. The British imposed an embargo on Iranian oil. Until that moment the world's fourth largest oil exporter, supplying roughly 90% of Europe's petroleum, Iran, which did not own a single tanker, suddenly could not export a drop.

The AIOC steadfastly refused to consider compensation offers from Iran for its nationalized property; Mosaddegh offered several times to enter negotiations on this point but was rebuffed every time because, from the company's point of view, agreeing to talk about compensation would be tantamount to accepting nationalization, which they were not willing nor prepared to do. In August the British government imposed economic sanctions on Iran, prohibiting the export of key British commodities to Iran and blocking Iran's

access to its own hard currency accounts in British banks. The British also ordered warships into the Persian Gulf to intimidate the Iranians.

The administration of US President Harry Truman watched these developments closely, alarmed at the nationalization not because US oil interests were at stake, but because US leaders worried about what it saw as Mosaddegh's pro-Soviet leanings (or the possibility of the communist Tudeh Party taking advantage of an unstable situation to seize power in a coup). The concerns of the US, however, were unwarranted or grossly overexaggerated; Mosaddegh was not a communist. He lifted the ban on the small Tudeh Party, which supported his nationalization drive but saw him as a class enemy, and he kept the party at a distance. He wanted to pursue a neutral course in the Cold War, which put him at odds with the staunchly pro-British and pro-US Shah.

In late 1951 Winston Churchill was elected British Prime Minister, and he immediately redoubled the effort to deal with Mosaddegh, who was very popular at home and had emerged as a champion of colonized and oppressed peoples everywhere. By summer 1952 the economic situation in Iran was worsening. Tens of thousands of Iranians had lost their jobs at the Abadan refinery and the oil embargo and sanctions imposed on the country were hurting the economy. A private Italian oil company made a deal with Mosaddegh's government to purchase 20mn tons of oil over a ten-year period. The company sent a tanker in June 1952 to get the first shipment, but British warships intercepted the tanker and forced it to port at Aden, Yemen, a British Protectorate at the time. The British argued that the AIOC was the legal owner of all Iranian oil and thus that the tanker was carrying stolen property. The incident scared off other potential customers for Iran's oil. In 1950, despite the unfair contract with AIOC, Iran had earned \$45mn from its oil exports, which amounted to more than 70% of its total export earnings. In 1951 that amount dropped by half and in 1952 it was close to zero.

In June 1952 Mosaddegh directly challenged the Shah's power, demanding that he relinquish control of Iran's military to the Majlis, despite a provision of the constitution that made the Shah supreme commander of the army. The Shah refused, Mosaddegh threatened to resign, and the Shah accepted his resignation. When word spread massive crowds poured into the streets of Tehran and other cities calling for Mosaddegh's return to power. They chanted, among other things, "Death or Mosaddegh!" The newly appointed Prime Minister replacing Mosaddegh called out elite army forces to suppress protests and soldiers fired on protesters, killing dozens. With the situation quickly spiraling out of control the Shah sent for Mosaddegh and agreed to relinquish control of the military to the Majlis if his supporters ended the protests, which they did. Mosaddegh was restored to power by the crowds despite the country's perilous economic situation caused by the nationalization of its oil (along with the intransigence of the AIOC and the British government).

“Operation Ajax” (1953)

These events in the summer of 1952 proved to be a warmup or dress rehearsal for a defining event in Iran’s modern history the following summer: “Operation Ajax.” Mosaddegh was at the height of his power and popularity, and it was not just because of the nationalization of Iran’s oil. During his short tenure as Prime Minister he had shown a commitment to social reform that further cemented his standing with the Iranian public: he freed peasants from an age-old practice of forced labor on their landlords’ estates and imposed a 20% tax on landlords, using the money raised to improve rural housing and carry out development projects in the countryside; he forced factory owners to pay workers for injuries on the job and set up a system of unemployment compensation; he supported women’s rights and allowed political freedoms to people throughout the country.

In October Mosaddegh broke diplomatic relations with Britain, forcing all diplomats and most British citizens to leave Iran. This was a blow to British plans to overthrow him because it meant that British intelligence agents had to leave, abandoning an extensive network of native spies and informants. However, the tide turned in Britain’s favor when Eisenhower won the 1952 US presidential elections. Eisenhower (like Truman before him) seemed lukewarm at first to the idea of a coup to overthrow Mosaddegh, but the plan had the strong support of two of his key appointees, the Dulles brothers, John Foster and Allen, the former as Secretary of State and the latter as Director of the CIA. The two convinced Eisenhower to support British calls for a coup.

The key CIA point man in “Operation Ajax” was Kermit Roosevelt, grandson of former US President Teddy Roosevelt. The mission was to oust Mosaddegh and increase the power of the Shah vis-à-vis the troublesome Iranian Parliament. Specifically, the plot was for the Shah to dismiss Mosaddegh and replace him with Fazlollah Zahedi, a right-wing general who had collaborated with the Nazis during World War II, for which the British imprisoned him during the war. Thanks to the de-classification in the early 2000s of the Wilber Report, written in 1954 by Don Wilber, an undercover CIA agent in Iran posing as an expert in archaeology who played a key role in “Operation Ajax,” we now know how the CIA carried out this act. In the months prior to the coup the CIA “purchased” members of the Iranian Majlis with “subsidies” (bribes) to support the overthrow of Mosaddegh; planted anti-Mosaddegh propaganda in the US and Iranian media; published and widely distributed in Iran false documents “proving” Mosaddegh’s “close ties” to the communist Tudeh; and harassed key Iranian religious leaders by making threatening phone calls to them and bombing one of their homes while falsely claiming to be members of the Tudeh and supporters of Mosaddegh.

The date set for the coup was August 15. However, Mosaddegh found out about the planned coup before it could begin (he had spies working for him too), and the Shah, worried about the potential backlash, fled to

Rome (Zahedi went into hiding) in what appeared at first to be a complete disaster for the US and the CIA. Large anti-Shah demonstrations followed in the streets of Tehran, just as had happened the previous summer. The CIA cabled Roosevelt that he should come home for fear of violence, but he responded that all was not yet lost: he used a suitcase full of cash he brought with him to secretly finance pro-Shah demonstrations against Mosaddegh, paying street gangs and others through the connections the British had left behind (a family of three very pro-British brothers, the Rashidian brothers, in particular). Unlike the year before, these protesters now shouted, "Death to Mosaddegh!" and "Long Live the Shah!" On August 18, according to the Wilbur Report, Roosevelt organized "gangs of alleged Tudehites on the streets with orders to loot and smash shops" and make it appear as though the Tudeh was doing these acts. Mosaddegh called out the army to put down those protests, which proved to be a mistake because while the military overall was divided many officers supported the Shah.

To make a long story short, by August 19 Mosaddegh, the country's democratically elected leader, wound up in prison, and the Shah was restored to power. Called back from Rome, he said when contacted, "I knew it! They [the Iranian people] love me!" The coup had not gone as planned, but the results were the same: the Shah was in control, Mosaddegh was removed, and the power of the Majlis was greatly curtailed. Eisenhower wrote in his diary that "Operation Ajax" "seemed more like a dime novel than a historical fact." About 300 people had died in the fighting during the coup, roughly half of them defending Mosaddegh at his home (Mosaddegh was sentenced to three years in prison and lived out the remaining eleven years of his life afterward under house arrest). In the weeks after the coup the Shah's forces arrested 600 military officers loyal to Mosaddegh and executed about sixty of them, along with several student leaders of the anti-Shah movement and the Tudeh. The Shah also banned Mosaddegh's National Front.

Newly appointed Prime Minister Zahedi received \$5mn directly from the CIA after the coup to help with the country's economic woes (plus an additional \$1mn for Zahedi personally). A new oil agreement drawn up with an international consortium granted AIOC, which changed its name to British Petroleum in 1954, 40% of the shares, while five US-owned companies divided another 40%, with the rest distributed to Royal Dutch/Shell and to a French company. The consortium also agreed to share its profits with Iran on a 50-50 basis, a major win for Iran (the US-based Aramco had made a similar deal with Saudi Arabia in 1951 at the height of the crisis) but refused to open its books to Iranian auditors or to allow Iranians on its board of directors.

The Shah learned from the crisis that almost ended his reign that one should crush one's enemies before they become too strong. Over the next two-and-a-half decades he would rule one of the world's most brutal and infamous dictatorships with strong US support. The Shah made repression of the communist Tudeh Party one of his main objectives; thousands were imprisoned and killed, even though the party's role in the events that

unfolded had been tangential at most. In 1957 with the direct assistance of the CIA and training by its agents the Shah formed his own version of an internal secret police force, the SAVAK, which would evolve into an effective but incredibly brutal organization charged with crushing internal opposition to the Shah.

The “White Revolution” (1963–75)

In the early 1960s the Shah embarked on his “White Revolution,” another crucial event and turning point in Iran’s modern history. Having consolidated his control and weakened the Iranian Parliament, the Shah embraced the idea sold to him by a few of his own advisers as well as US consultants to begin a bloodless revolution from above to modernize the country (rather than wait for the threat of a violent “red” communist revolution from below to materialize). US advisors during the Kennedy administration helped instigate this major policy change for economic modernization as their primary form of struggle against communism. The Kennedy liberals reasoned that communism fed off poverty, and thus that the best way to combat or “contain” communism was to eliminate poverty, to help countries develop their economies.

In the case of Iran, these ideas dovetailed nicely with what some of the Shah’s own internal advisers had been telling him since the late 1950s—take the initiative, modernize, reform the country’s economy and society in order to weaken the Tudeh and National Front by, in effect, appropriating their program. This was the rationale behind the White Revolution, which the Shah reluctantly agreed to at first but then seems to have enthusiastically embraced. The main objectives of the White Revolution, which was officially launched in 1963, were to build up industry and modernize the country on a secular basis; grant women greater rights (women were granted the right to vote in 1962 and also given the right to divorce their husbands in certain instances and to maintain custody of their children in some cases as well); and carry out land reform.

The land reform policy, however, proved disastrous as it had a tremendously negative impact on Iran’s traditional agricultural society. Designed to redistribute lands from the country’s largest landowners to landless (or almost landless) peasants who mostly worked as tenant farmers on the country’s large-landed estates, it failed for several reasons. For one, it was unevenly implemented in that not all landlords were subject to having lands confiscated. Those who implemented a degree of mechanization of agricultural production on their lands by introducing tractors, combines, or harvesters were largely exempt from having their lands seized and redistributed. Of course, what exactly constituted “mechanization” varied and was subject to interpretation, which led to corruption in the implementation of the land reform at the local level as wealthy landowners often paid bribes to have their efforts construed as “mechanization” whether or not that was the case. In addition,

exemptions were often granted to wealthy landowners with ties to the Shah. Historically the monarchy had derived much of its support from the country's largest, wealthiest landowners, so in some sense by implementing this policy the Shah was undermining his own base.

Another segment of society negatively impacted by the land reform was the *ulama* or Islamic clergy, much of whose funding derived from large landholdings bequeathed to the mosques over the years and farmed by landless tenants. Clerics considered the infringement on property rights to be un-Islamic and preached against the land reform on those grounds. Consequently, peasants, many of whom tended to be very devout, were hesitant to take the land deeds granted to them through the land reform process. In addition, the land holdings distributed to peasants were too small for efficient and economical cultivation; as a rule, peasants lacked the capital to mechanize or ensure the upkeep of their farms and maintain the irrigation systems vitally important and necessary for agricultural production in the dry, arid Iranian countryside (only about 10–12% of Iran's land is suitable for cultivation).

Traditionally, as tenant farmers on the landed estates owned by the landlords, peasants had looked to those wealthy landlords for loans to help with these matters, but now the landlords no longer had a stake in the land or its productivity, and they had lost capital because of the land reform, so they mostly refused to grant peasants loans or help them out with these issues. As a result, peasants who now owned their own small plots of land had to turn to usurers (loan sharks), and quickly found themselves heavily indebted, yet even that did not help as the irrigation systems vital to Iranian agriculture fell into disrepair. Thus, the tractors provided to peasants on lands distributed by the Shah's reforms proved useless because without water for irrigation the land could not be cultivated. As noted, large estates that accepted the mechanization of agriculture by purchasing tractors and other farm equipment were largely exempt from the land reform, but this also greatly reduced the amount of labor needed on their farms. Consequently, the small farms granted to peasants often failed in a few years and many of the newly enfranchised small-landholders sold their new farms (often to their former landlords) and left, partly because their labor was no longer needed on the land, migrating to the burgeoning cities.

In sum, over the course of a few years it was apparent that, contrary to the Shah's (and his US advisers') intentions, the land reform was leading to an additional consolidation of land holdings and the displacement of thousands of peasants from the countryside by disrupting the traditional mode of agricultural production and disregarding the upkeep of the irrigation systems. Most of the displaced peasants moved to urban areas, where many faced unemployment, underemployment, and/or low wages because urban industrialization proceeded slowly. Between 1973–79, 8% of the rural population left for cities annually; by 1979, the year of the revolution, 50% of the Iranian population was urban, a dramatic shift in a relatively short period in a country that was traditionally overwhelmingly rural.

The Iranian economy grew significantly during the White Revolution. Oil exports continued to drive economic growth and the fact that the new agreement gave Iran half of the profits derived from its own oil helped. Industry also grew as did agricultural production, the latter at least partly owing to increased mechanization and despite the problems caused by the land reform. Between 1954–69 the Iranian economy grew on average by 7–8% annually and there was a general improvement in living standards across the board, although certainly the benefits of the growth were distributed very unevenly. The Shah touted these numbers as proof that his reforms were working. The country's population growth meant that the wealth generated had to be distributed to more people: Iran's population in 1900 was 12mn; in 1938 15mn; in 1950 19.3mn; in 1968 27.3mn; and in 1976 33.7mn. This expansion was mostly due to natural population growth, but immigration was also a factor as South Asians, Afghans, and others migrated to Iran to work in its oil fields and elsewhere.

The Shah spent much of the country's oil wealth in the early mid-1970s on weapons, building one of the largest armies in the world. He touted Iran as a crucial Cold War bulwark against Soviet expansion, and by the mid-1970s Iran had the fourth largest army in the world. Between 1972–76 the Shah spent \$10bn on arms from the US, and he spent billions more on weapons from the UK and elsewhere in Europe. In 1973 alone the Shah spent \$3bn in military hardware, mostly purchased from the US. That year saw a major war in the Middle East between Israel and its neighbors that led to an oil embargo against the US and Israel's European allies by the Organization of Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC), leading to a major spike in the price of a barrel of oil on the international market (which we discuss in greater detail in a later chapter).

Thus, oil-rich countries like Iran suddenly had tons more money pouring into its coffers; in 1973 Iran received \$4bn from the consortium for its oil, which by 1975 was up to \$19bn! By 1975 the Shah was spending an estimated \$5bn a year on arms and military matériel. Corruption compounded matters, siphoning off much of the oil money. In sum, contrary to its intended goal, and despite the measurable economic growth achieved, in the long run the White Revolution *increased* disparities between rich and poor in Iran. Thus, rather than stabilizing Iranian society and keeping radical revolution at bay, the White Revolution undermined social stability and contributed to rising revolutionary tensions.

Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini

By undermining social stability, the White Revolution contributed to opposition to the Shah. The question, however, was where would that opposition come from? The Shah had managed to crush Iran's secular opposition in the person of Mosaddegh, his National Front, and also the Tudeh, which had been severely repressed since the mid-1950s. The SAVAK did a great job eliminating secular opposition from students and organized labor. By

the early 1960s, therefore, opposition to the Shah came primarily from religious fundamentalists, anti-secularists among the ulama. Prominent among these was Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini (the term “Ayatollah” means “the miraculous sign of God,” a title reserved for a small group of ulama who are the most admired and respected among Shia clerics for their learning and integrity; it is not an official title, but when a cleric reaches a certain level of eminence, his followers simply begin calling him “ayatollah” as a sign of respect). Ayatollah Khomeini gained that title in 1961.

Born in 1902, Khomeini rose to national prominence in Iran by leading protests in 1963 against the Shah’s White Revolution. In a sermon he said, “I don’t know where this White Revolution is that they are making such a fuss about. ...God knows that I am aware of the hunger of our people and the disordered state of our agrarian economy. Why not try to do something for this country, for this population, instead of piling up debts and enslaving yourselves [to the West]?” Khomeini was arrested a couple of times for his outspoken critiques of the Shah’s regime. He was exiled in 1964 for speaking out against a new law that granted diplomatic immunity to US military personnel in Iran. Khomeini continued to criticize the Shah’s regime while in exile in neighboring Iraq; his followers recorded his sermons on cassette tapes and smuggled them back into Iran, where they were very popular. The themes of Khomeini’s lectures remained consistent: that the Shah was a puppet of US oil companies and weapons’ manufacturers. In 1970 he declared: “Huge amounts of capital are being swallowed up; our public funds are being embezzled; our oil is being plundered; and our country is being turned into a market for expensive, unnecessary goods [i.e., weapons] by the representatives of foreign capitalists and their local agents to pocket the people’s money.” His sermons harped repeatedly on these themes, which definitely resonated with Iranians, and his notoriety and popularity spread even though he was out of the country.

In 1970 Khomeini published a book, *Islamic Government: Governance of the Jurist* (Hokumat-e Elsami: Velayat-e Faqih), which spelled out a truly revolutionary theory of Islamic thinking, one that set Khomeini apart from clerics in both the Shia and Sunni realms: he argued that Islamic clerics should rule directly, rather than merely serve as advisers and consultants for monarchs and secular rulers, as had been the common practice in the Islamic world for many centuries. This view countered a thousand-year plus doctrine within Shia Islam prohibiting clerical leadership, earning Khomeini the ire of even other powerful Shia clerics within Iran and Iraq. From this point forward Khomeini called for the Shah’s removal from power and the establishment of an Islamic government ruled by clerics.

The Iranian Islamic Revolution (1979)

Over the course of the 1970s several factors converged to lead to the Islamic Revolution in Iran in 1979: the growth of religious opposition led by

Ayatollah Khomeini and the ulama; the discontent of small urban merchants (*bazaari*) whose native products were being undersold by foreign imports; and the migration of large numbers of displaced peasants to the cities where they faced poverty and unemployment. These factors, moreover, fed off each other because historically the most devout sectors of Iranian society have been precisely these groups, Islamic clerics (obviously), rural peasants, and urban merchants. It was only natural that these groups would ally against the Shah, and increasingly over the course of the 1960s and into the 1970s that is what happened. Add to this the fact that the Shah's regime was among the most repressive in the world (in 1975 Amnesty International proclaimed the Iranian government to be one of the world's worst violators of human rights), and one sees the extent of the problems mounting (the revolutionary clouds gathering) in the country.

The Shah did not foresee his country's pending collapse. Referring to a BBC broadcast in 1973 that discussed the chances of a social revolution in Iran, the Shah allegedly declared in anger, "What the hell do they mean 'the chances of a revolution?' Our farmers and workers are far too happy ever to contemplate becoming revolutionaries." A few years later revolution engulfed Iran. At the end of 1977 the Shah welcomed US President Carter to Tehran where cameras caught them clinking champagne glasses to ring in the New Year, leading devout Iranians to question the Shah's faith. A few weeks later Iran entered a period of prolonged conflict sparked by an article in a pro-government newspaper denouncing Khomeini. The story suggested that Khomeini was a foreigner (his grandfather had been born in India) and falsely claimed that he was formerly a British spy. The article led to massive protests in the southern Iranian religious center of Qom that spread to other parts of the country as well. In the following months there were frequent demonstrations and battles in the streets between militant anti-government youth and the Shah's armed forces. A cycle emerged in which Iranian troops called out to quell the protests would fire on the crowds and kill several protesters, creating martyrs for the cause, and then, after a forty-day period of mourning for those martyrs, the same scenario would recur.

During the month-long observation of Ramadan, the main Islamic holiday, the protests grew and a terrible incident occurred on August 19, 1978, the twenty-fifth anniversary of "Operation Ajax": arsonists set fire to a cinema in the southern oil city of Abadan and blocked the doors, killing an estimated 370–420 people inside. The Shah blamed Islamic extremists because of their dislike of cinemas, while anti-Shah groups blamed the SAVAK. To this day no one knows for sure who was responsible for this horrendous act, although after the revolution members of the SAVAK were held responsible and executed. The cinema was showing a controversial 1974 film, "Deer" (*Gavaznha*) by a leftist director and pioneer in Iranian cinema, Masud Kimiai. The film was widely perceived as critical of the Shah's regime and had a difficult time passing government censorship. But, at the same time, Islamic extremists were opposed to cinemas and not fans of leftist films. Regardless,

it was a turning point: most people blamed the Shah's SAVAK and as a result the demonstrations against his government grew after the fire as many people joined who had not up until that point.

The Shah declared martial law, but in defiance of the order, huge protests occurred on September 8 in Tehran and other major cities. In one of Tehran's main squares a large crowd of unarmed protesters refused to disperse and soldiers gunned them down. With over 100 casualties this day became known as "Black Friday," a rallying cry for anti-Shah protesters who began openly chanting "Death to the Shah" at the demonstrations. The cycle of protests and martyrdom ended in early 1979 when some troops began deserting and/or refusing to fire on the crowds. The Shah fled the country in January 1979 and Khomeini returned (from exile in Paris at that point) in February.

The Iranian military, dominated by secular nationalists, did not enthusiastically welcome the return of Khomeini, and in fact members of the Shah's elite imperial guard continued to fight against the revolutionaries. On February 11 Khomeini called on his supporters to defy a military curfew and protest, at which point many soldiers joined the crowds of protesters. Afterward Iran's military leaders announced that they would remain neutral and that troops would remain in their barracks, signaling a victory for Khomeini and his supporters. The Revolution had succeeded, and this is the day on which Iranians celebrate its anniversary; with overwhelming support (97%) in a national referendum the country became the Islamic Republic of Iran on April 1, 1979.

Initially secular figures, moderate nationalists in the mold of Mosaddegh (several of them supporters of Mosaddegh from the 1950s), occupied key leadership positions in the new revolutionary government. For example, Khomeini's first Prime Minister was Mehdi Bazargan, whom Mosaddegh had appointed to run the Iranian National Oil Company after it was nationalized in 1951. His Foreign Minister, Ebrahim Yazdi, had been a strong supporter of Mosaddegh in his youth and Abolhassan Bani-Sadr, another admirer of Mosaddegh, ran for and won the presidency in early 1980. However, Khomeini and his strongest supporters among the clerics soon turned the table on the secular nationalists—he had broadened his mass appeal by embracing them (supporters of the National Front) to help oust the Shah, but as soon as he began consolidating power he forced them out of the picture. Tehran's main street (formerly Pahlavi Street) had been renamed for Mosaddegh right after the Revolution, but then was renamed again (Valiasr Street) in 1981 in honor of the Twelfth Imam revered by Twelver (the majority sect) Shia Muslims—a sign that Mosaddegh's secularism was becoming intolerable to Khomeini and his extremist regime.

The US Hostage Crisis

In November 1979 Khomeini supporters seized fifty-two American hostages in the US Embassy in Tehran. Iranian students seized the embassy because US

President Carter allowed the Shah entry to the US for cancer treatment and the students demanded that he be returned to Iran to stand trial. The Shah died of cancer in 1980. The hostage crisis helped religious extremists within Khomeini's revolutionary circles emerge as the most powerful group therein over the secular nationalist leftist element within the leadership that initially had the upper hand. A very wide spectrum of Iranian society had supported the overthrow of the Shah, a much-hated figure by the end of his reign, and most could agree on that goal. Opinions on the path the new Shah-less Iran should take, however, varied greatly between the more religious segment of society and secular nationalists, many of whom by this time were very left-leaning in their political persuasion.

Thus, the Islamic government's greatest threat in its early months was the rise of a leftist movement gaining strength on college campuses throughout Iran. Khomeini wanted to normalize relations with the US at first until he realized that anti-American sentiment was so strong (a legacy of "Operation Ajax" and US support for the Shah) that he could use it for political gain. The radical Islamic students decided to seize the US Embassy without informing Khomeini beforehand as a domestic power move to steal revolutionary zeal from the leftists, but because of the immediate popularity of the move among most Iranians Khomeini capitalized on the opportunity to bring anti-American rhetoric into his narrative. He first referred to the US as the "Great Satan" the day after the hostage crisis began, and thereafter he incorporated stark anti-American language in his public statements, speeches, and sermons. The nationalist secularist leaders in the government, Bazargan and his entire cabinet, including Yazdi, resigned in protest against the seizure of the hostages, which unfortunately strengthened the hand of the religious extremists because their replacements were from that wing of the revolutionary leadership circles.

The Constitution of the Islamic Republic adopted by a referendum in early December 1979 further strengthened the power of religious extremists around Khomeini. It established a very unique form of rule, providing for a secular branch of government comprised of an elected president, a Prime Minister appointed by the president, and a single-chamber National Assembly (Majlis) elected by the people. However, a twelve-member Council of Guardians limited the power of this secular arm of the government with veto power over all laws and regulations on the basis of its interpretation of Islamic law, or Shariah. Thus, all aspects of law in the Iranian Constitution are secondary to the principles of Islam—there is definitely no separation of mosque and state. The constitution also created the uniquely religious position of the Islamic Jurist, who occupies the most powerful position in the governmental structure based solely on religious credentials. The Islamic Jurist appoints half (six) of the members of the Council of Guardians, while the other half is elected by the Majlis from among Islamic scholars nominated by the head of the Iranian judiciary, whom the Islamic Jurist also appoints. The first Islamic Jurist, of course, was Ayatollah Khomeini, who served in this role until his

death in 1989, a realization of the views spelled out in his philosophy calling for clerics to rule directly rather than accept a backseat position as advisers and consultants.

The Iran-Iraq War (1980–1988): the Iranian Perspective

Despite these developments—the hostage crisis and the referendum approving Khomeini's Constitution—favoring the more radical Islamists within Iran's revolutionary leadership, their hold on power was not completely solidified until the outbreak of the Iran-Iraq War a year-and-a-half after the revolution. In Iraq, Saddam Hussein in July 1979 took over officially as leader of the country (many had seen him as that country's behind-the-scenes leader for some time already). Iraq's population is majority (about 65%) Shia Muslim, mostly centered in the southeast corner of that country along the border with Iran, reflecting the fact that that area once belonged to Ismail's Safavid Empire in its early days. There was concern among the Iraqi leadership that the ideas of the Iranian Revolution might spread to their own Shia majority (Iraq had long been politically controlled by its Sunni minority). So, Hussein resurrected a long-standing disagreement over control of the highly strategic and important Shatt-al-Arab waterway that runs between the two countries and invaded Iran in September 1980. Hussein no doubt thought that at the very least he would be able to take advantage of the chaotic revolutionary situation in Iran to gain control of some of the islands between the two countries in the Persian Gulf. The start of the war cemented Khomeini's drive to radicalize the regime by allowing him to use religious propaganda amid a crisis to remove the final remaining secularists within the revolutionary government.

Iran's population outnumbered that of Iraq a little less than three-to-one (38.52mn to 13.65mn), and as noted the Shah had built up the Iranian military over the previous decades with high-tech weaponry from the West. However, Iran's military was in a state of disarray, with many officers either fleeing abroad because they did not support the revolution or being purged from its ranks (many were imprisoned and executed), leaving an unskilled force behind untrained to use much of the high-tech weaponry at their disposal. The Iraqis had signed a fifteen-year Friendship Treaty with the USSR in 1972 and had been importing Soviet weaponry and were in a good position to use it. The US and Iraq's oil-rich neighboring Arab states supported Hussein's Iraq and the US covertly supplied it with weapons while initially withholding much needed spare parts from Iran for the military hardware the Shah had purchased over the decades.

The Iranians raised large numbers of volunteers and sent wave after wave of troops against the better-equipped Iraqis, leading to very high casualties (an estimated 1mn Iranians were killed in the war). The early stages of the conflict centered in Iran's Khuzestan Province, where Iraqi troops initially pushed back Iranian forces. An Iranian counteroffensive in the spring of

1982 recaptured the region and forced Iraqi troops back to the border, at which point many in the Iranian leadership wanted to end the war. However, Khomeini wanted to spread the revolution to Iraq with its Shia majority (and beyond), so rather than stop the fighting he demanded that Iraq pay very heavy reparations and also that Hussein be removed from power, demands he (and everyone else) knew Iraq would not meet. So, the fighting continued for six more brutal, bloody years as the war bogged down into a stalemate with little movement by either side but high casualties and heavy damage to both sides.

Beginning in 1984 Iraq attacked Iran's shipping in the Persian Gulf in an effort to disrupt Iran's oil exports and the Iranians soon responded in kind, leading to "the Tanker War" stage of the conflict. Thereafter the US and others kept ships in the Persian Gulf to protect international waters and allow the safe flow of oil for the global economy. In July 1988 a US warship chased several Iranian gunboats into Iranian territorial waters and, believing that the Iranians had responded by dispatching a warplane to attack it, mistakenly shot down an Iranian civilian airliner, killing all 290 on board. With the fighting by the late 1980s long at a stalemate both countries resorted to bombing each other's capitals and major cities, causing high casualties and killing many civilians. Iran's Speaker of the Majlis (and future President) Akbar Hashemi Rafsanjani convinced Khomeini that the US would never allow Iran to win the war and in July 1988, shortly after the US shot down the Iranian plane, Iran accepted UN Resolution 598 calling for a cessation of the fighting and Iraq followed suit—the war ended exactly where it had begun, neither side had gained an inch of territory in eight years of incredibly bloody fighting.

Iran in the 1980s

The war coincided in Iran with a period of harsh repression by the regime against any hint of opposition. Immediately after the Revolution, Khomeini set up Revolutionary Committees (*Komitehs*) comprised largely of deserters from the military (those, in other words, who had come over to the side of the Revolution) and religious extremists. They rounded up leading figures of the Shah's ousted regime, held hasty tribunals and executed many of them, including, on February 15, only four days after the revolution, the former head of the SAVAK, General Nematollah Nassiri. Between 400–500 leading figures of the Shah's regime were executed within just a few months of the Revolution (many more were imprisoned). After executing its leaders, the new revolutionary regime used lower-level figures within the SAVAK to form the Ministry of Intelligence and Security (MOIS), which would prove to be every bit as oppressive as its predecessor.

Khomeini also ordered the removal of civil servants throughout the governmental bureaucracy suspected of secularist or anti-revolutionary sentiments and closed the country's universities to cleanse them of leftist

tendencies and impose Islamic principles therein. Most universities re-opened in 1982, though with much smaller faculties and student bodies than before the Revolution. Women were ordered to wear the veil (hijab) in public, regardless of religion or nationality, a reversal of Reza Shah Pahlavi's mid-1920s order to the contrary. This marked an abrupt shift especially for urban women, many of whom were not used to wearing the veil. Large numbers of women turned out unveiled to protest the decree at Tehran University on March 8, International Women's Day, 1979, but to no avail. Khomeini used the Komitehs to enforce this decree; women caught not wearing the veil in public or wearing attire otherwise deemed inappropriate were fined and multiple offenses could lead to their arrest. Most came to accept it as an unfortunate necessity of Iran's new reality.

Iran spread its revolutionary influence abroad to some degree in the 1980s, particularly with the creation of Hezbollah (The Party of God) in Lebanon that formed during a brutal civil war there that began in 1975. Hezbollah carried out an infamous car bombing that killed 241 US Marines in Lebanon in 1983. Backed by Iran and linked to the Iranian Revolutionary Guards, Hezbollah began kidnapping Americans, including a CIA station chief. Iranians began to question its government's fiery anti-American rhetoric, however, when news leaked in early November 1986 of a secret arms deal with the US to free the hostages held by Hezbollah. Six years into the war with Iraq, Khomeini's regime was desperate for weapons and spare parts for its military hardware, so it turned to the best possible source thereof, the "Great Satan," the US, which wanted the release of its hostages in Lebanon (and to covertly divert the resources from the arms sales to the Contras in Nicaragua despite US laws banning such support to that country's anti-Sandinista rebels, a conflict we discuss later).

US President Ronald Reagan secretly approved the sale of more than 2,500 TOW anti-tank missiles to Iran over the next two years. Hezbollah began releasing its American hostages, and all seemed to be going according to plan until a disgruntled Iranian cleric who had served in the prestigious Iranian Revolutionary Guard, Mehdi Hashemi, disgusted by his country's ongoing secret dealings with the US, exposed the information to a Lebanese newspaper, thereby sparking the Iran-Contra scandal (and leading to his execution). This meant that, despite a UN Embargo against supplying arms to either side in the Iran-Iraq War, the US was illegally, covertly supplying weapons to *both* sides in the war.

Iran's economy in the 1980s stalled because of various factors. In the months following the 1979 Revolution, Bazargan's government, responding in part to the persistent demands of the radical left, which, as noted, had a major voice at the time, nationalized fifty-one of Iran's largest private industries and businesses, as well as all banks and insurance companies. This was in part a move of necessity; the government had inherited most of these businesses by default after the owners either fled the country or were imprisoned as supporters of the Shah. Over the course of the decade,

while most of the major enterprises remained state-owned, some of these businesses, or at least parts of them, were parceled out in an informal privatization process to supporters of the Islamic regime, “insiders” (*khodi*), often the sons of leading clerics, former members of the Iranian Revolutionary Guards, veterans of the Iran-Iraq War or sometimes the families of soldiers martyred in the war. The war wreaked great damage to the economy (and to the country’s infrastructure) and lowered living standards; by the end of the decade per capita income had fallen by about 40% since 1978. In addition, the country’s economic problems were worsened in the 1980s by an influx of refugees from neighboring Afghanistan fleeing the Soviet-Afghan War in that country.

Khomeini died of cancer on June 3, 1989. His body lay on display in a cemetery on the outskirts of Tehran and an estimated 10–17mn mourners paid their respects in the largest funeral in human history. The plan was to take the body in a simple wooden coffin, reflecting the Ayatollah’s simplistic, spartan lifestyle, to a nearby cemetery for burial, but the crowd was far too massive to allow passage for a procession. So they attempted to remove his body by helicopter, but young men in the crowd grabbed the coffin and pulled it down, after which Khomeini’s body fell from the coffin and people in the crowd surged forward to try and touch the burial shroud that blanketed his body (eight mourners were killed in a stampede that occurred during the funeral). In 1992 a mausoleum was completed at the burial site of the Ayatollah Khomeini.

Iran Since 1989

Khomeini’s handpicked successor as Islamic Jurist was Ali Khamenei, president of the country at the time. Another major figure, almost rivaling that of the new Islamic Jurist Khamenei, was Akbar Hashemi Rafsanjani, the former Speaker of the Majlis who had convinced Khomeini to end the Iran-Iraq War. Elected president (replacing Khamenei in that position) in 1989, he served two terms, from 1989–97, during which he kept the country’s strict religious laws in place but privatized most of the state’s remaining economic holdings. These policies (along with the end of the Iran-Iraq War) led to limited economic growth and a relative stabilization over the course of the 1990s, though economic growth was hindered by harsh US sanctions. Conversely, for those in rural areas electricity, running water and health services were extended to almost every village in the country, even in distant outlying areas largely untouched by the Shah’s regime. Access to education also improved and literacy rates climbed from 37% in 1975 to 93% in 2015. So, despite undeniable problems, there were some tangible gains coming out of the Revolution.

In 1997 a moderate reformist, Seyed Mohammad Khatami, won presidential elections with 70% of the vote and also convincingly won re-election in 2001. Following the attacks on the US on September 11, 2001, the Iranian

government, both President Khatami and Islamic Jurist Khamenei, offered their condolences to the US and condemned the act, while ordinary citizens showed their sympathies with candlelight vigils in the streets of Tehran. By the end of his second term in 2005 Khatami had failed to make major changes because the hardline leadership, namely Khamenei and the Council of Guardians, blocked any attempt at reforming the stringent theocratic system (the Council, for example, vetoed a 2000 law allowing greater freedom to the press that had passed the Majlis).

Hardliners within Iranian leadership circles gained the upper hand, moreover, following US President Bush Jr.'s 2002 State of the Union address, in which he lumped Iran together with Iraq and North Korea as an "axis of evil." This may have been a contributing factor in the 2005 election of a very hardline president as Khatami's successor, Mahmoud Ahmadinejad. His controversial re-election in 2009 amid claims of electoral fraud sparked massive protests, the largest since the 1979 Revolution, in the so-called Green Movement (so named because the campaign color of his opponent, popular former Prime Minister and presidential candidate Mir-Hossein Mousavi, who almost certainly won the election, was green, the color of Islam). Sporadic protests began soon after the announcement that Ahmadinejad allegedly received two-thirds of the votes. The Council of Guardians and Islamic Jurist Khamenei endorsed the fraudulent election results, which undermined their legitimacy and that of the country's religious leadership in the eyes of many people. The regime clamped down harshly on the protests, which gradually ebbed owing to the government's strategy of arrests; blaming foreign influence; creating counter protests; and impeding Internet access. Mir-Hossein Mousavi remained under house arrest for a decade.

Ahadinejad's second term ended in 2013, and again the pendulum swung back to a more moderate candidate, Hassan Rouhani, who won Iran's 2013 presidential elections and re-election in 2017. His popularity during the re-election campaign stemmed in part from the 2015 deal he negotiated with US President Obama and other major world powers (China, Russia, UK, France and Germany) lifting sanctions on Iran in return for allowing international inspections of Iran's nuclear power program. However, after assuming office in 2017 US President Trump pulled the US out of the agreement. Criticism of the deal in the US stemmed in part from the fact that the US sent crates of cash in August 2016 totaling \$400mn to Iran in accordance with the agreement. This was a portion of the repayment for the amount already paid to the US by the Shah in 1978 for warplanes that were never delivered owing to the revolution the following year. The actual agreement would return \$1.7bn to Iran, including assets frozen in US banks after the hostage crisis, with the \$400mn as the first installment of that payment, which was in cash because Iran's foreign currency reserves were severely depleted.

In August 2021 Iranians again elected a more hardline conservative president, Ebrahim Raisi, perhaps at least partly in response to the US withdrawal from the agreement reached by Rouhani and Obama. In the fall of 2022

massive protests erupted in Iran following the death while in police custody of Mahsa Amini, a twenty-two-year-old Kurdish woman and Sunni minority arrested in Tehran in September by Iran's morality police for not wearing her veil in public. The police claimed that she died of natural causes (heart failure), but others alleged that the police beat her after her arrest. Soon protests swept across the country in which women removed their veils in solidarity. In some instances, women burned their headscarves and chanted anti-government slogans such as "death to the dictator" and "woman, life, freedom." The Iranian police cracked down with large-scale arrests as the protests grew and responded much as they had in previous protests, such as in 2009 following Ahmadinejad's supposed "re-election": they blocked Internet access, blamed foreign interference (primarily the US and Israel) for allegedly backing the protests, and organized counter protests by regime supporters. The protests quieted down after several months following numerous deaths and many arrests, but smaller protests erupted in the fall of 2023 on the anniversary of Amini's death. There have also been smaller protests over the past several years in response to Iran's growing economic difficulties. The country clearly faces some major challenges going forward.



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Map 7.1 Map of Iraq, Kuwait, and Syria.

7 Iraq, Kuwait, and Syria

The Persian Gulf Wars and the Rise and Fall of ISIS

Iraq and Kuwait

In the heart of the Middle East, Iraq with its capital at Baghdad and a population over 46mn as of 2025, is located in one of the world's richest and most fertile river valleys between the Tigris and Euphrates Rivers, known by its Biblical name Mesopotamia, or "the land between the rivers," one of the early breadbaskets of civilization. On the southeastern border with Iraq is the tiny, oil-rich state of Kuwait with its capital at Kuwait City and a population of almost 5mn as of 2023. A strategic and important part of the southeastern border region between Iraq and Iran is the Shatt-al-Arab waterway, which forms an outlet onto the Persian Gulf. Iraq has a very small coastline (twenty-six miles) along the strategically important Persian Gulf, which makes secure access to the Shatt-al-Arab waterway extremely important for Iraq.

Religious differences within Islam are significant in the Gulf region. Iraq's population is about 65% Shia (centered mostly in the country's southeast) and 35% Sunni Muslim, but political power historically has been in the hands of the Sunni minority until recent decades. Kuwait's Muslim population is about 55% Sunni and 45% Shia. The majority of the population in both Iraq and Kuwait are Arabs, a linguistic designation describing those for whom Arabic is their native language, although there are a wide variety of dialects of Arabic and a significant difference between the Arabic spoken in, say, Morocco and that spoken in Iraq. Nonetheless it is the same language covering a wide swath of the region from Iraq in the northeast to Morocco in the northwest, encompassing no fewer than nineteen states (and as many as twenty-two) in which the Arabic-speaking population is a majority. Arabs are the majority group in Iraq (75–80%) but there is also a significant Kurdish minority (15–20%), who speak a language related to Persian/Farsi, residing mostly in the northern mountains along the border with Turkey. About 58% of Kuwait's population are Arabs and around 40% are Asians from South Asia and elsewhere, most of whom work in the country's oil fields.

This entire region like most of the Middle East and much of North Africa was part of the Ottoman Empire based in modern-day Turkey. Although originally part of the Ottoman province Basra, now southern Iraq, Kuwait

developed a unique cultural identity and a great deal of autonomy. Kuwait's location along the Gulf coastline, its flat, open border and relatively small population and thus weak defense have made it susceptible to invasion. It was, as noted, taken over by the Ottomans, subsequently by the British, and then attacked on several occasions in the twentieth century as we will see.

The legacy of artificial borders in the region drawn first by the Ottomans and then the Europeans in the early twentieth century has contributed to long-term instability in the Gulf. The European powers (primarily France and Britain) set the modern borders at the Versailles Peace Conference (1919) after World War I following the collapse of the Ottoman Empire, although some minor alterations were made afterward. The European powers formed Iraq from three separate provinces of the Ottoman Empire based on the three major cities in the area: Mosul, Baghdad, and Basra (minus Kuwait, which broke away from Ottoman control and become a British Protectorate in 1899).

The first attack against Kuwait, which was still a British Protectorate, occurred shortly after the Versailles Peace Conference when Saudi Arabia invaded in 1920. The British intervened militarily and ousted the Saudis. A second attack on Kuwait occurred in 1961, this time by Iraq, which invaded and occupied the country after it claimed its independence from Britain, which again intervened to maintain Kuwaiti sovereignty, despite the fact that it was no longer a British Protectorate. This conflict was similar to the First Gulf War that would erupt in the region three decades later.

After World War I Britain ruled Iraq under a "Mandate," meaning that Britain was charged to facilitate Iraq's "progressive development" to become a fully independent state. The British created the Kingdom of Iraq as part of its Mandate, granting it independence in 1932 while continuing to maintain military bases there. In the early stages of World War II in May 1941, a pro-German clique of Iraqi military officers overthrew the Iraqi Prime Minister in a coup, prompting a British invasion that successfully ousted the pro-Nazi Iraqi government within a month of its formation. Iraqi oil, a major prize during the war, thus remained in British hands.

In July 1958 a group of military officers overthrew the Iraqi monarchy, killing King Faisal II, and established the Republic of Iraq. A decade later yet another coup brought the Ba'ath Party, an Arab nationalist and moderately socialist party, back into power (it had ruled briefly earlier in the decade) under the leadership of General Hassan al-Bakr. A key player in his government, Saddam Hussein, became the power behind the scenes in Iraq and officially became Iraqi president in July 1979 when Hassan al-Bakr stepped aside for "health reasons."

Iran-Iraq War (1980–1988): the Iraqi Perspective

As we have seen, the political balance in the region changed dramatically earlier that same year when the Ayatollah Khomeini came to power in Iran in a radical, fundamentalist Shia revolution. Hussein feared that the Iranian

revolution would spread to Iraq, which has a large Shia population centered in the southeast, and resurrected long-standing border disagreements with Iran over control of the Shatt-al-Arab waterway. A series of border clashes between the two countries erupted into war when, as we saw, Iraq invaded Iran in September 1980, sparking one of the longest and bloodiest conflicts in the post-World War II era.

The Iranians broke through Iraqi lines in 1982 and moved to within forty miles of Basra, Iraq's major city in the south. The war settled into a stalemate of trench warfare with lots of casualties but little movement by either side. Meanwhile, Hussein faced a rebellion of the Kurds in the north, who controlled large parts of Iraqi territory along the border with Turkey. The situation looked bleak for Iraq in the mid-1980s, but Hussein had one major factor on his side: the other Arab states (remember Iran is *not* an Arab state)—like Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Syria, and Jordan—did *not* want to see the radical Shia regime under Khomeini in Iran emerge victorious in this conflict. For that matter, neither did the US, a sworn enemy of Iran since the hostage crisis of 1979–81.

So, Hussein turned to the US and his Arab neighbors for help in the war with Iran. Kuwait and Saudi Arabia gave massive amounts of monetary aid to Iraq while the US sent secret (and illegal) arms shipments to Iraq. This came to light in the so-called “Iraqgate” scandal of the late 1980s revealing (along with the Iran-Contra Affair discussed earlier) that, as previously noted, despite the UN arms embargo against providing weapons to either side in the war, the US supplied weapons covertly to *both* Iran and Iraq during the war. For the US Reagan administration the war was beneficial because it kept the radical Khomeini regime occupied and maintained a regional balance favoring (perceived) US interests. The US was not the only country breaking the arms embargo: a French company provided Iraq's Hussein with the material to create chemical weapons, which he used against the Iranians in 1988 and then against Kurdish rebels in the north. Iraq regained lost territory in its war with Iran and the two sides signed a ceasefire agreement ending the conflict in a stalemate in 1988.

The First Gulf War (1990–91)

The Iran-Iraq War of the 1980s was one of the main root causes of the First Gulf War in the early 1990s. Both Iran and Iraq were devastated and in debt as a result of the long conflict. Iraq had taken out \$30bn in loans from both Saudi Arabia and Kuwait (\$60bn total) and needed more money after the war to rebuild its war-torn oil fields and its overall economy. Hussein wanted to earn part of the money necessary to rebuild the economy by increasing oil revenues, which he hoped to do with support from the international oil cartel of the Oil and Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC). Formed in 1960 by the world's largest oil producing countries, OPEC set production quotas for member states and thus controlled the price of oil on the global market.

In the 1980s, however, the power and influence of OPEC, which gained prominence in the 1973 oil embargo, an event we discuss in the next chapter, was on the wane. Hussein wanted to increase Iraq's oil revenues by convincing the OPEC states to raise the price of oil on the international market by decreasing overall oil production. If OPEC member states agreed to lower the supply and demand remained roughly the same the price would go up; an increase of \$1 per barrel on the international market would raise Iraq's income by \$1bn a year at that time. So, at the OPEC meeting in early 1990, Hussein tried to convince the OPEC states to decrease production. He also tried to get Saudi Arabia and Kuwait to forgive the \$60bn in loans the two states had made to Iraq during the Iran-Iraq War because, Hussein reasoned, Iraq had been defending the interests of all the Arab states during that conflict.

Saudi Arabia and Kuwait, however, rejected Hussein's proposals, both to decrease oil production and to forgive the loans. In fact, both countries continued to produce oil over-and-above the limits set by their OPEC-imposed quotas, which enriched the Saudi king and the Kuwaiti emir while infuriating Iraq's Hussein. Also, during the Iran-Iraq War of the 1980s while Iraq's attention was diverted the Kuwaitis used a special slant-drilling technique to siphon oil from the Iraqi side of the Rumaila oil field, one of the richest oil fields in the world that straddles the border between Iraq and Kuwait (though it is mostly located in Iraq). After the war ended Hussein demanded compensation for the oil revenues thereby lost to (stolen by) Kuwait, linking that to the talks asking Kuwait to forgive the \$30bn loan it gave Iraq during the conflict, but talks between the two countries broke down in July 1990 without an agreement.

These are the direct roots of the First Gulf War that began in August 1990 when Hussein's Iraqi forces invaded and quickly overran Kuwait. Two months before the invasion, in June 1990, the US State Department produced a lengthy report on the Middle East that called Hussein a "secularist" (important given the comparison with Iran) and "a key to stability in the region," describing him as "someone we can work with." Prior to the invasion Hussein notified the US ambassador to Iraq, who responded that "the United States has no opinion concerning Iraq's border dispute with Kuwait," which Hussein interpreted as a green light for the invasion.

Immediately after Iraq invaded Kuwait there were reports in the US and international media, most of them attributed to unnamed State Department sources, that satellite photos showed Hussein now amassing troops along the border with Saudi Arabia. This was the Bush Sr. administration's justification for dispatching the first 200,000 US troops to the Gulf. However, claims of Iraqi troops amassing along the border with Saudi Arabia were greatly exaggerated and Pentagon sources later admitted that no such mobilization had taken place (Soviet leader Gorbachev undermined such claims by releasing satellite photos proving that there were no troop movements). US forces were already mobilized by then and on their way to Saudi Arabia and war was imminent.

Another account at the time described how invading Iraqi troops allegedly pulled the plug on incubators in a Kuwait City hospital, killing twenty-two premature babies. This story was included in an Amnesty International report of human rights abuses by Iraqi troops in Kuwait and quoted by US President Bush Sr. as one of the reasons he was dispatching US troops to the region. This tale, however, was a total fabrication based on an “eyewitness” report to the US Congress by a fifteen-year-old Kuwaiti girl who had supposedly fled after the invasion. She was in fact the daughter of the Kuwaiti ambassador to the US and was in Washington, DC at the time of the invasion. Someone working in a Washington, DC, public relations firm hired by the Kuwaiti emir thought up the story to increase popular support for the emir’s cause with the American public.

Yet another example of misinformation stemming from this conflict involves initial news reports in the US greatly exaggerating the effectiveness of the US-made “Patriot” missiles, anti-rocket missiles used to shoot down Iraq’s Scud missiles, which Iraq fired at US troops in Saudi Arabia and also at Israel. The “Patriot” missile allegedly had a near 100% accuracy rating, and the stock prices for the company that makes the missiles skyrocketed during the war. However, in 1994, three years after the war, a Pentagon report revealed that the truth of the Patriot missiles’ accuracy was not quite so glorious: the Patriot often misfired and even when it did hit the Scud missiles it targeted the result was often worse because of the debris created by the mid-air explosion.

Furthermore, a great deal of evidence suggests that Saddam Hussein was willing, even trying, to settle things at the negotiating table. In late August 1990, about two weeks after the Iraqi invasion of Kuwait, the emir of Kuwait, from exile, offered the Iraqi government \$500mn as partial compensation for oil siphoned from its side of the Rumaila oil field and as the first step toward a negotiated settlement to the conflict. The US government, however, intervened and asked the Kuwaiti emir to withdraw the offer because, as the Bush Sr. administration said at the time, it “did not want Saddam Hussein to benefit from his act of aggression.”

Later in the conflict, in mid-October 1990, Hussein announced that he had had a “prophetic vision” telling him to withdraw from all of Kuwait except for two uninhabited islands off the coast of the two countries and the disputed Rumaila oil field. This was an obvious gesture on the part of the Iraqi dictator to avoid an all-out war, but once again the Bush Sr. administration’s response was that Iraq should in no way be rewarded for its act of “naked aggression.” Finally, any chance for a negotiated settlement was missed in January 1991, only days before the war began, when European leaders and members of the UN coalition organized by President Bush Sr. to oppose Iraq, including the Soviet Union’s Gorbachev, called for a peace conference of all belligerents to settle the crisis. The US, however, refused to participate in such a conference because it promised to raise the issue of the Arab-Israeli Conflict and the Palestinian call for autonomy (Hussein pointed out that this was

another example of a Middle East occupation). The Bush Sr. administration argued this issue was irrelevant to Iraq's occupation of Kuwait and refused to participate in the conference.

In short, a negotiated settlement to the conflict was not in the offing. The UN set a deadline of January 15, 1991, for Iraqi troops to be out of Kuwait, and when Iraq did not meet that deadline, the bombing began. Iraq immediately tried to widen the conflict by bombing Israel, hoping to draw that country in on the side of the US and thereby splinter Arab support for the coalition. It did not work, however, as Israel stayed out of the war despite several Scud missile attacks against it.

The US strategy in the war was one of "overkill," to soften up the enemy with a massive air campaign and unleash the ground attack only when it would meet with little resistance. The rationale was to reduce US casualties and thereby decrease the potential for opposition to the war in the US. As a result, US casualties were kept to a minimum while Iraq took heavy losses. US tanks with bulldozer equipment on the front buried Iraqi troops alive in the trenches they had dug before the war. The US Air Force devastated Iraqi troops in the desert as they were retreating from Kuwait on the so-called "desert highway of death." Coalition bombing campaigns continued in Iraq's three main cities, Mosul, Baghdad, and Basra, and several smaller cities as well, destroying an estimated 90% of Iraq's infrastructure (roads, railroads, bridges, factories and sewage facilities). His country quickly and easily defeated, Hussein sued for peace a few weeks after the ground war began in February 1991.

The First Gulf War was a major ecological disaster. Iraqi troops retreating from Kuwait set oil refineries on fire, and the fires burned for months after the war was over, pouring dark smoke into the air. Also, the bombing campaign hit Iraqi oil refineries along the Persian Gulf, causing millions of barrels of oil to spill into the Gulf. The bombing also hit Iraqi chemical-weapons plants, speculated to have been one of the causes of the mysterious Gulf War Syndrome countless US Veterans suffered from upon returning home.

The US-led international coalition stopped short of ousting Saddam Hussein. The coalition of countries against Iraq included Turkey, Iraq's neighbor to the north. This is significant because a large Kurdish minority lives in both countries—Iraq and Turkey—that had been fighting for independence for several decades. Spread out mostly in Iraq, Turkey, Syria, and Iran, the Kurds are the largest geographically contiguous ethnic group in the world without their own state. Until recent years they fought off and on (mostly on) against Turkey (mainly) for an independent state of their own. This put the US in a dilemma regarding the Kurds: if the US supported the Kurdish drive for independence against Iraq it had to support their claim for independence against Turkey, which is a member of NATO and a US ally. That said, the Kurds were clearly one of the main benefactors of the First Gulf War because they gained a great deal

of control in the oil-rich northeastern corner of Iraq around Kirkuk bordering Turkey and Iran, which in the 1990s and after became a semi-autonomous Kurdish region.

To protect the Kurds against attacks by the Iraqi Air Force the UN created a “no-fly zone” in the north, which meant that no Iraqi military planes could enter the northern zone where the Kurdish population lives. There was, however, no provision keeping Hussein from sending ground forces against the Kurds, which he did in the aftermath of the Gulf War in 1991 to reassert his dominance in the area. There were also extensive battles between Kurdish and Iraqi forces in northern Iraq in 1998, and Turkey sent forces across the border into Iraqi territory several times between 1996 and 1998 to fight Kurdish rebels.

The other dilemma for the victorious allies was in southeastern Iraq where much of the country’s majority Shia population resided. After the First Gulf War, Shia Muslims in southern Iraq rose up against Hussein’s regime, but he quickly and brutally put down the uprising. Under the auspices of the UN, the US and its allies responded by creating a “no-fly zone” in the south as well as the north to keep out Iraqi military planes. The US and its allies stopped short of completely annihilating Iraq’s military forces because they feared Shia fundamentalism in Iran more than anything else in the region; thus, the last thing they wanted to do was to somehow facilitate the rise of another, potentially pro-Iranian Shia regime in Iraq. So, in many ways, despite his many flaws, Saddam Hussein was the least of several bad options for the US and its allies, which explains why he remained in power for twelve more years after the First Gulf War.

After the First Gulf War Iraq faced an embargo on oil sales. Restrictions were relaxed in the mid-1990s, allowing Iraq to export some of its oil to raise money for humanitarian goods. However, Iraq’s population continued to face serious problems stemming from the war throughout the 1990s and early 2000s. Reports in the mid-1990s claimed that 500,000 Iraqi children had died because of the harshness of the sanctions. In an infamous interview on CBS’ “60 Minutes” in 1996, reporter Lesley Stahl asked US Secretary of State Madeleine Albright of US President Bill Clinton’s administration if she thought the price in Iraqi lives was worth it; she answered “I think this is a very hard choice, but the price, we think the price is worth it” to continue the embargo if it led to Hussein’s downfall.

However, it would eventually take military action to overthrow Hussein. The US bombed Iraq periodically after the First Gulf War, including in late 1998 on the eve of President Clinton’s impeachment hearings. The main reason cited for the bombings was Iraq’s non-cooperation with UN weapons inspectors. Hussein’s regime said it was not cooperating because the inspection team was infiltrated by US spies, which the agreement specifically forbid. The US State Department consistently denied the claim and condemned Hussein for not cooperating with the weapons inspectors. In January 1999, however, several months after the bombing and after the story broke in the

Lebanese press, the US admitted that, in fact, there were members of its intelligence community on the inspection team in a breach of the agreement.

The Second Gulf War (2003–11)

The terrorist attacks on the World Trade Center and the Pentagon on September 11, 2001, brought Iraq into the crosshairs of the administration of US President Bush Jr. After toppling the Taliban regime in Afghanistan, Bush made Hussein's regime in Iraq his next target. As noted in the previous chapter, in his State of the Union Address in January 2002 Bush Jr. included Iraq (along with Iran and North Korea) as a member of what he called an "axis of evil" in the global political arena. Over the next year administration officials and others made the case that Saddam Hussein was a threat to US national security because he was stockpiling weapons of mass destruction (WMDs), biological and chemical weapons but also possibly including attempts to restart a nuclear weapons program that had been nixed by international inspectors following the First Gulf War. Along with British Prime Minister Tony Blair the Bush Jr. administration pushed the case that Hussein posed a threat to global security, especially if he provided weapons of mass destruction to terrorists. Another reason stated for his removal from power was the fact that he ruled in a brutal, dictatorial fashion over the people of Iraq.

With a coalition of supporting states much smaller than in the First Gulf War (dubbed "the coalition of the willing") the US and UK (mainly) invaded Iraq in March 2003 owing *primarily* to allegations that Hussein's regime was stockpiling WMDs. However, they never found WMDs (the US gave up the search in 2005). US officials, notably Undersecretary of Defense Paul Wolfowitz, stated afterward that the case for WMDs was exaggerated because it was one reason for the war that most people could agree upon. In his State of the Union Address in January 2003, two months prior to the invasion, President Bush Jr. made dubious claims based on flimsy evidence that Hussein's government was trying to secure a source for weapons-grade plutonium from an African country. Even critics of the war admit that the removal of Hussein from power in Iraq was a positive step for the country and the region, regardless of the existence of WMDs.

An insurgency against US troops developed in the months following Hussein's ouster from power, leading to a very bloody conflict in Iraq between 2003–06. A small-scale civil war between Sunni and Shia militias vying for power especially in the capital Baghdad, a city with a mixed population of both, made a precarious situation even worse. US troops found themselves caught in the middle of a bloody sectarian war. US President Barack Obama withdrew US troops from Iraq in 2011. In the aftermath of the Second Gulf War for the first time in Iraq's modern history the government has been ruled by the Shia majority, which has at times repressed the Sunni minority in a reverse of their previous power relations. Critics of US involvement in the

region point out that the main “victor” of the Second Gulf War, if we can even speak in such terms, was Iran in that its neighbor Iraq now has a Shia-dominated government as well, one that at times at least has acted essentially as an Iranian client state.

Syria

Syria has a long and fascinating history and has been a crossroads of trade, communication, and cultural interaction for millennia. With a population of around 23.5mn as of 2023, much of the country in the southeast is defined by the Syrian Desert. Damascus, the capital of Syria, and the major city Aleppo are two of the oldest continuously inhabited cities in the world. The ancient Assyrian Empire thrived in the region for centuries and one or another empire ruled Syria for many more centuries following that, including the Roman Empire; the Byzantine Empire, which explains the lasting Christian presence in the region; the Arab Islamic Empire in the first decades of the rise of Islam in the seventh century (Damascus was the center of the Islamic Empire or Caliphate, specifically the Umayyad Caliphate, from 661 to 750); and the Turkish-Muslim Ottoman Empire, which absorbed Syria in the early sixteenth century and ruled it for about three centuries until its eventual decline and collapse at the end of World War I. Ottoman rule is significant because of their practice of favoring Sunni Muslims in local governance and in the case of Syria persecuting the Alawite (Shia) minority and at times trying to forcibly convert them (unsuccessfully for the most part) to Sunni Islam.

A solid majority (77–80%) of Syria’s population are Arabs, but like Iran and Iraq the country is also home to a significant Kurdish minority (about 10%). Islam is the dominant religion of Syria, but the population is split; about 60% of the Arab majority in the country are Sunni Muslims, and most of the Kurdish minority is also Sunni Muslim, so in total about 70% of the country’s population are Sunni Muslims. However, there are some very important non-Sunni minority groups as well, especially the roughly 12% of the population that comprises an Arab-Alawite (Shia) minority, which ruled the country from 1970–2024.

The Alawites are generally recognized as a minority sect within the Shia branch of Islam (although some Shiites dispute the association; Iran’s Ayatollah Khomeini in the early 1980s issued a fatwa or edict proclaiming the Alawites to be Shias). The Alawites revere Ali, the Prophet Muhammad’s cousin and son-in-law and Fourth Caliph, or successor, to Muhammad in the mid-seventh century. The exact origins of the Alawite sect are unclear but date back to as early as the eighth century, though it seems to have mainly taken root in the coastal mountainous region of modern-day Syria in the eleventh century. They have historically comprised mostly a rural, lower-class peasantry. There are pockets of Alawite minorities in neighboring Lebanon and Turkey as well. There is a great deal of secrecy around their faith, but the Alawites reportedly believe in reincarnation and in addition to

Islamic festivals and holidays also celebrate some Christian holidays such as Christmas and Palm Sunday.

There are also other smaller Shia-related sects, the Druze and Ismaili specifically, that together make up about 5% of the country's overall population, and there is a significant Christian minority within Syria as well, mostly Greek Orthodox—a legacy of Byzantine rule—and Armenians who combined total about 15% of the country's overall population. So, while Syria's population is predominantly Arab and Muslim, within those majorities there are some important divisions and some significant non-Arab and non-Muslim minorities.

Syria in the Twentieth Century

In the early twentieth century the European powers, in this case France, shaped the fate of Syria. Following the collapse of the Ottoman Empire at the end of World War I the newly formed League of Nations granted France a “Mandate” to rule Syria (along with Lebanon). The French faced opposition immediately, including a 1919 rebellion among the Alawite minority crushed by French forces. After quelling the unrest the French encouraged the Alawites and other minority groups to serve in Syria's pro-colonial government army to counteract Sunni political domination in Syria, which, to reiterate, was largely a legacy of Ottoman practices in the region. As a result the Alawites gained an influence disproportionate to their numbers and economic power within Syrian society.

Syria gained its independence from France shortly after World War II in April 1946. In 1958 Syria joined Gamal Abdel Nasser's Egypt in the short-lived (1958–61) United Arab Republic (UAR), touted as a step toward pan-Arabic unity. Unfortunately for Syria, it quickly became apparent that Nasser planned to dominate the UAR, which alienated Syria and led to its withdrawal from the UAR in 1961 following a coup by a group of nationalistic-minded Syrian military officers. A series of coups ensued within Syria, including a 1963 coup by a group of military officers in the Syrian branch of the Ba'ath Party, the same secular, socialist-leaning party gaining dominance at that time throughout much of the Arab world, including, as we saw, Iraq. One of the officers taking power in the 1963 Syrian coup was an Alawite Air Force General, Hafez al-Assad, who seized power in 1970 and declared himself Syria's president the following year.

This was a surprising development for Syria given the historical lower-class, minority status of the Alawite community and because the Syrian Constitution at the time stipulated that only a Sunni Muslim could rule as president. Assad changed that in the country's new constitution promulgated in 1973 and proceeded to rule for three decades. He brought political stability to Syria, albeit through a repressive form of rule, establishing a secularist, pro-Soviet socialist state in the Cold War that dealt a brutal blow to any form of opposition. In 1982 Assad crushed an uprising by the Syrian

Muslim Brotherhood, killing an estimated 20,000 Islamists and sending a very clear message that political challenges would not be tolerated under his rule.

Assad favored the Alawite minority in ruling the country, but he was also careful not to completely alienate other segments of society, including the Sunni majority, many of whom supported his secularist, socialist regime (and benefited from it). Assad managed to forge a secularist alliance of different groups within Syria and hold the country together with Soviet/Russian aid and an iron grip on political power until his death in 2000, when his son Bashar al-Assad replaced him as leader. Bashar was not expected to be the successor; he was an eye doctor educated in London who became heir only because his older brother Basil died unexpectedly in 1994.

Bashar al-Assad and the Syrian Civil War (2012–24)

When the younger Assad took power in 2000 he relaxed political restrictions in the country, creating a great deal of hope for reform. The first seven-eight months of his rule was called the “Damascus Spring” (recalling the 1968 Prague Spring) as he amnestied political prisoners, allowed for private-owned newspapers to operate outside of governmental control, and took other steps toward political reform for Syria. However, about a year into his reign Assad succumbed to pressure from the military establishment and political old order inherited from his father and began to reverse the reforms, including even re-imprisoning a number of prodemocracy activists he had initially let out of jail!

One development that prompted the reversal was an uprising by the Druze minority, a Shia sect like the Alawites, in late 2000. Syrian government forces crushed the rebellion and afterward Assad began to back off from some of his early reforms and rule more like his father with a very heavy hand toward any form of political opposition. In Syria’s 2007 “elections” Assad reportedly won 97.6% of the vote. He also accelerated policies promoting market reforms initiated by his father in the early 1990s after the collapse of the Soviet Union and end of the Cold War. One consequence of these policies was to significantly redistribute wealth in Syria into the hands of Assad’s Ba’ath Party and Alawite supporters at the expense of other groups.

Assad seemed genuinely shocked when the 2011 Arab Spring protests (discussed in an upcoming chapter on North Africa) spread to his country. In Syria as throughout much of the Arab world (and elsewhere) higher commodity prices due to the 2008 global economic crisis made basic food items more expensive, while educated young people had a difficult time finding adequate jobs to allow them to earn a living. The number of people in Syria below age twenty-five in the early 2010s was about 60% of its overall population. The unemployment rate at that time was around 20–25% country-wide and much higher among those under age twenty-five.

The Syrian uprising as part of the Arab Spring that led to that country's civil war began in the southern city Daraa. In March 2011 school children scribbled anti-Assad graffiti on a wall and authorities reportedly responded by cracking down harshly on them for doing so. Protests erupted and the Syrian police opened fire, killing four and sparking broader protests that spread and grew, meeting further government opposition and spiraling into a civil war by the beginning of 2012. Rebel forces gradually emerged as numerous different militias that were not at all unified (one estimate put the number of militia groups at around eighty) fought against government troops. Assad's government forces lost a lot of ground and by mid-to-late 2012 it seemed as though they were about to lose power. However, the rebels gained so much territory so quickly in part because the Syrian Army conceded outlying areas and isolated rural outposts to focus its forces in urban areas and build up resistance to rebel advances in the cities. Beginning in summer 2013 this strategy helped Assad's government forces retake several rebel strongholds.

Two key developments allowed Assad to turn the tide in the war in his favor by mid-to-late 2013: arms shipments to the Syrian government forces, including anti-aircraft missiles from Russia in early 2013, the significance of which was to forestall calls from the Western powers for a no-fly zone to be imposed in Syria; and an influx of soldiers to help Assad's government forces in April/May 2013 from among neighboring Lebanon's Hezbollah fighters who are also Shia (some of them Alawites), as well as troops from Iran (and definitely weapons from Iran). This was partly in response to the fact that from very early on in the Syrian Civil War rebel militias were bolstered by forces from all over the Sunni world so the conflict increasingly took on a regional Sunni vs. Shia character. As a result of the fighting the Syrian people have suffered *terribly* (many have fled, creating a huge refugee problem in neighboring countries and Europe). Estimates put the number of deaths in the conflict at between 500,000–600,000, making the Syrian Civil War one of the most violent conflicts of the twenty-first century.

Russia has a major naval base in Tartus, Syria—a remnant of the Cold War era—and was a staunch supporter of the Assad regime in the civil war. In September 2015 at Assad's request Russian President Putin dispatched Russian Special Forces, advisers, and private mercenary groups to Syria to fight against the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS; more on that group below) and other opposition groups. The Russians unleashed airstrikes against numerous rebel groups fighting Assad's Syrian government forces, some of which were supported by the US and other Western powers, most notably the Free Syrian Army (FSA) formed by military leaders who defected from Assad's government and army in the early stages of the civil war. The US under President Obama condemned Russian intervention in Syria and declared a new round of sanctions against Russia for supporting Assad.

The worst of the fighting in round one of the Syrian Civil War occurred between 2012–17. Russian forces allied with Assad helped the Syrian government army, further bolstered by Hezbollah and Iranian forces, retake

territory first from ISIS and then from the US-backed FSA and other rebel groups. US air power along with Kurdish militias on the ground also fought against ISIS, whose hold on a large swath of Syrian territory claimed early in the war was greatly weakened as a result. By 2020, the Syrian government had reclaimed and controlled about two-thirds of the country and was re-consolidating power. Fighting between Assad's government forces and its allies against remaining opposition groups had mostly subsided by 2023, leading to an uncomfortable stalemate in a still unresolved conflict.

The Turkish-backed *Hayat Tahrir al-Sham* (HTS), a coalition of at least five different Sunni Islamicist rebel groups based out of the northern city Idlib, which it had ruled for several years, broke the stalemate by undertaking an offensive. Originating at the beginning of the Syrian Civil War the group mutated several times over the years, both in terms of its composition and its alliances. The US State Department proclaimed it a Foreign Terrorist Organization in 2018. In late November 2024 HTS launched a surprise attack on Aleppo, seizing control of the city and the surrounding region. They pushed on from there with minimal resistance, forcing Assad to flee to Russia on December 8 as the rebels took control of the country. Most observers agree that this sudden, surprise defeat of Assad and his Ba'ath Party stems in part from a loss of Russian attention and resources (diverted by the war in Ukraine) and Iranian attention and resources (diverted by the war in the Middle East).

The leader of HTS, Ahmed al-Sharaa, who was born in 1982, has taken control of the country, shedding his Islamicist rhetoric of the past to project an image of moderation and diplomacy. He was previously known by his jihadist name Muhammad al-Jolani, a reference to the disputed Golan Heights region on the border between Syria and Israel from which his family originally hailed. Upon taking control of Damascus one of the first things al-Sharaa did was visit the city's ancient Umayyad Mosque. Many of the country's Shia Muslim and Christian minorities are concerned with their new leader's Sunni Muslim extremist past, though he has gone to great lengths to promote unity and say that his rule is not a threat to these groups. He has also assured the international community that he will not allow Syria to become a "launching pad" for attacks against Israel. As the country's new leader he faces a difficult balancing act: if al-Sharaa leans too far into a role of moderation he will likely lose the support of the many extremist Islamicists who helped him gain power in the first place.

In early 2025 al-Sharaa took on the "temporary" role of Syrian President, dissolving the Ba'ath Party that had been in power for over sixty years. He also dissolved other parties and armed groups, including HTS, hoping to form a unified national army. He promised elections but said that it may take up to four years to hold them. Sporadic fighting continued, especially between rival groups in the north. In March 2025 international media reported several hundred deaths, most of them civilians and many of them from the Alawite community, as pitched battles erupted in the streets of Aleppo and elsewhere

in the country between forces backing al-Sharaa's new government and loyalists of the ousted Assad regime. Reports in the coastal regions where the Alawites mostly live told of reprisal killings of entire families in some cases by Sunni forces loyal to the new government. Assuming al-Sharaa manages to cling to power, his government now also faces the question of whether or not those who remain from the old order will face accountability for their role in the Assad family dictatorship, which led to the imprisonment, torture, and deaths of many Syrians (so far there has been no movement in that direction). In short, the future of Syria in this transitional period and the broader region and al-Sharaa's role therein remain to be seen.

The Rise and Fall of ISIS

One consequence of the instability in Syria as well as the Second Gulf War was the rise of the aforementioned Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS), a terrorist organization that created a great deal of havoc in the late 2010s before eventually subsiding. What constitutes "terrorism," a theme of the book and a key issue in contemporary world history, is very much in the eye of the beholder ("one person's terrorist," as they say, "is another person's freedom fighter"). Terrorism involves instilling fear by randomly killing people (often—even usually—civilians) for political purposes and/or an ideologically-driven cause. Modern terrorism originated in the late nineteenth century in Russia with the People's Will, a group that fought against Tsarist rule in that country, and with the Irish Brotherhood, which fought against British rule in Ireland in the same time period. It is a byproduct or consequence of the rise of nationalism and democracy in the last 250 years or so because in situations of national or political oppression terrorism is often adopted as a strategy of last resort—the tool of the powerless as observers have called it. Terrorism is obviously the complete opposite of Gandhi's strategy of nonviolence.

Again, however, defining "terrorism" depends on one's perspective; ISIS's supporters see themselves not as "terrorists," an obviously pejorative term, but rather as "freedom fighters" (or jihadists) struggling against what they perceive as an unfair US-imposed global oppression. Terrorism, moreover, is not *entirely* the domain of oppressed peoples struggling for power, which further complicates attempts to define it. The oft-heard phrase "state-sponsored terrorism" refers to acts of terrorism carried out by an empowered state apparatus against a (predominantly) civilian population. In short, it is a complicated concept that is very subjective and difficult to define.

Most scholars attribute the emergence of Middle Eastern terrorism in the modern era to the rise of Western Europe during the period of colonial expansion vis-à-vis the Middle East and Muslim world from the late eighteenth to the mid-twentieth centuries. In the centuries prior the Middle East was on a par with or more developed than Europe with the Muslim Ottoman Empire based in Turkey at its height and the highly-developed

Safavid Empire in Persia/Iran. By the early 1800s the Industrial Revolution cemented Europe's rise in economic, political, and military power compared to the Islamic world (and the rest of the world too for that matter). In this view, terrorism arises as a backlash against European imperialism, which reaches its height after World War I with the collapse of the Ottoman Empire and, as we have seen, the creation of "Mandates" for the European powers to rule in the Middle East.

In 1924 Kemal Atatürk, the modernizing, Westernizing founder of modern Turkey, abolished the Caliphate, the Islamic religious leadership of "successors" to the Prophet Muhammad as part of his broader secularizing agenda. He argued that the Ottoman Empire weakened and lost World War I because it was *too* Islamic. His decision to abolish the Caliphate enraged many Muslims and became a rallying cry for those who believed exactly the opposite, that they should return to the pure early roots of Islam and reject Westernization in all its forms. Muslims, they argued, had strayed from true Islam, which explained why the Muslim world had fallen behind the West (especially in terms of military might). Over time, and especially with the formation of the Muslim Brotherhood in Egypt in 1928 by a devout teacher, Hassan al-Banna, extremists began to resort to acts of terrorism against the Western powers in the Middle East.

At times the Western powers utilized or even created (seemingly inadvertently) terrorist groups for their own political ends, such as during the Soviet-Afghan War of the 1980s. To defeat the Soviets in the last major proxy war of the Cold War the US CIA recruited Muslim extremists from the Arab world, including Osama bin Laden, a development that eventually led to the formation of al-Qaeda, the organization that perpetrated the 911 terrorist attacks on the US. The formation of al-Qaeda, furthermore, eventually led to the rise of ISIS, which is a direct consequence of the 2003 US invasion of Iraq that led to the conflict between Shia and Sunni Muslims ignited by the Second Gulf War. Abu Musab-al Zarqawi played the crucial role in fomenting tensions between Shia and Sunni Muslims. A Jordanian who traveled to Afghanistan in 1989 at the end of the Soviet-Afghan War, in the 1990s Zarqawi formed an extremist Sunni Muslim terrorist organization dedicated to creating an Islamic regime in Jordan. In the aftermath of the 2003 US invasion of Iraq he moved his group there and in October 2004 issued a statement pledging allegiance to Osama bin Laden and al-Qaeda, at which point his group became known as al-Qaeda in Iraq (AQI), a Sunni Muslim extremist group. This group over time evolved and mutated into ISIS.

Zarqawi's/AQI's strategy was to incite sectarian violence between Sunni and Shia by attacking Shia Muslims. As part of Zarqawi's campaign of terror against Iraq's Shia majority, in February 2006 during the Shia holiday Ashura, Sunni militants bombed and severely damaged the tenth century Golden Mosque in Samarra, a very holy site for Shia Muslims. Zarqawi succeeded in sparking a sectarian conflict in Iraq, although he did not live to see much of it as he died in a 2006 US airstrike. Between 2006–08 Iraq was embroiled in

a bitter civil war between Shias and Sunnis, with an estimated 3,000 Iraqis killed every month in that conflict at its height and with US troops caught in the middle. Much of the fighting occurred in the country's capital, Baghdad, home historically to a very mixed population of Shia and Sunnis. The Shias, who comprise a significant majority of the Iraq's population, managed by the end of 2008 to largely purge Baghdad of its Sunni population, turning the city into a Shia power base.

The Sunni extremist AQI established itself as an alternative government or rogue state in the Western Anbar Province, a sizable but sparsely inhabited (mostly desert) area that borders Syria, Jordan, and Saudi Arabia. Following Zarqawi's death Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi emerged as the group's leader and renamed AQI the Islamic State of Iraq (ISI). The group alienated the predominantly Sunni population of Anbar Province because of its draconian Taliban-like policies, leading to a backlash against it in 2007 in the form of the Sunni/Anbar "Awakening." This entailed the emergence of Sunni militias who, with the support of the US, defected from, fought against, and ultimately defeated ISI. The Sunni Awakening coincided with a "surge" of US troops into Iraq in the mid-2000s and involved US payments to local militias in exchange for their support against ISI. The policy worked, turning the tide against ISI rather quickly (and thankfully ending the brutal Shia-Sunni Civil War in Iraq by 2008 as well).

The ISI remained a force, however, and, defeated in Iraq by the Sunni/Anbar "Awakening" and the US troop surge, the group moved to Syria (thereby becoming ISIS) with the onset of that country's civil war in 2011 to take advantage of another chaotic situation (terrorist groups both foment and feed off chaos at the same time). In 2012–13, now operating out of Syria, ISIS began to attack Iraqi prisons and release Sunni prisoners in operation "Breaking the Walls." They pursued this strategy successfully for a couple of years and in June 2014, to the shock of the world (after US President Obama referred to them disparagingly as a "Junior Varsity" team), ISIS forces took the major northern Iraqi city Mosul. Their goal was to attack the prison and free its Sunni prisoners; however, as ISIS forces advanced on the city, Iraq's mostly Shia army collapsed, fleeing and leaving tons of weaponry behind. During its drive through Iraq ISIS captured and massacred as many as 1,700 Iraqi troops, mostly Shia Muslims, at a military base near Tikrit.

After taking Mosul in June 2014, al-Baghdadi, who traced his ancestry to the Prophet Muhammad's Quraysh tribe (one of the main requirements to be Caliph), proclaimed himself the new Caliph, a position which, as noted, had been abolished in 1924 by Turkey's Atatürk. For about three years (2014–17) ISIS ruled a large territory, declared the Caliphate, a political-religious state led by a Caliph (al-Baghdadi), spanning territory from Mosul in northern Iraq south and across the Syrian border, most of it sparsely inhabited territory in the Syrian Desert. They attracted extremist recruits from around the world, including Europe and the US.

The ISIS Caliphate ruled harshly while facing military opposition from the Syrian regime as well as US air power combined with Kurdish militias seeking to uproot it. As a result, between 2014–17 ISIS lost 95% of the territory it once claimed as its Caliphate, and by 2019 it had been completely removed from its last stronghold in Syria. Remnants of ISIS remain, mostly as small terroristic pockets in parts of North Africa, Afghanistan, and elsewhere. In April 2024 a group labeling itself ISIS-K associated with Central Asian extremists attacked a crowded music theater in Russia near Moscow killing 130 people and injuring many more. The role of ISIS in the global arena in its now various splintered forms remains to be seen.



Map 8.1 Map of Israel/Palestine.

8 The Arab-Israeli Conflict

Israel/Palestine is small, though with a sizable population (combined) of almost 15mn. Located at the crossroads of Asia, Africa, and Europe, Israel/Palestine historically has been subjugated to many different outside rulers in an area of vibrant trade and cultural interaction. Israel/Palestine lacks fresh water sources and access to fresh water is a major issue in the region. The main sources of water are underground aquifers and the Jordan River that forms the border between Israel and Syria in the north and Jordan in the east.

The names “Israel” and “Palestine” derive from two peoples who emigrated into the region in large numbers at approximately the same time, 1200 BCE (about 700 years after Abraham first wandered into this “promised land” according to the Biblical chronology). The Jews called themselves Bnei Israel (“the people of Israel”) and believed that the land had been given to them by God. Palestine derives from the Philistines, a Greek-speaking people who settled the coastal plains of the area at about the same time the Jews settled Judea, the hilly countryside in the interior—now known as the West Bank (the first written reference to the region as Palestine in the historical sources appears in the work of the Greek historian Herodotus in the fifth century BCE). After about 200 years the various Hebrew tribes of Israel united to defeat and subjugate the Philistines and other peoples in the region, most notably the Canaanites, establishing the Kingdom of Israel 1000 BCE under the leadership of Kings Saul and David. King David’s son, King Solomon, built the first temple to the Jewish God *Yahweh* in Jerusalem, the focal point of Judaism and Jewish worship from that time onward.

At the time of Christ Jews mostly inhabited the hilly region of what is today the West Bank and were ruled by the Roman Empire. The Israelites rebelled against Roman rule between 66–73 CE, but the Romans crushed the rebellion and destroyed the Jewish Temple in Jerusalem. All that was left standing was the Western (or Wailing) Wall, thereafter—and to this day—the most sacred site in Judaism. The temple was built on a rock believed to be the site on which Abraham prepared to sacrifice his son Isaac to God; Muslims

believe that Muhammad ascended to Heaven from this same holy rock *many* centuries later.

Following a second failed revolt against Roman rule in the second century (the Bar Kokhba Revolt, 132–135 CE), the Romans exiled the Jews from their homeland and scattered them throughout the Mediterranean world and beyond, eventually up into Europe in an extensive diaspora or scattering of the population. Although Jews maintained a presence in what is today Israel/Palestine outside of the immediate surroundings of Jerusalem, after their forced exile for the next 1,700 years they lived without a homeland, many of them eventually in Europe, where they faced second-class citizenship, discrimination, persecution, and violent repression in periodic “pogroms,” or anti-Jewish riots. A long history of European anti-Semitism culminated with the Holocaust during World War II. Through it all, and despite constant pressure to assimilate into the societies they lived in, Jews maintained a separate linguistic (Hebrew/Yiddish), cultural, and religious identity.

Most scholars agree that the direct ancestors of the modern Palestinians moved into the area in the seventh century CE, conquering the area that is today Israel/Palestine between 635–640—Jerusalem, the “City of Light,” fell to the Arabs in 638—so about five-hundred years after the Jews had been exiled from the region and several centuries after the fall of the Roman Empire. However, some Palestinians trace their origin and heritage much earlier, to the aforementioned Philistines and Canaanites originally conquered by the Israelites in Biblical times.

The Arabs are a Semitic people related ethnically and linguistically to both the Canaanites and the Israelites. The term “Arab” first occurs in the written sources in Assyrian/Babylonian texts from the eighth century BCE, referring to camel herders of the desert. For most of their history Arabs were nomadic herders known as Bedouin scattered in clans or tribal groupings throughout the Arabian Peninsula and often engaged in warfare for pasturelands and scarce sources of water. That changed with the rise of Islam in the seventh century, the work primarily of the Prophet Muhammad, believed by Muslims to be the last in a line of prophets sent by God (Allah in Arabic) to reinforce the message of monotheism originally given to Abraham but since forgotten.

In the years following Muhammad’s death in 632 CE Islam spread at a remarkable pace, partly through peaceful conversion and partly through warfare and conquest. The Arab Muslim conquest of Israel/Palestine between 635–640 marked the beginning of a lengthy period of Muslim rule with one crucial interruption—the invasion and rule of Christian Crusaders, who captured much of Israel/Palestine in the final decade of the eleventh century and held on to parts of it for almost 200 years before they were ousted completely in 1291. Thereafter most of the region fell under Egyptian rule until the Ottoman Turks took Palestine in 1517 as part of their expansion that had begun roughly a century-and-a-half earlier. The Ottomans ruled the area until the end of World War I, which as we know led to the collapse of the Ottoman Empire.

The Zionist Movement

A crucial turning point in the eventual formation of the modern state of Israel was the late nineteenth century emergence of the Zionist Movement, a consequence of the rise of nationalism in Europe. Jews in Eastern Europe created the Zionist Movement, the name of which comes from “Zion,” a Hebrew term for Jerusalem. An early leader of the movement was Theodor Herzl, and the main goal of the movement, which formed in reaction to growing nationalist and anti-Semitic sentiments in Europe, was the re-establishment of a Jewish homeland in Palestine. Initially they considered other possible sites for a homeland, including Argentina, Uganda, and Kenya, but the Zionists settled on Palestine as the main goal of their movement because it was the Biblical homeland of the Jews. However, Arabs inhabited the area, which at the time belonged to the Ottoman Empire. There was a significant Jewish minority in Palestine prior to the Zionist movement that lived peacefully with the Palestinians, but relations between the two groups became more strained with the advent of Zionism.

In the mid-nineteenth century Ottoman rulers created a land market for the buying and selling of land in Palestine (as throughout the empire), something that prior to the 1858 Land Reform had not existed. The Ottomans carried out the reform to privatize land and clarify who owned what land to levy taxes more efficiently as state revenues had fallen sharply over recent years and the empire was in debt because of the Crimean War (1853–56). Traditionally Palestinian villagers farmed the land communally (mostly) or if individual families farmed specific plots of land everyone in the village knew who farmed which plots, with the occasional disputes settled by village elders. Private landownership, which the reform created, was an alien concept; the reform required villagers to register their land, a process open to manipulation and corruption. Often urban merchants and local Ottoman administrators registered large swaths of land, the ownership of which was unclear, in their own names, thereby becoming absentee landowners—meaning that they legally owned the land but did not physically live on it nor work it themselves. The local villagers, whose families in many cases had resided on and tilled the land for generations, thus became tenant farmers of these new absentee landowners, paying rents to them while the new landowners in turn paid taxes on that income to the Ottoman state. A subsequent change in the law the following decade allowed property in the Ottoman Empire to be sold to foreigners, which years later opened the door to Zionist settlement in Palestine.

Zionist settlers, in short, were able to realize their dream of creating a homeland in Ottoman-controlled Palestine by purchasing land in this newly created land market in the late 1800s. European Jews raised money through the Jewish National Fund (JNF) and gradually bought up land in Palestine from absentee (often Arab) landlords. Zionist settlers who used JNF funds could not sell land back to Arabs, and thus they gradually established a

foothold in Palestine. European Jews had *a lot* more resources to draw from than even the wealthiest Arab absentee landlords; land prices in Palestine were low for European Jews because of a relative lack of resources within the Ottoman Empire—a lack of capital in the Ottoman Empire in comparison with Europe kept land prices low—and so the Zionists were able to purchase land at what for them were relatively cheap prices. Land value had not been firmly established in the Ottoman Empire's new land market—the very concept of land ownership was not clearly defined. Between 1895–1914, 40,000 Jews from (mostly Eastern) Europe migrated to Palestine, taking advantage of the Ottoman reform laws and relatively low land prices to buy up and settle land mostly at first in the (comparatively sparsely inhabited) coastal regions using money from the JNF to do so.

Over time, as more and more Zionist settlers immigrated to Palestine and began buying up land in more densely populated areas, the Palestinian-Arab tenant farmers who had previously cultivated the land and paid rent to an absentee Arab landlord were either displaced or became paid laborers for the new Jewish landowners, who worked the land themselves with wage laborers rather than renting the land out to tenants. This amounted to a major drop in status for the Arabs and led to a great deal of resentment among them. The early Jewish settlers maintained a strong separatist sentiment and did not seek to assimilate with the local population (unlike the Jews who had lived there prior to the advent of Zionism). Along with an ideological slant toward socialism, this led to a unique type of social structure, the *kibbutz*, which means “commune” or “community.” The *kibbutzim* were intended to strengthen the Jews’ position in Palestine through unity—making it a very segregationist entity—and by pooling their resources—making it a socialistic structure—rather than having Jewish farmers compete among themselves. By 1914 there were forty-four Jewish agricultural settlements in Palestine of about 100,000 acres, and several of these were *kibbutzim* of various sizes (Jews at the time were about 10% of the overall population of Palestine).

The British Role

Europe, specifically Great Britain, played a major role in the developing Arab-Israeli Conflict in the early twentieth century. In 1917 during World War I, Britain released the Balfour Declaration, which supported the Zionist cause of creating a Jewish homeland in Palestine. Britain wanted to win the support of both American and Russian Jews for the British cause in World War I and they saw Jewish immigration as a potential check on France’s influence in the region. The British also stated their support for an Arab state in the region because they wanted to win Arab support for the war also. Arabs nonetheless interpreted the Balfour Declaration as being against their interests and protested it vehemently as anti-British and anti-Zionist demonstrations emerged all over Palestine.

In 1919 following World War I Britain received a Mandate from the newly formed League of Nations to rule Palestine and several other areas of the Arab world (including Iraq as we have seen and Transjordan at the time, modern-day Jordan; France, as we have also seen, received Mandates to rule Syria and Lebanon). As noted earlier, a Mandate meant that the foreign powers would maintain their presence indefinitely and oversee a gradual transformation to self-government. The Balfour Declaration and British Mandate in Palestine strengthened Jewish claims to a homeland in the region; Jewish immigration to Palestine grew gradually in the 1920s, at the rate of about 10,000 new settlers a year, and then very rapidly in the 1930s, from 55,000 (10% of the population) in 1918 to 450,000 (30% of the population) in 1939. Part of the Jewish immigration in the 1930s was due to persecution in Nazi Germany, and a lot of the immigration was done illegally, circumventing existing laws and quotas established by the British at the insistence of Palestinian Arabs.

The Palestinian-Arab population did not exactly welcome such large numbers of Zionist settlers, especially as they expanded into areas densely inhabited by Arabs. As their numbers increased so did the tensions; in the 1930s there were some isolated clashes between Jews and Arabs, and in 1936 a major uprising by Palestinian Arabs began that lasted three years. The British responded with an abrupt change in immigration policy, issuing the White Paper in 1939 seeking to limit Jewish immigration into Palestine (to 75,000 over the next five years), restricting further land sales to Jews, and leaving the area soon and giving the Arabs control (i.e., not creating an independent Jewish state). The British government justified the White Paper based on civil strife within Palestine, saying that it needed to slow Jewish immigration in order to maintain domestic stability in Palestine. Britain, however, may have had other motivations as well, such as protecting British oil interests in the Arab world and securing Arab support in a potential war with Germany.

Britain has been (and was at the time) harshly criticized for this abrupt policy change. This was during the early stages of the Holocaust, a year after Kristallnacht in November 1938 (the “Night of Broken Glass” when Nazi thugs attacked Jews and Jewish-owned businesses all over Germany), the early stages of Hitler’s “Final Solution” to exterminate the Jews, and it was precisely at this time that Jews needed to flee most of all. But limitations on Jewish immigration to Palestine and strict anti-immigration laws in Britain, France, the rest of Europe, and the US, due in large part to the Great Depression, made Hitler’s Holocaust worse than it might have otherwise been.

For the Jewish settlers in Palestine, however, things had changed greatly since 1917 and the Balfour Declaration, and they were less dependent upon Britain’s good will than they had been in the earlier period. Also, the Holocaust gave a greater moral imperative to Jewish claims for a homeland, and British control in the region was weakened by World War II. Palestinian leaders, moreover, were tainted by their association with Hitler’s anti-Semitic

Nazi regime; the Mufti, the chief legal representative of Muslim Palestinians from the early 1920s, met with Hitler in November 1941 and afterward recorded some highly anti-Semitic thoughts in his diary.

In the last few years of World War II and after, 1943–47, Jewish militias in Palestine armed themselves (mostly by raiding British weapons depots in Palestine) and some of them (Irgun and Stern Gang among others) resorted to terrorism in their struggle both against the British and the Arab majority. The most infamous act of terrorism by one of these groups, Irgun, was the bombing of the King David Hotel in Jerusalem in July 1946, in which ninety-one people were killed. One of the leaders of the group that carried out this terrorist act was Menachem Begin, who later became Prime Minister of Israel in the 1970s; as Prime Minister he steadfastly refused to negotiate with the PLO because, he said, they were terrorists—as we have noted, “terrorism” is a very subjective concept: “one person’s terrorist is another person’s freedom fighter!”

The immediate post-World War II conflict culminated in Israeli Independence (1948). In its weakened position after World War II, Britain was not able to deal with the increasing domestic strife in Palestine between Arabs and Jews. The British began withdrawing from Palestine in 1947, leaving the country in a state of civil war between Jewish and Arab militias and the problem for the newly created UN to solve (as we saw, Britain also withdrew from India in 1947, so this is part of a broader strategy to scale back its considerable colonial possessions).

The UN proposed partitioning Palestine into separate Jewish and Arab states (based on this plan the area around Jerusalem and Bethlehem would be an international city administered by the UN), but the Arabs adamantly opposed and rejected this proposal, arguing that the Zionists had no right to an independent state in the area at all. Thus, the civil war between the two sides continued. In 1947 the main Jewish militia, the Haganah, received an arms shipment from Czechoslovakia and went on the offensive, seizing new territory—obviously the course of the civil war, not the UN, would decide the fate of Palestine. Soldiers in the Jewish militias had benefited greatly from their military experience fighting alongside the British in World War II, whereas few Arabs had fought.

The 1948 War

During this phase of the war one of the worst atrocities of the conflict took place. On April 9, 1948, the Jewish terrorist group Irgun—along with a smaller, more extremist group called Lehi—attacked the Arab Palestinian village of Deir Yassin, which had negotiated a truce with the leaders of Haganah, the main Jewish militia, killing between 100 and 200 people (neighboring Jewish villagers intervened and put an end to the massacre, saving untold numbers of their Palestinian neighbors by doing so). The brutal attack seemed designed to *intentionally* terrorize the Arab population and

force them to flee. Irgun members drove around and announced their deed to neighboring Arab villages from mobile loudspeakers and openly threatened more attacks if the Arabs remained. In the aftermath of Deir Yassin, 50,000 Arabs fled in the next three days; by mid-May over 300,000 Arabs had fled. A key leader of the JNF had stated in February that the Zionists should undertake a policy “promoting measures designed to encourage Arab flight” and refusing to allow those who fled to return. Most of the Palestinians leaving took few possessions because they thought that they would be back in a few weeks at most; they have never returned.

On the battlefield the Jewish militias soundly defeated the Palestinian militias. Thus, when the last of the British troops withdrew from Palestine on May 14, 1948, Jewish leaders declared independence in the territory they controlled; both the US and the USSR recognized the newly independent state, giving the declaration legitimacy. The US was the first country in the world to officially recognize the new state of Israel, doing so because it was trying to gain a greater foothold in the Middle East and because incumbent US President Harry Truman wanted Jewish support in his tough re-election campaign (Truman cited the Holocaust as a factor in the speech announcing his decision). The USSR recognized Israel to decrease Britain’s role in the area and because the Soviets saw the kibbutzim model of socialistic settlements by the Zionist Jews as ideologically favorable.

For the neighboring Arab states, however, Israeli independence had no legitimacy at all, and they decided to invade and solve the problem themselves. A coalition of Arab states consisting of Egypt, Syria, Jordan, Lebanon, and Iraq (Saudi Arabia sent a small, token force) attacked Israel from all sides. The outcome was disastrous for the Arabs. During World War II the Jews in Palestine had built up an impressive military force; though slightly outnumbered, Israeli forces were well trained, well led, and unified whereas the Arab forces were poorly armed and lacked unity. The disunified Arab forces fought for their own goals rather than for the good of the Palestinian people, which hurt their cause.

Israeli forces won easily, extending their territory over what it had been at the time of their declaration of independence. For the Israelis, this was a war for Independence (a lot of Israeli Jews—and others—saw their victory in religious terms), and it is celebrated as such to this day. For the Palestinian Arabs, conversely, this was a war of conquest, *al Nakba*, the Catastrophe as they call it. Between 400,000–450,000 Palestinians were expelled or fled (this in addition to the 300,000 who had already fled). Of the 860,000 Palestinians who prior to April 1948 had lived in the area now under Israeli control, only 133,000 remained afterward. The rest entered refugee camps in the West Bank (controlled by Jordan after 1948), the Gaza Strip (controlled by Egypt after 1948), as well as Lebanon, Syria, Jordan and, to a lesser extent, Egypt and Iraq. In total, about 750,000 Palestinian Arabs became refugees from the war in 1948, creating one of the largest and longest-standing refugee problems in the world.

In the years following the 1948 War many Jews immigrated to Israel, shifting the demographics in favor of the Israeli state. Israel called upon Jews from around the world to come to the homeland in a formal decree, the 1950 Law of Return, which permitted any Jew (defined as someone with at least one Jewish grandparent) to enter Israel and receive Israeli citizenship. Consequently, between 1949–52, Israel's Jewish population more than doubled with 665,000 new arrivals, about equally divided between Jews of European origin (Ashkenazi) and those of non-European origin (Sephardic). Most of the latter came from Arab countries that pressured or forced them to leave, i.e., Iraq and Yemen, but also Algeria, Tunisia, Morocco and Libya.

Increasing Jewish settlement heightened tensions and there were regular border "incidents" in the late 1940s and early 1950s. Though no major wars broke out, Palestinian infiltration and Israeli retaliation, especially along the Jordanian (West Bank) border, defined Palestinian-Israeli relations in this period. In 1953 the Israeli government formed Unit 101 led by Colonel Ariel Sharon to carry out punitive expeditions into Arab-controlled territory. To take but one example, in October 1953, following the murder by Arabs of an Israeli mother and her two children, Unit 101 attacked the Palestinian village Qibya on the West Bank, destroying the village's houses, killing over fifty inhabitants, and wounding countless others. The intent of the Israeli response was to impose a price on the Arab community disproportionate to the crime committed against the Israelis in order to deter future acts.

Suez Canal Crisis (1956)

The next major crisis erupted in 1956, the Suez Canal Crisis, this time with the Israelis taking a more offensive role. A major country in the Arab-Israeli Conflict is Egypt, where the highly strategic Suez Canal connecting the Mediterranean and Red Seas, co-owned by British and French companies, opened for operation in 1869. In 1952 Egyptian army leader Gamal Abdel Nasser came to power with the goal of gaining control of the Suez Canal. Nasser was an ardent supporter of pan-Arabism, a belief originating in the nineteenth century that all Arab states should unite to defend themselves against the threat of European imperialism (we touched on the short-lived Egyptian union with Syria, the United Arab Republic that existed from 1958–61, in the previous chapter). In 1955 Nasser began accepting Soviet military assistance, and in 1956 he nationalized the Suez Canal, seizing control of it from its British and French private owners and claiming it as property of the Egyptian government. This was a major threat to European business interests because most of their shipping passed through the canal.

In response to Nasser's nationalization of the Suez Canal, Britain, France, and Israel planned a pre-emptive strike against Egypt, keeping it secret from the US (President Eisenhower and Secretary of State John Foster Dulles were irate about this). The Israelis invaded Egypt's Sinai Peninsula in October 1956, while British and French aircraft began bombing Egypt around the

site of the canal shortly thereafter. French and British troops landed at the Canal Zone in November but failed to retake control of the canal (in fact, as a result of the invasion, Egypt put damaged ships from the fighting into the canal, blocking passage for months to come!). The US, worried that the USSR might take the opportunity to send troops to Nasser's defense, which was unlikely because the Soviets had invaded Hungary at the same time as the Suez Canal Crisis, intervened through the UN and demanded that all foreign (i.e., Israeli, French, and British) troops be withdrawn. By early 1957 everyone had withdrawn and Egypt set about repairing the canal. The UN Resolution condemning this invasion of Egypt was one of the only times in this period that the US and USSR voted together. The Suez Canal Crisis heightened tensions between Israel and its Arab neighbors; increased Arab nationalism, pan-Arabic sentiments, and anti-Western feelings among Arabs; marked the demise of European control in the region and the rise of US influence in Middle Eastern affairs; and showed that the Cold War was now more important than colonialism in international affairs.

The Suez Canal Crisis was followed by a decade of relative calm and, again, increased Jewish settlement as the population of Israel tripled between 1956–66. In 1964 Nasser sponsored the creation of the Palestinian Liberation Organization (PLO). Syria promoted *al-Fatah* ("the conquest"), which had formed in 1958 and called for armed struggle as the only means to liberate Palestine. Nasser and the PLO took a relatively moderate stance at the outset, preferring to avoid military confrontation with Israel. Among the young leadership of *al-Fatah* was Yassir Arafat, although he did not emerge as *the* leader for several more years. In 1967 Fatah joined the PLO, with Arafat becoming its leader.

The 1967 Six-Day War

In 1967 war broke out again, a major conflict that completely realigned the balance of power in the region. This conflict was rooted mainly in the struggle for control over water, noted as a scarce and important resource in this region. In early 1967 Syria tried to divert the water of the Jordan River, which runs along its border with Israel, for irrigation purposes, and Israel wanted to stop them from doing so. In July 1966 Israel bombed a Syrian canal project, escalating tensions. Amid this dispute over water, in May 1967 Nasser amassed 130,000 Egyptian troops in the Sinai Peninsula along the border with Israel, forcing out a UN Peacekeeping contingent that had been there since the end of the Suez Canal Crisis and telling the Israelis to leave Syria alone. The Israelis, however, decided to act first in a "pre-emptive" strike—this is debated because it is not clear that the Arabs were preparing to strike at all—on several fronts that proved to be very quick (six days) and very successful. In a surprise attack the Israelis wiped out most (about 80%) of the Egyptian Air Force within the first three hours, and without adequate air cover Egypt's ground forces were easily defeated. Meanwhile

in the East, Israeli forces defeated Jordanian and Syrian troops as well, and in all of six days the fighting was over and the map of the Middle East completely redrawn.

As a result of this war, Israel took the Sinai Peninsula and Gaza Strip from Egypt, the West Bank from Jordan, the Golan Heights from Syria, and seized full control of Jerusalem (which had been divided between Israel and Jordan since 1948). These areas became the disputed occupied territories, which had a majority Arab population but were now under Israeli control. Israelis began to settle these territories, especially Gaza and the West Bank, heightening tensions even further in those areas. The war also worsened the Palestinian refugee problem, as over 100,000 people fled into Jordan. In November 1967 the UN passed Resolution 242 calling for Israel to withdraw from the territories it seized during the war and on the Arab states to recognize Israel's right to exist, which none of them had done. However, neither side accepted the terms of UN Resolution 242. Israel seemed determined to keep the occupied territories for strategic reasons, feeling that this gave them secure borders for the first time, especially along the West Bank. The Arab states, meanwhile, continued to call for the annihilation of Israel and a return of the region to Palestinian control. The UN's efforts to resolve the conflict proved fruitless and tensions in the region remained high.

The 1973 War

Following the 1967 Six-Day War Nasser took full blame for the disastrous events for the Arab side and offered to resign, but the Egyptian people begged him to remain in power. He died in 1970 and Egyptian Vice-President Anwar Sadat replaced him; Sadat's main goal was to return the Sinai to Egyptian control. He had a two-pronged strategy for doing so: military force combined with negotiations; he felt that he had to flex military muscle to establish Egypt and the Arab world as a viable threat to Israel because up until that point the Arabs had not done very well in conflicts with Israel. First, however, he had to disentangle Egypt from the Cold War rivalries that had dominated the conflict since Nasser's rise to power twenty years earlier. In July 1972, rather abruptly and to the surprise of both the Soviets and the US, Sadat ordered all Soviet advisors and military personnel to leave Egypt.

Soon thereafter Sadat planned another attack on Israel along with Syrian leader Hafez al-Assad. The Egyptians and Syrians tried to bring Jordan's King Hussein into the plan, but he said no and even warned Israeli Prime Minister Golda Meir about the imminent attack. She did not trust him, however, and thus did not bother to call up the reserves, which would lead to scandal and the downfall of her government afterward. Sadat invaded Israel along with Syria from the other side in an unprovoked attack on the Yom Kippur Jewish holiday (also during the Muslim holiday Ramadan) in October 1973. The Egyptians initially broke through Israeli front lines in the surprise attack, while Syrian troops fared worse on the Eastern front. Arab forces held Israeli

troops at bay for several weeks, their best showing in any war with Israel to that point. After about a month of fighting the tide turned in Israel's favor and a peace agreement ended the war in November 1973. The month-long 1973 War showed that the Arabs could militarily threaten Israel's existence, thus increasing the impetus for a peaceful settlement to the Arab-Israeli Conflict.

The 1973 War also led to one of the most important developments in the international economy in the post-World War II period: the 1973 OPEC Oil Embargo, the Arab response to a massive arms shipment US President Richard Nixon sent to Israel during the war. For roughly six months the embargo wreaked havoc on the economies of the US and Western Europe and showed how important oil had become as a global commodity—the price of a barrel of oil on the international market increased fourfold overnight, *greatly* enriching the OPEC nations as a result. We return to the global implications of this development in subsequent chapters.

Efforts at Peace

Following the 1973 War the move toward negotiations was gradual but with Cold War entanglements no longer an issue—Egypt was a US ally by the mid-1970s—talks began soon after the election of President Jimmy Carter in 1976. With Carter acting as negotiator, Sadat and Israeli Prime Minister Menachem Begin signed the Camp David Accords in 1978. Israel agreed to return the Sinai Peninsula to Egypt, who in return granted diplomatic recognition to Israel, becoming the first Arab state to do so. At this point Israel was the number one recipient of US aid and Egypt the second largest recipient thereof.

The negotiations at Camp David were not easy. Sadat and Begin reached an impasse at their first face-to-face meeting over the Palestinian issue. Sadat raised the question of an independent Palestinian state, a topic Begin refused to broach. The Israeli team walked out and wanted to leave the summit, but Carter persuaded them to stay. After that first meeting Sadat and Begin never saw each other again for the remainder of the twelve-day summit! Carter played the crucial mediating role, carrying texts and proposals back and forth to both sides (he clearly deserved the Nobel Prize he won belatedly in 2002 for his efforts at Camp David). Carter persuaded Sadat to drop demands for a Palestinian state, although Carter remembers that Sadat was very hesitant to do so. Other Arab leaders condemned Sadat for these efforts (including and especially Iraq's Saddam Hussein), as did radical Islamicist elements within his own country.

The main issue under discussion at Camp David was Israeli withdrawal from the Sinai. The existence of Israeli settlements in the Sinai, which they began building after the 1967 Six-Day War, complicated matters. Begin refused to withdraw Israeli settlements from the Sinai, in part because he had made an election promise to never withdraw a single Israeli settlement from anywhere. He agreed to compromise by declaring he would accept a vote

by the Israeli Parliament, the Knesset, on the matter, and the Knesset voted to withdraw the settlements in exchange for peace. The agreement called for a staged withdrawal of the Sinai by Israel to end by 1982 in return for Egyptian recognition of Israel's right to exist. Many more people within the Arab world opposed the agreement than supported it, and a couple of years later in 1981 Islamic fundamentalists in Egypt assassinated Sadat for recognizing Israel's right to exist. It was a brazen assassination: they infiltrated a military parade and when the tank they were riding in was across from where Sadat and other leaders sat, they sprang out from it and shot him (and several other Egyptian leaders) dead.

The Camp David Accords brought relative peace between Israel and Egypt, but it did *not* solve the Arab-Israeli Conflict. The PLO, a nationalistic, secularist organization created as we saw by Nasser in 1964 and led by Yasser Arafat, had been forced out of Jordan, where it had become essentially a state within a state, by King Hussein in 1971. Afterward they set up their headquarters in Southern Lebanon, where they carried out regular raids and bombing attacks across the border into Israel. Arafat condoned terrorism—or “freedom fighting” as he no doubt would have called it—including several highly publicized plane hijackings linked to the PLO in the late 1960s and early 1970s. Palestinian terrorists possibly linked to the PLO attacked and killed the entire Israeli team of athletes at the 1972 Summer Olympic Games in Munich, Germany—eleven in total along with one German police officer and five (of the eight) terrorists. It is not entirely clear that the Palestinian terrorist group that carried out this horrible act, Black September as they called themselves, were linked to the PLO, but Arafat did not condemn the act.

In the early 1980s, facing constant attacks and bombings across the border from the PLO, Israel retaliated with frequent military excursions into Southern Lebanon. Tensions boiled over in 1982. In early June someone assassinated the Israeli ambassador to the UK in London, probably an Iraqi-backed group (Abu Nidal), but Israeli Prime Minister Begin (and Defense Minister Ariel Sharon) blamed the PLO and ordered the bombardment of the PLO's headquarters in West Beirut. The PLO continued to send rocket and artillery fire across the border into Israel, which invaded Lebanon in response. Israel's main goal was to rid Lebanon of the PLO, which agreed to pack up and leave for Tunisia in a deal brokered by special US envoy Philip Habib dispatched by US President Ronald Reagan.

As part of the agreement PLO leaders and fighters left Lebanon while their families remained amid assurances that they would be protected until everyone could be reunited in Tunis. However, on the night of September 16, 1982, in the Palestinian refugee camps Sabra and Shatila in Lebanon, a Lebanese Christian (Maronite) militia group, the Phalangists, which had been trained and armed by Israel since 1976, massacred at least 800 people (estimates run as high as 2,000), mostly the families of the PLO fighters who had left for Tunis. The massacre was definitely carried out by a Lebanese

militia group, *not* by the Israeli Defense Forces (IDF), but it had been assisted by a clearly complicit IDF. Israeli forces arranged for the militia to be transported to the area surrounding the camps and IDF flares lit up the night skies as the massacre occurred. The Kahan Commission, an investigation subsequently carried out by the Israeli government, found Israeli officials, including Sharon, “indirectly responsible” for the massacre because they “should have known what would happen.”

The First Intifada

The move to Tunis weakened the PLO and distanced it from the Palestinian people. This became clear in late 1987 when Palestinians started the Intifada (“earthquake” or “earth-shaking”), a spontaneous uprising of youth not controlled by the PLO. The Intifada began after an Israeli tank-transport truck crashed into several cars in Gaza, killing four Palestinians. Protests exploded and spread to the West Bank as well. Although not nonviolent, the nature of the uprising was purposely restrained; one decision made early and held to remarkably well (although with some exceptions) was to restrict protests to stone throwing—knives and guns were banned. However, Palestinian protesters did throw Molotov cocktails.

The Intifada was a David vs. Goliath type confrontation, with stone-throwing Palestinians going against Israeli tanks day after day, and it led to a militant crackdown on Palestinians by the Israeli Security Forces. The Intifada also involved a boycott of Israeli goods and a refusal to pay Israeli taxes, so it included a strong element of civil disobedience as well. Gradually the Intifada turned international opinion against Israel, especially after Defense Minister Yitzhak Rabin ordered the IDF to “break some bones” in response to the protests and soon afterward video surfaced showing IDF troops doing precisely that. Also, in 1989 Arafat announced his willingness to recognize Israel’s right to exist, which put added pressure on Israel to negotiate. Largely in response to the brutal Israeli crackdown against the Intifada, an extremist Islamic group formed among the Palestinians (linked to the Muslim Brotherhood), Hamas, which literally means “zeal” but stands for the Islamic Resistance Movement.

Hamas competed with the Palestinian Islamic Jihad, which had formed earlier in the 1980s following Iran’s 1979 Revolution, for support among the most extremist elements of the Palestinian population. The latter group claimed responsibility for what is widely considered to be the first suicide attack by a Palestinian terrorist against Israeli civilians in July 1989. A twenty-five-year-old Palestinian terrorist grabbed the steering wheel of Bus 405 on the Tel Aviv-Jerusalem route and drove it over a steep cliff into a ravine, killing sixteen (including himself) and injuring seventeen, the first “suicide killing” that would unfortunately become very common in the conflict over the next two decades. In the 1990s there were no fewer than twenty-three suicide attacks against Israeli civilians (mainly) with an estimated 165 deaths

and many more injured; most of these attacks were suicide bombings carried out by Hamas as well as a few by the Palestinian Islamic Jihad.

More Efforts at Peace

The end of the Cold War in the late 1980s and the First Gulf War in the early 1990s, in which Israel was tacitly on the side of several Arab states against Saddam Hussein's Iraq, gave impetus to further peace talks. Economic problems for Israel played a role as well as it sought greater trade with its Arab neighbors. The PLO's Arafat had backed the wrong side (Iraq) in the First Gulf War, as a result of which the organization lost millions in funding, compelling them to the negotiating table as well. In 1993 Israeli Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin, Arafat, and US President Bill Clinton signed the Oslo Agreement granting Palestinians limited self-rule, *not* complete independence, within the occupied territories (the West Bank and Gaza Strip). The Oslo Agreement obviously did not bring lasting peace and stability to the region; tensions have remained high, especially over continued Israeli settlements in the West Bank. An extremist Israeli student opposed to the peace process assassinated Rabin in 1995, mirroring the fate of Anwar Sadat fourteen years prior.

At the end of the 1990s Clinton sought to negotiate a permanent peace agreement, a two-state solution, between Arafat and Israeli Prime Minister Ehud Barak. Although there was considerable hope for these talks, unfortunately they broke down and Arafat refused to sign an agreement for a variety of reasons, including that it did not recognize the Palestinian demand for a return to pre-1967 borders; because Israel refused to recognize the Right of Return for Palestinian refugees ousted during the 1948 and 1967 wars; and because based on the proposed agreement Israel would continue to control large swaths of the West Bank, including the Jordan River Valley and several of the West Bank's main aquifers (and thus the region's water supply). Arafat said the deal would solidify Israel's occupation of the West Bank while turning "Palestine" into dissected "Bantustans" or powerless tribal states (as in South Africa, which we discuss later) still under the control of Israel, which is why he refused to sign it.

About two months after the talks failed, a second Intifada began in late September 2000. Israeli opposition leader Ariel Sharon paid a highly controversial visit to the disputed site of the Temple Mount/Al-Aqsa Mosque in East (Old) Jerusalem, saying "The Temple Mount is in our hands," echoing a famous Israeli radio broadcast from the 1967 Six-Day War. Palestinians saw Sharon's visit as a deliberate provocation, and many protested by throwing rocks at Israeli troops, who opened fire on the protesters, killing four and sparking massive demonstrations in the West Bank and Gaza. Sharon subsequently won elections in February 2001 to become Israel's Prime Minister. The Second Intifada lasted until the resumption of peace talks in 2005 between Sharon and new Palestinian leader Mahmoud Abbas (Arafat died in 2004).

Sharon suffered a debilitating stroke while in office in January 2006 and lay in a coma until his death in January 2015.

Peace in the Arab-Israeli Conflict has obviously not been achieved. Talks initiated by US President Barack Obama in 2009 and then again in 2012 failed miserably. US President Donald Trump's first administration made some progress, mainly getting a few peripheral Arab countries to acknowledge Israel's right to exist and begin diplomatic relations in 2020, but no major steps toward a negotiated settlement between Israelis and Palestinians have occurred since Oslo over thirty years ago. One reason for this is the disputed status of Jerusalem, which both sides claim as their capital. In 2017 the Trump administration recognized Jerusalem as Israel's capital, which complicates matters for a possible independent Palestine. Would the city be divided again (as it was between 1948–67) and Jerusalem the capital of both? A second key stumbling block to peace in the region is the Palestinian claim of a Right to Return (from the wars of 1948 and 1967). As noted this was a major reason for the breakdown of the 2000 talks between Barack and Arafat. A third major stumbling block for peace are the Israeli settlements in the West Bank, which are in violation of International Law forbidding an occupying power from making significant changes on the ground in a territory it occupies. Supporters of the Israeli settlements in the West Bank justify them on religious grounds because of their Biblical claim to the region but also because not controlling the West Bank would make Israel vulnerable to an attack and the country being cut in two by foreign forces.

The Arab-Israeli Conflict in the Twenty-First Century

Citing the high number of suicide bombings carried out by Palestinian terrorists in the 1990s and the heightened tensions of the Second Intifada, in 2000 Israel began construction of a "security wall" along the borders between it and the West Bank that was largely completed by 2005 (though parts of the wall remained under construction for years thereafter). Suicide bombings by Palestinian terrorists, which as noted numbered about twenty-three in the 1990s with roughly 165 (mostly civilian) Israeli victims, continued into the twenty-first century. There were no fewer than seventy-three between 2000–2003 with an estimated 445 deaths and many more wounded. In June 2001 Palestinian terrorists bombed the Dolphinarium Discotheque in Tel Aviv, killing twenty-one Israelis and wounding over 100 more. The security wall, which runs approximately 440 miles total, has contributed to a decline in the number of such attacks, of which there were about twenty-one between 2004–10. Other factors may have also helped with that decline, such as improved Israeli infiltration of Palestinian extremist groups in the West Bank, but on the surface at least it appears as though the wall, while adding a major barrier between people with negative economic consequences for many Palestinians, played at least some role in reducing the number of terrorist attacks carried out by Palestinian terrorists in Israel.

In 2005 Israeli Prime Minister Sharon agreed to unilaterally withdraw all Jewish settlements from the Gaza Strip and four from the West Bank. In total over 9,000 Israelis were forced out of the settlements, mostly from Gaza. The move led to a break between Sharon and his ally Benjamin Netanyahu, who opposed the withdrawal without a referendum to let the population decide and resigned his post in Sharon's government as a result. The purpose of the withdrawal was to improve Israel's security and international status by conceding some territory to the Palestinians in the absence of any ongoing peace talks. However, a concerted effort by the Israeli government to form *new settlements* in other parts of the West Bank followed this move; while 9,000 Israeli settlers left Gaza (mostly) and the West Bank in 2005, that same year an additional 15,000 Israeli settlers moved to the West Bank, further heightening tensions with the Palestinians.

In early 2005 Palestinians elected Arafat's successor, Mahmoud Abbas, as President of the Palestinian National Authority based in the West Bank. However, the unity of the Palestinian people in that election proved short-lived: a year later the militant Hamas won elections to the Palestinian Legislative Council (seventy-four of 132 seats) in Gaza, splitting the two Palestinian lands politically as the more moderate Fatah Party of the Palestinian National Authority under Abbas continued to rule the West Bank. The consequences of this election were disastrous for Gaza because it led to brutal infighting between Palestinian supporters of the two rival political factions, Hamas and Fatah, with several thousand killed in internecine conflict, and because it led to *extreme* isolation for the Palestinian population in Gaza. Hamas has not held elections since taking power in 2006 and by most accounts has ruled Gaza with a heavy hand, stifling all opposition and controlling distribution of UN aid to the population.

When Hamas assumed power in Gaza in 2007, Israel imposed a blockade against it, limiting the mobility of goods and people in and out of the territory. This blockade made life miserable in Gaza, one of the most densely populated parts of the world with a population of 2.2mn (in comparison the much larger West Bank has a population of 2.4mn). Egypt followed suit and helped close off Gaza, which made the situation worse than it might have otherwise been. Egypt's support of the blockade loosened during the Arab Spring (2011–13), which we discuss in the next chapter, but mostly remained intact. The stated goal of the blockade was to keep weapons from being smuggled into Gaza/Hamas, though in retrospect that seems to have largely failed. The main impact of the blockade was to keep food supplies out of the hands of the population, many of whom depend on UN and foreign aid for survival, as well as to crush economic activity leading to extremely high unemployment in Gaza.

In 2006 Hamas militants crossed into southern Israel, ambushed a border patrol and kidnapped an Israeli soldier, Gilad Shalit, holding him for five years before finally releasing him in a 2011 prisoner exchange. There was a small-scale, three-week war in Gaza in late 2008 as Israel began airstrikes in

retaliation for Hamas' ongoing bombardment of rockets across the border into southern Israel. There was a repeat of this four years later in 2012 with about a week of Israeli bombardment in response (again) to Hamas firing more than 100 rockets from Gaza into southern Israel. In June 2014 Hamas militants in the West Bank kidnapped and killed three Israeli teenagers near a Jewish settlement. Several weeks later Israeli extremists abducted and burned alive a sixteen-year-old Palestinian boy from Jerusalem in retaliation. Amid mounting tensions Israel began airstrikes in both the West Bank and Gaza in what turned out to be a seven-week war (July 8-August 16). Hamas retaliated with rockets fired from Gaza into southern Israel.

Major Palestinian protests erupted in 2018 along the Gazan border with southern Israel, leading to a crackdown by Israel and a small-scale war. Amid increasing tensions and protests by Palestinians in the West Bank in May 2021 Israeli police raided the al-Aqsa Mosque in East (Old) Jerusalem, one of the holiest sites in Islam. Hamas responded by firing thousands of rockets into southern Israel, which responded with airstrikes in another small-scale war. The following spring a string of terrorist attacks by Palestinians, including several knife attacks on Israeli civilians, led Israel to launch another military operation in the West Bank. In December 2022 Israelis elected Benjamin Netanyahu for his sixth (non-consecutive) term as Prime Minister, this time with the most far-right ruling coalition in the country's history. In the summer of 2023 Netanyahu faced major domestic protests by Israelis against his efforts to limit the power of the Israeli Supreme Court to reverse decisions by the executive branch.

On October 7, 2023, Hamas militants crossed from Gaza into southern Israel and attacked, killing an estimated 1,200 Israelis, mostly civilians, and seizing 250 Israeli civilians as hostages. The timing may have been tied in part to a possible peace agreement between Israel and Saudi Arabia, similar to those achieved earlier (Fall 2020) between Israel and the United Arab Emirates and Bahrain, as well as Morocco and Sudan. Earlier in 2023 Saudi Arabia opened its airspace to Israeli flights, which pointed to a broader agreement possibly being in the works that would have been potentially disastrous for Hamas. The attack also not coincidentally came a day after the fiftieth anniversary of the start of the 1973 War.

One can draw a number of comparisons with the situation in 1973. As in the earlier conflict the Israeli government had intelligence that Hamas was planning an attack, but political leaders ignored the warning signs. In this case it seems likely that Hamas wanted in part to shine the light back on the Palestinian question as international attention was focused on the war in Ukraine and other issues. Also, as in 1973 Hamas may have sought to prove that it could threaten the security of Israelis as a way of creating a greater impetus for peace talks leading to a two-state solution, to show Israelis that a two-state solution would be in their own best long-term interests. This latter presupposition is based on the premise that Hamas would accept a two-state solution, a notion that is not entirely apparent from the rhetoric of its

militant wing, which calls for the complete destruction of Israel (a one-state solution with Palestine, not Israel, as the one state). However, it seems likely that most Palestinians, and even most of Hamas, would be content with a legitimate two-state solution based on pre-1967 borders. Thus, one goal of the October 2023 attacks may have been (much as in 1973) to prove Hamas' ability to pose a viable threat to Israel's security in order to compel them to the negotiating table for a long-term two-state solution, although that is by no means entirely clear.

Israel responded to the October 7, 2023, attacks with *overwhelmingly* brutal force, bombing Gaza for months and wreaking tremendous devastation on the population as well as the infrastructure of the entire Gaza Strip. At the outset of the conflict Netanyahu stated that the goal of the Israeli military mission was to eliminate Hamas, which among other things built extensive networks of tunnels beneath the streets of Gaza City and elsewhere in preparation for such a conflict. Israel accused Hamas of using Palestinian civilians as "human shields" and killed many thousands of civilians, including children, in its exhaustive bombing campaigns. Many observers have accused Israel of committing genocide, most notably the government of South Africa, which presented a case for Israeli genocide against the Palestinians at the UN International Court of Justice at the Hague, Netherlands, in early 2024. The Israeli government rejected the accusation, saying that it has "the right and duty to protect its citizens." The Court, which will likely not give a final ruling in the case for some time, issued a preliminary order that Israel should do everything within its power to prevent death, destruction, and any acts of genocide in its campaign in Gaza.

A year after the initial attacks that sparked the conflict the entire region seemed to be on the brink of a possible major war. In some sense this battle from its outset has been a proxy war between Israel and Iran, a major regional power and staunch enemy of the Israeli state. Iran is the key backer of both Hamas, which is a mostly Sunni Muslim organization, and Hezbollah in neighboring Lebanon, which (like Iran) is a Shia Muslim organization. In late September 2024 Israel extended its bombing campaign to Southern Lebanon and its capital Beirut (much as in 1982), attempting to dislodge Hezbollah militants who since the conflict began launched rockets into northern Israel, displacing some 60,000 Israelis from their homes. An Israeli airstrike killed Hezbollah's leader, Hassan Nasrallah, in late September, prompting an Iranian missile attack on Israel in early October (a similar tit-for-tat bombing between the two countries had occurred in April 2024 as well).

At the time of writing, the possibility of a broader regional war seems to have been averted after the ceasefire agreement signed between Israel and Hamas in late January 2025. Hamas agreed to the gradual release over a six-week period of the thirty-three remaining hostages (those still alive and not already free), while Israel agreed to release thousands of Palestinian prisoners, most of whom were captured in this most recent war, provide humanitarian aid to Palestinians in Gaza, and withdraw its military forces

to a buffer zone. The agreement is very similar to one put forward in May 2024 but rejected by Israel at that time. There is widespread speculation that pressure from then-incoming US President Donald Trump, assuming power for his second term January 20, 2025, may have played a role in the timing of Israel's acceptance of the deal. However, the deal has not held, and Israel's bombing of Gaza has continued, reportedly owing to Hamas' refusal to stick to details of the deal involving prisoner releases. It remains to be seen how the situation will develop from here, as the casualty toll continues to grow.



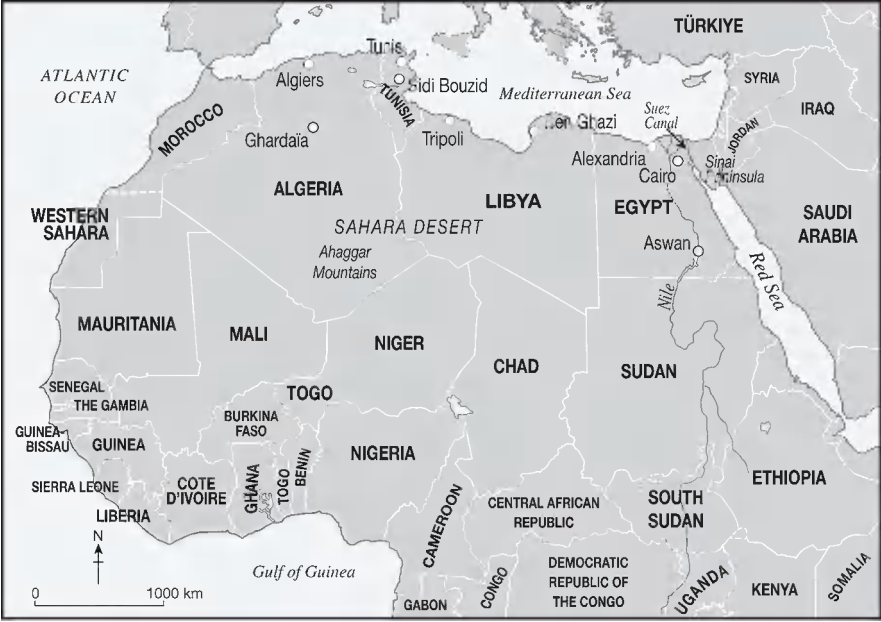
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Part IV

Africa



Map 9.1 Map of North Africa.

9 North Africa

Egypt, Libya, Algeria, Tunisia and the Arab Spring

Egypt

Egypt, with its capital Cairo, is the eastern-most country of North Africa and a key player in the Arab-Israeli Conflict as we have seen. It has a long and rich history as one of the earliest countries to develop an agricultural-based society, with the Nile River, the world's largest, and its many tributaries as the basis thereof. Egypt's population as of 2024 is estimated at over 116mn, the vast majority of whom (about 99%) are Arab-speaking Egyptians. Around 90% of those are Sunni Muslims with a minority Christian population of about 9%.

In the mid-nineteenth century Europeans significantly altered the history of Egypt, at the time part of the Ottoman Empire, when a French company began construction of the Suez Canal. An arduous task accomplished partly with slave labor, it took fifteen years to finish the canal at a horrific cost both financially *and* in terms of lives lost, but when completed in 1869 the Suez Canal literally shifted the geopolitical balance. The British feared French control of the canal, which quickly became a major part of Britain's vast overseas empire and trade; in 1875 the Egyptian government sold its share in the canal to British interests, although the French remained the predominant shareholders. The completion of the Suez Canal changed Egypt's role globally and contributed to the rise of a strong nationalist, anti-foreign military segment of Egyptian society.

Fearing a disruption of their trade through the canal, the British occupied Egypt in 1882 following an uprising against foreign influences (both Turkish and European) led by Egyptian nationalists. At the beginning of World War I in 1914 the British declared Egypt a "Protectorate," which meant that it was under the protection of the British Empire's armed forces and represented by British diplomats in international affairs. Thus, while not a colony Egypt had limited autonomy, especially with respect to its foreign affairs.

In 1922 the British removed Egypt's Protectorate status and granted it sovereignty while retaining control of the Suez Canal Zone (along with the French company co-owning the canal). In its first three decades of independence from British control Egypt was a monarchy, but that changed shortly

after World War II. In 1952 a group of military officers overthrew the monarchy; one of them, Gamal Abdel Nasser, emerged as the country's sole leader by 1954. The following year Nasser bought weapons from the USSR and rejected US assistance in the Aswan Dam project, calling on help from the Soviets for that as well. Nasser's main goal was to gain control of the canal, and thus in July 1956 he nationalized the Suez Canal, seizing it from the British and French consortium that owned it, which made him a hero throughout the Arab world. As we saw, military intervention by the British, French, and Israelis in the 1956 Suez Canal Crisis failed to retake control of the canal and left it partially damaged.

As we also saw, Anwar Sadat succeeded Nasser as President of Egypt with the latter's death in 1970, switched sides in the Cold War, returning Egypt to the pro-US camp, and signed the Camp David Accords in 1978 recognizing Israel's right to exist in exchange for the return of the Sinai Peninsula to Egyptian control. Hosni Mubarak succeeded Sadat following the latter's assassination in 1981, beginning his reign with a brutal crackdown against the Islamic extremists responsible for killing Sadat.

The Egyptian Muslim Brotherhood

The Muslim Brotherhood, which contains a broad range of views, traces back to the 1860s, but Hassan al-Banna, a twenty-two-year-old school-teacher, founded the organization in its current form (after a lull of several decades) in 1928. Al-Banna was responding to the continued presence in Egypt of British soldiers (after World War I he participated at age thirteen in an uprising against British rule or "protection" in Egypt), but he was also responding to events in Turkey following the dismantling of the Ottoman Empire. As part of his broad secularizing reforms Turkey's post-World War I ruler Kemal Atatürk abolished the Caliphate, the religious leadership of successors to the Prophet Muhammad that had been recognized by Sunni Muslims in much of the world (including Egypt) for centuries. This enraged many devout Muslims including al-Banna, who argued that Islam should return to its true Islamic roots, from which it had strayed in recent centuries. Banna seems not to have advocated terrorist tactics, if only because he feared that a government crackdown would destroy his fledgling organization, but some of his followers resorted to terrorism against Egypt's monarchy and at times against British troops, who continued to maintain a strong presence in Egypt, especially the canal zone.

In 1936 the Muslim Brotherhood had a mere 800 members, but owing to the rise of Nazi Germany, which led to the arrival of more European Jewish settlers as part of the Zionist Movement to Palestine, and also because of the 1936–39 Palestinian Uprising against British Mandate rule the organization grew rapidly to 200,000 members by 1940. During World War II the Muslim Brotherhood officially called for neutrality, but leaders, including al-Banna, had ties and sympathies with Nazi Germany going back to the 1930s—the

two shared anti-British and anti-Semitic outlooks. In 1948 a member of the Muslim Brotherhood assassinated Egypt's Prime Minister, which led to a government ban on the organization. In the crackdown that followed government agents killed al-Banna in 1949. Nasser initially courted the support of the Muslim Brotherhood and lifted the ban against them after seizing power in the 1952 coup; however, after a failed assassination attempt on Nasser in 1954, allegedly by members of the Muslim Brotherhood (though this was never proven), he too banned and repressed the organization.

In the early 1970s Sadat released members of the Muslim Brotherhood from prison, even those implicated in a second alleged assassination plot against Nasser in 1965, and pledged that he would implement Sharia or Islamic law in Egypt, one of the main goals of the Muslim Brotherhood. In response, the mainstream leadership of the Muslim Brotherhood denounced the use of violence in 1970, which led to several defections and offshoots from the organization that could not accept this more peaceful path. Since 1970 the Egyptian state has largely tolerated the Muslim Brotherhood as a community organization providing services and cultural activities, even though it remained officially banned as a political grouping since 1954. One of the main offshoots of the Muslim Brotherhood was the Egyptian Islamic Jihad, founded by (among others) Ayman Muhammad al-Zawahiri, a key figure later in al-Qaeda and considered to be the mastermind behind the September 11, 2001, attacks on the US.

The four men who assassinated Sadat in 1981 were members of the Egyptian Islamic Jihad. Mubarak intensified the repression of both the Islamic Jihad and the Muslim Brotherhood, many of whose members spent a lot of time in prison in the 1980s and 1990s, but the latter organization nonetheless continued to operate semi-openly at a community level. It ran members as candidates for parliament in 2005 as "Independents" and received 20% of the vote, giving it eighty-eight representatives (out of 440) in the Egyptian Parliament, which made it the single largest opposition group. The Muslim Brotherhood is a broad umbrella organization, meaning that its members vary to a significant degree in their beliefs on the role and position of Islam in society. The more extremist groups, the Salafis, Islamic Jihad and others who could not accept the Muslim Brotherhood's denunciation of violence in 1970, are small (due in part to their secretive, conspiratorial nature) and attract the most radical, extremist segment of society. We pick up with developments and divisions within Egypt since 2010 in the section below on the Arab Spring.

Libya

Much of Libya, with its capital Tripoli, is sparsely inhabited desert and semi-desert, so it has a relatively small population of about 7.5mn (compared to Egypt's 116mn), 90% of which lives in the northern coastal regions. There is a significant difference between the densely populated northern coastal areas

of Libya, which has a Mediterranean climate, and the interior and south of the country with its hot, dry desert climate unsuitable for agriculture.

Libya is largely homogeneous in ethnic terms in that 97% of the population is Arab/Imazighen (or Berber), which means that they speak Arabic *and* one (or more) of five native Amazigh languages and are part of the Imazighen/Berber ethnic/tribal groupings. These groups have predominated in this part of the world for a *very* long time (their origins go back some 7,000 years, well before the migration of Arabs to the Maghreb with the spread of Islam in the seventh and eighth centuries CE). The term “Berber” comes from the Latin word “barbarous,” which the Romans used to describe the non-Latin speaking peoples of the Maghreb, so not surprisingly the people themselves in this region prefer the term Imazighen, which means “free men” in the native languages. There are small groups of ethnic minorities in the country (Europeans and South Asians). Libya is also homogeneous in religious terms with 97% of the population being Sunni Muslims (there is about a 3% non-Muslim minority, but not really a Shia Muslim presence in the country other than a small number of South Asian descent).

Oil was discovered in Libya in the late 1950s and it now ranks among the world’s top oil producing countries in the world and is also a major producer and exporter of natural gas. The oil sector in Libya contributes about 95% of the country’s export earnings, 25% of GDP, and 8% of government revenue. It joined OPEC in 1962, the year after the Cartel’s formation. Most of the country’s oil and natural gas resources are concentrated in the resource-rich but relatively sparsely populated eastern part of the country; oil is *very* important for Libya’s economy.

Libya was part of the Ottoman Empire from the early sixteenth century until 1911 when Italy claimed it as a colony, although Britain controlled southeastern Libya at that time. Libya was a major battlefield in World War II during the war’s early stages between 1940–43 (as it had been to a lesser degree in World War I). Following Italy’s defeat in 1943 British forces occupied most of Libya, although French forces occupied the southwest. In 1947 the UN declared Libya a Trusteeship under joint British and French control, creating a unique situation with two powers controlling different parts of the former Italian colony. Libya gained its independence in December 1951 as a monarchy. The royal government of King Idris sided with the West in the early stages of the Cold War and the US had a major Air Force Base (Wheelus) near Tripoli.

The Muammar Qaddafi Era

The king’s failing health led him to abdicate in favor of the Crown Prince, his nephew, effective September 2, 1969. However, during the transition in leadership while King Idris was in Turkey for medical treatment, Colonel Muammar Qaddafi, twenty-seven years old at the time, overthrew the royal government and established an Islamic-Socialist state. He expelled

all Italians from the country in 1970. Initially the official name of Libya under Qaddafi was the Libyan Arab Republic, but in 1977 he changed it to the “Great Socialist People’s Libyan Arab *Jamahiriya*,” which means “state of the masses.” Significantly, “Islam” was *not* part of the country’s official title—Qaddafi was a secular ruler, although he considered Islam important and used it as a political tool. After he relinquished the position of Prime Minister in 1972, Qaddafi never actually held any official title, although he was *de facto* chief of state in the country and was commonly referred to as the Brotherly Leader and Guide of the First of September Revolution of the Great Socialist People’s Libyan Arab *Jamahiriya* in government statements and the press.

Qaddafi touted himself as the purveyor of a new ideology, which he called “The Third Universal Theory” (i.e., neither communist nor capitalist). It involved elements of Islamic spirituality mixed with aspects of a secular welfare state based on the country’s oil wealth. As opposed to Mao’s “Little Red Book” of communist proverbs, Qaddafi published his “Little Green Book” (green being the color of Islam). The US supported him initially after the 1969 coup because he appeared to be anti-communist. However, he defined himself as a socialist, was an ardent Arab nationalist and supporter of the pan-Arabic unity movement of Egypt’s Gamal Abdel Nasser, and a strong opponent of Western imperialism, which soon put him at odds with the US. Thus, he leaned to the Soviet camp in the Cold War. He was never a close ally of the USSR, but he knew that he could count on Soviet help in case of difficulty. The US and Libya negotiated an early departure from the Wheelus Air Force Base near Tripoli, which the US abandoned in 1970, two years ahead of schedule according to a previous treaty signed with King Idris. The Soviets provided Qaddafi with support and military equipment beginning in the mid-1970s, so by then he was more firmly in the Soviet camp in the Cold War.

Qaddafi also supported terrorist activities from very early in his reign, including some evidence of financial backing for the infamous 1972 attack on Israeli athletes at the Munich Olympics. Libyan agents were reportedly behind the 1986 bombing of a discotheque in Berlin that killed two US servicemen and wounded many more, for which US President Reagan retaliated by bombing several sites in Libya, including Qaddafi’s palace, causing the death of his adopted fifteen-month-old daughter. December 1988 saw the most infamous Libyan-backed terrorist attack with the bombing of Pan Am Flight 103, which exploded in mid-air and crashed in Lockerbie, Scotland after a bomb set by Libyan agents detonated, killing all 259 people aboard (most of whom were Americans), and eleven people on the ground. Initial blame was put on Iran but that soon unraveled and it became clear by the early 1990s that Libya was behind the attack, although Qaddafi denied responsibility.

During the 1990s Qaddafi tried to rebuild his relationship with Europe. In April 1999 the UN suspended sanctions imposed on Libya after the Lockerbie bombing and finally lifted them completely in 2003 after Libya

accepted responsibility for the attack. Libya announced that it would reveal and end its programs to develop weapons of mass destruction and renounce terrorism, after which the normalization of relations with the US and EU countries proceeded rapidly. It is unclear what exactly motivated Qaddafi for this sudden change of heart, although the aftermath of the terrorist attacks on the US on September 11, 2001, seems to have been one reason. Higher oil prices on the world market may also have been a contributing factor as Qaddafi hoped to cash in on increased oil revenues. The US rescinded Libya's status as a state sponsoring terrorism in 2006, and in 2009 the two countries exchanged ambassadors for the first time since 1973. His newfound "friendship" with the West notwithstanding, Qaddafi's position internally in Libya began to unravel amid the changes brought by the Arab Spring, which led to his eventual downfall as we return to in detail below.

Algeria

Algeria with its capital Algiers is the largest country in Africa. As part of the Maghreb it runs along the Mediterranean Sea across from Spain and France. Algeria has a population of 47mn as of 2024 and the vast majority is concentrated in the densely populated northern coastal regions of the country because the interior is mostly desert (about 80% of the country total is desert). Like Libya it has a very homogeneous population in that 99% of the population is Arab/Imazighen along with a small 1% European minority. Ninety-nine percent of the population is Sunni Muslim (there are very small Christian and Jewish minorities as well). Algeria is a significant exporter of oil and natural gas; it has the eighth-largest reserves of natural gas in the world and is the fourth largest gas exporter, while it ranks sixteenth in known oil reserves. It joined OPEC in 1969.

Algeria remained part of the Ottoman Empire until the French colonized it in 1830. It gradually became the main area of French settlement in North Africa as more than 1mn French settled Algeria in the nineteenth century, as a result of which many Algerians lost their land during the colonial period. French settlers seized the best land, creating a great deal of tension. The French designated Algeria as a "department" or province—not just a colony but now literally part of France—in 1848, which certainly did not help the rising problems between the native population and the French settlers.

Tensions between the Algerian majority and the small but powerful French settler community (*colons*) exploded at the end of World War II, beginning on Victory in Europe Day (May 8, 1945), when the colonial police force cracked down on Algerian marchers demanding full political rights. In subsequent weeks the crackdown continued, leading to thousands of deaths. Following the humiliation it suffered in World War II, with France easily defeated by Nazi Germany and the country either occupied or run by a pro-Nazi proxy (the Vichy regime) for most of the war, France seemed determined to reimpose firm control over its vast overseas empire, including Algeria. World

War II was a turning point because it compelled the natives to fight for independence while leading the French to dig in their heels and become more entrenched than ever, unwilling to budge on their colonial control over North Africa and especially Algeria.

Events in Algeria after World War II were driven by those elsewhere in France's overseas empire. As we saw, the French were fighting Ho Chi Minh's Viet Minh, a communist-led nationalist force, beginning in 1946, and the Viet Minh scored a triumphant victory over the French at the 1954 Battle of Dien Bien Phu that led to the ouster of France from Southeast Asia. This development emboldened Algerians to challenge French rule while also stiffening France's resolve to hang on to what was left of its dwindling empire, leading to one of the most brutal conflicts of the post-World War II period, the Algerian War of Independence (1954–62). The conflict began when the Algerian National Liberation Front (FLN), led by Ahmed Ben Bella, launched attacks against French forces in several parts of Algeria. By the late 1950s the war was not going well for France and was becoming increasingly unpopular. Peace talks between representatives of Charles de Gaulle's French government and the FLN resulted in an independent Algeria on July 5, 1962.

Independent Algeria

Algeria thus entered a new phase of its history as an independent state, which over its now more than sixty years of existence has been characterized by three main trends: repression of the remaining French settlers; dictatorial, corrupt states; and a history of popular protest. Elected as the country's first president in 1963, Ben Bella expropriated the landed estates of the French *colons* and granted the land to Algerian farmers, forcing the *colons* to leave Algeria in droves (an estimated 800,000 *colons* left for France in a very brief time). Ben Bella's government proved to be short-lived as his one-time ally and close associate, Houari Boumedienne, overthrew the Algerian government in a military coup in 1965, ushering in an era of military dominance over Algerian politics (Ben Bella, who lived until 2012, disappeared out of the public eye under house arrest until 1980). Boumedienne ruled until his death in 1978, when Colonel Chadli Bendjedid replaced him, with the military remaining dominant.

A series of riots and demonstrations in 1989 forced the Algerian government to grant the country a new constitution limiting the military's role in politics and allowing for political parties other than the FLN. The results of the first wave of elections in 1991 led to a surprising result: the militant, fundamentalist Islamic Salvation Front (FIS), which had strong support in the Algerian countryside, won a solid majority, leading to an immediate military backlash as the army intervened, reversed the election results, cracked down on the FIS and canceled subsequent elections. This brutal response by the military prompted a violent reaction from the Islamists, defined as those

who use Islam for political purposes, leading to a ten-year civil war (1992–2002), with an estimated 100,000 casualties on both sides.

In 1996 the Algerian government banned the participation of Islamist parties in elections, and Abdelaziz Bouteflika subsequently won clearly fraudulent elections in 1999. Bouteflika granted amnesty to rebels who would accept it, and a significant number did, but at the same time he clamped down against those who refused to accept the amnesty. By the middle of 2002 the Algerian government had mostly defeated the Islamist rebels, although some low-scale armed opposition continued. Bouteflika won a second five-year term in 2004 and after altering the constitution to remove presidential term limits he won a third term in 2009. In 2006 remnants of Algeria's extremist Islamist forces merged with the terrorist group led by Osama bin Laden, al-Qaeda, to form "al-Qaeda in the Lands of the Islamic Maghreb," which has carried out several kidnappings and bombings targeting the Algerian Government and Western interests, including a major attack against a Western oil refinery in 2013 leading to the deaths of at least thirty-nine foreign hostages. We return to the course of events in Algeria and the fate of Bouteflika's government during the Arab Spring of the early 2010s below.

Tunisia

Tunisia, with its capital in Tunis, is the smallest Maghreb country located between Libya and Algeria (the northwestern corner of the former and the northeastern corner of the latter). Tunisia has a population of over 12mn as of 2024, 99% of whom are Sunni Muslims. There are major regional differences within the country, with the coastal regions being more developed than the interior and southern parts of the country, which tend to be poorer, less well educated, more devout in religious terms, and more socially and politically conservative. Unlike the other countries of the Maghreb, Tunisia does not have a large Imazighen/Berber population as 98% of its inhabitants are Arab. Like the rest of the region Tunisia was part of the Ottoman Empire until the French seized it as a colony in 1881, fifty years after the French conquered Algeria.

Considered to be one of the most secular countries in the Arab world, Tunisia received its independence in 1956 without a civil war under the leadership of Habib Bourguiba, who ruled the country as a one-party dictatorship for the next thirty-one years. Near the end of his long reign amid major economic problems in 1984 Bourguiba's government faced huge street protests, which he crushed with a massive show of force, managing to remain in power at the time. However, the unrest contributed to Bourguiba's ouster from power three years later in a "medical coup": he was removed for "health reasons" (although he lived for another thirteen years). The new leader as of 1987 was Zine el Abidine Ben Ali. Both Bourguiba and Ben Ali were secular rulers who utilized support from the military, which they in turn rewarded with economic benefits, to crush opposition from Islamicists as

well as from other forms of opposition. The Arab Spring in the early 2010s began in Tunisia and greatly affected it and the fate of Ben Ali, so let us turn to that development.

The Arab Spring

The “Arab Spring,” so named because of the call for democratic reform at its root as in the 1968 Prague Spring, began in Sidi Bouzid, a city in the center of Tunisia. An impoverished street vendor, Mohamed Bouazizi, set himself on fire in front of a local government building on December 10, 2010, to protest the confiscation of his goods and his humiliating treatment at the hands of government officials. Bouazizi’s act of self-immolation (he died in early January 2011) ignited a major regional movement for change throughout North Africa and parts of the Middle East (including Syria as we have already seen).

As with any complicated large-scale movement there were numerous causes and contributing factors to the Arab Spring. One long-term cause was the growing demand for more freedom of expression throughout North Africa, including Tunisia where it began. Protests erupted occasionally in several North African countries (including a decade-long civil war in Algeria), and dictatorial, often military-led regimes brutally crushed such uprisings. Thus, a key factor in the Arab Spring was the region’s growing political disenchantment with long-ruling corrupt, secular dictatorial regimes with opposition coming both from other secularists and Islamists—the major political divide throughout the region (one thing both forms of opposition could agree on is that they did not like the military-supported corrupt dictatorships ruling their countries).

Along with these political issues another key development contributing to the Arab Spring is the demographic factor, namely the emergence of “youth bulges” in all of these countries, meaning that their populations are comprised of a disproportionate number of young people, often much more so than in any other region in the world. At the time of the Arab Spring in the early 2010s, roughly one out of every three people was between the ages of ten and twenty-four throughout the entire Middle East and North Africa. Young people are much more likely than other demographic groups or cohorts to act on their grievances to try and rectify them, even if this means through violence (and even if it means being met with violence). The youthfulness of these populations in turn contributes to another key aspect of the Arab Spring: the rise of modern social media in all its varied high-tech forms early in the twenty-first century. Social media platforms allowed people greater space for at least some degree of free expression outside of governmental control. While not a *cause* of the unrest during the Arab Spring, most observers agree that modern technology and social media played a pivotal role *as a tool* in the organizing of protests and thus the spread of the Arab Spring.

Finally, economic factors clearly played a significant causal role in the Arab Spring. The global financial meltdown that began in late 2008 and its repercussions in the region led to a spike in prices in 2010 for basic foodstuffs. This combined with the lasting, endemic problem of high youth unemployment rates in the region, which also worsened as a result of the global economic downturn, contributed greatly to the outbreak of the Arab Spring, which was a perfect storm of sorts, the causes of which had been brewing for some time. Thus, the three key ingredients of the Arab Spring are politics, in particular aspirations for greater political freedom but also disenchantment with corrupt, long-ruling, dictatorial regimes; demographics, specifically the existence of sizable “youth bulges” in the populations of these countries; and the economic issues of high youth unemployment rates combined with higher commodity (foodstuffs) prices stemming from the global economic crisis of the late 2000s/early 2010s.

Tunisia's Arab Spring

When the Arab Spring began in late 2010 with Bouazizi's self-immolation protest more than 42% of Tunisia's population, which in general tends to be better educated than that of the other countries in the region, was under the age of twenty-five. The story of Bouazizi, who was twenty-six, highlights the economic woes underlying the Arab Spring; he was unemployed and set himself on fire to protest the confiscation by the Tunisian police of fruit he was selling. He lived in the country's interior, a region long disadvantaged regarding economic investment and development compared to the coastal areas. Following Bouazizi's self-immolation and hospitalization massive protests began in the central parts of Tunisia and gradually spread throughout the country. President Ben Ali paid a highly publicized visit to Bouazizi as the latter lay dying in the hospital, but it was too little too late as in early 2011 protests led to Ben Ali's overthrow after twenty-three years of rule.

A major contributing long-term factor to Tunisia's economic woes was its considerable debt incurred through International Monetary Fund (IMF) loans over many years, with much of the money siphoned off by Ben Ali and his cronies for their own benefit. At the time of the Arab Spring Tunisia owed the IMF \$2.66bn (so, in other words, every Tunisian citizen owed the IMF about \$2300 each), and debt repayment was the third largest item in Tunisia's national budget. Regarding the corruption of Ben Ali's government, a US State Department cable from 2006 leaked to *WikiLeaks* estimated that more than 50% of the country's economic wealth was held by two families and their extended relations, those of Ben Ali and his wife!

The ouster Ben Ali in early 2011 did *not* end Tunisia's economic problems, which continued and even worsened to some degree (in part because of a dip in tourism to the region). The big winner in Tunisia's October 2011 parliamentary elections was the *Ennahda* (“Renaissance”) Party, a long-banned moderate Islamicist Party linked to the Muslim Brotherhood and legalized

only after Ben Ali's fall. Secular critics both inside and outside the country questioned just how "moderate" the Ennahda Party really was, especially as more extremist elements emerged within the party as well as within Tunisian society as a whole.

On September 13, 2012, two days after the events at the US Consulate in Benghazi, Libya described below, Islamicists in Tunisia attacked the US Embassy in Tunis, burning vehicles and looting the US Embassy school in a show of solidarity with the Libyan terrorists. Still, internal and external calls for the Tunisian government to crack down on Islamicists went largely unheeded. However, in August 2013, following the assassination by extremists of two prominent secular Tunisian politicians, Chokri Belaïd in February and Muhammad Brahmi in July, the Ennahda government led by President Moncef Marzouki banned the country's largest extremist Islamicist organization, *Ansar al-Shariah*. Thus, a more moderate Islamic Party in power banned a more extremist opposition Islamicist Party as a terrorist organization.

By the summer of 2013, over two years into the Arab Spring, Tunisia was on the brink of, at worst, a civil war or, at best, a return to dictatorship with either Ben Ali (he fled to Saudi Arabia and eventually died there in 2019) restored to power or, more likely, one of his former cronies occupying his position atop a repressive regime. Daily protests continued in the streets throughout much of the country, especially Tunis. On September 1, 2013, demonstrators formed a two-mile chain from the Parliament building to the government headquarters, demanding political change and some attention to the country's continuing economic woes. Amid the chaos four civil leaders, later dubbed "the quartet," emerged to negotiate with the ruling Ennahda party and opposition leaders to forge a constitution for the country. The new constitution limited the influence of Islam on the government, though in a concession to Ennahda it required that the President must always be a Muslim.

In January 2014 the ruling government resigned in accordance with the agreement reached with "the quartet," Parliament passed a constitution guaranteeing broad freedoms of speech and assembly, and a timetable for new elections was established. In the new elections, held peacefully in October, the ruling party Ennahda, which had been widely seen as a failure during its two years in power, lost badly. Challenges remained, including continuing economic woes and the deep socioeconomic and regional inequalities that had contributed to the outbreak of the Arab Spring in the first place; but at least a modicum of political stability prevailed thanks to the actions of "the quartet" (Houcine Abbassi, Wided Bouchamaoui, Abdessatar Ben Moussa, and Fadhel Mahfoudh), for which they were awarded the Nobel Prize for Peace in 2015. In the decade since democracy has held in Tunisia, there has been political instability and considerable turnover in government, and many Tunisians lament that the country's underlying economic problems and inequalities have still not been addressed (the problems of high

unemployment, corruption, and prevailing regional inequality remain paramount), but at least there is a new constitution and there has been progress on the political front, especially in the realm of freedom of expression.

Algeria's Arab Spring

The Arab Spring spread early to Algeria as massive protests began in the streets of Algiers and elsewhere in December 2010 in response to events in Tunisia. Citing high food prices, unemployment, the lack of housing, government corruption, restrictions on freedom of speech, and poor living conditions, protesters called for Bouteflika's resignation in early 2011. After the initial wave of protests the government stepped in to reduce food prices, dealing with at least the immediate cause of the protests. The protests continued through March, but unlike Ben Ali in Tunisia, Bouteflika's regime survived, perhaps in part because of the price controls imposed on food as well as \$23bn in public grants, retroactive salary payments, and benefit increases for the population. The government remained as dictatorial as ever; in February 2013 it carried out a round of arrests against political opponents, mostly leaders of Islamicist parties but also of labor unions.

Bouteflika suffered a serious stroke in 2013 at age seventy-six, yet he ran for re-election in April 2014 and reportedly won 82% of the vote, although the country's main Islamicist parties and others boycotted the elections. Constant reports and rumors of corruption plagued Bouteflika and his cronies, especially those running the country's state-owned oil and gas company. Debilitated by his stroke, Bouteflika made his last public appearance in 2017, but nonetheless announced his intention to run for a fifth term in February 2019. The announcement sparked massive peaceful protests throughout the country in a sort of Arab Spring revisited. Amid the unrest military leaders insisted that Bouteflika resign, which he did in early April 2019 after twenty years as the country's president. Protests continued through the year as Algerians feared that members of Bouteflika's regime would run in his place, leading to little substantive change in the country. And, in fact, that is exactly what happened: amid very low turnout with the vast majority of the voting public boycotting the December 2019 elections, seventy-four-year-old Abdelmadjid Tebboune, who had served as Bouteflika's Prime Minister, won the presidential elections. Bouteflika died in 2021. In the final analysis the Arab Spring brought a great deal of turmoil but very little change to Algeria.

Libya's Arab Spring

The Arab Spring played out very differently in Libya. For one thing, the causes of events in Libya differed at least in degree from those of Tunisia and elsewhere. While there was a demographic "youth bulge" in the country, it was not as pronounced as that of most of the other countries in the Arab Spring. Also, while economic woes contributed to these events (Libya was

particularly vulnerable to the spike in food prices resulting from the global economic downturn due to its weak agricultural sector and thus the fact that it imports roughly 75% of its food), the main factor driving events was political disenchantment with the long-running (since 1969) government of Muammar Qaddafi.

Following the downfall of Ben Ali's regime in Tunisia and, as we will see, that of Hosni Mubarak in Egypt, in mid-February 2011 opponents of Qaddafi's regime in Libya called for "a day of rage." Qaddafi's security forces responded by firing on protesters, killing twelve. Rather than end the protests this just enraged people further and the protests grew. Rebels took over Benghazi on the country's eastern coast on February 20 and many in the Libyan armed forces defected to their side. In March the UN imposed a no-fly zone to prevent Qaddafi's Air Force from bombing civilians, although Russia, China, Germany, India, and Brazil all abstained from supporting this decision. Fighting raged for months until in August Qaddafi fled Tripoli and went into hiding. Rebels captured and killed him in October.

The ouster of Qaddafi pushed the country into a period of civil war and total chaos. Following his overthrow and death, the armed rebel forces that fought against Qaddafi's loyal troops (and his hired sub-Saharan African mercenaries) broke down into small militias, many acting as bandit groups. In March 2012 a UN Human Rights Council reported that the Libyan rebels were committing war crimes. A lot of the violence was aimed at sub-Saharan Africans, many of whom worked as migrant laborers in Libya's oil and natural gas fields. As noted, Qaddafi hired sub-Saharan African mercenaries to fight for him in his final months, which led to anger against them among Arab rebels and their supporters fighting to oust Qaddafi, so after his fall there were many attacks against sub-Saharan African laborers in the country.

The situation worsened significantly as an effective centralized government failed to emerge in the immediate post-Qaddafi era and fighting between militia groups escalated. The fighting in turn worsened the economic situation as oil production plummeted due to armed conflict among the country's various armed militia groups/gangs. Islamicists attacked the US Consulate in Benghazi on September 11, 2012, killing US Ambassador Christopher Stevens and three other members of the US diplomatic team, an event that became a major sore point in internal US politics for President Barack Obama and his Secretary of State, Hillary Clinton, when she unsuccessfully ran for president four years later.

A brutal six-year civil war followed as feuding factions vied for control. While the worst of the fighting subsided by 2020, violence has remained endemic to Libya's political and social situation as two rival governments took root, the internationally recognized (since 2021) Government of National Unity (GNU) under Prime Minister Abdul Hamid Dbeibeh, which operates out of the capital Tripoli in the west, and the Government of National Stability (GNS), which operates out of Benghazi in the east and controls much of

the south as well and most of the country's oil fields. Both governments are secular and anti-Islamist. Fighting has erupted often over the years in a scenario of ever-shifting alliances between the two rival governments and the various militias and armed gangs operating in the country, which includes several Islamist and terrorist groups. In 2019 the GNS under the leadership of Khalifa Haftar, commander of the Libyan National Army (LNA), launched an offensive to take Tripoli, but the attempt failed and in 2020 the two sides signed a ceasefire agreement leading to relative stability, albeit with the country still divided between the two governments.

Following the ceasefire the UN attempted to broker a deal leading to a reunified Libyan government. The agreement reached in Geneva in early 2021 appointed Abdul Hamid Dbeibeh Interim Prime Minister of the GNU in Tripoli, with countrywide elections scheduled for December. However, disputes over the legal framework for the planned elections led to their indefinite postponement, as a result of which they have yet to be held and Abdul Hamid Dbeibeh has now ruled the country's internationally recognized government in Western Libya for over three years without ever being elected to that position. Khalifa Haftar rules the parts of the country under his control as a family fiefdom and with an iron hand against any form of opposition, including against Islamists therein. Both of the country's two rival governments are terribly corrupt and repressive of the populations within their realms. In sum, for all of Qaddafi's many indisputable faults and failings, his overthrow during the Arab Spring has definitely been a net loss for Libya as it led to a breakdown of centralized governance, civil war, widespread violence, and continuing political and social instability.

Egypt's Arab Spring

In Egypt following the resignation of Tunisia's Ben Ali in mid-January 2011 massive protests began in Cairo's central Tahrir ("Liberation") Square (and elsewhere) against the government of Hosni Mubarak, whose corrupt, repressive regime had been in power for thirty years. In addition, in the case of Egypt the key demographic factor, the "youth bulge," a disproportionate percentage of the population age twenty-five and under, was extremely relevant, as 51% of the country's total population was under twenty-five. Egypt had the fastest growing population in the region since the 1970s partly due to immigration from Palestine and Sudan (and elsewhere).

There were also major economic problems in Egypt, many of them exacerbated by the 2008 global financial meltdown. At the time of the Arab Spring, an estimated 44% of Egyptians were "extremely poor" (unable to meet minimal food needs), "poor" (unable to meet basic food needs), or "near-poor" (able to meet basic food needs, but not much more), and more than 40% of Egypt's population lived on less than \$2 per day. High food prices and unemployment were huge problems for Egypt, where in the two years prior to the Arab Spring food prices rose by 37% and unemployment

for university graduates in 2008 reached 25%, a situation that worsened considerably over the next couple of years.

The ouster of Mubarak was just the beginning of Egypt's political turmoil during the Arab Spring. Military leaders took over following Mubarak's resignation but the country held its first truly democratic elections, initially to a newly formed Egyptian Legislature, in late 2011/early 2012, and the big winner was the only competitor with a strong national organization, the Muslim Brotherhood (organized in its political wing the Freedom and Justice Party—FJP), which won 45% percent of the seats in the lower house (the People's Assembly) and 58% percent in the upper house (the Shura Council). Even more telling of the mood of the electorate, the extremist Islamicist (Salafi) al-Nur party won 25% in each house, a surprise to most analysts. By comparison, several different secularist/liberal parties combined into two blocs won only about 14% and 12% in each house.

The Muslim Brotherhood and its political wing, the FJP, decided to put Muhammad Morsi forward for the presidential elections. He ran against a pro-Mubarak/military establishment candidate, Ahmed Shafiq, and a secularist (a poet), Hamdeen Sabahi, who emphasized the need for dramatic economic reform in the country. These candidates reflected the three key competing strands of Egypt's post-Mubarak political struggle: the Islamicists (mainly—but not just—in the form of the Muslim Brotherhood/FJP, although this is a very broad and divided segment of Egyptian society); the military/old establishment order; and the secularists/liberals, the most “Westernized” element of society, those credited with starting the protests to oust Mubarak.

The results of the first round of the presidential elections show the division of Egyptian society along those three fault lines: Morsi won with slightly over 24%; Shafiq, the military establishment/old order candidate closely associated with Mubarak came in second with a little over 23%; and Sabahi, the secularist/liberal candidate was third with over 20%. Those results put the secularists in a bind for the second round of the elections held in June 2012: with their candidate now eliminated they had to either vote for the Muslim Brotherhood/FJP candidate, the old order/military establishment candidate most closely linked to Mubarak, whom most of them hated, or not vote at all. Many chose the third option, but quite a few seem to have voted for Morsi, whose campaign in the runoff stressed his moderate Islamic and ardently anti-establishment views. Morsi won the runoff with 51.7% of the vote compared to Shafiq's 48.3%.

Morsi took over as president in the summer of 2012, but his rule proved to be very inept, at least in part because political opponents sabotaged his efforts to reform the economy and the political system. At the same time, he ruled autocratically, crushing dissent and trying to stack the judicial system with his (moderate) Islamist judges. Also, the country's economic situation worsened even more (in part because of a huge fall in Egypt's very important tourism industry), and that more than anything else may have spelled Morsi's doom. Egyptian courts, admittedly without Morsi's agreement, began

reversing a number of cases of privatization (at least eleven) involving foreign companies with state-owned Egyptian entities sold off much earlier often at bargain-basement prices, with most of the proceeds pocketed by Mubarak and his cronies (the Mubarak family fortune according to one estimate was somewhere around \$70bn).

Egypt began the “privatization” of state-owned assets in 1991 with the end of the Cold War and continued gradually until 2008 (Egypt’s state-owned banks, for example, were sold off to Italian and Greek banks between 2004–08, which proved to be a very bad decision because the economy of Greece imploded shortly thereafter and Italy’s also faltered). The decisions by the Egyptian courts to reverse these privatization deals scared off foreign investors precisely when Egypt needed large-scale foreign investment to help jumpstart its stalled economy, so this also contributed to the country’s economic woes under Morsi. In addition, in an oddity of the Egyptian military-state that had evolved over time, the military directly owned at least thirty-five companies that produced everything from cars to foodstuffs to washing machines. This peculiar aspect was crucial to the Egyptian military leadership’s privileged position in society and also at the heart of a lot of the country’s long-standing corruption problems as well.

A showdown between Morsi’s government and Egypt’s military leadership began in late June 2013, a year into Morsi’s presidency, amid huge protests (again) in Cairo’s Tahrir Square, which ended in Morsi’s ouster. The country’s key behind-the-scenes military leader, Defense Minister Abdel Fattah al-Sisi (appointed to head the military by Morsi in August 2012 as a move to placate the Islamicists because al-Sisi is reportedly a devout Muslim), used the threat of “the street”/“the masses” to his political benefit to oust Morsi and then quickly turned on the protesters, reigning in this power of mass demonstrations by repressing continued dissent very harshly once Morsi resigned and al-Sisi secured control of the government.

Turmoil continued into the summer and fall with large-scale Muslim Brotherhood protests against Morsi’s ouster, including an encampment on Tahrir Square at one point. However, al-Sisi rounded up and detained protesters in large numbers (an unknown number of protesters died during this time). In September 2013 Egypt’s Supreme Court outlawed the political activities of the Muslim Brotherhood/FJP and froze its financial assets, a stunning reversal for a group that in the early stages of the Arab Spring held power there just a few months prior! This returned the Muslim Brotherhood to the status of being a banned political grouping as it had been for so long.

Over a decade after the Arab Spring Egypt looks a lot like it did prior to the upheaval, if perhaps worse in several ways. Critics accuse the al-Sisi government of imprisoning tens of thousands of political prisoners (as many as 60,000), an accusation the government denies. Al-Sisi’s government stresses the need for security first, economic development second, and democratic rights in the country, however those may be defined, third. Freedom of speech is greatly restricted by the al-Sisi regime: more than thirty journalists

have been arrested, making Egypt one of the worst countries in the world with regard to its treatment of journalists. The regime also practices very strict censorship of online and other forms of media.

In the economic realm a decade plus of al-Sisi's rule has proven disastrous for the majority of Egyptians, who have seen a worsening of their own economic situation and an overall growth in the country's poverty rate. In 2021, ten years after the beginning of the Arab Spring, one estimate found that around 60% of the Egyptian population lived at or below the poverty level, a situation even worse than that of the Mubarak era. Under al-Sisi Egypt has become the world's second largest borrower from the IMF; in 2014, the country had a foreign debt of \$46bn, whereas by 2021 Egypt owed international investors through the IMF more than \$125bn, with more than 50% of the country's revenue spent to pay back its foreign debt. Despite that al-Sisi has managed to build several large presidential palaces. Given this situation, not surprisingly sporadic small-scale protests against al-Sisi's military-backed regime have broken out in recent years. Met invariably with a harsh government response none of the protests have grown to anywhere near the level of the early 2010s. In the case of Egypt, then, the aftermath of the Arab Spring has seen a return to a similar if not worse situation with a corrupt, dictatorial military-backed regime in power amid terrible economic conditions in the country.



Map 10.1 Map of West Africa.

10 West Africa

Ghana, Nigeria, Liberia, and Sierra Leone

The vast continent of Africa, second in size to Asia, is divided by the Saharan Desert, the world's largest, which separates the continent's interior from North Africa. The equator dissects the continent, running through Gabon, Congo, the Democratic Republic of Congo, Kenya, Uganda, and Somalia. Africa is home to numerous lakes, the largest being Lake Victoria, the reservoir of the Nile River, located between Kenya, Uganda, and Tanzania. In addition to the Nile there are several large river systems in Africa: the Congo, the continent's second largest, and its tributaries run through mostly the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) in the continent's central west and interior; the Niger River system, Africa's third largest, runs through Nigeria, Niger, Mali and Guinea. There are some small mountain chains in Africa; the largest mountain, Kilimanjaro in Tanzania, part of the Eastern Rift mountains, is one of the highest free-standing mountains in the world.

Africa south of the Sahara was for centuries a crucial hub connecting miners, agriculturalists, and others with savanna and desert traders and with merchants and rulers in North Africa and beyond. Like the rest of the world, a major theme in the history of modern Africa is its interaction with the West and the impact thereof. Unlike the rest of the world, that relationship took the particularly nefarious form of the slave trade. Slavery as an institution has existed for millennia in many parts of the world, but the modern slave trade centered around Africa, which began in the sixteenth century and lasted into the nineteenth century, was very different because of its exclusively racial basis and because of its overwhelmingly dramatic and long-term impact on the continent itself and the rest of the world. Many of the issues facing Africa today stem from changes brought by the slave trade.

The slave trade had a dramatic demographic impact, as roughly 8mn Africans were enslaved and forcibly exported to the New World between 1500–1850, creating the largest diaspora, or spreading of population, in history. The slave trade set the pattern for European-African relations throughout the modern period: Europeans financed, organized, and profited highly from the slave trade, but the capture, delivery, and control of slaves was mostly handled by Africans. A small indigenous African elite benefited

from ties with the West by dominating the majority, and the continent's ethnic groups were polarized as slave hunters and their victims, especially in Africa's West Coast where the slave trade flourished. This type of relationship is not limited to nor unique to Africa; in other areas of the world, as we have seen, native elites have also sought to benefit from the colonial relationship with the West at the expense of others. The specific form of the slave trade as the basis of this relationship, however, is unique. In addition, the slave trade reoriented the continent's economy to the supply and export of slaves and led to a strengthening of centralized power among African states. Europeans armed and supported a few specific leaders whose power and wealth grew as they controlled and taxed the slave traders.

Just as the rise of the slave trade had dramatic consequences for Africa, the sudden end of the trade in the nineteenth century likewise had a serious impact. The artificially strong, highly centralized slave kingdoms that sprang up to fulfill the demand for slaves gradually began to disintegrate, leading to chaos and warfare between various groups over much of the continent's interior. Consequently, Africa was in a relatively weakened state by the middle of the nineteenth century, which facilitated European colonial expansion into the continent. Hot on the trails of Africa's two main explorers, the Scotsman Dr. David Livingstone and New York journalist Henry Morton Stanley, European colonists began moving into Africa in the mid-to-late nineteenth century. By the 1880s, competition for colonies in Africa had become intense, so Germany's Chancellor Otto von Bismark called for a conference to settle disputed boundaries and set rules for expansion.

At the Berlin Conference in 1884–85, the European powers reached an agreement regulating European colonization and trade in Africa, leading to a heightened period of colonial activity in Africa. The colonial powers built railroads and modern cities as administrative centers, gradually opening up the African interior to the international economy as a supplier of cash crops such as cocoa, coffee, peanuts, rubber, palm oil, timber, and others. Africa became a large supplier of raw materials and cash crops to Europe, which completely transformed African society. Economic “development” had a profoundly negative environmental impact, especially in mineral-rich regions of the continent, of which there were several. In addition, Europeans settled some African lands as settler colonialism was prevalent in Algeria, as we have seen, but also in Kenya and several other areas such as Portuguese-controlled Mozambique and Angola, as well as Rhodesia (now Zimbabwe) and South Africa, which we examine in a later chapter.

Ghana

The west coast of Africa, also known as the “gold coast” or “slave coast,” includes Ghana, our first case study for this unit. The interior of the African continent has historically been home to some highly advanced civilizations, including one from the eighth to the fifteenth centuries called Ghana, from

which the modern-day country takes its name. With its capital at Accra modern Ghana is the second most populous country in West Africa with just shy of 35mn people as of 2025. The Volta River system runs through much of the country and a dam constructed in the south in the early 1960s created the Lake Volta reservoir, which is among the world's largest.

After several unsuccessful attempts the British conquered the Ashanti people, Ghana's largest ethnic group on the coast of West Africa, in the late nineteenth century. They ruled the colony through their typical form of indirect colonialism and introduced the cultivation of cocoa on a large scale. Before they started planting cocoa seeds, Ghanaian peasants grew food crops for subsistence. Those who made the switch to cocoa did so voluntarily, and clearly it benefited some as the introduction of this cash crop gave incentive to produce more and make more money. As we have seen in the case of colonial India and elsewhere, the introduction of a major cash crop (in this case cocoa) transformed Ghana's economy into one based on cash, tying Ghanaian peasants to the international economy as producers of a cash crop for sale on the international market. They used that cash to pay expenses and buy food, which previously they had grown for themselves, constituting a radical transformation of the traditional Ghanaian economy. One consequence of the commercialization of agriculture is that it weakened the power of local chiefs in villages throughout the country because they had no claim or control over the money being made.

Ghana Under Nkrumah (1957–66)

As elsewhere in the world, there was movement in Africa toward independence or de-colonization after World War II. Under the leadership of Kwame Nkrumah Ghana was the first African colony to receive its independence in 1957. Born in 1909 into a relatively wealthy family of the Akan ethnic group (closely related to the Ashanti and part of the majority group), Nkrumah studied in the US between 1935–45. He returned to Ghana after World War II and quickly became very popular by calling for immediate independence. The British arrested and jailed him in 1950, which made him more popular. Nkrumah, an avowedly socialist leader and member of the Convention People's Party (CPP), won the country's first elections and ruled Ghana for a decade, 1957–66.

Nkrumah felt that a planned, state-guided economy was the best path to rapid economic development. He welcomed foreign investors if they agreed to reinvest part of their profits back into the country, and Ghana took loans from Western banks through the World Bank and IMF after independence. He hoped that Ghana could use revenue generated by exporting cocoa, the country's main cash crop and resource, to industrialize and diversify the economy, thereby overcoming Ghana's dependence on cocoa. Nkrumah looked to the countryside, to the peasants, to pay for economic modernization, greatly favoring urban development. The government paid for

modernization projects by purchasing cocoa from farmers for far less than the world market price, then reselling it at that higher price to raise funds for (primarily) urban development programs. Nkrumah kept private property in the countryside intact and did not collectivize agriculture, so he was not following the Soviet model completely.

The problem with Nkrumah's policy was that it did not give Ghana's peasant farmers incentive to grow cocoa, the government's main source of income, so when many of them switched from cocoa back to subsistence food crops, the government's income fell sharply. Cocoa growers smuggled their crop out of the country so they could get higher prices for it. Large numbers of peasants abandoned agriculture altogether and migrated to the cities, leading to rapid urbanization, which contributed further to a decrease in agricultural production. Compounding matters, in the mid-1960s the price of cocoa fell dramatically on the world market because of an increase in supply, causing a sharp drop in income for Ghana.

While Nkrumah was on a state visit to North Vietnam and China in 1966 a group of political opponents with support from the military overthrew his government, which had lost most of its initial public support and popularity owing to the economic woes in the country. The overthrow of Nkrumah led to a long period of political instability in Ghana, marked by ethnic rivalries and conflict. Between 1966–81 there were fourteen coups and the military dominated the country's political process. Economic woes continued as well as the country's government, amid rampant corruption, continued underpaying peasant farmers for their cocoa crops and skimming income from the resell of the cocoa on the world market. As a result, Ghana's cocoa-dependent economy ground to a halt in the early 1980s.

Ghana under Jerry Rawlings (1981–2001)

A young military leader, Jerry Rawlings, took over the government in another coup in 1981, but with a very different, pro-market economic mindset. Rawlings turned to the World Bank and IMF for help getting Ghana out of its economic crisis. These organizations promised loans to Ghana if it would institute free-market reforms, which Ghana began to do in 1983. Rawlings privatized state-controlled monopolies, allocated more resources to rural development, cut government spending, and shrank the bureaucracy, all at the urging of the international lending agencies. Most importantly, Rawlings' new government allowed peasant growers to keep a far larger share of the income from their cocoa crops, as a result of which cocoa production rose sharply in Ghana over the mid-1980s.

The free-market approach worked excellently for about five years and Ghana's economy gained ground that had been lost in the previous twenty years. But a major problem remained, the very problem that Nkrumah had hoped to overcome through his own unsuccessful programs: the country's continued dependence on the international market for its main cash crop,

cocoa. The trap or catch-22 that Ghana discovered was that the very success of the free-market reforms it instigated in the early and mid-1980s led to economic crisis in the late 1980s. Owing to the reforms and the greater emphasis on the rural economy under Rawlings, cocoa production rose dramatically. But as a result of the increased supply of cocoa on the international market because of higher production in Ghana (and elsewhere) the price of cocoa on the international market fell sharply, by about one-third, in 1987, and cocoa prices remained low for about the next five years. Amid a new economic crisis, Ghana turned to the World Bank and IMF for still more loans, with more strings attached. By the early 1990s, the country was heavily in debt with about one-fifth of its national income going just to repay previous loans.

Ghana's economy remains dependent on the production of cocoa, as it and neighboring Ivory Coast are by far the world's two largest growers of cocoa, accounting for over 50% of the global supply (Ivory Coast being the larger supplier of the two). Cocoa prices on the global market improved in the late 1990s, partly because Ghana's peasants once again returned to producing food crops, which led to a decrease in supply. Between late 1991–2003 the price of cocoa on the global market fluctuated between \$1,316 per metric ton (pmt) and \$2,230pmt. Prices declined thereafter but remained relatively stable, reaching a high point of \$3,517pmt in late 2009. The civil war in the 2000s in neighboring Ivory Coast disrupted cocoa production in that country and sent prices for the crop higher on the international market, which benefited Ghana. While fluctuating somewhat, prices remained relatively stable in recent years until a sharp rise from \$2,432pmt in October 2022 to a peak of \$9,865pmt in April 2024 owing to a decrease in supply caused by dry, hot weather on Africa's West Coast, a consequence of climate change as well as sharp increases in production costs. Prices have begun to come back down since.

Politically, Rawlings, like Nkrumah before him, left office amid significant economic problems, stepping down in late 2000. Opposition candidate John Kufuor of the New Patriotic Party (NPP) won a close election over Rawling's preferred successor and assumed power in January 2001. Re-elected in 2005, Kufuor stepped aside four years later because of term limits. Close but stable elections and peaceful transfers of power have characterized Ghana's politics this century, making it a poor country with a relatively stable democratic government. John Dramani Mahama, a member of Ghana's National Democratic Congress (NDC), won the country's 2024 elections. He had previously served as president from 2012–17 but lost his re-election bid; his election in 2024 makes him the first president in Ghanaian history to be elected to two non-consecutive terms.

Nigeria

Nigeria with its capital at Abuja and a population of roughly 218.5mn as of 2023 is the most populous country in Africa and the sixth most populous

country in the world. It is a remarkably diverse country with about 250 different ethnic groups and a major religious and cultural divide between the predominantly Muslim north and the predominantly Christian south. Of the many different ethnic groups in Nigeria, the dominant and most numerous are the Hausa and Fulani, centered mainly in the north. They were two of the main slave-hunting groups during the era of the slave trade. Other groups include the Ibo in the south, who were one of the main victimized groups of the slave hunters, and the Yorubas in the west. The Ogoni residing mainly in the Niger River Delta in the country's south and numbering about 2mn are an example of one of the country's many small ethnic groups.

As in the case of Ghana, the British colonized what is today Nigeria in the late nineteenth century. Nigeria gained its independence from Britain in 1960 as part of the process of de-colonization; control of the central government since independence is key because the ethnic group(s) that control the government control the allocation of resources. This is particularly important since oil was discovered in the Niger River Delta in southern Nigeria in 1958 and quickly became central to the country's economic development. Nigeria is now the largest oil producer in Africa; it joined OPEC in 1971. Whereas the oil is mostly located in the country's south, the central government, and therefore the budget, has been controlled for most of Nigeria's history by ethnic groups primarily from the north, who have allocated a disproportionate amount of the government's resources to the benefit of that region and their own people. Thus, control of the allocation of resources (economic power) as well as (or along with) ethnic and cultural divisions are at the root of many of Nigeria's post-independence problems, which is true for a lot of other post-independence African states as well.

Nigeria has a history of ethnic conflict. Between 1966–70 a civil war raged in the oil-rich southern Biafra region as groups there tried unsuccessfully to secede and declare independence. The northern groups controlling the central government did not want the oil-rich south to secede and the government resorted to a blockade of the region that led to widespread starvation among the Ibo, one of the largest southern groups leading the drive to break off and become independent. After an estimated 1mn casualties the war ended with the surrender of the Ibo in the Biafra region in 1970. After the Biafra War ended oil money fueled economic growth in the 1970s (due in part to the 1973 OPEC oil embargo and increase in oil prices on the world market) and there was a rapid migration of rural farm workers to the cities, urbanization being another development common to post-independence African states.

Since independence a succession of military dictators ruled Nigeria. The dramatic drop in oil prices due to a glut of supply on the world oil market in the 1980s led to economic problems. The military annulled democratic elections in 1993 and General Sani Abacha seized power. A major controversy in Nigeria during Abacha's rule involved the British-Dutch Shell Oil Company's role, particularly with respect to the Ogoni people in the southern Niger River Delta. The Ogoni traditionally lived off agriculture and fishing,

but the polluting of their land and water after the discovery of oil in the area in the late 1950s greatly damaged the region's environment and disrupted their lifestyle. Abacha's military regime executed Ken Saro-wiwa, leader of the Movement for the Solidarity of the Ogoni People (MOSOP), in November 1995, leading to international criticism of the Nigerian regime as well as of Shell Oil because of its role buttressing the dictatorship.

Abacha's death in July 1998 cleared the way for highly disputed elections reportedly won by a former general, Olusegun Obasanjo, amid widespread claims of voter fraud. Re-elected for a second term (again amid claims of voter fraud), Obasanjo tried unsuccessfully to alter Nigeria's Constitution so that he could run for a third term in 2007, but the country's legislature refused to approve the changes needed for him to run again. Umaru Musa Yar'adua won the (once again disputed) 2007 elections, which ended in a peaceful transfer of power. Yar'adua died in 2010 and Vice-President Goodluck Jonathan replaced him, ruling during a period of relative economic boom in Nigeria, fueled in large part by very high oil prices on the international market. However, his presidency was marred by widespread corruption as well as the rise of terrorism reflecting an upsurge in Islamic extremism primarily in the northern part of the country. The militant Islamicist group Boko Haram (the word "boko" is a holdover from the colonial era for the English word "book" and together with "haram" the phrase means "Western Education is forbidden for you") began an armed insurgency against the government of Nigeria with the aim of establishing an Islamic state in the region in 2009. The insurgency spread to several neighboring countries as well.

In 2014 insurgents seized control of territory in northeastern Nigeria amid increasing violence and bloodshed in the country, with an estimated 10,000 deaths in the conflict that year alone. In an incident that gained international attention, Boko Haram terrorists in April 2014 kidnapped 276 mostly Christian and some Muslim female students aged 16–18 at a government-run girl's school in Chibok, Borno state in the country's northeastern corner. Some of the girls escaped in the days following the kidnapping, and the bodies of some killed by the terrorists have been discovered since, but now over a decade later the whereabouts of over one hundred of the young women remain unknown. Boko Haram aligned with ISIS in 2015. A concerted military effort by the Nigerian Army allied with those of neighboring states had largely contained the Boko Haram insurgency by 2023, though some elements of the group remain unaccounted for.

In part because of this unrest, but also because of the issue of corruption in the country, Jonathan lost his bid for re-election in Nigeria in 2015 to one of the country's former military dictators, Muhammadu Buhari, who promised to clamp down on corruption. This marked the first time an incumbent president in the country lost a bid for re-election. Buhari was re-elected in 2019 and his handpicked successor, Bola Tinubu, won a closely contested and highly disputed 2023 election. After assuming power (amid controversy over the election results), Tinubu enacted harsh austerity reforms, ending

fuel subsidies and sharply devaluing Nigeria's currency, the *Naira*, which lost approximately 60% of its value between June-August 2024. He justified the reforms as a way to attract foreign investment into the country, but their impact on the population's living standards has been extremely negative, leading to the highest level of inflation in the country in thirty years and prompting massive protests in the capital Abuja, the southern port city Lagos, and other parts of Nigeria in August 2024. About half of Nigeria's population lives in extreme poverty on a monthly minimum wage of around \$19 amid the worst economic crisis to hit the country in decades. In the protests against the austerity reforms the military and police killed an estimated thirteen protesters. It remains to be seen how the unstable situation in Nigeria will unfold.

Liberia

Liberia, a small country with a population of about 5.7mn as of 2025, is rich in resources such as timber, diamond and gold deposits, which have been the mainstay of its economy for decades. Like most of Africa, Liberia is very diverse in ethno-linguistic and religious terms. The majority of its people are from indigenous African tribal groups, including the Kpelle, Bassa, Dei, Krahn, Mano, and Gio, along with at least ten other groups. Together these various indigenous tribal groups make up about 95% of the country's population; the other 5% are the Creole (Krio), descendants of American and Caribbean slaves who settled the country in the mid-nineteenth century. Religiously the country is split between Christianity, about 40%, indigenous beliefs, also about 40%, and Islam, about 20%. English is Liberia's official language, although it is the native language for only about 20% of the population. The remaining 80% speak any of more than twenty tribal languages as their native tongue, but most people in the country speak English.

In 1815 an African-American Quaker and maritime entrepreneur, Paul Cuffee, led a voyage to Sierra Leone, where he helped a small group of African-American immigrants establish themselves. Although he died two years later before he could build on these first steps, Cuffee's voyage set the stage for the eventual formation of Liberia. Following Cuffee's death the American Colonization Society (ACS) formed to continue his project of returning freed American slaves to Africa, where they felt freed slaves would have a greater chance of establishing themselves than in the US. In 1821 the ACS dispatched Dr. Eli Ayres to purchase land farther north up the coast from Sierra Leone. With the assistance of a US Naval Officer, Lieutenant Robert Stockton, Ayres "convinced"—some accounts suggest forced, possibly even at gunpoint—leaders of the indigenous Dei and Bassa peoples, who resided in the area of Cape Mesurado, to part with a thirty-six-mile long, three-mile-wide strip of land along the coast in exchange for various goods, including weapons and rum, worth a total of about \$300.

In 1825 the settlement that sprang up as a result of that agreement became Monrovia, named after US President James Monroe, and the area as a whole was formally called Liberia. Slave states in the US, increasingly interested in exiling some of their free African-American populations, encouraged the settlement of Liberia in the decades to follow. The main source of income for this early Liberian proto-state (nominally run by the ACS) was the customs duties levied on indigenous traders and the British merchants who did business with them. In the 1840s this led to increasing tensions, and in 1846 the British government informed Liberian authorities that it did not recognize the right of the ACS to levy taxes. This prompted Liberia's leaders to move toward statehood with full taxing authority, which was increasingly seen as necessary for the survival of its immigrant, settler population. Thus, in October 1846, the relatively small number of Americo-Liberian settlers voted in favor of independence.

On July 26, 1847, leaders adopted and signed the Liberian Declaration of Independence, in which they charged their "mother country," the US, with injustices that compelled them to leave and make new lives for themselves and their descendants in Africa. The US did not recognize the independence of Liberia until 1862, during the US Civil War. Liberia established a limited democracy (the right to vote was not extended to indigenous African peoples nor women) led mostly by formerly free African-Americans, now Afro-Liberian settlers. The first several presidents of the country were US born, and the first president in the country's history born in Liberia, Hilary Johnson, elected in 1885, was the son of Americo-Liberian settlers.

Tensions arose between the Americo-Liberian settlers, who tended to be very Westernized and well educated, and the native, indigenous African peoples of the region, who resented and resisted the imposition of economic and political control over their traditional homelands by the newly independent state of Liberia. From the outset of the country's history the Americo-Liberian (Creole) settlers formed an elite that excluded local African peoples from full participation in the nation's social and political life. Liberia avoided being colonized by European powers, the fate of most African territories at the time, though it did lose territories along the border with Sierra Leone to the British. Liberia's status as an independent African nation was acknowledged by its entry into the League of Nations in 1919 following World War I.

Liberia After World War II

In 1946 the right to vote and participate as candidates in elections was extended to Liberia's indigenous peoples, who comprised a large majority of the population. Liberia's history from 1944–80 was shaped by the democratically elected leadership of several strong individuals, members of the Americo-Liberian Creole elite and representatives of the True Whig Party that had formed in 1869 and had dominated Liberian politics since the late

nineteenth century. Notable among the country's post-World War II leaders was William Tubman, elected to the first of seven terms in 1944. He died while still in office in 1971 and Vice-President William Tolbert, also of the True Whig Party, replaced him. Tolbert was re-elected in 1972 and 1976. Growing economic difficulties, however, undermined Tolbert's government, as did his alleged corruption and nepotism (Tolbert had twenty siblings, and he appointed several of them to powerful cabinet positions). In April 1979 a large protest against increased food prices, especially for rice, a staple of the Liberian diet, turned violent, and Tolbert called out the military to put it down.

This event foreshadowed a major turning point in the country's history: in April 1980 a military coup led by Master Sergeant Samuel Doe overthrew Tolbert, who died in the coup. This was the first time Liberia's government was overthrown by a military coup, an otherwise common occurrence for most of the African continent. Also, in a stark shift in the country's political history, Doe was not part of the small Americo-Liberian Creole elite that had dominated the country's politics since independence in 1847. He was from a poor rural family and part of the Krahn tribe, one of the indigenous ethnic groups excluded from political participation for much of Liberia's history. The military takeover led by Doe was a bloody one, labeled "a revolution" by the eighteen enlisted men of the Liberian Armed Forces who carried out the coup. By the end of April 1980, less than a month after the coup, the entire ruling cabinet of the previous government had been put on trial and sentenced to death. They were publicly executed on a beach near Monrovia, with one exception—a single cabinet member was spared because he was the only minister of tribal origin, underscoring the long-standing tensions between the country's Americo-Liberian Creole elite minority and its mostly impoverished Afro-Liberian majority.

Doe, who took over leadership of the country as Chairman of the People's Redemption Council, did not substantially alter Liberia's economic or political position. He maintained (to the relief of US leaders) the country's anti-communist stance in the Cold War. During an official state visit to the US in 1981, President Reagan shook Doe's hand while mistakenly referring to him as "Chairman Moe." On several occasions Doe promised to return the government to civilian rule, but his actions contradicted his promises. He increasingly surrounded himself with members of his own (small) Krahn tribe. Yet Liberia received more political and military assistance from the US in the decade of Doe's rule than ever before, despite an increasingly atrocious human rights record by the regime.

Doe returned the country to "civilian" rule in elections that he won in late 1985. One month after the elections Doe's former right-hand man, General Thomas Quiwonkpa, led an armed invasion from the north of the country. The rebels, who were mainly from the Mano and Gio tribal groups, moved into Monrovia and attacked the Executive Mansion. However, during the revolt Doe's troops killed General Quiwonkpa and publicly displayed his

mutilated body, which put an end to the uprising. The excessive and brutal reprisals of the Krahn-led Liberian Army against the northern tribal groups, the Mano and Gio, proved to be an important development in the civil war to come, which began in late 1989. In December an alliance composed of Americo-Liberians as well as the Mano and Gio ethnic groups from the north, united in the National Patriotic Front of Liberia (NPLF), invaded Liberia from the Ivory Coast.

The leader of the NPLF was Charles Taylor, son of an Americo-Liberian father and an Afro-Liberian mother from the Gola ethnic group and a corrupt former civil servant under Doe's reign. Taylor had been exiled from Liberia for corruption, but Libya's Muammar Qaddafi granted him refuge and financial support to begin training a militia of Liberian exiles in Libya. The rebel group led by Taylor invaded Liberia in 1989 and occupied territory there. In September 1990, despite the presence of a West African peacekeeping force in the country, Yormie Johnson, an Afro-Liberian leader originally part of the NPLF until he broke with Taylor, captured Doe. Johnson tortured, mutilated, and brutally killed Doe and several of his men, videotaping the gruesome details of this incident. In the months that followed confusion reigned in Liberia, and years of civil war and fighting between several different factions ensued, breaking down mostly along ethnic/tribal lines. A West African peacekeeping contingent restored some semblance of order in 1995 and a ceasefire finally ended the fighting and allowed for elections to be held in 1996. Charles Taylor won the elections in a landslide.

However, hopes for a peaceful resolution to Liberia's problems proved short-lived, as Afro-Liberian rebel groups formed to fight Taylor's armed forces. Since 2000 when large-scale fighting erupted again in the country three main factions have contended for power: Taylor's own government armed forces in the areas around the capital, Monrovia, largely comprised of poorly disciplined and unorganized militia groups; Liberians United for Reconciliation and Democracy (LURD) rebels, representing northern tribal groups, especially the Mano and Gio, who initially operated from bases in Guinea but gradually gained ground in the north and west of Liberia; and The Movement for Democracy in Liberia (MODEL), comprised of many former supporters of Samuel Doe and dominated by the Krahn tribal group, which gained control of strategic areas in the south and east and managed to cut off revenue from timber exports, a key government source of revenue. All three of these factions relied on very young boys as soldiers, often as young as ten.

In 2001, while he was still nominally President of Liberia amid an ongoing civil war in the country, the UN accused Taylor of destabilizing neighboring countries, especially Sierra Leone, where he profited from supporting rebels operating in diamond mining areas. The British, former colonial rulers of Sierra Leone, led an international peacekeeping operation to end the fighting there, drying up one of Taylor's main revenue sources. In addition, the Liberian government's problems were compounded when in 2001 the UN

imposed sanctions on Liberian diamonds and a ban on selling weapons to the country. With government income from timber likewise cut off owing to rebel actions in the south, Taylor began to run short of money to pay his troops, especially since he was forced to buy weapons illegally and thus at higher prices. As a result, he basically gave militia groups loyal to him a free hand to terrorize and rob the population as a form of compensation, which alienated him from most Liberians, who accused Taylor of ruling the country like a warlord.

Compounding matters further for Taylor, while he was in Ghana for peace talks in July 2003 the UN-backed war crimes tribunal in Sierra Leone issued a warrant for his arrest because of his support of rebel groups there. Nigeria offered Taylor exile should he step down, which he agreed to do with the arrival of an International Peacekeeping Force. Fortunately, the 2003 peace agreement held, and after two years of rule by a transitional government, democratic elections in late 2005 brought President Ellen Johnson Sirleaf to power, the first woman elected as an African head of state. The UN Mission in Liberia (UNMIL) maintains a strong presence throughout the country, but the security situation is still fragile and the process of rebuilding the social and economic structure of this war-torn country will take many years. For her efforts to stabilize Liberia Sirleaf was awarded the Nobel Prize for Peace in 2011, soon after which she won re-election for a second term. With Sirleaf unable to run for a third term in 2017 former soccer star George Weah ran for and won the presidency, which he held until early 2024, at which time Joseph Boakai assumed the office following his electoral victory.

Sierra Leone

Sierra Leone, with its capital at Freetown, is a small country on Africa's West Coast with a population of about 8.6mn as of 2024, making it one of the most densely populated countries on Africa's West Coast. Like most African countries, Sierra Leone is a very ethnically and religiously mixed country. It has been the site of African settlement for many years (originally the Sherbo, but then joined by the migration of the Temne to the North and the Mende to the Southeast). Like Liberia the modern history of Sierra Leone began with the settlement of the port city Freetown in 1787 by about 400 freed slaves from North America. Soon other freed slaves brought there mainly by British abolitionists joined them, including a large group of freed slaves from Jamaica who arrived in 1800. The British banned the slave trade for its citizens in 1807, and the following year they declared Freetown a crown colony and used it as a naval base for antislavery patrols. Sierra Leone thus became Britain's first African colony in West Africa in the heart of mostly French-controlled territory.

Today the majority of Sierra Leone's population belong to one of the two largest ethnic/linguistic groups, the Temne (about 35%) and Mende (about 31%). The Krio (Creole), descendants of the freed North American and

Jamaican slaves who settled in Freetown, make up about 10% of the overall total, and some fifteen other smaller groups make up the rest. About 60% of the population is Muslim, about 10% Christian, and about 30% maintain indigenous beliefs. Their Islam (and no doubt their Christianity too) is mixed with indigenous beliefs and practices, particularly ancestor worship.

The British introduced coffee as a cash crop for production in Sierra Leone and also extracted palm oil from the country as an export. In the 1930s British geologists discovered major deposits of diamonds in the eastern region of the country, mainly the Kono and Mende regions, which would change the trajectory of the country's history for decades to come. Sierra Leone gained its independence in 1961 and eventually became a one-party state with a *very* corrupt government, the corruption fueled by the country's diamond wealth. Between 1967–71 there were several military coups and a revolving door leadership. Eventually a degree of stability, albeit amid continuing corruption and political repression, returned under the lengthy presidency of Siaka Stevens, who ruled as President of Sierra Leone between 1971–85. Retiring from office in 1985, Stevens chose Major General Joseph Momoh as his handpicked successor.

In 1989 as we saw, Charles Taylor's forces invaded neighboring Liberia. Among Taylor's rebel group were his followers from Liberia, mercenaries from Burkina Faso, and a few from Sierra Leone, including a former army officer Foday Sankoh, a close ally of Taylor who formed the Revolutionary United Front (RUF). The brutal civil war in Liberia sparked by Taylor's invasion spilled over into neighboring Sierra Leone, where the RUF, led by Sankoh but clearly under Taylor's command, invaded in March 1991, sparking a civil war that would last off and on for eleven years (1991–2002).

According to the report of Sierra Leone's Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC) released in 2005, in the RUF's original invading force of several thousand troops, only one in five was a native of Sierra Leone—most were Taylor's rebels from Liberia and quite a few were from Burkina Faso—and they took their commands from Taylor, *not* Sankoh. In other words, this was not an entirely home-grown rebellion; nor, however, was it an entirely external attack or invasion—it was somewhere in between. Widespread corruption definitely sparked legitimate opposition to Momoh's government in Sierra Leone, but at the same time the brutality of the rebels and their greedy motivation—diamonds—did not gain them a lot of popular support either.

The make up of the rebel forces quickly changed as the RUF coerced many men and young boys to “fight” with them. As a result, the rebel forces quickly became much more of a native Sierra Leone force. It is possible that some did so out of genuine support for the rebels or out of sincere dislike for the Momoh government (or both); but many were forced to fight with the rebels whether they wanted to or not. The country's diamond wealth, the diamond rich eastern Kono region in particular, attracted the RUF to Sierra Leone. They terrorized the local population and forced many of them

out of the area so that they could mine the diamonds with little interference (enslaving others to mine the diamonds for them). Taylor and Sankoh used the wealth generated from the diamonds they stole from Sierra Leone—blood diamonds as they became known—to pay for the weapons they needed for their rebel soldiers.

The government changed hands several times during the fighting in Sierra Leone in the 1990s; the RUF controlled large parts of the country, especially the diamond rich Kono region, and even threatened areas around the capital Freetown on a couple of occasions in the mid-1990s. The rebels seized the capital for a while in 1999, the fighting leaving much of Freetown in ruins. The TRC report in 2005 estimated that 60% of the country's women had been raped during a very bloody and brutal civil war in which both sides, the RUF *and* the government army, used child soldiers.

Stability gradually returned following a 1999 peace agreement (the Lomé Peace Accord) that brought a large contingent of UN Peacekeepers into the country. According to the agreement, Sankoh, leader of the rebel RUF forces, took over the government post of Minister of Strategic Minerals. Thus, he had control over the country's diamond production and was known for handing out sacks of money from his palace in Freetown to his supporters from the diamond wealth he attained. However, Sankoh and some of his closest supporters were arrested in 2000 for violating the peace agreement, and finally by early 2002 President Ahmad Kabbah, who had been elected in 1996, ousted and then returned to power in 1998, proclaimed an end to the country's bloody civil war that had claimed 75,000 lives and displaced around 1mn people (including half a million refugees in neighboring countries, mostly Guinea). In 2012 an International Tribunal found Charles Taylor guilty for his role in the civil wars in Sierra Leone and Liberia and sentenced him to fifty years in prison, an effective life sentence for him.

One legacy of the brutal war was the number of people with their fingers or hands cut off. The government marked people's fingers with a purple dye when they voted, so the rebels cut off arms, hands, and fingers, presumably to keep people from voting. The RUF even had specific units that specialized in amputating limbs! One faction in the fighting was known for forcing its recruits and others to eat human flesh as an initiation. The war was neither politically nor ideologically motivated but criminally driven, with dispossessed youths brainwashed to wreak vengeance on a society that left many of them despairing and poor.

Economically Sierra Leone remains a major exporter of diamonds, an estimated two-thirds of which are purchased in the US, yet it is one of the poorest countries in the world, with an average income for its population as of 2022 of around \$600/year. Politically the country has had five elections in the twenty-first century, which is a sign of improvement over the twentieth century (and the civil war of the 1990s in particular), though problems certainly remain. In September 2007 the Vice-President of the ruling Mende-dominated Sierra Leone People's Party (SLPP) and an opposition candidate of

the All People's Congress (APC) competed for the presidency. The opposition candidate, Ernest Bai Koroma, won and took office peacefully. Koroma ruled until 2018, when he lost a very close (and disputed) election to Julius Maada Bio of the SLPP. Bio "won" re-election in 2023 over APC opposition candidate Samura Kamara in a highly disputed election denounced by local and international observers owing to the lack of transparency in the vote counting process. As an indication of the country's lingering political instability, in January 2024 President Bio ordered the arrest of former President Koroma following an alleged coup attempt the previous November.



Map 11.1 Map of Sudan and South Sudan.

11 Sudan, South Sudan, and the Crisis in Darfur

Sudan and South Sudan

Before South Sudan became the newest country in the world by breaking away and declaring its independence in 2011, Sudan with its capital Khartoum was the largest country in Africa (it is now the third largest). Sudan has a population of around 50mn as of 2024, whereas South Sudan, a landlocked country with its capital at Juba, has a population of almost 11.5mn as of 2023. The Libyan/Saharan desert dominates northwestern Sudan, while the Nile and its tributaries dissect Sudan and South Sudan, which are comprised mostly of flat plains with a few small mountainous areas in the West (Darfur) region of Sudan and in South Sudan. There are an estimated nineteen different major ethnic groups and countless different languages in Sudan (there are nearly 600 different ethnic subgroups in the country speaking over 100 languages). The official language in Sudan is Arabic, spoken by roughly 40% of the population in northern and central Sudan, the area that has historically been the power base of Sudanese politics since its independence from British rule in 1956.

As part of Sudan in the west the Darfur region has about 12mn residents and is partly in the Arab-speaking region and partly outside of it. Sudanese Arabs make up the majority of Sudan's population at approximately 70%, although many of them (about 30%) speak various dialects of Arabic. Significant minority groups in Sudan include the Zaghawa and Fur, both of which predominate in Darfur, which means "the land of the Fur"—and the broadly defined Arabic-speaking Baggara (Baqqarah), who are further subdivided into several subgroups. Other small ethnic groups in Sudan include the Beja, Nuba, and Fallata; there are many more.

South Sudan has a population of about 13mn with around twenty main ethnic groups and numerous other smaller subgroups. The largest and most influential ethnic group in South Sudan is the Dinka (about 40%) and one of the main smaller groups is the Nuer (about 15%). A key distinction between the different ethnic groups in Sudan and South Sudan historically is that some are settled agriculturalists, whereas others are nomadic and semi-nomadic herders. This is the most important breakdown of all, more a

matter of lifestyle than ethnicity or language, and this divide between farmers and nomadic/semi-nomadic herders is very much at the heart of the crisis in Darfur. The Fur are mostly settled agriculturalists who also herd cattle, and the Zaghawa, who comprise one of the largest groups in neighboring Chad, are pastoralists who herd mostly cattle and camels. The Baggara groups are nomadic and semi-nomadic herders.

Along with the ethno-linguistic, economic, and lifestyle differences within Sudan, another key factor in the two countries is religion, with Islam being Sudan's majority religion while Christianity predominates in South Sudan. Following the secession of the mostly Christian south, now the vast majority of Sudan's population (nearly 97%) are Sunni Muslims. Islam came early (mid-seventh century) to northern Sudan but spread more slowly toward the central and southern parts of the country, which explains why the south is mostly non-Muslim. Indigenous African religions are also present, making up about a quarter of the total population in South Sudan. Religion was central to past conflicts in Sudan but it is *not* a divisive factor in the conflict in Sudan's Darfur region because the groups involved in the struggle there are all predominantly Muslim.

British Colonial Rule, Independence (1956), and the First Civil War (1955–72)

With the help of proxy Egyptian troops the British colonized Sudan at the end of the nineteenth century (1899), and their impact and legacy have been profound for modern Sudan. Aside from largely drawing the borders for this extremely ethnically mixed colony/country, the British had a lasting influence on Sudanese politics. In the 1920s and 1930s the British sought to rule indirectly—a strategy we have noted elsewhere in India, Ghana, etc.—via local sheiks in the north and tribal chiefs in the south. They bought off local rulers and administered the colony through its own native elites, a typical pattern of colonial rule as we have seen. Over the long-term this created a fractured and weak ruling system in Sudan as the British encouraged and exacerbated the already deep divisions and differences between north and south—another example of their divide-and-conquer style of colonial rule—with extremely disastrous long-term post-colonial consequences. The British encouraged the work of Christian missionaries in the south while banning colonial subjects in the north from traveling to southern Sudan, further reinforcing the differences between these two regions.

When Sudan received its independence in 1956—among the first African states to do so—political power and wealth were concentrated in the predominantly Muslim, Arab-speaking central and northern parts of the country, although most of the country's natural resources (gold, copper, chromium, and subsequently oil, discovered in 1979) are located mainly in the south and west (Darfur). Military regimes favoring Islamic-oriented governments dominated Sudan's national politics following independence, though there

were a number of failed attempts at secular civilian quasi-democratic governments. Post-Independence Sudan has had an infamously unstable government with the second most (to Bolivia) coups or attempted coups of any country in the world since 1950.

From the outset Sudan faced major tensions between the government in the north and residents in the south, who began calling for a separate South Sudan even before the colony itself received independence. Tensions heightened following the newly independent country's first military coup in 1958. Afterward Sudan's military regime imposed a policy of "Arabization" and "Islamization" on the mostly non-Arabic, non-Muslim populations (Christians and followers of indigenous religions) in the south. They made Arabic the language of school instruction; Friday the weekly religious day off, in accordance with Muslim practice; they restricted the freedom of worship for Christians; and they expelled all foreign (Christian) missionaries in 1964. The central government's actions in the south intensified a low-scale civil war already underway since the mid-1950s (led predominantly by the Dinka ethnic group, now the largest group in South Sudan, but also the Madi ethnic group and others). They fought to break away from Sudan and become an independent state. Religion was thus central to this first conflict in post-Independence Sudan, which led to an estimated half million deaths, as it pitted the majority Islamic north against the predominantly Christian south.

Jaafar Nimeiry

Jaafar Nimeiry emerged as military ruler in Sudan, seizing power in yet another coup in 1969. Although a military dictator, he was widely popular even among some southerners who hoped he could resolve the country's civil war. Unlike his predecessors, who tended to be devout Muslims and much more religiously minded, Nimeiri was a secularist, and people hoped that with the religious factor out of the way he could achieve a peaceful settlement to the civil war. Owing in large part to Nimeiri's initiative the warring parties achieved a peaceful settlement to Sudan's prolonged civil war. The 1972 peace treaty ended the conflict by granting the south a great deal of autonomy while keeping it within the country. The agreement specified that the central government would control the exploitation of all natural resources in the south; this included oil, as yet undiscovered although oil exploration in the south was underway, which was one reason the government wanted to end the civil war there. But the newly formed autonomous Southern Regional Government had the right to all profits on the exports from the region, as well as taxes from private businesses located there. As you might expect, this became a key issue again when, in fact, a few years later they did discover oil.

In the mid-1970s after the civil war the government began receiving massive World Bank and IMF loans for development projects, especially irrigation projects involving the Nile and its tributaries. As elsewhere the international recession in 1979–80 led to much higher interest rates on those loans and

a substantial drop in the prices of the country's exports—a double blow to Sudan's already fragile economy, which was consequently a mess by the early 1980s. The IMF rushed in to “help” the Sudanese government deal with its debt crisis, but its loans as always came with major strings attached: the government had to keep domestic interest rates very high, which stifled domestic economic development, cut social spending, fire civil servants, which led to higher unemployment, etc., a common pattern we have seen in several other countries as well.

Sudan's Second Civil War (1983–2003)

When geologists discovered oil in southern Sudan in 1979 Nimeiri's government responded by subdividing regions in the south in blatant violation of the 1972 peace treaty that ended Sudan's First Civil War. He wanted to weaken the south's administrative hold over its own resources and thus ensure that money from oil exports would flow smoothly into the central government's coffers (and some of it perhaps into his own pockets). The re-division particularly antagonized the Dinka, the largest southern ethnic group, who responded by forming the Sudanese People's Liberation Army (SPLA). The central government's decisions to divide the south and also to locate its main oil refinery in the north led directly to the formation of the SPLA in 1983. This sparked Sudan's Second Civil War, which lasted twenty years. As in the first conflict, this war pitted the mostly Muslim-led central government against the mostly Christian south and its significant minority of adherents to indigenous religions.

Continued economic woes and civil war contributed to political instability. In 1985 another military coup brought down Nimeiri's government, forcing him into exile. Coup leaders attempted to transition to civilian rule but failed to either calm the fighting in the civil war or stabilize the country's economic mess. Thus, in 1989 yet another military coup brought a fundamentalist Islamicist regime to power under the leadership of General Omar al-Bashir, a member of the Sudanese branch of the Muslim Brotherhood, who intensified the civil war against the SPLA in the south and imposed Sharia (Islamic) law on the country. He also welcomed al-Qaeda founder and leader Osama bin Laden to come live in Sudan in the early 1990s after bin Laden had a falling out with the Saudi royal family over their decision to allow US troops onto Saudi soil during the First Gulf War. Bin Laden lived in Sudan from 1991–96 when he returned to Afghanistan.

In part because of bin Laden's presence in the 1990s and the extremist nature of al-Bashir's regime Sudan was an enemy of the US during the decade. The US bombed Sudan during President Clinton's administration in August 1998 in response to the coordinated al-Qaeda attacks on the US Embassies in Kenya and Tanzania earlier that month. The main target of the bombing in Sudan was the *Al-Shifa* (Arabic: “healing”) pharmaceutical plant in Khartoum, which the Clinton administration alleged was producing

chemicals to make nerve gas. Clinton's National Security Advisor Sandy Berger stated that he had "irrefutable" evidence that the plant was producing chemical weapons. However, a UN investigation later concluded that there was no evidence that the plant had been manufacturing or storing nerve gas. The bombing occurred during US Congressional impeachment hearings over Clinton's sex scandal involving Monica Lewinsky.

Peace talks finally began in 2002 with a ceasefire that more or less held until the signing of the final North/South Comprehensive Peace Agreement (CPA) in January 2005. The agreement granted the south a great deal of autonomy—just as the 1972 settlement had done—and called for a referendum on independence in the south in six years. That referendum, held as planned in 2011, resulted in the independence of South Sudan. The CPA specified that prior to the referendum half of the oil revenue from the south would remain there. Since 2011 the bulk of the oil wealth has gone to the new government of South Sudan, though border disputes along oil fields shared between the two countries remain. The Second Sudanese Civil War disrupted the country's agricultural and herding-based economy, leading to famine and resulting in more than 4mn people being displaced and more than 2mn deaths over a period of two decades. The end of this war, moreover, spilled over into Sudan's other tragedy: Darfur.

Conflict in Darfur

Almost as soon as the conflict in the south ended in early 2003 the conflict in the western region of Darfur began, sparked by the attacks of two new rebel groups, the Sudanese Liberation Army (SLA), comprised of a mix of Fur, Zaghawa, and Masalit ethnic groups, and the Justice and Equality Movement (JEM), led primarily by members of the Zaghawa ethnic group. Once again oil was a key factor in the conflict. Since the discovery of several major oil fields in the late 1970s and early 1980s, Sudanese oil went largely untapped because of the civil war—because of the fighting but also because of sabotage by the SPLA rebel forces in the south—and because the US led an international embargo against Sudanese oil. Beginning in the 1990s, however, China ignored the embargo and by the late-1990s became strongly involved in Sudanese oil, both in terms of production (China heavily invested in an oil pipeline that went online in Sudan in 1999) and, especially, consumption. China quickly became the largest recipient of a resurgent Sudanese oil export economy, importing about 5.5% of its overall oil consumption from Sudan in the 2000s. That changed with the independence of South Sudan in 2011, but the discovery of oil in Darfur in the early 2000s altered the situation there greatly.

The SLM and JEM felt both empowered by the peace agreement in the south but also frustrated that they were not included in the settlement. The two groups joined forces in early 2003 and attacked police stations and the main army airbase in Darfur, demanding autonomy and control over their

own oil resources, in part because outlying regions like Darfur suffered from a lack of investment. Thus, the discovery of oil in Darfur brought a push and a movement among the people of that region, primarily the Zaghawa and the Fur, to fight for autonomy and thereby ensure that *they*—not just groups in the central/northern part of the country—benefited from the region's oil wealth. In some ways the conflict in Darfur was a continuation of the just-ended North/South Civil War, but with one major difference: in Darfur all sides are Muslim. Conversely, like the peoples of the south, the main groups of Darfur are also non-Arabic speakers.

The two Darfur rebel groups attacked government forces initially with considerable success, catching the government unaware. Al-Bashir's regime responded as it had done in the latter stages of the war in the south by forming proxy armies or militias, comprised in this case primarily of people from the various nomadic and semi-nomadic herding tribal groups of the Darfur region, the Arabic-speaking Baggara, who carried out absolutely brutal attacks against supporters of the SLM and JEM. Organized in unofficial militia/bandit groups known as *Janjaweed* (which translates loosely as "Devils on Horseback"), they rampaged villages, killing men and raping women and burning everything in their path. They stole all the village's cows and sheep to add to their own herds.

In several cases the al-Bashir regime, which claimed to have nothing to do with the Janjaweed and said it was trying to reign them in, provided the Janjaweed militia with weapons as well as air support for their attacks on rebel positions and villages. The government, to be clear, did not pay the Janjaweed militias a salary; the understanding was that their payment would be whatever—including the land—they could steal from the villagers they attacked. Control of the land, moreover, is vitally important because of an extensive drought in Sudan since the mid-1980s, making access to land for cultivation and/or herding scarce and more important than ever. The situation in Darfur is one of the first "climate change" driven wars as unfortunately the environmental degradation of the planet is a crucial factor in this conflict.

After a flurry of attacks by the Janjaweed between 2003–05 they began to decline thankfully, though this may simply be because they destroyed an estimated 90% of the villages in the heart of Darfur in that two-year period. The Sudanese government allowed these militiamen/bandits to occupy the land of the villagers they attacked, contributing to a dramatic reformulation of the ethnic composition of the region because targeted groups, primarily the Fur and Zaghawa, fled to refugee camps in other parts of Darfur that are more or less peaceful or (more commonly) in neighboring Chad. Many of these camps are located in wide open, unprotected areas. The women in the camps in Darfur and Chad risked rape because of the need for firewood to cook, and with Janjaweed militia often lurking nearby the excursion to collect firewood could be very risky. The Janjaweed usually killed the men they caught, whereas women were most often raped but let go. As a result,

women collected the firewood, but at *great* peril. Estimates put the number of dead from Darfur (originally a population of between 6–8mn) at around 300,000 between 2003–08, with *at least* another 2.7mn people displaced—thus the need for all the camps.

In 2004 the US Congress passed a resolution calling the acts in Darfur a “genocide” and three years later President George Bush Jr. also described the situation there as a genocide. The US was a harsh critic of the Sudanese regime for its atrocities in Darfur, whereas for varying reasons Russia and China held up any attempt to denounce the al-Bashir regime, vetoing UN Resolutions to that effect. China as noted had major oil interests in Sudan and both they and Russia sold weapons to the Sudanese government. The UN increased its relief programs in Sudan and for Sudanese refugees in neighboring Chad. In 2009 the International Criminal Court issued arrest warrants for several Sudanese senior officials, including al-Bashir, for alleged crimes against humanity. The UN worked with the African Union to dispatch a joint peacekeeping force to Darfur in 2007, which succeeded in keeping the violence in the region at least somewhat in check. Attacks on villages in Darfur continued, but a tense relative peace prevailed for several years. In 2013 Khartoum folded the remnants of the Janjaweed militias into a new paramilitary body based in Darfur, the Rapid Support Forces (RSF), led by Muhammad Hamdan Dagalo, a member of the Arab-speaking Baggara group based in Darfur and himself a former leader of the Janjaweed.

The situation in Sudan shifted dramatically with the overthrow of al-Bashir in April 2019, bringing an end to his regime after thirty years. At the top, Dagalo and several army generals, primarily Abdel Fattah al-Burhan, felt emboldened to challenge the weakened al-Bashir. Meanwhile, at the bottom, growing economic woes led to popular protests in Khartoum and elsewhere and the Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF), called upon to quell the demonstrations, largely sided with the protesters, partly because of orders from al-Burhan and Dagalo. Developments culminated with the removal, arrest, and imprisonment of al-Bashir. A joint military-civilian body, the Sovereign Council, with al-Burhan as acting president and Dagalo as vice-president, took over, declaring a transition period leading up to elections and civilian rule. Al-Bashir’s ouster created hopes for a lasting peace in Darfur. The joint UN-African Union peacekeeping mission in place in the region since 2007 was scheduled to end by December 31, 2020, prompting peace talks that culminated in an agreement earlier that year. The Sovereign Council transitional government of Sudan assumed responsibility for the protection of civilians in Darfur while agreeing to a joint force comprised of government troops, RSF forces, and members of the SLM and JEM to oversee a transition to peace in Darfur.

However, hopes for a peaceful resolution to Sudan’s and Darfur’s many problems ended abruptly with yet another military coup. In October 2021 al-Burhan dissolved the Sovereign Council and terminated his power-sharing arrangement with Dagalo. This sparked a power struggle between the two

leaders and their respective power bases, al-Burhan's SAF, predominantly comprised of the long-standing Arab elites of northern and central Sudan, and Dagalo's RSF, made up of many former Janjaweed—Arabic speakers from the Darfur region—but also of others throughout the country brought into the fold by Dagalo in recent years. Al-Burhan sought the integration of the RSF with the SAF, an initiative strongly resisted by Dagalo. Clashes between the competing forces erupted in April 2023 when the SAF, reportedly supported by elements of the Muslim Brotherhood, attacked the RSF in Soba, a military base in southern Khartoum. Fighting ensued across the country, but mostly in Khartoum and Darfur, leading to warfare once again.

The Armed Conflict and Location and Event Data Project estimates that between April 15, 2023, and October 25, 2024, there were no less than 8,942 attacks (averaging sixteen a day) between the SAF and RSF or carried out by one or the other group against civilians. More than half of the attacks were in or around Khartoum, with parts of the city now divided between the two groups as well as other, smaller armed militias and paramilitary groups. In total 1,448 or about 16% of these attacks occurred in the Darfur region, which is largely under the control of the RSF, though parts of it are likewise controlled by smaller armed militia groups. At least 24,000 people were killed in Sudan as a whole during this period, though the total number is probably higher. Over 14mn people, or roughly 30% of the country's population, have fled their homes either for other, neighboring countries (almost 3mn) or as Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs, roughly 11mn). In mid-April 2025 RSF leader Dagalo declared a separate country in the areas under his control, calling it the "Government of Peace and Unity." In short, a Third Sudanese Civil War is underway and the immediate future of Sudan, including its Darfur region, seems bleak.



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Map 12.1 Map of East Africa.

12 East Africa

Kenya and Somalia

Kenya

Kenya, with its capital at Nairobi, is located on the eastern coast of Africa. It has a long coast on the Indian Ocean in the southwest and two of the largest natural lakes in Africa, Lake Victoria and Lake Turkana, grace its borders. Home to rich savannas and much wildlife, Kenya, with a population of about 55.3mn as of 2023, has a relatively low population density. The coastal plain that stretches north-south in the country's eastern half is arid, with little rainfall and poor soil for growing crops. The northwest corner is also inhospitable, and Lake Turkana in the north is in the middle of a semi-desert between two mountain chains, the Ethiopian Plateau in the north and the Kenyan Plateau in the south. Only about 3% of the country's land is arable; most of it located in a mountainous plateau in the southwest corner. Much of Kenya's population has historically settled there because the region gets enough rainfall and has good enough soil for cultivation.

There are about forty different ethnic groups and three main language groups (and many different dialects) in Kenya. The dominant ethnic groups are agriculturalists and pastoralists, like the Kikuyu (around 17%), the largest single group who predominate in the central part of the country and have largely maintained political power since independence; the Luhya (about 14%), who reside mostly in the western part of the country (and also across the border in neighboring Uganda); the Kalenjin (roughly 13%), who likewise reside in the west along the Ugandan border (further south than the Luhya) and in Uganda; and the Luo (nearly 10%), who reside mostly in southwestern Kenya and in Tanzania. There are numerous other smaller native African groups, such as the Maasai (2.5%), a semi-nomadic hunting and herding group, as well as small minorities of Europeans, Asians (mostly from the Indian subcontinent), and Arabs in the country.

Many Kenyans converted to Christianity during the colonial period, while some retained traditional belief systems (or a mix thereof). In Kenya today, about 85% of the population is Christian, with both Catholics and Protestants, and about 11% is Muslim, mostly in the eastern coastal region. Small minorities practice Africanized versions of Christianity or indigenous

African religions. Historically the Kikuyu and some of the other groups had a highly decentralized social organization with no formal sense of state organization or of land ownership; people worked the land communally with harvests divided among the population. Traditional religious practices emphasized a strong sense of community and extended family.

British Colonial Rule

Traditional life changed markedly with the impact of European expansion. In the nineteenth century, the British gradually moved in as the most influential European power on Africa's east coast in the area that is Kenya today. Britain controlled large parts of modern-day Kenya from the end of the nineteenth century as part of the British East Africa Protectorate, setting Kenya's borders following World War I in 1920 when they claimed it as a colony. British farmers settled Kenyan territory in significant numbers, primarily after 1903 with the completion of a railroad linking the port city Mombasa with the country's interior all the way to Uganda. The British government encouraged European settlement in the fertile highlands. The problem, however, was that the Kikuyu and other groups already inhabited this southwestern mountain plateau, as a result of which British settlement displaced many natives.

The British also introduced cash crops, encouraging British settlers and natives alike to plant tea, coffee, sugarcane, and cotton. The lack of legally defined land ownership in traditional native societies and the force of arms allowed British settlers to lay claim to Kikuyu land. In a relatively short period, many native farmers were transformed into wage laborers on the British settlers' land, forced to move into the small areas with poor land not settled by the British, or forced to migrate to the cities (mostly Nairobi), where they faced poverty and high rates of unemployment.

As elsewhere World War II acted as an important stimulant to African nationalism and de-colonization. After the war, Kenyans began to increasingly demand their independence. In the early 1950s the Kikuyu took up arms to fight the British settlers in the Mau Mau Rebellion. Rebels hiding in the mountains attacked and killed British settlers and other Kikuyu who collaborated with the British. The British arrested Jomo Kenyatta in 1953 for supposedly starting the rebellion, although he denounced violence and denied the charge. He remained in jail for eight years. Imprisonment by the British granted Kenyatta wide popularity among the Kenyan people.

The British crushed the Mau Mau Rebellion by 1956 owing to a brutal campaign in which they imprisoned over 90,000 Kikuyu in conditions comparable to the concentration camps of World War II. Around 10,000 Kikuyu died during the Mau Mau Rebellion, a high casualty count partly due to the fact that the rebels also targeted other Kikuyu whom they felt collaborated with the British. The rebels killed around 100 British settlers in the uprising. The Mau Mau Rebellion, though unsuccessful, accelerated independence for

Kenya, proving to the British that prolonged armed rule of the country was untenable.

Post-Independence Kenya

During the Mau Mau Rebellion Britain committed about 50,000 troops and police to Kenya, and while the settler population in the country wanted them to stay, London could not afford to pay for such a large-scale operation over a long period of time. Also, given developments on the rest of the continent (and the world), it was clear that independence would be granted eventually in any case. Consequently, the British decided it was time to find someone they could trust to rule the country on their terms. They chose Jomo Kenyatta, the man imprisoned and under house arrest for eight years (1953–61) for his alleged role in the Mau Mau Rebellion. When they were looking for a suitable successor to rule Kenya after their withdrawal, the British remembered that Kenyatta had denounced violence and terrorism when he was arrested for supposedly starting a terrorist movement. This was exactly what the British needed because they did not want to leave European settlers without some degree of safety. When Kenya gained its independence in 1963, Kenyatta became president.

At the outset, Kenya had a two-party system, the Kenya Africa National Union (KANU), led by Kenyatta and dominated by Kikuyu, and the opposition Kenya African Democratic Union (KADU), dominated by several minority groups, mostly the Luo. In this early period, one of the main disagreements between the two parties was over the power granted to the central government, a common issue in African politics. KANU, representing the country's majority ethnic group, wanted a strong central government, whereas KADU wanted a loose federation of autonomous regions that reflected the interests of the country's minority groups. Control of the central government in the post-independence African states often gives some ethnic groups control over the allocation of resources at the expense of others (as we saw for example in Sudan).

Kenyatta and KANU established political control in the country and gradually moved toward one-party dictatorship, strengthening the central government, disbanding opposition parties, and ruling as a dictatorial one-party state. When Kenyatta died in 1978 his Vice-President Daniel arap Moi, a member of the Kalenjin ethnic minority and founding member of KADU who shifted to KANU at Kenyatta's invitation, replaced him. Like Kenyatta before him, arap Moi ruled in a corrupt and dictatorial manner. After an unsuccessful coup attempt against his government in 1982 he tightened his control with further restrictions on the opposition and the media. During this period Kenya was allied in the Cold War with the US/West, which overlooked the corrupt, dictatorial nature of the government (as in other countries) as long as it was anti-communist.

The KANU governments of Kenyatta and arap Moi bought up land owned by British settlers, many of whom left for Europe after Kenyan independence, and resettled Africans on the land. However, land remained in the hands of a small elite with connections to the British (a situation often described as “neo-colonialism”) and now with the KANU government, which continued to encourage the cultivation of cash crops, especially coffee and sugarcane, for export on the international market. Thus, in the post-independence period, wealth in Kenya, one of the most prosperous African countries, remained very unevenly divided, with underlying social tensions increasing over time because of high unemployment amid rural-urban migration.

After the Cold War ended Kenya’s western allies promoted reforms in the country, including imposing term limits on the presidency. In 1992 Kenya held its first truly multi-party elections since the 1960s. In 1997 arap Moi “won” a disputed election, setting off anti-government riots. After over twenty years in office, arap Moi stepped down owing to term limits in December 2002. Mwai Kibaki, a Kikuyu and founding member of the Democratic Party of Kenya (DPK), became president as the DPK soundly defeated the KANU candidate Uhuru Kenyatta, arap Moi’s handpicked successor and son of the country’s first president, Jomo Kenyatta.

Kibaki won on an anti-corruption campaign and despite suffering serious injuries in a car wreck just a few weeks prior to the elections. He was subsequently re-elected in December 2007 amid charges of voter fraud from opposition candidate Raila Odinga, a member of the Luo ethnic minority, unleashing two months of ethnic violence, mostly involving the Kikuyu and Luo, in which as many as 1,500 people were killed. UN-sponsored talks in late February led to a power-sharing agreement that brought Odinga into the government as prime minister, after which tensions cooled. Uhuru Kenyatta won the country’s 2012 elections over Odinga and subsequently won re-election in 2017. Unable to run again in 2022 because of term limits, Kenyatta stepped aside as William Ruto, a member of the Kalenjin ethnic minority, won the elections, once again defeating Odinga.

Over the decades Kenya has been a target of global terrorists, in recent years largely a spillover from conflict in neighboring Somalia. In 1998 al-Qaeda planted a bomb in the US Embassy in Nairobi, killing 224 people, mostly Kenyans (this was coordinated with an attack on the US Embassy at Dar es Salaam, Tanzania). Four years later al-Qaeda supporters attacked an Israeli owned resort in the coastal city Mombasa, killing ten Kenyans and injuring three Israelis. They also tried but failed to shoot down an Israeli airliner as part of a coordinated attack. In the summer of 2011 terrorists affiliated with the Somali-based al-Shabaab movement raided Kenyan coastal resorts and a refugee camp, targeting foreigners. Kenya responded by dispatching troops across the Somali border to attack the rebels, who were also reportedly involved in several kidnappings of Kenyan citizens. Demanding that Kenya withdraw troops from Somalia, al-Shabaab terrorists responded with reprisal attacks, including a 2013 raid on a large shopping mall in Nairobi that killed

more than sixty people. The following year forty-eight Kenyans died in an al-Shabaab attack on hotels and a police station on a resort island off the coast of Kenya, and in 2015 al-Shabaab militants massacred 148 people, mostly Christian students, at Garissa University in northwest Kenya. The terrorist threat remains strong in the country.

Somalia

Somalia, with its capital at Mogadishu and a population of about 19.4mn as of 2025, is steeped in thousands of years of history (the ancient Egyptians spoke of the area as “God’s Land”) and is strategically located in East Africa in the “horn of Africa” adjacent to the Arabian Peninsula. A considerable part of the country’s interior is desert and semi-desert grasslands. Although currently divided into numerous warring clans vying for power, Somalia does not have the same degree of ethnic diversity as other African states. About 85% of the country’s population is Somali and speaks the official language, Somali, as their native tongue. There is a small Arab minority in the country as well as non-Somali African tribal groups, such as the Oromo. Nomadic and semi-nomadic people dependent upon livestock for their livelihood make up a large portion of the population. The vast majority of Somalia’s population is Sunni Muslim (about 98% with a 1% Shia minority); there is a small Christian minority as well.

Somalia’s modern history is an intricate and complex mix of traditional clan politics, colonialism, and Cold War intrigues. Genealogy and clan politics constitute the heart of the Somali social system, the basis for the Somali inclination toward internecine conflict, as well as of the Somalis’ sense of being a distinct national group, two seemingly contradictory impulses. There are six major branches of the Somali lineage system, four mostly pastoral nomadic clan-families (the Dir, Darood, Isaaq, and Hawiye, each of which is further subdivided into smaller sub-clan groupings), and two settled agricultural ones (the Digil and Rahanweyn). The Dir, Darood, Isaaq, and Hawiye together constitute roughly 75% of the population. The Digil and Rahanweyn constitute about 20% of the population and mostly inhabit the riverbeds of southern Somalia. These are *not* distinct ethnic groups but rather rival tribal clans *within* the country’s dominant Somali ethnic group. The post-independence politics of Somalia have been dominated by the Darood clan and its sub-clans in alliance with the Hawiye and Isaaq clans and their sub-clans.

European Colonial Rule

In part because of its strategic location, during the colonial period (1884–1960) Somalia was divided among three European powers: British Somaliland (north central); French Somaliland (east and southeast); and Italian Somaliland (south). Of these the British and Italian areas were the

largest and most important because of their location along the coasts. In the early twentieth century northern Somali clans resisted British rule. A Sufi holy man, Mahammad Abdille Hasan, dubbed the “mad mullah” by the British, led a persistent resistance movement against British rule between 1899–1920. The fighting devastated northern Somalia, resulting in the death of an estimated one-third of the area’s population and the near destruction of its economy. The British finally managed to end the uprising in 1920 with the death of Hasan, a hero of Somali nationalism. While this conflict spilled over somewhat into the southern Italian-held territories, it was mostly contained to the north because the supporting clans hailed from there. Thus, this early resistance movement against European rule among the Somalis reflected the significance of clan divisions in the divided territories of Somaliland.

After Italian Premier Benito Mussolini’s armies marched into Ethiopia and toppled Emperor Haile Selassie in 1935 the Italians seized British Somaliland, uniting for the first time in forty years all the Somali clans that had been arbitrarily separated by the Anglo-Italo-Ethiopian boundaries. The unification of the Somali Peninsula enabled the Italians to set prices, impose taxes, and issue a common currency for the entire area. However, Italian control of the region proved to be short-lived. In March 1941 the British counterattacked and reoccupied northern Somalia, from which they launched their campaign to retake the whole region from Italy and restore Emperor Haile Selassie to his throne in neighboring Ethiopia. The British then placed southern Somalia and the Ogaden (the region on the border between Somalia and Ethiopia) under a military administration.

In the aftermath of World War II Somalia found itself caught between the conflicting interests of the victorious allies. Allied leaders at the Potsdam Conference in the summer of 1945 decided not to return southern Somalia to Italian rule, but rather to form a Council of Ministers representing Britain, France, the USSR, and the US to decide the region’s fate. No agreement could be reached, however, and the question of Somalia’s status was passed to the UN to decide. In November 1949 the UN voted to make southern Somalia a trust territory to be placed under Italian control for ten years, following which it would become independent. Northern Somalia would remain under British control indefinitely. The UN felt that Italy, because of its experience and economic interests in the region, was best suited to administer southern Somalia. However, this decision clearly went against the increasing demands of educated Somalis, many of whom were organized as of 1943 into the Somali Youth League (SYL), which wanted all areas populated by Somali-speaking people united in an independent state.

Momentum for a transition to independence increased as the end of the ten-year period of UN-Italian rule in the south neared. The British government acquiesced to the growing force of Somali nationalist public opinion and agreed to terminate its rule of northern Somaliland in 1960 in time

for the protectorate to merge with the trust territory on the independence date already fixed by the UN commission. Accordingly, British Somaliland received its independence in late June and united with the trust territory to establish the Somali Republic on July 1, 1960. (The French-controlled territory became the independent state of Djibouti in 1977).

Independent Somalia

Although unified as a single nation at independence, the south and the north were, from an institutional perspective, two separate countries. Italy and Britain left two separate administrative, legal, and education systems in which affairs were conducted according to different procedures and in different languages. Police, taxes, and the exchange rates of their respective currencies also differed and economic contacts between the two regions were virtually nonexistent. Many southerners believed that, because of experience gained under the UN-Italian trusteeship, their region was better prepared for self-government. Northern political, administrative, and commercial elites, meanwhile, were reluctant to bow to Mogadishu, the capital of the newly declared state located on the coast deep in the formerly UN-Italian-ruled south. Northern misgivings about being too tightly harnessed to the south were demonstrated by the voting pattern in the June 1961 referendum on the constitution, Somalia's first national election. Although the draft was overwhelmingly approved in the south, it was supported by less than 50% of the northern electorate. Thus, from the outset the newly independent country had some major regional divisions to overcome in large part owing to the legacy of colonialism.

Another issue facing Somalia was the existence of large ethnic Somali populations outside its borders, in neighboring Kenya, Ethiopia, and Djibouti. This is a common consequence of colonialism with the imposition of artificial borders in Africa and throughout much of the formerly colonized world that divide ethnic groups. In the early 1960s Somali bands carried out raids across the Kenyan border and in 1964 a small-scale war erupted between Ethiopia and Somalia over its disputed border regions. Hostilities ended through the mediation of Sudan, acting under the auspices of the Organization of African Unity (OAU), with the disputed Somali-inhabited territory remaining under Ethiopian control. Ethiopia and Kenya concluded a mutual defense pact in 1964 in response to what both countries perceived as a continuing threat from Somalia. Most OAU members feared that if Somalia was successful in detaching the Somali-populated portions of Kenya and Ethiopia the example might inspire their own restive minorities divided by borders imposed during the colonial period. "Pan-Somalism" remains an important domestic political issue within Somalia, although several decades of clan warfare there seems to have diminished the importance of territorial disputes with neighboring states.

Muhammad Siad Barre

In October 1969 a military coup overthrew Somalia's short-lived multi-party democracy. Following the assassination of President Rashid Shermarke the military seized power under the leadership of Major General Muhammad Siad Barre, a member of the Darood clan. The new governing body, the Supreme Revolutionary Council (SRC), arrested and detained leading members of the democratic government, including Prime Minister Muhammad Ibrahim Egal. The SRC banned political parties, abolished the National Assembly, and suspended the constitution. The new regime's goals included an end to "tribalism, nepotism, corruption, and misrule" and the unification of all Somali people under a single state. It renamed the country the Somali Democratic Republic.

The SRC retroactively defined the military coup as a Marxist revolution and reorganized the country's political and legal institutions based on a guiding ideology stemming from a mix of Quranic and Marxist thought (Barre published his own equivalent of Mao's Little Red Book—the "Blue-and-white book"). The SRC sought the solidarity of the country's six main clans, condemning "tribalism" as a form of class rule and as the most serious impediment to national unity. The regime replaced local clan leaders, whom the previous government had paid a stipend, with SRC-appointed dignitaries known as "peacekeepers." Barre often contrasted the benefits of "socialism" to the evils he associated with "tribalism." The SRC also began a policy of forcibly settling the country's nomadic peoples into fishing and farming communities as a way of breaking clan identities. However, despite government efforts to eliminate it, clan identity and consciousness persisted. In addition, the SRC's attempts to improve the status of Somali women proved unpopular in this traditional, conservative Muslim society despite Barre's insistence that such reforms were consistent with Islamic principles.

In the mid-1970s Somalia received military aid from the Soviet side in the Cold War, building up one of sub-Saharan Africa's largest military forces while allowing the Soviets to establish a naval base in the port city Berbera. In 1977 Somali troops invaded the disputed border region with Ethiopia, sparking the Ogaden War (1977–78). The USSR switched sides and began supporting Ethiopia during the conflict because leftist military officers had overthrown the government of Emperor Heile Selassie in 1974. In response, Barre expelled Soviet advisors and ousted them from the naval base in Berbera. Soviet aid to Ethiopia turned the tide in their favor, and Somalia's subsequent loss in the war led to increasing political pressure and repression at home. Barre clamped down on any form of perceived political dissidence and collectively punished entire clans whose members allegedly engaged in organized political resistance. The Ogaden War also led to Somalia's shift to a pro-Western stance in the Cold War, with the US replacing the USSR as Barre's main supplier of weapons and economic aid, as well as becoming the main user of the naval base at Berbera.

Thus, by 1980 Somalia and Ethiopia had completed one of the most bizarre turnarounds in Cold War politics, with the latter, a staunch US ally from the end of World War II to 1974, now firmly in the Soviet camp, and the former, still under the leadership of the avowedly “Marxist” Siad Barre, now firmly in the US camp. In 1986 the US and Somalia held joint military exercises in the Indian Ocean, while that same year Amnesty International criticized Barre’s regime as among the world’s most repressive, prompting the US Congress in 1987 to make deep cuts in military aid to Somalia.

Economically the IMF and World Bank pressured the Somali regime between 1983–87 to liberalize its economy and create a free-market system. To meet IMF standards for “structural adjustment” loans, the Barre government terminated its policy of guaranteeing employment to everyone with a secondary school education. As elsewhere, the international lending agencies active in Somalia in the 1980s encouraged the elimination of civil service jobs, privatized the banking sector and other state-dominated areas of the economy, and promoted the devaluation of the country’s currency, the Somali shilling. The immediate results of these reforms were disastrous: unemployment soared, leading to a growing sector of disgruntled, educated former civil service employees; manufacturing declined 0.5% per year between 1980–87; exports decreased by 16.3% per annum from 1979–86; and a negligible 0.8% rise in Gross Domestic Product (GDP) per annum from 1979–86 failed to keep up with population growth. The World Bank’s own estimates show that between 1980–89 real Gross National Product (GNP)—the measure of all wealth produced in a country—per person declined in Somalia at a rate of 1.7% per year. These economic problems further compounded the political tensions that eventually erupted in civil war by the late 1980s.

Clan Warfare and Chaos

Faced with declining popularity and a growing, clan-based armed resistance, by 1986 Siad Barre resorted to that which he so vehemently preached against earlier in his reign—clan warfare. He unleashed a reign of terror against the Majeerteen, the Hawiye, and the Isaaq clans, relying on a paramilitary group dubbed the Red Berets, a dreaded elite unit recruited from among the president’s own Marehan sub-clan (his father was from the Marehan sub-clan of the larger Darood clan grouping). The Red Berets carried out one of the worst atrocities of Somalia’s civil war in the late 1980s against the Isaaq clan, which in 1988 had initiated an armed movement under the auspices of the Somali National Movement (SNM) in the north to unseat Barre. The SNM captured two northern cities, but government forces loyal to Barre responded by bombarding the cities heavily in June 1988, forcing the SNM to withdraw and causing more than 300,000 Isaaq to flee to Ethiopia. After re-imposing its control in the north, Barre’s military regime conducted savage reprisals against the Isaaq. In a particularly nefarious form of warfare, they destroyed or poisoned water wells, burned the grazing grounds of Isaaq pastoralists,

and systematically raped Isaaq women, killing an estimated 5,000 members of the clan by the end of 1988, allegedly bayoneting about 1,000 of them, including women and children, to death.

Barre calculated that dealing harshly with resistance would “nip it in the bud,” but he was wrong as resistance to his rule continued and even escalated. In 1989 his hold on power increasingly tenuous, Barre ordered the Red Berets to massacre civilians. Torture and murder became commonplace in Mogadishu. On July 9, 1989, an unknown assassin gunned down Somalia’s Italian-born Roman Catholic bishop, Salvatore Colombo, an outspoken critic of the regime, in his church in Mogadishu. On the heels of the bishop’s murder came the infamous July 14 massacre in which the Red Berets killed 450 Somalis and injured many more for demonstrating against the arrest of fourteen leading outspoken Muslim clerics who criticized the Barre regime. The following day the regime executed forty-seven people, mainly from the Isaaq clan, on a beach near Mogadishu. The July massacres prompted a shift in US policy as the administration of President George Bush Sr. decided to distance itself from Barre. Much of his political career had rested on one of the two major Cold War superpowers, and as the Cold War receded in importance by the late 1980s, Barre was suddenly no longer important to either side.

With the end of US support and domestic pressures mounting against him Barre’s days were numbered. In late January 1991 the Hawiye clan-based United Somali Congress (USC) led by General Muhammad Farah Hassan Aideed entered Mogadishu, forcing Barre and his remaining troops to flee the capital. A period of looting and chaos ensued that displaced hundreds of thousands of Somalis, many of whom relocated to areas controlled by their clans (including Barre himself, who fled to the relative safety of his Marehan clan’s territory in southern Somalia). In place of the centralized government, armed clan militias emerged to fight one another for political power: Aideed’s Hawiye-led USC, which controlled Mogadishu; the Isaaq-affiliated SNM, which declared an independent Somaliland Republic in the north in accordance with the borders of the former British colony there; the Majeerteen-based Somali Salvation Democratic Front (SSDF); the Rahanweyn-based Somali Democratic Movement (SDM); and other groups as well. By 1992 the centralized state constructed on the Somali Peninsula had disintegrated into its constituent lineages and clans, whose internecine wars drenched the country in bloodshed. A drought in the country in 1991–92 compounded problems, leading to a potential humanitarian disaster.

Following the deaths of more than 50,000 people in the conflict and more than 300,000 owing to starvation, in 1992 the UN intervened. A UN peace-keeping force, led by US Marines dispatched by President Bush Sr., supervised the distribution of food and other humanitarian aid. Critics of US foreign policy note that its intentions were less humanitarian than meets the eye as Somalia had long sat atop considerable (and as yet untapped) oil reserves first discovered in the late 1940s. Several oil companies, including Conoco,

Amoco, Chevron, and Phillips, had signed agreements with Barre to begin exploiting Somalia's rich oil resources but the onset of the war made that impossible.

In March 1993 UN officials negotiated a ceasefire between rival warlords in southern Somalia, after which UN peacekeepers took control of the region, though the militias remained armed. In June Aideed, leader of the Hawiye clan-based USC that had ousted Barre, broke the ceasefire and attacked UN peacekeepers. Clashes between Aideed's militia and the UN peacekeepers intensified, making it impossible for the UN mission to operate in Somalia. Thus, the US and UN made the removal of Aideed a primary goal of the mission, which had not been the case at the outset of the intervention. Aideed, however, was backed by a well-armed militia and resisted US and UN calls to turn himself in.

These events set up one of the most gruesome engagements in US military history: the street battle in Mogadishu in October 1993, in which eighteen US Marines and countless Somali civilians were killed. Days later, after major US media outlets aired footage of celebrating Somalis dragging the corpse of an American soldier through the city's streets, US President Bill Clinton, who had taken over from Bush Sr. that year and inherited the conflict, decided to abruptly end the mission and withdraw US troops from Somalia. The lesson various groups around the world took from these events, from al-Qaeda head Osama bin Laden to leaders of the Hutu nationalist Interahamwe militias in Rwanda and others, was that if you make members of the Western powers bleed they will flee. While the US left in disgrace, Aideed remained in charge of his clan's militia until his death in 1996, when he was replaced by his son Hussein Aideed.

Fighting in Somalia continued in the early mid-1990s, and in March 1995 the UN aborted its humanitarian mission in the country, withdrawing all UN personnel from the country for their own safety. Somalia descended into chaos and civil war (perhaps best described as internecine clan warfare), which remained the norm there for years to come. In December 1997 Somali clan leaders met in Cairo and agreed on a plan to select a new unified national government. The summit was delayed for two years, however, as clan leaders failed to secure a ceasefire between the various militia leaders or warlords. The trend toward disintegration continued in 1998 when groups in the country's northeastern corner declared the autonomous Puntland State of Somalia, with leaders therein ruling the region as a state within a (failed) state. Two years later leaders of rival clan groups in northern Somalia (roughly analogous to the area controlled by the British during the colonial period) declared the region the independent state of Somaliland, though no country in the world to date has recognized its status as an independent country.

In May 2000 leaders held a national reconciliation summit in Djibouti. Over the course of four months, Somali clan leaders, warlords, and politicians discussed their country's future. In August Somali delegates

elected a transitional assembly representative of the various clans and chose Abdulkassim Salad Hassan interim president of a Transitional National Assembly (TNA). This summit did not bring all Somali factions to the table as both Puntland and Somaliland boycotted it. The TNA initially established control over southern Somalia; however, factional fighting erupted once again and by May 2001 the TNA lost control over most of the country.

The legacy of clan-based conflict, colonialism, and the Cold War have left Somalia a very divided and torn nation—a failed state—despite the fact that it began over sixty years ago as an independent country with a potentially promising future. The chaos reached such a level with the lack of an effective centralized government to reign in criminal groups and militia forces that Somalia became associated with piracy off its coast during the late 2000s and early to mid-2010s. The suffering of the population amid all the fighting is horrific; life expectancy in Somalia as of 2020 is a mere fifty-six and a half years, among the lowest in the world. Compounding matters as well is that neighboring countries, notably Ethiopia and, as we have seen, Kenya, have intervened militarily in Somalia periodically amid the breakdown of its centralized government and chaos of the last few decades. Finally, making matters *even* worse, the al-Qaeda affiliated (as of 2010) Islamist terrorist group al-Shabaab emerged in Somalia in the 2000s and over the years since has ruled rural areas of the country, terrorizing local populations therein while carrying out attacks in Kenya, Djibouti, and elsewhere. In 2017 al-Shabaab carried out a double truck bombing in Mogadishu that killed about 350 people, and it has remained active as a terrorist threat both within and outside the country into the 2020s. Somalia, in short, is a failed state with a troubled outlook for the foreseeable future.



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Map 13.1 Rwanda and the Democratic Republic of Congo.

13 The Rwandan Genocide and the Democratic Republic of Congo

Rwanda

We examined the genocides in Indonesia in the mid-1960s, Cambodia in the late 1970s, and Darfur in the 2000s, and this unit on Rwanda allows us to revisit that unfortunate theme. Rwanda, with its capital of Kigali, is a small country in the heart of sub-Saharan Africa. With a population of about 14.5mn as of 2025, Rwanda, a landlocked country, is one of the most densely populated countries in the world. There are two main ethnic groups in Rwanda, the Hutu (about 85%) and the Tutsi (around 14%) although there is debate among ethnographers and historians as to whether they should be categorized as distinct ethnic groups. Hutu and Tutsi identities existed prior to the colonization of Rwanda by Germany in the late nineteenth century, but they could best be described as social categories in that time period rather than as different ethnic groups.

The biggest difference between them historically was their economic role: Hutus were cultivators and Tutsis were herdsman. However, this was not a perfect split because some Hutus owned cattle (most people did) and some Tutsis farmed the land. Nevertheless, this was the single most important difference between them because they looked the same, spoke the same language (*Kinyarwanda*), and following colonization most shared the same religion: Christianity (about 57% Catholic and 37% Protestant). Because cattle are considered more valuable than produce the Tutsis were seen as an elite. But at the same time, the differences between them—even economically speaking—were minimal; there were poor Tutsis and wealthy Hutus, and there was also considerable intermarriage and intermingling between the two groups.

European Colonialism and Eugenics

The differences between Hutu and Tutsi may not have amounted to much except for the arrival of Europeans who had very clear ideas of race related to a type of “race science.” One of the main legacies of colonialism in this part of Africa was ethnic tension and conflict. By dividing social groups in

the process of colonization and creating artificial state boundaries, European leaders contributed to long-term instability on the African continent. To be clear, there was ethnic tension and conflict (tribal wars) on the continent long before the arrival of Europeans to sub-Saharan Africa in the seventeenth century and after; different tribal groupings fought for control over land for crops and grazing land as well as for access to water and hunting grounds. But European influences greatly altered the understanding of ethnicity and race on the continent, thereby opening the way for modern genocide.

The Europeans, in short, introduced a sense of racial hierarchy and with it the notion of a “scientific” way of looking at race (Eugenics). This came with an inherent sense of racial superiority, with the Europeans themselves at the top of that racial hierarchy. Nowhere is that outlook more prominent than in Rwanda, where white Europeans introduced the idea of race as a social construct. The Europeans also brought large-scale coffee production as a cash crop to the Rwandan highlands, the consequences of which are discussed later. Germany colonized parts of modern-day Tanzania, Rwanda, and Burundi in the late nineteenth century. During World War I, however, Belgium replaced Germany as the colonial rulers of these areas in 1916, and it was under Belgian rule that the supposed differences between Hutu and Tutsi were highlighted and solidified.

The Belgians decided to allow the “purer,” more “noble” Tutsi to rule as an elite on their behalf, but to do so they first had to determine who was who—one could not tell simply by looking at them. So, in 1933–34 the Belgians conducted a census in Rwanda to issue identity cards, labeling every citizen as either Hutu or Tutsi. Utilizing the race “science” (pseudo-science) eugenics, Belgian colonists measured Rwandan’s foreheads, noses, and other features, literally constructing ethnic identities for the Tutsis, whom the Belgians saw as lighter skinned, taller, etc., and the Hutus, whom they saw as short, with broader noses, darker skin, etc. On the “nasal index” of data compiled by these Belgian “scientists,” for instance, the median Tutsi nose was about two-and-a-half-millimeters longer and nearly five millimeters narrower than the median Hutu nose.

The Tutsi minority willingly accepted the elite status granted them by the Belgians; they discriminated against the Hutus in politics, in areas of education, and in most other realms of social life. Thus, under the tutelage of first the Germans and then (especially) the Belgians, the social categories of “Tutsi” and “Hutu” became distinct ethnic groups, and over a relatively short time “ethnic” identity, which had not been a major factor traditionally in Africa, became *the* defining feature of Rwandan existence. At the same time, however, a great deal of interaction and intermarriage between the two groups remained, and the differences between Hutu and Tutsi seldom turned violent in the colonial period.

Violence erupted in the late 1950s, and by that time the political atmosphere of Belgian rule was quite different from the early post-World War I years. De-colonization was in the air in Africa in the 1950s, and it spread

to Rwanda. Only by then, owing to the outcome of World War II (a victory over Hitler's racist ideology), the main agenda was no longer racial rule, but democracy, the rule of the majority. Belgium in the late 1950s encouraged the rule of the Hutu majority in Rwanda over the Tutsi minority. Hutus, feeling empowered, attacked Tutsis in several locations in 1959 (a brief and much less bloody prelude to the 1994 genocide). When Rwanda received its independence in 1962, a Hutu dictator took over as leader, and Hutu nationalism became a strong force in the country. Hutu nationalists and extremists referred to their Tutsi neighbors as "cockroaches" and condemned them for allegedly ruling over the Hutu majority on behalf of Belgium with a heavy hand during colonialism. In 1963 there was another wave of violence against the Tutsi minority, ending in several thousand deaths, and yet another wave of anti-Tutsi attacks a decade later. One consequence of these periodic outbursts of violence is that many thousands of Tutsis fled to neighboring countries, especially Uganda.

Hatred Unleashed: Genocide in Rwanda

The spark that eventually culminated in genocide occurred in 1990 when a rebel army of mostly Tutsi refugees from Uganda calling itself the Rwandese Patriotic Front (RPF), which had formed two years earlier in 1988, invaded Rwanda, seeking an end to the country's Hutu-dominated dictatorship. From that point on, the rebellion, which was relatively small and isolated in nature, became the justification for any move by the government and Hutu nationalists. The regime considered all Tutsis to be RPF accomplices and supporters, though that was far from the case, and targeted many of them for repression. Nationalists labeled moderate Hutus who did not go along with such policies "Tutsi-loving accomplices" and also targeted them. Hutu nationalists began recruiting militiamen (*Interahamwe*, meaning "those who stand/fight together"), arming them with machetes and inciting them with rhetoric of hatred against the "cockroaches," the Tutsi. Hutu nationalists used aid money from the IMF to buy thousands of cheap machetes from China and handed them out to young Hutu militiamen.

The collapse of coffee prices on the world market in the early to mid-1990s, which left many poor rural Hutu farmers even poorer, facilitated the recruitment efforts of the *Interahamwe*. In the late 1980s, the IMF introduced coffee cultivation in Vietnam, a country that had not historically grown the crop; it grew very well and within a few years Vietnam became a significant coffee producer, thereby putting a downward pressure on prices for the crop on the world market by increasing supply (an example of how changes in one part of the vast international economy can have a profound impact elsewhere in the world). Compounding matters, agricultural production in Rwanda declined sharply in the early 1990s owing to several factors: disruption from the fighting in the civil war; greater cultivation of coffee on lands traditionally used for food crops because the drop in coffee prices compelled people

to grow more coffee to get the same return in cash (which only increased the supply and thus further reduced the price on the global market in a vicious cycle); and a relative lack of rainfall. In short, it was a perfect storm of sorts, and by 1994 the stage was set for a terrible genocide.

Facing significant international pressure, and despite being close to several leading Hutu extremists within his own governing party, the National Revolutionary Movement for Development (MRND), Rwanda's Hutu President Juvenal Habyarimana sought a peace treaty with the RPF. In early April 1994 he signed the Arusha Accords in Tanzania with the Hutu President of neighboring Burundi, Cyprien Ntaryamira, acting as mediator. It seemed that peace had finally arrived in Rwanda, but, alas, it was short-lived. On April 6, someone shot down Habyarimana's plane at the airport in Kigali as he was returning home; he, the president of Burundi, and several of his top aides were killed. The plane was shot down with a missile, but to this day no one knows who shot the missile. Regardless, Hutu nationalists blamed it on the RPF and used the incident to begin the genocide.

One of the worst inciters of the violence that began immediately after Habyarimana's assassination was a radio announcer, George Rutaganda. He allegedly gave the signal to start the genocide: "cut the tall trees" he announced to listeners, and with that the bloodshed in Kigali and other areas of the country began (in 1999 Rutaganda was sentenced to life imprisonment by the International Criminal Tribunal for Rwanda; he died in custody in 2010). With the president killed in the plane crash the country's Prime Minister, Agathe Uwilingiyimana, a moderate Hutu, should have taken control of the country. However, on the following day, April 7, 1994, extremist Hutus within the Rwandan Armed Forces killed her and ten Belgian guards protecting her as part of a UN peacekeeping force. Their rationale for this heinous act: Uwilingiyimana was moderate and would not support their planned genocide, so she had to be eliminated; and to clear the way to carry out the genocide without international interference they needed to make (European) peacekeepers in the country bleed, believing that this event would cause them to withdraw from the country, which it did. The architects of the genocide calculated this on the basis of events six months earlier in Somalia where the US had withdrawn in disgrace following the deaths of several US servicemen in Mogadishu.

After Uwilingiyimana's death Hutu extremist Colonel Théoneste Bagosora, a key engineer of the genocide, seized control of the country (detained in Cameroon in 1996, Bagosora was sentenced to life; he died in prison in 2021). His Prime Minister, Jean Kambanda, another Hutu extremist, also helped engineer the genocide (arrested in 1997 in Kenya, Kambanda is currently serving a life sentence). Over the next 100 days between April-July 1994, Hutu extremists within the Rwandan Armed Forces, militiamen in the Interahamwe, and Hutu villagers carried out a brutal genocide, killing an estimated 800,000 to 1mn people in Rwanda, most of them Tutsi (75% of the overall Tutsi population), but also moderate Hutus who were considered

too “soft” on the Tutsis. Many Hutus were involved in carrying out genocide against their Tutsi neighbors; thirty years later the hunt for perpetrators and the leaders of the genocide continues.

The US and the UN sat idle while the killing continued. The US Clinton administration forbade use of the “g-word,” “genocide,” because to call it a genocide would require the US, as a signatory to the 1948 Genocide Convention, to intervene to stop it. In one infamous press conference Clinton administration spokesperson Christine Shelley said that individual “acts of genocide may have occurred,” but refused to characterize the entire situation as genocide. Clinton himself would later admit on a visit to Rwanda on the tenth anniversary of the genocide in 2004 that he considered US inaction in Rwanda the greatest failing of his presidency.

The genocide finally ended in mid-July 1994 when RPF rebels ousted the Hutu nationalists in power. Many instigators of the genocide as well as mid-level and even low-level perpetrators fled to refugee camps in neighboring Zaire (since 1997 the Democratic Republic of Congo, which we discuss below) along with millions of other Hutus fearing retribution from the Tutsi-led RPF. The conflict thus spilled over the border there, as we will see. In Rwanda, there were some revenge killings by Tutsi against Hutu, and the Tutsi-led government since 1994 has tended to favor Tutsis over Hutus in land disputes and other legal claims. The government discourages using the terms “Tutsi” and “Hutu” and promotes the idea that everyone in their country are “Rwandans.” Following the genocide, many thousands of Tutsis returned to the country from exile in Uganda and elsewhere, so that the country’s population soon became the same as it was before the genocide: 85% Hutu and 14% Tutsi.

Paul Kagame

Since the end of the genocide in 1994 Rwanda has had one leader: Paul Kagame, Tutsi leader of the RPF rebel forces that formed in neighboring Uganda, attacked Rwanda in 1990, and ousted the Hutu extremists to end the genocide in July 1994. For several years Kagame was recognized as the power behind the scenes, but in 2000 the National Assembly elected him as the country’s president of a transitional government, and three years later he won presidential elections in a landslide. He won re-election in another landslide in 2010 amid growing criticisms of repression of political opponents carried out by his regime (a journalist and opposition political leader were both murdered during the runup to the election, though Kagame claimed to have nothing to do with these incidents).

Amid praise for strengthening the Rwandan economy, fostering reconciliation between its peoples, and improving social conditions in the country, Kagame has nonetheless faced criticism for the repressive and dictatorial manner of his rule, particularly the government’s restrictions on the media and dissenting political voices. Despite the criticisms, in a 2015 referendum

voters approved a change to the country's constitution to override term limits, allowing Kagame to serve two more seven-year terms and an additional two five-year terms as president after that (allowing him to rule the country until 2034!) He ran for and easily won "re-election" in 2017 and again in 2024 (in the latter case reportedly tallying more than 99% of the vote!), although in each case actual political opponents were greatly restricted and strongly discouraged from running legitimate campaigns to challenge him. In short, thirty years after its genocide Rwanda has made tremendous strides in many ways, but politically it may yet have a way to go.

The Democratic Republic of Congo

A country in the heart of central Africa, the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC; formerly Zaire), which straddles the equator, has had a turbulent modern history, including bloody conflicts in recent decades. The third largest country in Africa, the DRC, with its capital Kinshasa (formerly Leopoldville), is almost totally landlocked except for a roughly twenty-seven-mile coastline along the Atlantic Ocean that is the outlet of the Congo River, the second largest river (to the Nile) on the African continent, and its tributaries. The DRC has tremendous mineral wealth, especially diamond deposits, probably the most of any country in the world, and is also rich in copper, zinc, and cobalt, which is used in lithium-ion batteries in phones and computers.

The DRC is the most diverse country on a continent of great diversity: there are over 200 African ethnic groups in the Congo; the three largest tribal groupings, the Mongo, Luba, and Kongo are all Bantu-speaking peoples, and together with the fourth largest group, the Mangbetu-Azande (a Hamitic-speaking people), make up about 45% of the country's total population. About 27% of the population are Christians (divided between roughly 50% Roman Catholic and about 20% Protestant), nearly 10% are Muslim, and the remainder ascribe to native religions.

The DRC was a Belgian colony known throughout the colonial period as the Belgian Congo. Belgium ruled the colony directly, not depending on a trained native elite to run affairs for them. As elsewhere, World War II weakened Belgium's hold on its African colony and empowered the colonized peoples, and during the 1950s there were increasing pressures from within the colony for independence. The Belgians seemed poised to put up a fight to hang on to the colony, their only major colonial possession, which was considered "the prize of Africa" among Europeans. In 1959, however, the Belgian Congo erupted into mass rioting and disorder, mostly targeting European businesses and homes in the colony's capital, Leopoldville (now Kinshasa). Because Belgium had ruled the colony directly it had not trained nor educated Africans in the colony, so there were few trained and educated figures to hand power to in a gradual transition.

The uprising in the Belgian Congo forced the hand of the ruling European power—either it had to fight to hold on or let the colony go. The Belgians

decided to leave, granting the Belgian Congo independence in 1960. This was a calculated move by Belgium intended to maintain the most influence possible in the region. The Belgians believed that leaving the Congo with no educated elite to rule it and with tribal divisions tearing it apart would force them to turn to Belgian business and mining interests for support.

Divided among numerous ethnic groups, all vying for control of some share of the country's mineral wealth, the Belgian Congo disintegrated into civil war immediately after independence, as two important regions tried to break off from the central government. The first leader of independent Congo was the popular Patrice Lumumba, who had led the country's struggle for independence against Belgium. He requested UN help in defeating the rebel provinces and keeping the country together. However, Lumumba soon came to suspect that elements within the UN, namely Belgium, the US, and other European powers, were more interested in seeing the country split apart because one of the separatist provinces, Katanga, located in the most mineral-rich area in the southeastern corner of the country, would be very vulnerable and dependent upon the West if it gained its independence. Given this situation in the early 1960s, growing tensions with the US and other Western powers, Lumumba turned to the USSR for help.

By turning to the Soviets, Lumumba gained the enmity of the US, who began working behind the scenes to have him removed from power. The US supported the pro-Western military leader Joseph Mobutu in a 1960 coup that overthrew Lumumba, who nonetheless remained a threat because of his popularity as a hero who had led the fight against colonialism. Consequently, the CIA hatched a plan to assassinate Lumumba. A US Congressional probe found that, while it was uncertain whether or not US President Eisenhower knew of or approved the plans, CIA Director Allen Dulles authorized a plot to assassinate Lumumba. According to the report's conclusion, however, the CIA did not assassinate Lumumba, whose political rivals beat them to the job, arresting him in the capital and killing him in 1961 in Katanga Province.

With Mobutu, an anti-Soviet leader and US supporter, in power, the US decided it best to keep the Congo united. The UN intervened with a massive operation at one point involving around 20,000 peacekeeping forces, mostly from other African but also Asian countries, who fought alongside the Congolese National Army and helped defeat the separatist rebels in Katanga in 1963. In 1966, hoping to "Africanize" his country's image, Mobutu changed the name of its capital from Leopoldville to Kinshasa, the name of the small African village in the region before the arrival of the Belgians. Mobutu renamed the country the Republic of Zaire in October 1971, and the following year he renamed himself Mobutu Sese Seko Koko Ngbendu Wa Za Banga, which means "The all-powerful warrior who, because of his endurance and inflexible will to win, will go from conquest to conquest, leaving fire in his wake." He ruled the country for over two decades as one of the most infamously corrupt and brutal dictators in Africa and the world, but

because he was staunchly anti-Communist the US supported him throughout the Cold War era.

The population, on the other hand, was increasingly impoverished, and when the Cold War ended in the late 1980s/early 1990s, Mobutu was suddenly less important for the US as an anti-communist ally. In the mid-1990s the horrible conflict and genocide in neighboring Rwanda spilled over into Zaire, with Hutu extremists fleeing that country and forming militias in Zaire. In response the Rwandan government of Paul Kagame supported Tutsi militias in Zaire to fight against the Hutu extremists, all amid an armed revolutionary movement against Mobutu that gradually picked up momentum, especially as the country's economic situation worsened (in 1989 the country had been forced to default on its massive international debt to mostly Belgian-owned banks, in part because of massive government embezzlement of state funds). In mid-1997 Mobutu fled to Morocco as rebel forces took over the capital; by the end of his reign Mobutu, who died of cancer later that year, had become one of the world's richest men because of his lucrative dealings with Western mining companies in his country.

Laurent-Désiré Kabila led the rebel forces who ousted Mobutu. The first move of the new government was to change the country's name from Zaire to The Democratic Republic of Congo, presumably to distance itself from the country's recent history dominated by Mobutu. Kabila, a former Marxist, came to power promising to follow a free-market path. He dealt with political opposition in much the same way as his predecessor: he banned all opposition parties and declared that no new elections would be held for at least a year, leading to widespread condemnation in the West. Kabila responded by calling the West (mainly the US and France, his harshest critics) hypocrites for supporting Mobutu for decades and now suddenly calling for democratic elections.

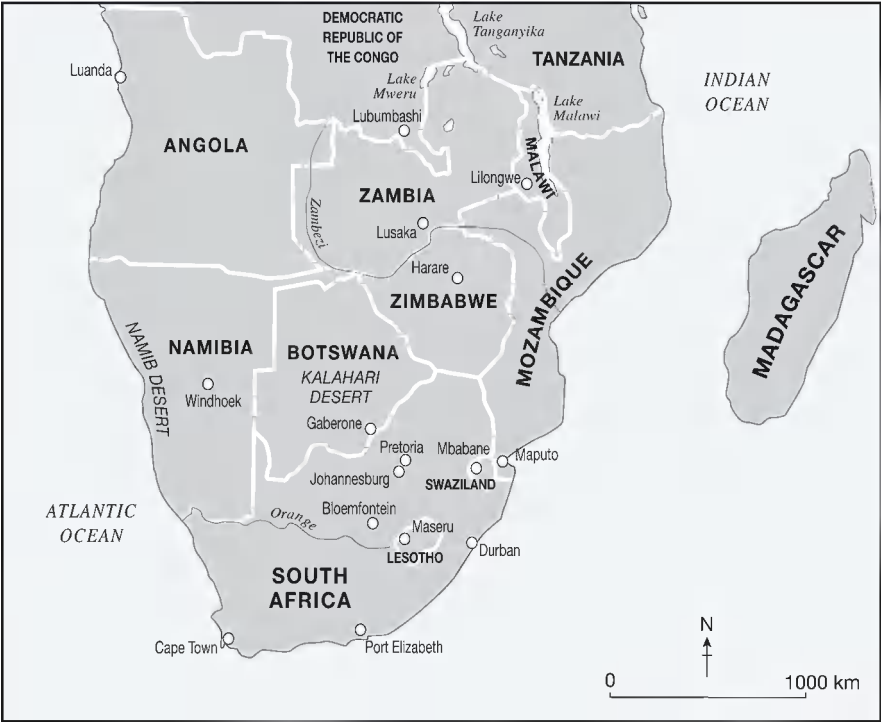
Kabila proved unable to bring peace and stability to the war-torn country. In August 1998 the conflict in the country worsened, with rebel forces backed by neighboring Uganda and Rwanda challenging Kabila's tenuous hold on power. Troops from Zimbabwe, Angola, Namibia, Chad, and Sudan intervened to support Kabila's regime and a ceasefire was signed in July 1999, though sporadic fighting continued. Laurent Kabila was assassinated in January 2001 and his son Joseph Kabila took over as head of state. In October 2002 Joseph Kabila forced occupying Rwandan troops to withdraw from eastern Congo; two months later all remaining warring parties signed an agreement to end the fighting and set up a government of national unity.

Kabila continued to rule the country's transitional government until elections in 2006, which he won as the country's first freely-elected leader in four decades. However, in August 2007 rebel leader Laurent Nkunda, with support from the Rwandan government, initiated the fighting again with his mostly Tutsi-militia organized in the March 23 Movement (M23) attacking Hutu militias and the Congolese National Army, thereby setting off a new round of a brutal conflict in which mass rapes as a form of intimidation

were common. Fighting was heaviest in the eastern parts of the country, the Kivu and North Kivu regions, especially at times around the city of Goma on the border with Rwanda. Sporadic fighting and violence continued in the country's east as Félix Tshisekedi won a disputed 2018 election, assuming the presidency (from Kabila) in the first peaceful transition of power in the country's history.

In the 2000s the Chinese government spent considerable sums to purchase most of the DRC's cobalt, copper, and uranium mines from the (primarily US, Belgian and French) companies that previously owned them. China also provided weapons and drones to the Congolese National Army in its fight against the M23 rebels in the east, who had laid mostly dormant for several years before re-emerging in 2022 and gaining control of large parts of North Kivu Province by mid-2023.

In December 2023 Tshisekedi reportedly won re-election amid widespread accusations of voting fraud. M23 and other militia groups responded by increasing their attacks in the east as tensions had also risen nationally—not just in the east—because of the disputed elections. In 2024 an estimated 358,000 Congolese were displaced by the fighting, and by one account there are around 100 different non-state armed militias active in the country, including, aside from M23, the ISIS-aligned Allied Democratic Forces (ADF). UN observers warn of a possible expansion of the conflict from the east to the rest of the country. As many as 6mn Congolese have died since the country's civil war began in the mid-1990s, and peace to this day remains elusive.



Map 14.1 Map of Southern Africa.

14 Southern Africa

Zimbabwe and South Africa

Zimbabwe

Zimbabwe, formerly known as Southern Rhodesia, is a landlocked country with its capital at Harare and a population of around 16.3mn as of 2023. It has relatively little ethnic diversity, especially when compared to most African states. The vast majority of the country's indigenous population belong to the Shona ethnic group (almost 82%) with a minority belonging to the Ndebele ethnic group (about 14%). The remaining population is comprised of various native groups, an Asian minority (roughly 1%), and a small (less than 1%) white minority.

The British crown conquered the area that is today Zimbabwe and Zambia when an adventurous settler, Cecil Rhodes, ventured north from South Africa in the late nineteenth century with a small army of well trained and highly armed troops. The discovery of copper, chromium, nickel, and other minerals led to increased white settlement, and the British claimed the area as a colony. White settlers (mostly British) moved into Northern and Southern Rhodesia in large numbers from South Africa and, to a lesser extent, from Britain itself. White settlement in Rhodesia became very rapid after World War II. In the 1950s to avoid the pressures of de-colonization emerging throughout Africa and the world, the two Rhodesias merged (along with Nyasaland, now Malawi) in a Central African Federation theoretically based on multiracial rule. However, power remained disproportionately in the hands of the white minority, a mere 250,000 in Southern Rhodesia, which had a population of roughly 4mn indigenous Africans. The white minority could not introduce a purely democratic form of one person one vote, and anything short of that was seen as undemocratic and repressive by the black majority.

Demonstrations and strikes against white minority rule intensified in the late 1950s and early 1960s, and the Central African Federation broke down. Black majority rule emerged in Northern Rhodesia, which became Zambia in 1964, and Nyasaland became Malawi later that same year. Only Southern Rhodesia, thereafter known simply as Rhodesia, held out. Whites from Northern Rhodesia and Nyasaland moved to Rhodesia, where they were determined to maintain their rule. On the one hand the country remained

a British colony, but the British realized that black majority rule was just a matter of time and pressed the Rhodesians to back down. The minority white leaders of Rhodesia, on the other hand, not only wanted to maintain their rule, but also demanded their independence from Britain. The British refused to grant independence, hoping they could maintain some influence in the region and oversee a smooth transition to black majority rule. In 1965 Ian Smith, leader of the white Rhodesian Front, took the initiative and declared Rhodesia's independence in the Unilateral Declaration of Independence (UDI), a measure rooted in the failure of the Central African Federation. Rhodesia's white minority celebrated this act, but not the black majority, who remained under white minority rule.

Smith's actions intensified black opposition and sparked a guerrilla war when it became clear that Rhodesia would not smoothly transform to black majority rule like Northern Rhodesia (Zambia) and Nyasaland (Malawi). White minority rule also isolated the country internationally, leading to UN sanctions in 1971 (which the US did not abide by). This combined with black opposition and an armed rebellion led by Robert Mugabe forced Smith to negotiate, leading to black majority rule and the establishment of Zimbabwe in 1980. Mugabe won the elections to become the country's first president. Some whites fled the country, and the government confiscated their land and redistributed it to black farmers. In 1980 whites comprised only 2% of the population, but they controlled 40% of the land. The whites who stayed initially kept their land but in 1990 the government seized (with compensation) and redistributed more of the country's white-owned land. The question of land ownership remains a heated political issue in Zimbabwe.

The IMF and World Bank have been active in Zimbabwe. They began lending to the Mugabe government in the early 1980s, at the time estimating that Zimbabwe's debt repayment would be about 4% of its export earnings. However, by 1987 debt repayment was taking up 35% of the country's export earnings, putting a severe drain on its economy, forcing Mugabe's government to turn again to the IMF and World Bank for "structural adjustment" loans with various stipulations and restrictions attached. In the late 1980s and early 1990s the lending institutions liberalized trade and finance, tightened monetary policy, oversaw major interest rate hikes, devalued Zimbabwe's currency by 35%, and eliminated key price controls. The short-term results of these reforms were devastating: exports fell by over 3% in 1991; inflation rose sharply by mid-1991, quickly doubling average 1980s levels; in 1991 IMF/World Bank officials persuaded Zimbabwe's Reserve Bank to raise short-term interest rates from 27.5% to 44%, leading to a massive credit crisis (e.g., no home mortgages were available), a sustained property market downturn, disastrous pension fund returns, a major corporate financial crisis, and a sudden crash of the Zimbabwe Stock Exchange, which lost close to one-third of its value. These economic woes faced by the population were compounded by a drought that ravaged a large part of the country in 1991–92, cutting further into the country's agricultural exports.

By 1998, the last year Mugabe paid the country's full debt to foreign creditors, it amounted to 38% of export earnings (the third highest in the world, after Brazil and Burundi). The following year the IMF negotiated a \$200mn loan to Zimbabwe, but again with strings attached. The loan was approved only after the reduction of tariffs on luxury goods and the removal of remaining price controls, but the latter measure led to an inflationary spiral that ate away at people's already low real wages. Inflation rose from an annual rate of 32% in 1998 to 59% in 1999, 60% in 2000, and to 100% by 2001. Economic woes contributed to political turmoil in the country. In 2000 Mugabe initiated a land redistribution campaign targeting white-owned farms. In several instances farms were seized by force, as Mugabe supporters, often veterans of the struggle for independence twenty years earlier, chased white farmers from their lands.

Land Redistribution Campaign

The results of the land redistribution were disastrous, part of the problem being that the new landholders often lacked the necessary operating capital to run the seized estates. Also, the division of the larger land holdings into smaller and smaller plots led to a decline in production, leading by 2002 to widespread shortages of basic commodities. Mugabe, ignoring international condemnation, rigged the 2002 presidential election to have himself re-elected. In addition, Zimbabwe is one of several African countries severely hit by the epidemic of AIDS sweeping through the southern part of the continent, and its budgetary woes worsened owing to the Mugabe government's support for rebel forces in the conflict in the DRC. In June 2003 the IMF announced the suspension of its earlier loan package to Zimbabwe, which had been on hold since 2001.

The 2000s were extremely difficult economically for Zimbabwe. The Bank of Zimbabwe routinely printed money to fund the country's huge budget deficit, causing the official annual inflation rate to rise from 32% in 1998, to 133% in 2004, 585% in 2005, 1000% percent in 2006, and an estimated 26000% in 2007! Meanwhile, the official exchange rate of the Zimbabwean dollar fell sharply. Amid this madness the country held its first presidential elections in six years in March 2008 with great hope that Mugabe would finally go peacefully after an electoral defeat. Following the elections the main opposition party Movement for Democratic Change (MDC) announced that its candidate, trade union leader Morgan Tsvangirai, had won an outright majority of 50.6% of the vote, thus negating the need for a runoff. After a lengthy delay Mugabe's government announced that no candidate had received an outright majority of the vote (it did not, however, release the actual voting results) and thus a runoff would be necessary.

On the day of the runoff election the police raided the office of the MDC, which set the tone for the elections. In the aftermath of the elections, which

Tsvangirai refused to participate in because of government intimidation, both sides reached a power-sharing agreement for February 2009 that recognized Mugabe as President and Tsvangirai as Prime Minister. The economy bottomed out that same year, forcing Mugabe to abandon Zimbabwe's currency, which had become worthless owing to hyperinflation, in favor of the US dollar. The move stabilized the wearied economy and modest growth returned despite the global economic crisis. However, economic woes soon returned because of government corruption, high repayment rates on international loans, and poor agricultural production because of the lingering effects of the redistribution campaign.

Amid another growing economic crisis, the thirty-seven-year Mugabe era came to an end in 2017 with a military coup led by Emmerson Mnangagwa, who placed Mugabe under house arrest with assurances of his safe keeping. Mugabe died of natural causes in Singapore in 2019 at age ninety-five. Meanwhile Mnangagwa won a close 2018 election against the MDC opposition, which accused the new government of election fraud in an all-too-familiar scenario. Questions likewise surrounded Mnangagwa's re-election in 2023. At least the country's economy seems to have stabilized at last and by the early 2020s was recording modest growth.

South Africa: The Rise of Apartheid

The Republic of South Africa with its administrative capital at Pretoria and its population of about 63.2mn as of 2023 is located, as its name implies, on the southernmost tip of the African continent. South Africa's three major cities are Cape Town, which is where European settlement began in the sixteenth century; Pretoria, the administrative capital; and Johannesburg, which was built up in the nineteenth century as a center of the country's booming mining industries. Although surrounded by the Atlantic and Indian Oceans with a huge coastline, South Africa until the modern era was relatively isolated owing to strong ocean currents impeding regular access to its coast by sea. Also, South Africa has no navigable rivers coming into it from the north, and it has very few good natural harbors. It was only with the navigational advances of the early modern period by Europeans that South Africa became accessible by sea and subsequently opened to Western impact.

Little of South Africa's land is suitable for agriculture. The Kalahari Desert stretches over much of southern Africa, from Namibia and Botswana down into South Africa, and this area, the northwestern corner of South Africa, is sparsely inhabited. Other areas of the country have poor soil or too little rainfall for agriculture. The best agricultural land is in the northeastern corner of the country near the border with Mozambique. In this area in and around Johannesburg the soil is suitable and there is enough rainfall for extensive cultivation. South Africa is one of the world's largest suppliers of gold and diamonds and also has major deposits of copper, platinum, chrome, and uranium, making it one of the most mineral-rich nations in the world.

Before the arrival of Europeans, South Africa was inhabited by numerous ethnic groups, the largest being agriculturalists settled in the northeast corner of the country, the Xhosa and Zulu. Other smaller groups lived scattered throughout the country. The first Europeans to set shore on what is today South Africa were the Portuguese led by explorer Bartholomeu Dias, who landed on Africa's southern coast in 1487 to avoid a storm at sea. But Portugal did not settle the region of South Africa. Their experience with navigational hazards and a hostile African population made them wary of the area. It would be over a century before Europe's navigational skills allowed it to sail through the strong currents and regularly visit Africa's southern coast, and by that time the Dutch had replaced the Portuguese as Europe's greatest expansionist power. In 1652 Dutchman Jan van Riebeeck and eighty men arrived in South Africa on behalf of the Dutch East India Company to establish a port settlement where European ships on their way to India could stop. The port they settled was Cape Town, the beginning of European settlement in South Africa.

From a meager beginning in 1654 the first Dutch settlement on the southernmost tip of the African continent expanded and changed the history, demography, and landscape of the entire area. The Dutch settlers brought in slaves from other parts of Africa (mostly from the island Madagascar off Africa's southeastern coast). The Dutch East India Company released employees from their contracts and gave them land in and around the Cape Town settlement, which displaced the semi-nomadic African herders occupying the land, forcing them to migrate further north. The Dutch East India Company also brought in more Dutch settlers and expanded the territory under their control; by 1793 there were 13,830 Dutch landowners in and around Cape Town.

The majority of the Dutch settlers were men, and as a result there was a lot of intermixture with slaves and the native African population, creating the origins of what would become a racially mixed or "colored" population. A study in the 1980s estimated that about 7% of the genes of South Africa's Afrikaner, or white population of Dutch descent, are non-European in origin, reflecting this early period of racial intermixture. Gradually Dutch settlers in South Africa developed their own language, Afrikaans, which is closely related to Dutch, and their own unique cultural identity. White South Africans of Dutch descent are known as Afrikaners (derogatorily as Boers). A series of battles against the semi-nomadic herding Xhosa peoples and the outbreak of smallpox among the native Africans in the eighteenth century greatly reduced the native population in the region, facilitating the expansion of the original Dutch settlement.

The arrival of the British in the late eighteenth century threatened Dutch control in South Africa. The British, by that time the most powerful country in the world, forced the Cape Town settlement to capitulate to British rule. Thus, from the late eighteenth century on, the history of South Africa's white population is characterized by division and struggle between the original Afrikaner settlers and the British, who also began to settle the region. In

the early nineteenth century the British conquered the Xhosa, which began the piecemeal conquest of South Africa's native population. After 1820 British settlers started arriving in South Africa in large numbers because of unemployment and social unrest back in Britain—and because Britain had lost its American colonies as an outlet for its “excess” population. In the 1820s British settlers introduced sheep herding in the grasslands around Cape Town and the surrounding area and wool soon became the area's main export. Increased pressure on the land because of sheep herding compelled the Afrikaner population, descendants of the original Dutch settlers, to leave the British-controlled areas and migrate on the so-called “Great Trek,” 1836–54, into the northeast corner with the best agricultural land most densely inhabited by native Africans.

Afrikaners exploited differences and conflicts between native ethnic groups, in particular the Xhosa and Zulu. The “Great Trek,” as it is remembered in the history books of the Afrikaners, was a “great conquest” for native South Africans. Black South Africans resisted European advances (both Afrikaner and British) into their territory and managed to hold off the Europeans for a while in several places. Native leader Moshoeshe forged a coalition of ethnic groups that held European advancement at bay in the 1820s. The Zulus defeated British troops at the Battle of Isandlwana in 1879. However, the British returned with a larger force six months later and avenged the loss. Native resistance continued—the British crushed a rebellion by Chief Signananda and his sons in 1906. Eventually the superior military technology of the invading Afrikaners and British overwhelmed native Africans. The British introduced cotton and to a lesser extent sugar cane (cash crops) in the 1850s and brought South Asians as laborers in the 1860s. Between 1860–66 about 6,000 Indians migrated to South Africa introducing another racial minority group into the region.

The balance of economic and political power in South Africa shifted again in the late nineteenth century owing to the discovery of gold and diamonds in the 1870s in areas of the country now controlled by the Afrikaners (the north and northeast). Soon the thriving mining industry around the boom towns Pretoria and Johannesburg drew the attention of the British, who moved into the area only recently conquered by Afrikaners. During the South African War (also known as the “Boer War”) of 1899–1902, the British defeated Afrikaner separatists in the northeast and incorporated the area into the British empire, albeit with a great deal of autonomy. Thus, South African history is characterized by division and conflict among the country's white population, the Afrikaners and the British (there is a slight majority, 55%, Afrikaner population today).

Apartheid South Africa

After the South African War, conflict within South Africa's minority white population decreased, as whites of both Afrikaner and British heritage, who

combined made up only about 15–16% of the overall population, united to protect their common interests against the majority black population. Britain granted South Africa its independence in 1910, creating the Union of South Africa. The constitution of the newly independent country limited the right to vote to the white minority, and among the white minority those of British origin remained in control of the government. At this early date, the government began enforcing segregationist policies that would culminate in the post-World War II system of Apartheid. In response to these policies, in 1912 black leaders formed the African National Congress (ANC) to resist white minority rule through nonviolence. The ANC formed partly under the influence of Gandhi, whose career began in South Africa (he lived there for over twenty years), where he formed the Indian National Congress to resist discriminatory laws aimed at the country's Indian minority.

As we have noted, World War II dealt a blow to colonialism and empowered people of color around the world. In South Africa, however, the opposite was true as the postwar period was one of reaction by whites who, making up about 16% of the population, seemed determined to keep control of the nonwhite majority. Apartheid literally means “apartness” or “separateness,” and while it would not become official governmental policy until 1948, its roots can be traced to a series of laws enacted earlier:

1. “Pass” laws (established in the late nineteenth century) requiring nonwhites to carry an ID card listing their place of residence and a work permit were expanded to control the movement of nonwhite population groups. This was the most hated aspect of Apartheid for blacks, coloreds, and Asians. The Pass included a residency stamp, nationality (such as Zulu, Xhosa, and so on), place of employment, and the names of one's dependents. The police could stop any nonwhite and demand to see his or her pass at any time.
2. The Natives Land Act (1913) set aside 7% of the land as “homelands,” known as Bantustans, for blacks (who made up 73% of the population); in the 1930s this was revised to a total of 12% of the country's land. The land granted as black homelands was some of the worst land available (this policy was consciously based on the model of Native American reservations in the US). Because of the poor (and inadequate) land in the homelands, most native black African men migrated to work in the country's mines or in the cities, which is exactly what white leaders wanted—a cheap labor force. This led to the breakup of black families as men often lived away from their wives and children for most of the year.
3. The Group Areas Act (1923) segregated urban areas, seeking to control black migration to the cities. The law was intended to limit the number of black families in cities, with urban authorities empowered to remove what they called “excess females,” usually women living with their husbands in town but without the required work or residency passes.

During World War II the country's white leadership was divided. Most Afrikaners sympathized with Nazi Germany, but the government was still controlled by South Africans of British origin and so sided with the allies during the war. Also, the government relaxed the pass laws and other restrictions on the majority black population during the war because they wanted to garner the support of nonwhites for the war cause (and also because they wanted to increase production, which the laws restricting population movement hindered). Thus, it appeared during the war that South Africa might evolve toward a more inclusive society based on racial integration. After World War II, however, there was an abrupt reversal in policy and a movement toward rigid, institutionalized segregation with the official implementation of Apartheid.

The imposition of Apartheid was achieved through the ballot box. In South Africa's 1948 elections (in which the right to vote was still limited to whites), the Afrikaner-dominated National Party (NP) won and initiated the official state policy of Apartheid. The chief architect of Apartheid, Hendrik Verwoerd, called it a policy of "good neighborliness." The Apartheid system Verwoerd constructed was based on a series of laws: The Prohibition of Mixed Marriages Act (1949) and the Immorality Act (1950) made it illegal for people of different races to marry or have sexual relations. The goal of these acts was to maintain racial "purity" among the various groups of South Africa, and thus it was important to determine which group everyone belonged to. The Population Registration Act (1950) categorized the entire South African population into one of four "racial groups"—white, colored, Asian, and black.

However, there had been a lot of intermixture between the races, and it was not always clear which category someone belonged to (as noted, the Afrikaners themselves are by no means racially "pure"). There were instances in which people in the same family were registered in different racial groups. In cases where there might have been some doubt about someone's race, officials carried out the so-called "comb test." They would pass a comb through someone's hair, and if the comb passed smoothly, they were registered as non-black, but if it did not pass smoothly, they were considered black. Another part of the system was the segregation of public facilities, or petty Apartheid, with blacks, coloreds, and Asians usually clumped together as nonwhites and restricted as such in their access to bathrooms, water fountains, beaches, walkways and sidewalks, stairways and elevators. Everyone in South Africa grew up with a very rigid understanding of racial identity and one's place in society.

The Afrikaner-dominated NP also nationalized (granted control to the state) a significant sector of the economy (especially in the mining industries) to give themselves economic power over whites of British descent. Also, the NP began a long-term plan in the 1950s to turn the African "homelands" created in 1913 into independent states, turning all blacks into "citizens" of their homeland and thus "aliens" or immigrants in South Africa proper,

which would thus belong only to whites. This allowed whites in South Africa to consider their government a “democracy”—which, as we have seen, is a relative term meaning different things to different people—because whereas blacks could not vote in South Africa itself, they were all legal citizens with full voting rights in one or another of the ten “homelands.” This policy also created black-led governments in the “homelands” whose existence (and therefore power) depended on Apartheid—it created black leaders with a vested interest in maintaining Apartheid, which was particularly true, as we will see, in the Zulu homeland. This plan reached its fruition in the 1970s when the South African government granted “independence” (not recognized by any other country in the world) to South Africa’s ten native “homelands.”

As in the earlier period there was considerable black resistance to the imposition of Apartheid after World War II. Initially this took the form of passive resistance. Protests against the pass laws reached a violent climax in March 1960 at the Sharpeville Massacre. A large crowd of black Africans gathered at a police station near Johannesburg and police opened fire on the crowd, killing sixty-seven and wounding 186. Afterward, the government outlawed the ANC, although it had not organized the protests, and denounced the organization’s leader, Nelson Mandela, as a terrorist. The ANC responded to the Sharpeville Massacre by renouncing nonviolence, declaring its right to defend the native black African population with violence when necessary. Mandela was forced into hiding after Sharpeville. In 1963, a CIA operative in South Africa discovered his whereabouts and tipped off the South African government, leading to Mandela’s arrest and imprisonment. He would not be released until 1990, twenty-seven years later.

After the Sharpeville Massacre and the imprisonment of Mandela, black resistance to Apartheid took a more militant, nationalistic turn with the rise of the Black Consciousness Movement led by Stephen Biko, an influential leader among black African youth. In 1976 students in Soweto, a black township outside Johannesburg, protested against the government’s decision to make Afrikaans the official school language, setting off one of the most significant demonstrations and protests in the history of Apartheid. The government declared a state of emergency, arrested Biko, who was killed by police while in custody in September 1977, and Apartheid reached a peak of repression in the late 1970s and early 1980s.

The End of Apartheid

Facing international pressure and internal protest, President P.W. Botha, who ruled from 1978–84, began a policy of gradual reform in South Africa in the early 1980s. He ended the pass laws, removed some of the more stringent segregationist aspects of petty Apartheid, and passed a new constitution granting representation to Asians and coloreds, but maintaining white rule and still excluding the black majority from the political process. On an economic and social level, South African society remained extremely divided. In

1987 blacks made up 73% of the population, whites 16%, coloreds 10%, Asians 1%; the annual average income (per person, in rands) was 14,880 for whites, 4,560 for Asians, 3,000 for coloreds, and 1,246 for blacks; infant mortality (per 1,000 live births for first year) was nine for whites, sixteen for Asians, forty-one for coloreds, and sixty-three for blacks; government spending on education (per child, in rands) was 2,538 for whites, 1,857 for Asians, 1,286 for coloreds, and 504 for blacks.

Botha's piecemeal reforms did nothing to alleviate the poverty of the black masses, nor did it deal with the unjust political roots of the Apartheid system. In fact, the half-hearted reforms only heightened opposition, leading to violent riots throughout the country. Botha responded by declaring a state of emergency and intensifying repression. He left office begrudgingly following a stroke in 1989, replaced as head of the NP and the state by F.W. DeKlerk, who made reforming Apartheid his major goal. He began by granting representation to blacks in South Africa's Parliament.

In 1990, DeKlerk released Mandela from prison and legalized the ANC. But change came gradually and with resistance from both whites and blacks. Among the blacks, as noted earlier the chiefs of the "independent homelands" had a vested interest in maintaining Apartheid since their own power was very directly linked to the system. The most prominent was Chief Buthelezi of the Zulu kingdom (or "homeland"), leader of the Inkatha Freedom Party (IFP). Thus, the black majority population was divided on the nature of reform, and violence broke out often in the early 1990s between mostly Zulu supporters of the IFP and supporters of the ANC, led by Mandela. There were allegations that the DeKlerk government instigated the violence at times to strengthen its negotiating position with the ANC.

The obstacles to change were tremendous, but there were also strong forces compelling change. The end of the Cold War made ending Apartheid more plausible as the white minority government could no longer justify Apartheid as a bulwark against communist expansion on the African continent. International sanctions were taking a toll on the country economically, while the limitations on population movement at home hindered modernization and production. In 1993 an agreement was reached suiting DeKlerk's government, Mandela and the ANC, and Buthelezi and the IFP. Elections were held in 1994 for the first time in the country's history on the basis of one person, one vote, giving way to black majority rule under Mandela's leadership, a moment of rejoicing for many South Africans.

Post-Apartheid South Africa

Profound challenges faced the new Mandela/ANC-led post-Apartheid South African government. Key among them was the country's wide economic disparities, which did not go away with the end of Apartheid. Economic inequalities in the country worsened because of a plan the de Klerk government enacted in the early 1990s. In its last years in power the NP government

privatized key economic resources the party had nationalized in the late 1940s/early 1950s, especially mining resources, with the white minority overwhelmingly benefited from this process, which helped lock into place the race-based economic disparities of the Apartheid era. This in turn contributed to a huge crime problem in post-Apartheid South Africa, which suffers from one of the worst crime rates in the world. In addition, the AIDS epidemic that impacted much of Africa was particularly acute in South Africa in the 1990s.

The government also faced lingering tensions from the Apartheid era and the possibility of violent backlash by the native black majority against the white minority. Fearing such backlash, many whites left the country in the mid-1990s. The South African government created the Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC) to deal with this issue in 1995. Anglican Archbishop Desmond Tutu chaired the committee, which heard over 7,000 cases, with the goal of establishing peace and justice in the country. The TRC granted amnesty to those who committed crimes during the Apartheid era *if* they made a full disclosure of their offense to the committee and showed that their actions were politically motivated. The TRC became a model for such practices around the world.

In the political realm post-Apartheid South Africa has seen a great deal of instability, albeit with the ANC maintaining its grip on power. Mandela held to an earlier promise to only serve one term as president, and in 1999 his handpicked successor Thabo Mbeki won easily. Mbeki won re-election by a wide margin in 2004 as well, despite downplaying (and largely ignoring) the country's AIDS crisis. However, Mbeki resigned in 2008 prior to the end of his second term amid allegations that he interfered in a corruption case against one of his key deputies (and heir apparent), ANC leader Jacob Zuma. The corruption case was dropped, which cleared the way for Zuma to run for and win the 2009 presidential elections. Mandela died in 2013 as tributes to "the father of the nation" poured in from around the world. The following year Zuma won re-election as ANC leader, although claims of corruption continued to hound him, especially after a multi-million-dollar renovation of his private home. In March 2016 the South African Supreme Court ruled that President Zuma violated the country's constitution for not repaying public money used to upgrade his private residency. Two years later, in February 2018, Zuma resigned amid growing pressures owing to the corruption charges against him.

Cyril Ramaphosa replaced Zuma as president of the ANC, subsequently running for and winning the presidency in 2019 and re-election in 2024. Although still winning a majority, the ANC did far worse in each of those elections than in previous ones, forcing the party to enter a coalition with several other parties in 2024. Observers credit Ramaphosa with reigning in corruption compared to the Zuma era, but major problems remain, including high crime rates and economic disparities. A 2017 government audit found that white farmers, who now make up 9% of the overall population, own 72% of the country's private farmlands. Native black Africans make up about

81% of South Africa's population and the "colored" population around 8%. In 2024 the South African government enacted the Expropriation Act that allows it under certain circumstances to take over privately held land for public use. In response US President Trump in early February 2025 issued an executive order to freeze all US aid to South Africa for allegedly "discriminating against whites" in the country and to grant refugee status to Afrikaners who want to leave South Africa (Trump's former close advisor Elon Musk, founder of Tesla and Space X, is a white South African). Based on recent figures black poverty in South Africa is 64% whereas white poverty is 1%, a discrepancy largely attributed to a pattern of generational privilege under Apartheid. Thirty years after the end of Apartheid the legacy of that era still defines many of the issues and challenges facing South Africa.

Part V

Latin America



Map 15.1 Map of South America.

15 South America

Venezuela, Argentina, and Chile

Like Africa, South America is a large and very diverse continent. The equator crosses South America in the north running through Ecuador (from which the country takes its name), Columbia, and Brazil. The physical geography of South America includes the extensive Amazon River basin and the Brazilian rain forests, the decimation of which constitutes one of the world's worst environmental problems. The South American plain runs through Argentina, and the very high Andes Mountains run north-south along the west. South America has a wealth of natural resources from Venezuela's oil to Brazil's timber-rich forests (one of the reasons for their decimation) to Chile's copper mines, which makes it very important in the international economy.

Spain and Portugal colonized South America beginning in the sixteenth century, the "first wave" of colonial conquest. South America prior to European arrival was home to the Incan civilization based primarily in modern-day Peru. Spain and Portugal *greatly* impacted on South America between the sixteenth and nineteenth centuries by conquering the native population, settling the region in large numbers, and transforming the region's economy to one based on cash crop production on haciendas (large estates). They brought in African slaves to work on the haciendas, adding to the region's ethnic diversity. The main cash crops they grew were coffee, sugar, and cotton. In contrast to sub-Saharan Africa, this transformation took place much earlier in South America's history.

Ethnic composition varies from country to country in South America. Brazil, which was most geared toward hacienda production, is the most diverse. Chile is much more ethnically homogenous; Bolivia, Peru, and Ecuador have the largest native populations (in that order). The conquest of South America by Europeans led to settler colonialism, giving rise throughout most of South America to an elite landowning class of European descent, whose wealth was derived from the haciendas, slave labor, and the labor of indigenous peasants. This is the root of the continent's ethnic diversity, which cuts clearly across economic lines between the relatively wealthy landowning class of European descent and the comparatively poorer descendants of African slaves and Native Americans. Europe's impact on South America

is also reflected in the fact that the population is almost entirely Catholic, and that the majority speaks Spanish, except for Brazil, which was a Portuguese colony and thus speaks Portuguese. There are native languages on the continent as well, but most people in South America speak either Spanish or Portuguese.

Most of Latin America achieved independence from Europe by the 1820s, a few decades after the US Revolutionary War (two notable exceptions are Cuba, which did not gain its independence from Spain until the Spanish-American War of 1898, and Panama, which broke away from Columbia in the early twentieth century). Politically dictatorship became the norm throughout most of South America after independence as in country after country a strongman, or caudillo, allied with the landowning class of European descent, ruled authoritatively (Chile, as we will see, was an exception to this rule, at least until 1973). The countries of South America exported raw materials and cash crops in exchange for finished manufactured goods from more industrialized countries (the US and Europe). With the onset of the Great Depression in the early 1930s, however, there was much less demand and buying power in the industrialized world for the cotton, coffee, sugar, minerals and other export items produced in South America. Consequently, the price of their agricultural exports on the international market plummeted, and the countries of South America could no longer raise the money needed to buy the manufactured goods that they had traditionally imported from the West.

To deal with this crisis most South American countries instituted a policy (to varying degrees) of "Import Substitution Industrialization" (ISI) intended to develop their own industry to replace the manufactured goods they had traditionally imported from the West. This policy entailed the imposition of high tariffs (taxes on imports) to pay for domestic industrialization and protect domestic industries from foreign competition. In a familiar pattern we have noted elsewhere (the USSR, Ghana, etc.), the governments of South America mostly paid for their ISI programs with resources extracted from the countryside. This policy drew peasants from the countryside to work in the newly developing factories in the cities (urbanization).

Several South American countries, most notably Argentina, Chile, and Brazil, industrialized during the 1930s and even more so during World War II and after, when demand (and the price) for their various exports and raw materials increased on the world market. The social changes brought about by industrialization, namely the rise of an urban working class, had significant political ramifications. In the postwar period, a new generation of charismatic populist leaders rose to the fore throughout much of South America, drawing their support from the new industrial working class that the ISI helped create. South America's urban workers were well organized in state-controlled unions that demanded improvements in pay and working conditions, and in country after country populist leaders rode this wave of social change to power. They gained popularity by improving pay and

working conditions; but this led to budgetary difficulties, inflation, and eventually a slowdown in productivity.

As time passed and the countries of South America continued to develop along the lines of ISI, additional problems arose. In fact, the initial success of the policy created new challenges; it is comparatively easy for an undeveloped economy to industrialize in relative isolation from the international market through import substitution by emphasizing basic industrial goods such as steel and textiles. However, as the economy develops, there is a need to expand and multiply into new branches of industry to maintain economic growth, which often require goods that these countries cannot produce on their own without importing new technologies. An example of this same situation is the Soviet Union, which industrialized over the decades of Stalinist rule and centralized planning but found that the very success of industrialization created problems once the economy had become highly industrialized by the 1970s. In the Soviet case as we saw this led to “stagnation” because the command economy created supply bottlenecks and could not sustain economic growth without imports of new technologies. This same problem began to plague the import-substitution economies of South America in the 1960s when economic growth on the continent, which had been quite high in the 1940s and early 1950s, suddenly slowed to a snail’s pace.

South America’s economic slowdown led to a return to a relationship of dependency with (primarily) the US as most South American countries reduced the high tariffs that had protected domestic industries and pursued a more open or free-trade oriented economy based on the export of agricultural goods and raw materials and the import of finished industrial goods, basically the same strategy they had pursued prior to the Great Depression of the 1930s. In addition, they began to rely more heavily on loans from the IMF and World Bank and foreign investment more generally to finance economic growth. The changing economic tides again had significant political ramifications.

Economic downturn brought increasing protests by workers and peasants alike. Whereas the populist regimes of the 1940s–50s depended on the mass support of labor to stay in power, the economies of the 1960s–70s relied more on the exploitation of both urban and rural labor. As a result, military regimes ruling with heightened repression became the norm across the continent as political opposition took the form of radical leftist guerrilla movements, the activities of which only heightened the level of governmental repression in response in an ever-increasing cycle of conflict and terror. After the Cuban Revolution of 1959 and the rise to power of Fidel Castro only ninety miles off the coast of Florida, which we discuss in the last chapter, the US built up the military governments of Central and South America as a bulwark against communist expansion in the Western Hemisphere. As we have seen elsewhere, US leaders were willing to provide financial and military support to even the worst dictators as long as they were anti-communist.

The economic policies in many South American countries in the 1960s–70s led to economic crisis in the continent in later decades as foreign investment effectively drained resources out of the region. Between 1985–95, for example, the IMF took \$347mn more out of Brazil in the form of loan repayments than it put into the country as new investment capital, owing primarily to the debt problem that originated in the early 1980s and plagued South America more than any other region of the world. We touched on the origins of the debt problem in the chapter on the Arab-Israeli Conflict but let us return to and expand upon that crucial development because of its direct implications for South America. After the 1973 oil embargo by OPEC in response to the 1973 War in the Middle East (the price of a barrel of oil on the global market literally rose fourfold overnight), oil revenue poured into the coffers of the OPEC countries. These countries, in turn, put much of the newfound wealth (dubbed “Petro dollars”) in Western banks, which in turn looked for developing countries to offer loans to at what were then (mid-1970s) very low interest rates because of the high availability of investment capital in the international economy (much of this investment was done through the auspices of the IMF).

However, the interest rates on those loans jumped *sharply* as a result of the 1980–81 worldwide recession, and the countries that took out low-interest loans several years earlier suddenly found themselves paying back those loans at greatly inflated interest rates and, thus, became very heavily in debt. Two of the three countries with the highest debts in the world in the 1980s–90s were in South America, Brazil and Argentina. Mexico was third, and Chile had one of the largest per capita foreign debts in the world. The debt problem further compounded the already serious problems of poverty and unequal income distribution that plagued South America.

Economic change on the continent combined with changes in the international realm in the late 1980s and early 1990s to alter South America’s political course once again. The economic policies of the military regimes ruling most of the countries in the 1960s–70s led to a crisis, which heightened social tensions throughout the continent. The end of the Cold War was a key factor as well. Faced with the serious economic problems that their policies had created, and with the communist threat abated by the collapse of the Soviet Union, the military regimes of South America began handing over political power to civilian leaders in the late 1980s and early 1990s in a wave of “democratization” across the continent. Military rulers in Argentina, Brazil, Chile, and elsewhere handed over power to elected civilian leaders. In each of these countries the military’s presence certainly remained strong, but if there is one positive consequence that has come from the disastrous economic policies pursued by South America’s generals in the 1960s–70s it is this transition to a more democratic, civilian-based political system in recent decades throughout the continent (though with some exceptions as we will see).

Venezuela

Venezuela with its capital Caracas has a population of 28.3mn as of 2023. The vast Orinoco River system with its many tributaries dissects the country's interior, which is comprised of a mix of tropical forests and grasslands in a mountainous terrain as Venezuela lies in the shadows and foothills of the Andes Mountains. The large Lake Maracaibo is in the country's northwestern corner. Regarding its ethnic composition Venezuela has a majority (about 51%) of mixed Native American and European descent with a "white" minority (around 43%) of more purely European heritage, which as elsewhere in Latin America tends also to be the country's wealthiest segment, and a small (3.6%) minority of African ancestry.

Venezuela was the birthplace of the man who turned the Spanish Empire on its head: Simón Bolívar, the great hero of Latin America's anti-colonial struggle, whose name echoes through history down to the modern day. With the help of British mercenaries, Bolívar and his army marched across the Andes and liberated Colombia from Spanish rule in 1819, Venezuela in 1821, and Ecuador, Peru, and Bolivia in 1825. Much of his army was comprised of native Venezuelans. Independence from the Spanish, however, did not bring peace and prosperity to Venezuela (or the region as a whole); civil strife, conflict, and dictatorships were the norm in the country well into the next century.

A key turning point in Venezuelan history was the discovery of oil in 1914; by the 1920s Venezuela was beginning to reap the benefits, but most of the wealth generated from the oil was in the hands of foreign oil executives and the country's small ruling class. One dictator after another ruled—most of them amassing great wealth in the process—until 1947 when Rómulo Betancourt, the "father of Venezuelan democracy," led a popular revolt and rewrote Venezuela's constitution. He ruled as president for two terms: 1945–48 and 1959–64. There were still several military coups in between and afterward and by no means was Venezuela's political system a smooth-running democracy throughout this era, but at least Betancourt had raised that possibility and the consciousness of his countrymen of the need for democracy.

Oil remained the backbone of Venezuela's economy, especially after the discovery of major new fields in the late 1940s and the 1950s (mostly Mobil, Exxon, Chevron, and Shell were involved in producing and exporting Venezuelan oil). Betancourt pushed for the nationalization of Venezuela's oil fields (much like his contemporary Muhammad Mosaddegh in Iran) but was unable to achieve that goal because of internal opposition and staunch resistance from the (mostly) US-owned oil companies operating in the country. When Betancourt assumed office for his first term in 1945 Venezuela received a mere 20% of the revenue generated from its oil, but he changed that to a fifty-fifty split. When he took office for a second time in 1959, he changed that ratio again so that Venezuela received a sixty-forty share of oil revenues.

By 1960 Venezuela was among the world's largest producers and exporters of oil and natural gas and became a founding member of OPEC, whose role and importance we have touched on. The oil boom stemming from the OPEC Embargo in the 1973 War in the Middle East, the significance of which we have also already touched on, saw enormous wealth pour into Venezuela. As usual, however, the benefits of that wealth were poorly distributed, and the vast lower class gained little. In 1976 Venezuela's President Carlos Andrés Pérez "nationalized"—sort of—Venezuela's oil, giving rise to the country's massive nationally-owned oil company *Petróleos de Venezuela S.A.* (PDVSA) comprised of smaller Venezuelan enterprises in place of the foreign oil companies that once did business in the country. However, in reality these "national" Venezuelan companies simply substituted for the foreign-owned entities, maintaining the structures and functions of the multi-national corporation preceding them with little change, except that now more members of the Venezuelan elite were in positions to profit from their roles in the newly created PDVSA.

The Rise of Hugo Chávez

In the 1970s a young military officer, Hugo Chávez, was working his way through the ranks of the Venezuelan Army. Chávez was born in 1954 to a poor family in a small town along the eastern slopes of the Andes Mountains. In his youth Chávez earned money walking the streets of his hometown selling homemade candy; he later attributed his difficult childhood, including frequent beatings by his mother, for giving him a strong affinity for the down-trodden and impoverished and an equally strong disdain for the wealthy. As a teenager his father secured an opportunity for him to join the Venezuelan Military Academy, granting him the chance at a quality education. Chávez graduated in 1975 and joined the army at age twenty as a Second Lieutenant, gradually working his way up through the ranks from there. Chávez became acquainted with other young military officers from similar backgrounds who shared his concern for the poor. They secretly formed the Bolivarian Movement (named for South America's great liberator Simón Bolívar) of mostly young officers concerned about the country's economic problems, namely inequality, poverty, and corruption.

Those problems worsened in Venezuela with the decrease in oil prices on the global market in the 1980s and a growing national debt problem—another issue we have already touched on—for the country. Re-elected in 1989 to a second non-consecutive term (his first being 1974–79), Venezuelan President Carlos Andrés Pérez accepted a \$4.5bn IMF loan with strings attached in the form of austerity measures, including massive cuts in social spending, a devaluation of the currency, and a very significant increase in interest rates designed to attract foreign investment (but often at the expense of domestic businesses). These measures were very unpopular among an already impoverished population (in a country with massive oil wealth) and

protests ensued, which the government violently repressed, leaving hundreds dead. Among the troops called upon to put down these protests was a young Hugo Chávez (along with his comrades in the Bolivarian Movement), and although they fulfilled their orders, they decided to act soon in the long-term interests of the country (as they perceived them).

Three years later officers in the Bolivarian Movement attempted a coup against the extremely unpopular government of President Pérez. Chávez led troops trying to overthrow the government in the capital Caracas while other leaders of the movement led the coup in other cities. The coup attempt succeeded everywhere *but* Caracas; the other leaders of the Bolivarian Movement, thinking that they had succeeded in overthrowing Pérez's corrupt and unpopular government, were shocked to learn that Chávez had surrendered in the capital. They felt betrayed and thought that Chávez had surrendered too easily and prematurely, although Chávez did so with one condition: that he be allowed to address the population on national television. This speech by a young military officer (at the time Chávez was thirty-seven) no one knew proved to be *the* key turning point in his political career—he was catapulted onto the national stage by giving an extremely effective statement that appealed to the country's poor. "We have failed for now," he told his countrymen, "but we have not given up the struggle!" The speech gave him notoriety and fame overnight as this young unknown officer who had led a failed coup was carted off to jail by an unpopular government—in one fell swoop he became a hero, a victim of the regime, the face of the opposition, and the voice of the poor. The coup had failed, but for Chávez personally it was also a great success.

In the aftermath of the failed coup the Venezuelan government sentenced Chávez to a long prison term, but he only served two-and-a-half years before being pardoned and released (along with his other co-conspirators in the coup) in 1994 by a new left-leaning president who won the election that year in part because of his promise to free Chávez. Upon his release Chávez immediately began his political career, gathering supporters for the upcoming election of 1998. He benefited from the country's continuing economic mess as oil prices remained low throughout the late 1990s, and he proved very adept at running a media-driven campaign—he became the darling of the Venezuelan media. Chávez won the country's 1998 election in a landslide.

Declaring himself a socialist, Chávez's main promise to Venezuelan voters was to share the country's vast oil wealth with the poor, and he took office in February 1999 with that goal in mind. He passed the Oil Law doubling the amount of royalties paid by PDVSA to the government. He also passed a land reform law allowing the confiscation and redistribution of land to landless peasants. Both policies were extremely popular among his supporters but equally unpopular among his detractors as the country became increasingly polarized.

In April 2002 thousands of opponents to these policies marched to Caracas to demand that Chávez resign. Military officers loyal to the

opposition arrested him and a wealthy businessman (a former IMF banker) was sworn in as president and immediately recognized by the US Bush Jr. administration, which some evidence implicates in the coup. Thus, it appeared as though Chávez's rule would be short-lived. However, huge numbers of Chávez supporters from the shantytowns and slums of Caracas and the surrounding areas flooded the city to demand his return to power and amid the massive protests Chávez was restored to power about forty-eight hours after the coup began in a tremendous vindication for him and for Venezuelan democracy. The US role in these events remains unclear, but Chávez blamed US imperialism for his dismissal and for all the country's other many woes as well.

Later that year (2002) Chávez faced another very different challenge: oil workers in PDVSA went on strike, literally all of them from the top administrator to the workers in the field. The strike continued for months with devastating effects on the economy—it looked as though Chávez would be forced out of power owing to the strike, despite the results of the coup. But then a group of oil smugglers loyal to Chávez broke the strike by surreptitiously producing oil and gas and smuggling it out of the country; PDVSA backed down and ended the strike as Chávez won again. He subsequently fired and replaced about half of the company's workforce, mainly those in top administrative positions.

In 2004 the parliamentary opposition to Chávez tried again to have him removed from power, this time through democratic means, but he again prevailed. He won re-election in 2006 with the highest percentage of the vote of any candidate since 1958—since the beginning of Venezuelan democracy with the second reign of Betancourt. International observers agreed that the election was free and unmarred by fraud. Following this 2006 election, however, Chávez canceled the license of the television station (RCTV) that had mainly opposed his bid for re-election, causing some consternation even among his supporters because of the obvious free speech implications of such a move. He began to clamp down more and more on any form of opposition to his rule.

At the same time, Chávez remained tremendously popular among the poor by expanding Venezuela's social welfare system, using funds from record high oil prices on the international market in the late 2000s and early 2010s to do so. He used the government's increased oil revenue to improve health care services for the poor, subsidize housing costs, and in 2011 he launched the "Great Sons of Venezuela Mission" allowing poor income households to claim about \$100 a month for each child up to three. The program also expanded benefits to the disabled and elderly as well. Chávez hosted a weekly television program in which he attacked political opponents around the world, primarily the US. In 2011 Chávez announced that he was battling cancer but that he still intended to run for re-election the following year (a Constitutional Amendment passed in 2009 ended term limits, allowing him to run again). He ran despite battling cancer and won the election with about

55% of the vote. He was inaugurated for a third term in January 2013 but died just two months later.

Venezuela Since Chávez

Vice-president Nicolás Maduro, who at one time had been Chávez's driver, took over and won an election to succeed Chávez as the country's president. Maduro clearly benefited from the Chávez sympathy vote and rode his coattails to power. He blamed the US/CIA for allegedly poisoning Chávez and giving him cancer, an accusation that the US State Department dismissed as "absurd." Maduro inherited a mess from Chávez; by the mid-2010s oil prices on the world market had fallen sharply and despite Chávez's promises and efforts to share the oil wealth more evenly, poverty and corruption remained huge problems in the country. Caracas had one of the highest crime rates in Latin America along with many other problems (in the first decade of Chávez's rule between 1999–2009 there were over 2,000 kidnappings in Venezuela; robberies and murder were likewise huge problems in the country). Maduro, who lacks Chávez's charisma, faced major protests against his rule and the country's continuing economic woes—especially inflation—in 2014, only a year into his presidency, and again in 2017.

Venezuela remained highly dependent on oil revenues, which in 2009 accounted for roughly 90% of export earnings, about half of the federal budget revenues, and around 30% of the country's GDP. For decades the main recipient of Venezuela's oil exports was the US, which imported an estimated 1.5bn barrels of oil per day in the late 2000s, although both Russia, itself an oil-rich country, and China have imported larger shares of Venezuelan oil since 2010. Opposition to Maduro's government led to harsh US sanctions against Venezuela in the 2010s; in 2019 the first Trump administration banned any US companies or individuals from doing business with PDVSA. As a result, the country's oil exports to the US, which provided the Maduro government with its largest source of income, plummeted by an estimated 40%; Russia's *Rosneft* oil company and China both increased their imports of Venezuelan oil in response, but not enough to make up for the lost revenue coming from sales to the US. Consequently, Venezuela's economy began to suffer even more than before. An estimated 7.7mn Venezuelans have fled the country in the past decade, mostly to Columbia, Brazil, and Chile, because of the country's economic and political turmoil.

Venezuela faced a major presidential crisis owing to accusations that Maduro's re-election in 2018 was fraudulent. The Venezuelan National Assembly refused to acknowledge Maduro's January 2019 inauguration for a second term as president, although he went through with it anyway. With the backing of the National Assembly, as well as the US, Juan Guaidó declared himself the legitimate president of the country. Massive anti-government protests called by Guaidó and his supporters met in Caracas to demand Maduro's resignation. Maduro responded by calling a pro-government

demonstration also in Caracas in honor of the twentieth anniversary of Hugo Chávez's rise to power. Guaidó called on Venezuelan military leaders to defect from the government; a couple did so but most did not. The military stuck with Maduro and thus he has remained in power.

When he became president in 1999 Chávez followed the example of Cuba's revolutionary President Fidel Castro by purging the military leadership of figures he considered disloyal to his new government. He carried out a second such "cleansing" of the military after the failed 2002 coup against him. Following also the example of Indonesia's Sukarno as discussed in an earlier chapter, in 2009 Chávez also created and armed a People's Militia as a counter to the Venezuelan military, the loyalty of which he apparently continued to question. Finally, Chávez also adopted the Egyptian model of greatly rewarding the country's military leaders; Venezuela has the highest per capital number of generals (3,000) of any country in the world, and they are granted early "retirement" and plum positions with high returns in state-controlled industries, especially the PDVSA. As a result, most of the military remained loyal first to Chávez, and now to Maduro, who inherited this system.

In July 2024 elections Maduro allegedly won with about 52% of the vote, though again the legitimacy of the results was called into question. Edmundo González, who reportedly lost the election with around 43% of the vote, declared himself Venezuela's legitimate president on the eve of the January 2025 inauguration, a scenario very similar to that of Maduro vs. Guaidó six years earlier. On January 10, 2025, Maduro was inaugurated for a third term amid accusations of fraud. The leaders of the Group of Seven, the US, UK, France, Canada, Germany, Italy, and Japan declared the election illegitimate, as did several Latin American states, including Chile and Argentina. They also criticized the Maduro regime's growing crackdowns against opposition. For now, Maduro remains in power amid a very challenging situation in Venezuela.

Argentina

Argentina, with its capital at Buenos Aires and a population of 45.5mn as of 2023, is mostly located in the vast South American plain and is great herding country, thus it has a prosperous agricultural economy based on livestock, with beef and dairy products (along with other agricultural goods) remaining important exports for decades. Argentina is unique on the continent regarding its ethnic composition as most of its population (about 97%) are of European (mostly Spanish and Italian) or mixed European and Native American descent.

Argentina initiated ISI policies mostly after World War II. The industrialization of the country during the 1930s and (mostly) during and after World War II led to a rapid growth of the urban working class. The country underwent a familiar pattern of economic development, with peasants lured

to the cities to work in factories. Workers began to organize and demand better pay and conditions, and their presence as a political voice in society increased dramatically. In 1943 a young military officer who had worked his way up through the ranks, Juan Perón, took power in a coup. He had gained popularity as Labor Minister by improving wages and working conditions. Initially he was jailed but labor unions organized protests demanding his release and a massive rally in his honor signaled his rise to power. A major help to Juan Perón in his climb to the top was his wife Eva (Evita), who was from a peasant family. Evita Perón herself became a major political figure in the country during her husband's rule. She organized and led a vast charity network and rallied support for women's suffrage, granted in 1948, after which she organized a Women's Party.

The Peróns were populist leaders. The term "populism" is vague and difficult to define; it is rule based on popular support, but not necessarily on a democratic foundation. While Perón raised living standards for workers early in his rule, he also built up the army and police and ruled dictatorially. His government has been loosely compared to those of Benito Mussolini (Italy, 1922–43) and Francisco Franco (Spain, 1936–75) in Europe—rulers who enjoyed a lot of popularity, at least at times among some of the population, but who also relied on harsh police repression of political opponents, especially when their popularity waned.

Evita died of cancer in 1952 and by the mid-1950s Juan Perón's popularity declined as his economic policies led to difficulty. The main problem undermining his program was inflation, which made the pay hikes to workers meaningless because ever-rising prices annulled any gain in wages. Military leaders overthrew Perón in a coup in 1955. Juan Perón returned to power briefly in 1973 before his death the following year, when his second wife, Isabel, replaced him. Perón's legacy remains significant in Argentine politics to this day (political parties are often either defined as Peronist or anti-Peronist).

Argentina's "Dirty War" and After

For most of the period 1966–83, military dictatorships ruled Argentina, rolling back some of the gains made by workers and others during the populist era (a military coup overthrew Isabel Perón's government in 1976). The military rulers crushed labor organizations, froze wages, sold off public services, and sought foreign investment. These military regimes responded to leftist guerrilla movements against their rule with increasing repression, ordering the "disappearance" of thousands of suspected dissidents in Argentina's so-called "Dirty War" (1976–82). Military officials took some of the "disappeared" in helicopters above the ocean and pushed them to their deaths below.

In 1982 Argentine military leaders embarked on a foolhardy military venture against Great Britain for control of the disputed Falkland Islands off the coast of Argentina. Great Britain won the brief war and, humiliated by the

affair, Argentina's military rulers stepped down in favor of a transition to civilian rule in 1983, leaving the new government with tons of foreign debt and the issue of whether or not the generals who led the Dirty War should be punished. Even before the transition to civilian rule a group of women in Argentina, "Mothers of the Disappeared," protested and demanded accountability for the repression of thousands, but the civilian government pardoned the instigators of the Dirty War.

A major economic crisis in the late 1990s overshadowed problems associated with the Dirty War and Argentina's political past. President Saúl Menem, who was elected in 1989 and re-elected in 1995, applied economic austerity measures in line with IMF/World Bank prescriptions to deal with the country's economic problems. As we have seen, these included reducing subsidies for the poor, privatizing state-owned companies, and reducing government regulation of businesses. In 1991 the government fixed the country's currency, the Argentine peso, at a one-to-one rate with the US dollar as a way of combating hyperinflation. The policy worked for a while and brought inflation under control. However, maintaining the policy for a long period of time proved disastrous owing to the fact that the US dollar (and thus the Argentine peso) became overvalued, which led to higher and higher interest rates in the Argentine economy thereby stifling domestic investment. Moreover, the impact of the so-called "Asian flu," the economic crisis that, as we have seen, began in the Pacific Rim countries in 1997 but spread from there throughout the international economy, led to a prolonged recession in Argentina and an economic collapse of catastrophic proportions in the country in the late 1990s and early 2000s.

In 2000 the IMF responded to the growing economic crisis in Argentina, hoping to make sure it did not spread throughout the region, by granting the country an additional \$40bn loan, although, of course, with strings attached, most notably requiring the government to balance its budget. Nonetheless, growth in Argentina's economy in 2000 was a negative 0.5%, as both domestic and foreign investors remained skeptical of the government's ability to pay its debts and maintain the peso's fixed exchange rate with the US dollar. The economic situation worsened in 2001 with massive cash withdrawals from the banks, leading to an extended period of government-proposed bank closings at one point and a further decline in consumer and investor confidence. Government efforts to achieve a "zero deficit" in accordance with IMF stipulations, to stabilize the banking system, and to restore economic growth proved inadequate in the face of the mounting economic problems. The peso's peg to the dollar was finally abandoned in early 2002, and the exchange rate plunged as a result, with inflation picking up and eating away at the population's savings and real wages. In 2001 production was 14.7% below the previous year's figure, while unemployment remained at a very high rate of 21.5%.

The country's economic mess had political reverberations. Menem stepped down in 1999 amid accusations of corruption, leading to a revolving door

of leadership with several governments resigning amid the crisis between 2000–02. The economic situation in Argentina gradually stabilized over the next few years, especially after the election in May 2003 of Néstor Kirchner, whose campaign against government corruption returned some confidence to the economy. In the summer of 2007 Kirchner announced that he would not run for re-election, however his wife, Cristina Kirchner, ran and served as President for two terms, until December 2015. She was succeeded by the center-right Mauricio Macri, who lost his 2019 bid for re-election to the more left-leaning Alberto Fernandez. Former President Cristina Kirchner served as his Vice-President, and many believed that she was the true power behind the scenes. Fernandez decided not to run for re-election in 2023, and Javier Gerardo Milei, described as a right-wing populist, won the presidency. In February 2025 a scandal broke amid allegations of fraud against President Milei for his brief promotion of the \$LIBRA cryptocurrency, the value of which collapsed within hours of its launch earlier that month. Milei distanced himself from the scandal and said he acted in good faith.

Chile

Chile, with its capital at Santiago and a population of about 19.8mn as of 2024, is a very long, very thin country on the continent's southwestern coast that runs between the Andes Mountains and the Pacific Ocean. In length Chile stretches 2,635 miles, but nowhere is the country more than 255 miles wide. The Andes Mountains are the main physical feature of Chile. They are some of the highest mountains in the world (second to the Himalayas). The Andes run through central Peru and down the spine of Chile, separating it from and forming its border with Bolivia and much of Argentina. The humid central part of the country in and around Santiago has the country's best agricultural land and is home to approximately 75% of the population. Only about 8% of the land area in Chile is used for the cultivation of crops, whereas about twice that amount is used for herding cattle, another important aspect of the economy. Like Argentina, Chile has a largely homogeneous population with an estimated 95% of its people being of mixed European (Spanish) and Native American origin. The remaining 5% are more purely native, but racial intermixture over the centuries makes the distinctions there less clear than in other South American countries.

Chile is unique on the continent in political terms because of its long-running democratic system based on civilian rule, and in economic terms because, while its landholdings were divided into large estates like the other colonies/countries, its most important economic resource has historically been its mineral wealth, particularly copper. Chile also has very rich deposits of coal, gold, iron ore, nitrates, and other valuable minerals. It was these raw materials, rather than cash crops, that Chile mostly exported on the international market in the colonial era. Like the rest of the continent, Chile adopted an ISI policy during the Great Depression of the 1930s when

demand for its mineral exports decreased. Following the general pattern of developments on the continent, Chile between 1930–60 entered a phase of industrialization and urbanization that brought dramatic social changes with increased political power for the urban working class. Economic growth slowed in the 1960s, giving way to high inflation and a dramatic drop in living standards for the working class. Thus, the 1960s saw a retreat from ISI in Chile (as elsewhere in South America) and a return to the export of raw materials (minerals) as the mainstay of economic development. US-owned mining companies, in particular the Kennecott Copper Company and the Anaconda Copper Company, invested heavily in Chile and by the mid-1960s controlled about 75% of the country's copper production.

A decade of economic woes led to a major political showdown in Chile's 1970 elections. The candidate of the incumbent centrist Christian Democratic Party, Radomiro Tomic, faced a conservative former president of the National Party, Jorge Alessandri, and a Socialist opponent, Salvador Allende, who won the elections by a slight plurality. Allende won despite the fact that the US tried to sway the elections by contributing an estimated \$2mn (including both CIA and private contributions) to the campaigns of his opponents, something that would be illegal if done in a US election. Allende stated that his goal was to "make Chile a socialist state through peaceful and democratic means." However, he would never achieve that goal for two reasons: his own policies, which led to economic chaos, and opposition from the US.

Following Allende's 1970 electoral victory the Nixon administration was determined to oust the Marxist leader from power even before he took office. A CIA document dated mid-September 1970, after Allende's election but prior to his early November inauguration, reads "President Nixon had decided that an Allende regime in Chile was not acceptable to the United States. The President asked the Agency [CIA] to prevent Allende from coming to power or to unseat him," allocating \$10mn for this purpose. A second CIA memo dated a month later reiterated the goal: "It is firm and continuing policy that Allende be overthrown in a coup ... We are to continue to generate maximum pressure to this end utilizing every appropriate resource." One problematic figure in the plan for a coup was Chilean General René Schneider, Commander of the Chilean Armed Forces. Schneider said repeatedly that while he did not support Allende's socialist views, he did support Chilean democracy and thus would not help carry out a coup. He was assassinated in October 1970, not long after Allende's election, and the CIA has been heavily implicated in his death because he refused to overthrow Allende. Based on documentation since unearthed, a CIA-led operation called for Schneider to be kidnapped and either convinced to help with a coup or be replaced, but the plan went awry and he was killed instead.

Once in power, Allende's first major policy change was to raise the minimum wage in industry by a very dramatic 66%. This raised living standards in the short term and won him widespread popularity among the working class, but it also led to a decrease in investment in industry, an increase in

unemployment, and a dramatic rise in inflation. Thus, over a relatively short period of time much of the initial rise in living standards for the working class resulting from the increased minimum wage was eaten away by inflation.

In 1971 Allende made his most dramatic move, one that would put him very much at odds with the US: he nationalized the country's copper mines. The Allende government promised compensation to foreign companies, such as Kennecott and Anaconda (also International Telephone & Telegraph, ITT, as Allende nationalized the country's communications infrastructure too), but these companies refused to negotiate a settlement. Then Allende changed his mind, and, arguing that the companies had taken "excess profits" (profits more than the legally allowed 10% on investment per year) out of the country since 1955, withdrew the offer to compensate, further alienating the US government.

The US instigated an international campaign to isolate Chile. The US and Canada began mining more copper at home, leading to a drop in the price of copper on the international market, which further compounded the Allende government's growing economic problems. An embargo imposed by the US, the country Chile had previously been dependent upon, meant that spare parts and materials needed for industrial production could not be attained, and gradually the economy ground to a halt. Inflation within Chile led to strikes, especially among miners and truckers, who were important for getting the mined products to the coast for export. A 1975 US Congressional investigation (the Church Commission Report) revealed that between 1971–73 the CIA spent an estimated \$8mn to destabilize Allende's government, most of the money going to pay striking truck drivers so that they could prolong their strike.

In the summer of 1973 workers in the country began spontaneously taking over factories even though Allende tried to stop them from doing so. In early autumn, sensing that the army did not support Allende's government, militant labor unionists called on Allende to supply them with weapons, which he refused to do. During this time the US covertly provided funds and weapons to the Chilean army, and in the end the army decided the country's fate. On September 11, 1973, with full US support, General Augusto Pinochet, Commander-in-Chief of the Chilean armed forces (having replaced Schneider in that position), overthrew Allende's democratically-elected government in a coup. Following its seizure of power in the country the army arrested thousands of Allende supporters, executing many of them. Allende himself died in the attack on the Presidential Palace. The soccer stadium in Santiago was transformed into a prison, and an estimated 10,000 victims died at the hands of Pinochet's army within the first six months of his rule.

The Pinochet Regime

During the Pinochet years Chile turned to free-market economics on a scale hardly seen beforehand. Led by a group of Chilean economists dubbed the

“Chicago Boys” because they had studied at the University of Chicago, reformists created short-term economic growth by the late 1970s, although the benefits thereof were not distributed widely to the population as a whole. Over time, moreover, the dramatic liberalization of the Chilean economy proved counterproductive, especially with the rise of an increasing debt problem to international investors. Thus, like other military dictators in South America, Pinochet oversaw economic policies that led to crisis by the mid-1980s. By the end of the decade these policies, compounded by the aforementioned debt problem, created major economic woes for the Chilean people.

Hoping to hang on to power despite the wave of democratization sweeping South America, in 1988 Pinochet promoted a national referendum that would allow him to stay in office for another eight years. However, the population rallied to decisively defeat the referendum and in 1989 Pinochet allowed for the country’s first free elections since 1970, naming himself “senator for life” before stepping down. British officials arrested Pinochet in 1998 while he was on a trip to London for medical care because a handful of European citizens were killed in Chile during his military dictatorship. The British government eventually released him, but he was put on trial upon his return to Chile; accused of some 300 counts including human rights abuses during his reign as well as embezzlement of state funds; he died in 2006 before the completion of his trial.

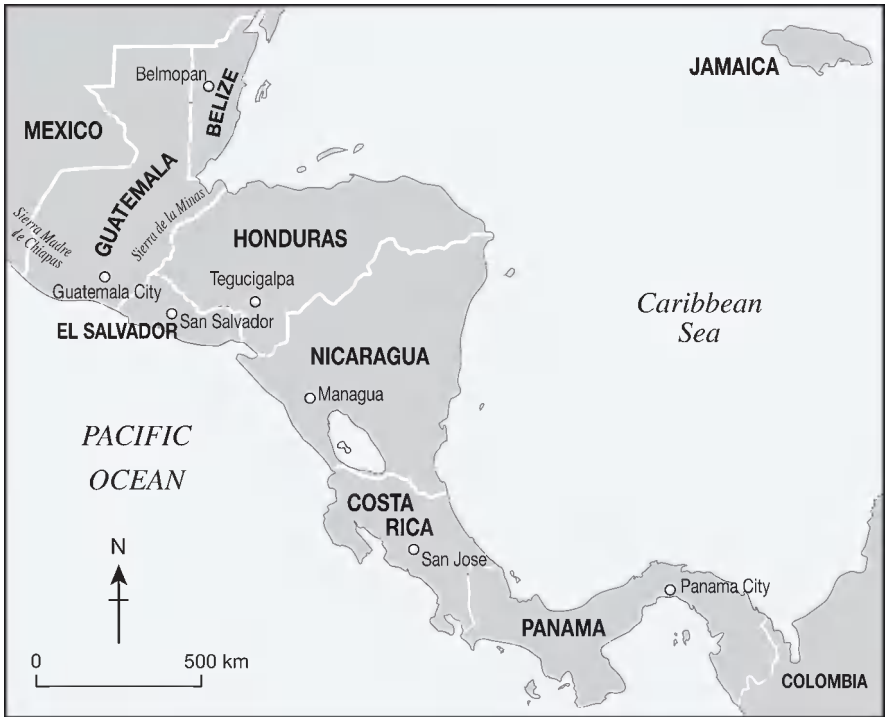
Chile Since Pinochet

In the late 1990s Chile’s democratic government under Eduardo Frei (the son of a president in the 1960s) and its free-market economy were seen as a model for developing countries, as growth in the country’s real Gross Domestic Product (GDP) averaged about 8% between 1991–97. However, Chile, like the rest of the region, was hit by the international economic problems of the late 1990s (the so-called “Asian Flu”), and in 1998 GDP growth fell by half to around 4%. In 1999 Chile experienced negative economic growth for the first time in more than fifteen years, but by early 2000 (unlike the situation in Argentina) exports and economic activity had begun to recover, with growth rebounding to 5.4% for that year. Unemployment, however, remained stubbornly high while the Argentine financial meltdown put pressure on the Chilean peso and slowed the country’s economic growth.

The economic problems in Chile in the late 1990s, though not nearly as severe as those in Argentina, led to political change: Ricardo Lagos Escobar of the opposition Socialist Party won Chile’s 1999 elections. Lagos distanced himself from Allende’s legacy, as did fellow socialist Michelle Bachelet when she won elections in 2006. Following Bachelet’s term (the Chilean Constitution does not allow for two consecutive terms, though presidents can run for a second term later), the conservative Sebastián Piñera won in 2010, followed again by Bachelet in 2014, followed again by Piñera in 2018 in a

bit of a revolving door presidency. Massive street protests against the rising cost of living and income inequality in Chile erupted in Santiago in 2019, prompting Piñera to declare a state of emergency. The National Congress decided to hold a referendum to create a new constitution partly because aspects of the constitution integrated from the Pinochet years locked in strategies of economic liberalization and free-market policies that many Chileans felt favored the wealthy and maintained economic disparities in the country. The vote for the referendum was postponed because of the Covid pandemic, but when held in 2021 a large majority of the country (about 78%) voted in favor of writing a new constitution for Chile, although voter turnout was low, estimated at just over 50%.

Piñera's second term in office proved difficult as he faced massive protests, Covid, and an effort by the opposition to impeach him owing to accusations of corruption revealed in the Pandora Papers, a massive release of documents showing world leaders, businessmen, and others engaged in large-scale economic fraud. Some of the materials implicated Piñera in shady dealings, causing national outrage, but the attempt to impeach him, which passed in the lower house, failed to pass the two-thirds required in the higher house of Congress and he was spared impeachment. He could not run again (and probably did not want to) in the country's 2022 elections, which were won by a 35-year-old socialist and former student protest leader, Gabriel Boric, who thereby became the world's youngest leader. However, Chilean voters dealt their young president a major political defeat when the commission created to write the country's new constitution, which Boric strongly supported, presented it to the population in a referendum in early 2023 and the majority rejected it. Later that year in December voters also rejected a second, much more moderate draft constitution. The future of the constitutional rewrite remains unclear. Piñera meanwhile sadly died in a helicopter crash in early 2024. Chile has come a long way since the Cold War era and the struggle between Allende and Pinochet, but it seems to be in many ways as divided as ever.



Map 16.1 Map of Central America.

16 Central America

Guatemala and Nicaragua

Central America encompasses the region between Mexico and Columbia and was home to some advanced civilizations prior to the arrival of Europeans in the sixteenth century. The Mayans lived in southern Mexico along the Yucatan Peninsula and further south into Guatemala. After the Mayans, the Aztecs rose to prominence in Mexico and Central America. Like much of South America (with the exception of Brazil), the Spanish colonized Central America (conquering the Aztec Empire in order to do so) in the sixteenth through the early nineteenth centuries, gearing the economy toward the production of cash crops and the extraction of raw materials. Unlike South America, in the case of Central America the Europeans did not bring in large numbers of African slaves, relying instead on Native Americans for labor. Colonialism set the region's position within the international economy that largely still holds—producers of cash crops and raw materials—although some small factories producing mainly textiles and other light manufacturing items for mostly Western markets have appeared in the last few decades.

An important theme in Central American history is the region's ethnic diversity, which breaks down along economic lines similar to South America: a wealthy landowning class of Spanish descent at the top of the social order; a mixed Native American and Spanish group in the middle of the social and economic order, often comprising an educated urban middle class; and a large mostly rural Native American population at the bottom of the socio-economic order. The numbers vary from country to country; Guatemala has by far the largest Native American population in Central America, Costa Rica the largest percentage of those of more direct European heritage, while El Salvador, Nicaragua, Honduras, and Panama have larger mixed European and Native American populations.

The US has historically played a pivotal role in the history of Central America, even prior to the Cold War. In the first decades of the twentieth century the US intervened militarily in the affairs of Central American countries no less than thirty-seven times (depending on how one defines military intervention). At some point in the early twentieth century (between 1900–32), the US occupied all the countries of Central America and the Caribbean

except for Belize, Costa Rica, and Mexico, which US troops invaded but did not occupy during the era of the Mexican Revolution in the 1910s. US President Franklin Roosevelt withdrew US troops from the region in 1933, partly to save funds, and launched a “Good Neighbor” policy promising non-intervention and non-interference in those countries’ internal affairs. The US mostly held to the former promise by no longer intervening militarily in the affairs of Central American countries, with the notable exception of the US invasion of Panama in 1989. However, in the Cold War era following World War II, the US definitely did *not* hold to its promise of non-interference, meddling quite substantially as we will see in the affairs of Guatemala, as well as in El Salvador, Honduras, Nicaragua, and of course Panama. Thus, the theme of US involvement in Central America is a very important one.

Guatemala

Guatemala, with its capital at Guatemala City, is the most populous country in Central America with a population of slightly over 18mn as of 2023. It is a very mountainous country with large plains on either side of the mountains running down the spine of the country. As noted, the country has a high percentage of native population, about 60%. Guatemala’s Native American population is divided into countless small ethnic groups, over fifty different groups by most estimates, for whom Spanish is not their native language. The native population resides mostly in the mountains where they engage in subsistence agriculture. To supplement their meager incomes (and raise money needed to pay for their small plots of land and pay taxes), they also work as seasonal laborers on Guatemala’s vast fruit, sugar, and coffee estates in the north and on the country’s coastal plains in the southwest.

Historically, since its independence from Spain in 1821, a small land-owning class of Spanish descent (about 5% or 6%), “ladinos” as they are derogatorily called by the natives, ruled the country. They maintained an alliance with the US government and specific US companies and derived their wealth from the coastal plantations and seasonal labor of native migrant workers. A significant mixed white and native population, mostly educated urban professionals and workers, makes up about 35% of the country’s population. For decades the majority of the Native American population in the country’s mountainous interior spoke one or more of numerous native languages and tended not to speak Spanish. That has begun to change in recent decades as it is now more common for them to speak Spanish in addition to their native language(s).

A US-Made Coup

In 1954 the US intervened very directly in Guatemala’s internal affairs. The backstory began a decade earlier, during World War II in 1944 amid the first free elections in the country’s history. The elections followed the

overthrow of Guatemala's dictator, Jorge Ubico, who found Hitler's fascist dictatorship based on racist ideology appealing, which is not surprising given Guatemala's history of dictatorship based on a racially stratified social system. Thus, Ubico voiced his support for the German cause during the war, thereby alienating Guatemala's powerful neighbor to the north, the traditional patron of Central American dictators, the US. It is unclear the extent to which his overthrow was the work of the US Office of Strategic Services (OSS), wartime predecessor to the CIA, but there is evidence to suggest that the OSS had a hand in Ubico's overthrow. In any case, he was overthrown, and the fact that he was not replaced by another dictator, the usual pattern in Guatemalan politics up to that point, shows the influence of the war: the Western allies were fighting for democracy around the globe, and Ubico's overthrow posed the perfect opportunity to introduce democratic elections into Guatemala.

However, to the surprise and dismay of the US, a populist leader with alleged leftist leanings, Juan Arévalo, won Guatemala's 1944 elections with over 86% of the vote running on a vague party platform calling for "spiritual socialism." Arévalo was by most accounts a moderate who actually banned Guatemala's small communist party and deported communists, but his administration began two important reforms in the late 1940s that worried US leaders: the nationalization (taking over state control from private owners, often foreign companies) of key sectors of the economy, and a limited policy of land redistribution. The US State Department saw both policies as infringements on property rights (much of the property affected by the reforms was owned by US business interests), and as too radical in nature. In 1948, with the Cold War in its early stages, the US broke off diplomatic relations with Guatemala's new democratically-elected government, refused to sell weapons to the Arévalo government, and encouraged its allies to do the same. In the next round of elections in 1952, Arévalo's associate, Jacobo Arbenz, won after the assassination of his main opponent, a right-wing military official. The US feared that Arbenz was even more radical and left-leaning than his predecessor Arévalo. Arbenz sped up the pace of land reform begun by Arévalo and lifted the ban on the Guatemalan Communist Party (which was very small, with only about 4,000 members by 1954), allowing it to operate openly, two moves that quickly won him the ire of the US amid growing Cold War tensions.

The issue of land reform proved to be the crucial test of US-Guatemalan relations under Arbenz's presidency. His 1952 Agrarian Reform Law, a program of nationalizing unused land and redistributing it to Guatemala's peasants, brought him into conflict with the United Fruit Company (UFCo), the largest US-owned enterprise in Central America. By 1950 UFCo was Guatemala's largest employer with over 10,000 workers and was the country's largest landowner, owning roughly one-third of the land in Guatemala, mostly along the coastal plains in the north and southwest. The company left much of the land that it owned in the country untilled to deny competitors

access to fertile land. The Agrarian Reform Law called for the nationalization *only* of land not in use, exempting plantations in full production.

The law also offered compensation to the owners for the land that would be nationalized, although with a significant catch: compensation would be based on the value of the land as fixed by the owners' own current tax assessments. The Guatemalan government, in other words, agreed to pay what the owners themselves had estimated the land to be worth on their most recent tax statements. The problem with this from the owners' point of view is that they had traditionally underestimated the value of their landholdings to pay less taxes, which UFCo had certainly done over the years. As the country's largest landowner, the company was hit hardest by the new law. The Guatemalan government expropriated around 300,000 acres of unused UFCo lands for redistribution to Guatemalan peasants, and, on the basis of the Company's own tax statements, offered \$630,000 in compensation. UFCo, with the backing of the US State Department, objected, claiming that the land was actually worth \$16mn.

The subsequent overthrow of the Arbenz government definitely involved the very direct intervention of the US; it also raises serious questions about the intentions of US leaders at the time during the administration of US President Eisenhower. In probably no other case in post-1945 history has US foreign policy been so tainted by personal interest conflicts involving US business, in this case UFCo (now renamed Chiquita). Specifically, before John Foster Dulles became US Secretary of State under Eisenhower, his law firm had represented UFCo. His brother, Allen Dulles, head of the CIA, which oversaw the operation in Guatemala to overthrow Arbenz, had been a member of the company's board of trustees. Henry Cabot Lodge, head of the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, was one of the largest stockholders in UFCo. The American who headed up the CIA operation against Arbenz's government subsequently became CEO of the company! It is safe to say that UFCo had friends in very high places.

The move that sealed the fate of the Arbenz government was an arms shipment it received in early 1954 from Czechoslovakia, an East European Soviet bloc country. For Arbenz the decision to buy weapons from a Soviet bloc country was a last resort; he tried to make purchases in Cuba (this is before Castro when Cuba was still a US ally), Western Europe, Mexico, and Argentina (under Juan Perón) but the US pressured those countries not to sell arms to Guatemala. So, Arbenz turned to the Soviet bloc to purchase weapons and it was this arms shipment, portrayed propagandistically in the US media as proof that Arbenz was a committed communist, which he was not, that convinced the Eisenhower administration that Arbenz had to go.

The CIA covertly trained a small force of Guatemalan exiles under the command of Colonel Castillo Armas in neighboring Honduras (using UFCo lands), and in June 1954 they crossed into Guatemala and attacked. At first Armas' army did not fare very well, especially since there was no anti-Arbenz uprising of the population as the CIA and Armas had hoped. Two things

decided the course of the operation: Eisenhower dispatched two US Air Force planes to support Armas' ground forces and give the impression that the invasion had the direct backing and involvement of the US military; and the Guatemalan army, especially the Officers Corp that hailed mostly from the country's non-Native elite and had always been wary of Arbenz's reform program, after wavering at first sided with Armas in large numbers, which facilitated the coup. Thus, the operation was a success and would serve as a model for the Bay of Pigs invasion of Cuba several years later in 1961 (which, however, proved to be much less successful).

Guatemalan Civil War

Once in power Castillo Armas canceled the land reform and restored the property of UFCo and other landowners, forcing peasants to vacate their new farms. He also arrested and executed thousands of Arbenz's supporters and passed Spanish literacy qualifications for voting, which eliminated most of the native population from the electoral process since few spoke Spanish and most were illiterate. Armas fell victim to another coup three years later but by that time Guatemala's short-lived democracy was over: for more than the next thirty years Guatemala was ruled by a series of dictators and experienced the Western Hemisphere's longest civil war, as Native Americans (mostly), excluded from the electoral process, took up arms to fight against the government. A defining moment in the long civil war occurred in 1980 when rebels took over and occupied the Spanish Embassy in Guatemala City. The military regime responded by attacking and burning down the embassy, causing the deaths of thirty-six rebels.

The poorly armed natives were no match for the well-trained and US-supplied Guatemalan army, as well as paramilitary death squads that carried out mass executions of suspected rebels and their supporters (almost entirely Native Americans) in the mountains. This was particularly the case during the brief but bloody rule (1982–83) of General Efraín Ríos Montt. By 1989 the civil war had led to an estimated 100,000 deaths and another 40,000 disappearances, the vast majority in both cases Native Americans in the mountains. Despite the human rights abuses of the Guatemalan military dictatorships the US continued to support the regimes with military and financial aid throughout the Cold War era as a bulwark against the spread of communism in the region.

The Guatemalan Civil War finally ended in 1996 with a transition to the country's first truly democratically-elected civilian government in decades (there had been a short-lived civilian government in the late 1960s). In 1998 the UN established a Truth Commission to investigate human rights abuses, including the US role therein, in Guatemala's long and bloody civil war. The 1989 kidnapping, torture, and rape of an American nun working in Guatemala, Dianna Ortiz, by the Guatemalan military, allegedly with the complicity of US military advisors in the country, helped spark the formation

of the commission. Among other things the commission discovered a CIA manual from the 1950s instructing Guatemalan death squads how to carry out assassinations and political murders. The commission's report, released in 1999, concluded that Guatemalan Security Forces were responsible for 93% of all human right atrocities during the country's civil war, carrying out no fewer than 626 massacres in native villages, claiming the lives of about 200,000 people. The report called the Guatemalan government's role in the civil war "genocidal" and strongly condemned US involvement. Following the issuance of the report US President Clinton formally apologized to the people of Guatemala for the role played by the US government in the conflict there.

Guatemala in the Twenty-First Century

Fortunately, to date a democratic form of government has held in Guatemala, albeit amid major economic problems, alarming crime rates and gang activity, and tremendous political tensions and turmoil. Similar to the countries of South America, one issue facing the new democratic government of Guatemala was whether or not to hold accountable those responsible for the many deaths during the country's long civil war. In 2004 the civilian government of Oscar Berger, a businessman and former mayor of Guatemala City, placed former military leader Montt, who had overseen some of the worst of the atrocities during his brief reign in the early 1980s, under house arrest. Amid a soaring murder and crime rate, much of it drug related, center-left candidate Álvaro Colom won the country's 2007 elections (presidents are limited to one-four-year term so Berger could not run again). Two years later the government jailed—for the first time—a key figure in the regime's murderous civil war history, Felipe Cusanero, leader of a paramilitary group ("death squad") during the conflict. Several years later in 2011 a Guatemalan court found four former soldiers guilty of human rights abuses for their role in carrying out a massacre against Native Americans in a mountain village during the civil war.

In a sharp political turn former army General Otto Pérez Molina of the right-wing Patriotic Party, running on a law-and-order campaign amid the country's growing crime rate and drug trade, won Guatemala's 2011 elections. Two years later a Guatemalan court convicted Montt of genocide and human rights abuses, but the country's constitutional court overturned the conviction on appeal. President Molina resigned in 2015 amid accusations of corruption and a former comedian, Ernesto "Jimmy" Morales, won the elections to replace him on a platform to "return to conservative values." Conservative candidate Alejandro Giammettei, former director of the country's penitentiary system, won Guatemala's 2019 elections, defeating his center-left rival Sally Torres.

In November 2020 Giammettei faced massive protests in Guatemala City owing to a controversial budget proposal that, critics argued, largely ignored

the needs of the country's poor. The police brutally crushed the demonstrations, and shortly thereafter someone set the country's Congressional building on fire amid calls for Giammettei to resign. He did not, however, and remained in office despite being immensely unpopular because of the government's mis-handling of the Covid pandemic, the increasing cost of living, an ever-growing crime rate, and accusations of corruption. In 2024 the US barred Giammettei from entering owing to his "involvement in significant corruption" as president, namely "accepting bribes in exchange for the performance of his public functions." Bernardo Arévalo de León, son of Juan Arévalo, former president in the 1950s whose overthrow in the 1954 coup had set the country on such a torturous path in the decades that followed, won Guatemala's 2023 elections. Arévalo, a left-leaning progressive figure, assumed power mid-January 2024.

Nicaragua

With its capital at Managua, Nicaragua has a population of over 6.8mn as of 2023. The mountains in the northern part of Central America are much lower by the time they reach northern Nicaragua, so much of the country is coastal plain. The interior of central and southern Nicaragua is dominated by jungle with thin soil not very well suited to agriculture. Along with Panama, Western businessmen and engineers at one point considered Nicaragua an ideal site for a canal linking the Pacific Ocean and Caribbean Sea because of the huge Lake Nicaragua in the south. However, for a variety of logistical and political reasons they chose Panama as the site for the canal instead.

Like Guatemala, Nicaragua received its independence from Spain in 1821, and like most of the countries of Central America a major theme in Nicaraguan history is US intervention. In the mid-nineteenth century a US businessman, William Walker, invaded Nicaragua with a mercenary force intending to extend slavery into Central America and wound up ruling the country for two years between 1855–57. In the early twentieth century, US Marines invaded Nicaragua several times and occupied the country between 1909–10, 1912–25, and 1926–33. In the late 1920s and early 1930s, Nicaraguan troops under rebel leader Augusto Sandino fought a guerrilla war against US Marines occupying their country.

In 1933 newly elected US President Franklin Roosevelt withdrew US troops from direct involvement in the conflict and installed a pro-US force, the Nicaraguan National Guard, to fight against Sandino instead. The leader of the new US-created and trained National Guard was Anastasio Somoza García. In 1934, with the end of US occupation, Somoza lured Sandino to the country's capital for negotiations and, with the knowledge and complicity of the US ambassador to Nicaragua, had Sandino killed. Somoza took over official leadership of the country in a coup two years later, in 1936, beginning a family dynasty that would last over four decades. For most of that time the Somoza family had strong support and financial aid from the US. Roosevelt's

famous phrase describing the first Somoza was, "He's a son of a bitch, but he's our son of a bitch."

An opponent of the Nicaraguan government assassinated the elder Somoza in 1956, but his son replaced him and continued the dictatorial and corrupt rule instituted by his father. The Cuban Revolution in 1959 had serious repercussions throughout the region and worried the US greatly. As we discussed with regard to Iran, the Kennedy administration of the early 1960s concluded that communism preyed on poverty, so the best way to check or contain the spread of communism was to address the problem of poverty in the region. Consequently, Kennedy began an aid program, geared specifically for the countries of Latin America, dubbed the Alliance for Progress. Modeled very consciously on the Marshall Plan that had proven so successful in rebuilding Western Europe's economy after World War II, the Alliance for Progress, which continued after Kennedy's demise, poured money into the coffers of Central American governments in the 1960s. Nicaragua under the Somozas, staunch anti-communist allies, was one of the main recipients; in just a few years the US loaned Nicaragua \$35mn for economic development projects.

However, there was no mechanism for controlling the distribution and use of the aid money, and the Somoza family and their associates in the Nicaraguan government used the money to expand their own wealth and family holdings at the expense of the population at large. The Nicaraguan government used some of the aid money to build 600 miles of hard-surface roads connecting all the Somoza family's various farms and properties. For those with wealth and power in the country the aid money came at just the right time because a cotton boom had begun in Nicaragua in the early 1950s. A few landowners with connections to the Somoza family used US aid money to buy up more and more land on the country's fertile Pacific coast, displacing peasants and forcing them either into the cities or into the country's interior, where the land was of much lower quality.

In addition, US "aid" money from the Alliance for Progress directly funded the growth of another boom industry in the country, cattle herding. Between 1958–65, Nicaraguan beef exports to the US increased from a negligible level to \$6.7mn and continued to increase rapidly thereafter, reaching \$26.6mn by 1970. The expansion of the cattle industry took place in the Nicaraguan interior where the land was not as fertile as along the coast but was nonetheless suitable for grazing. The area used for pasture doubled between 1960–79, which led to the displacement of peasants producing food crops, many of whom had only recently been displaced by the cotton boom on the coast. This left Nicaragua's peasants with a difficult choice: move further and further into the jungle and engage in slash-and-burn agriculture, after which they faced the threat of displacement again, or move to the cities. Many migrated to the cities, where unemployment was high owing to sluggish industrial growth.

The “Sandinistas” Rebel

Given these developments, by the 1970s the country was a political powder keg of revolutionary sentiments. Formed by three Nicaraguan intellectuals in the early 1960s, the Sandinista National Liberation Front (FSLN), named of course after Augusto Sandino and better known as the “Sandinistas,” had grown by the early-1970s into a formidable military and opposition force. An increasingly intense civil war pitted Sandinista rebels in the countryside against the Nicaraguan National Guard. A devastating earthquake hit Nicaragua in late 1972 and made matters in the country much worse, its impact killing thousands in and around Managua. Aid poured in from countries such as the US and Mexico but was *very* poorly and unevenly distributed by the government, leading to further criticism of the Somoza regime (baseball great Roberto Clemente died in a plane crash delivering supplies to the victims of the earthquake).

After the earthquake support for the Sandinistas grew. The US government as usual played an important role in events. US President Gerald Ford doubled the amount of aid to Somoza, but in 1977 his successor President Carter greatly reduced US aid to Nicaragua because of the Somoza regime’s infamously horrible human rights record—he wanted to make an example of the Somozas. Also, apparently Carter did not consider the FSLN a formidable threat and knew that Somoza would still get the weapons he needed to fight the civil war from Argentina and Israel.

The Sandinistas, however, proved to be a more legitimate force than the US expected, and in 1979 they succeeded in overthrowing the third of three Somoza rulers and instituting a leftist government based on the Cuban model. This was the last successful armed communist takeover of power anywhere in the world in the Cold War era. Carter initially tried to work with the FSLN to assure a voice for moderates in the anti-Somoza movement, but moderates were gradually squeezed out of the ruling junta in favor of a more radical FSLN faction headed by Daniel Ortega. The Sandinistas nationalized the substantial landholdings of the Somoza family and turned them into cooperatives for peasant families; instituted a major health care reform that opened up free clinics throughout the country; and initiated a literacy campaign in the early 1980s. Somoza had basically neglected education, at least for the masses, and the Sandinistas in a relatively short time were able to reduce the illiteracy rate by about half.

The Nicaraguan Revolution caused great concern for the US government, seeing in this event the fulfillment of its worst nightmare—another pro-Soviet, Cuban-like communist regime in “our own backyard,” as US politicians often called Central America. The US Reagan administration, elected in 1980, led a crusade to topple the Sandinistas. In the early 1980s CIA operatives in Nicaragua formed an anti-communist guerrilla group comprised mostly of former members of Somoza’s National Guard, the Contras, to fight against

the Sandinista government, leading to more civil war in the country. The FSLN's Sandinista government, led by Ortega, responded by canceling promised elections, restricting the media, and declaring a state of emergency. These moves in turn added fuel to the fire of US opposition, as the US State Department increasingly painted the Sandinistas out to be puppets of Castro and the USSR.

The Contras assassinated teachers and doctors and others who supported the Sandinista regime, raising criticism of US policy in Nicaragua, and in 1984 the US Congress banned US financial and military support to the Contras. Whereas critics widely denounced the Contras as a "terrorist" organization, President Reagan in a speech said, "I am a Contra, I am a 'freedom fighter'"—another illustration of the subjectivity of "terrorism." In 1983 the CIA mined Nicaragua's harbors, an act condemned by the International Court of Justice in the Hague. Members of the US Congress, fearing that a mine could blow up a Soviet ship and start a war with the USSR, passed the Boland Amendment limiting US involvement in Nicaragua (two years later a second Boland Amendment, named for the Congressional representative who introduced it, further tightened restrictions on US efforts to overthrow the Sandinistas). As we know from our chapter on Iran, US support for the Contras nonetheless continued covertly, which was one of the reasons for the Iran-Contra scandal involving Colonel Oliver North and others that broke in late 1986. The US covertly shipped arms to Iran during the Iran-Iraq War and, ignoring the Boland Amendment(s), used the money raised by these illegal arms sales to illegally support the Contras.

The civil war in Nicaragua continued in the late 1980s, though it decreased in intensity after the Iran-Contra Affair. In 1988, the FSLN ended the state of emergency and made plans for long-promised elections, which were held two years later in 1990. Violetta Chamorro, heading a coalition of opposition parties, defeated the FSLN's Ortega. The widow of a famous moderate journalist assassinated by Somoza's National Guard in 1978, Chamorro negotiated an end to the civil war. Even after losing the 1990 elections, the FSLN continued to play a prominent role in the country's bureaucracy, army, and especially its trade unions, at least until a right-wing candidate, Arnaldo Alemán, won Nicaragua's 1996 elections. Alemán made rooting out FSLN influence in the government, military, and labor unions a top priority, though he had only mixed success in that regard. Alemán ruled during one of the worst banking scandals in the country's history, which racked consumer and investment confidence, dealing a severe blow to Nicaragua's economy. Alemán, who left office in January 2002, was put on trial because of the scandal, found guilty of corruption, and sentenced to twenty years in prison in late 2003, though that sentence was later lifted and he was released in 2009. In November 2020 the US State Department added Alemán to a list of corrupt foreign officials barred from entering the US.

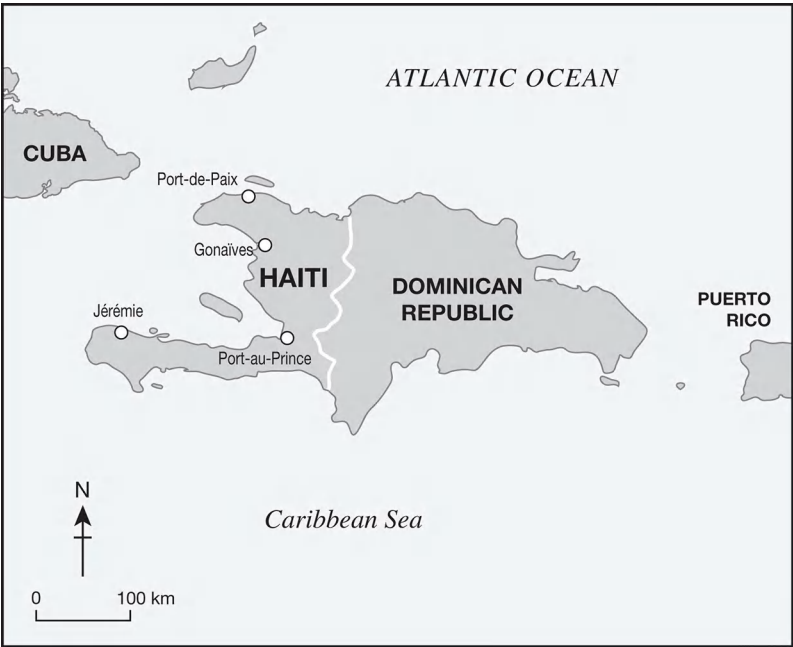
Alemán's successor, Enrique Bolaños Geyer, a conservative candidate who defeated the FSLN's Ortega in Nicaragua's 2001 elections, was unable to

greatly improve the country's economy or root out corruption. More than a decade after the removal of the Sandinistas from power Nicaragua remained one of the hemisphere's poorest countries, with a very low per capita income and a huge external debt, much of which dates back to the Somoza era prior to 1979. The distribution of income in the country, moreover, is extremely unequal. Since 1990, as elsewhere in the global economy, the IMF (especially) and World Bank have been very active in Nicaragua, but not only have they failed to alleviate poverty in the country, but also critics (including Ortega) point out that the problem has worsened under their policies promoting austerity and privatization of government services like water and communications. In 2004 the World Bank forgave 80% of Nicaragua's outstanding debt, which certainly improved its situation. However, according to the IMF's own web page as of mid-January 2025 Nicaragua, with its population of less than 7mn, has an outstanding debt of \$86.7mn!

Amid continuing economic woes Nicaraguan voters elected Sandinista leader Daniel Ortega president in late 2006, completing an impressive political comeback. In 2009 Nicaragua's Constitutional Court lifted a ban on consecutive terms for the presidency, clearing the way for Ortega to run for re-election in 2011. He did, reportedly winning in a landslide. A 2014 law lifted term limits for the presidency, allowing Ortega to run again in 2016 amid opposition criticisms that the move threatened democracy. Ortega won again, naming his wife Rosario Murillo vice-president. In 2018 the government proposed major changes in the country's Social Security program, leading to mass protests that forced Ortega and the FSLN to back down and rescind the proposed changes. Ortega cracked down on these demonstrations harshly and has increasingly ruled with a heavy hand since. He "won" re-election again in 2021, reportedly with almost 76% percent of the vote, though most doubt the validity of the country's elections by this point. Ortega's wife Rosaria Murillo remains his vice-president and in late 2024 he proposed a constitutional change that would recognize the couple as "co-presidents" and extend presidential terms from five to six years. The National Assembly approved the proposal. In short, Nicaragua has (once again) become a family dictatorship.



Map 17.1 Map of Cuba.



Map 17.2 Map of Haiti.

17 The Caribbean

Haiti and Cuba

The Caribbean region is made up of a number of island nations, including The Bahamas, Cuba, Jamaica, Haiti (formerly Saint Domingue) and the Dominican Republic (DR) among others. The region is defined by the Caribbean Sea as part of the North Atlantic Ocean south of the US, east of Mexico and Central America, and north of the northernmost South American states. The Caribbean is one of the most ethnically diverse regions of the world owing to the legacy of colonization by the Spanish (Cuba and the DR), the French (Haiti), and the British (The Bahamas and Jamaica), as well as the impact of the Atlantic Slave trade in the region. Most of the indigenous Native American populations of the Caribbean were *greatly* reduced during the period of European conquest and colonization in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries.

Haiti

Haiti, with its capital at Port-au-Prince and a population of almost 12mn as of 2025, shares the hilly, mountainous island of Hispaniola (the western part) with the DR (the eastern part). Haiti has a 95% black population, while the remaining 5% are white and mixed. It is a majority Christian country with about 50% of the population Catholic and roughly 29% Protestant. There is a small 2% minority who ascribe to Vodou, recognized as an official religion in Haiti in 2003. The fate of the indigenous Native American population of Hispaniola, the Taíno, is a tragic one; after being conquered and enslaved the Taíno's numbers greatly diminished within the first hundred years of European colonial rule. The rapid decrease of the Taíno population led French colonialists to import African slaves in very large numbers to work the island's growing coffee, sugar, tobacco, and cotton plantations. After years of conflict France and Spain agreed to divide the island between them, thereby creating the separate colonies of Haiti and the DR as noted. From that point on, the two sides of the island developed along very different lines regarding ethnic composition, language (French and Creole in the case of Haiti, Spanish in the case of the DR), and culture.

A major environmental challenge Haiti has faced for some time is deforestation, a problem not nearly as bad in neighboring DR, so the contrast is stark. Over the centuries colonial rulers, Haitian peasants, and (mostly foreign-owned) corporations have cut down trees at a rapid rate in Haiti to clear land for agriculture, grazing cattle, and fuel. Deforestation began in the colonial period as the French cleared land for cash crop production, especially sugar and coffee, but it accelerated rapidly in the latter half of the twentieth century, long after Haiti had received its independence from France. Key factors include the use of wood as the main fuel for the island nation's population and also the destruction of forests for agriculture for a growing population over the decades. This, however, proved to be counterproductive because deforestation leads to soil erosion and lower crop yields among other environmental problems.

Haiti was widely acknowledged as the wealthiest of all the Caribbean colonies. Throughout the eighteenth century, the French continued to bring in large numbers of African slaves to work on the island's cash crop plantations. This policy created a demographic problem for the French as they were greatly outnumbered by their own slaves, making them susceptible to revolt. After a prolonged slave rebellion that began in 1791, Haiti won its independence in 1804, the first example of a successful slave revolt, and renamed the island nation Haiti (it had been Saint Domingue), believed to be the name the indigenous Taíno people called it. France's ruler Napoleon dispatched troops to put down the rebellion and reclaim Haiti for France. French generals invited Toussaint Louverture, leader of the Haitian uprising, to negotiate a settlement; when Toussaint arrived they had him arrested, chained, and sent back to France. He died there in prison but the uprising that he began continued, and in 1804 Haiti became the first independent black republic in the world. Many of the French landowners and colonial administrators who did not escape were executed. The Haitian Revolution struck fear in the hearts of slaveowners throughout the region, including the southern US, which responded to the Haitian Revolution by imposing a trade embargo that lasted until 1862 when US President Abraham Lincoln finally recognized Haiti as an independent country during the US Civil War.

The US and Haiti

Since then the US has played a very active role in Haitian history. US forces intervened militarily in Haiti nineteen times in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, and US troops occupied Haiti between 1915–34. In 1915 US President Woodrow Wilson sent US Marines to Haiti because, as the official dispatch of the time vaguely declared, "US interests were threatened." They would remain in Haiti as an occupying force for the next nineteen years, until US President Franklin Roosevelt withdrew US troops in 1934 (part of his Good Neighbor policy that included withdrawing troops

from Nicaragua and elsewhere in Latin America as well). Afterward the US supported a series of military dictatorships in Haiti. US leaders of all political persuasions exhibited a clearly racist assumption that Haitians were incapable of ruling themselves and needed “help” to do so from their northern neighbor.

Working with a Haitian elite in a very stratified society, foreign (especially US) business interests came to control much of the country’s economy. During the long period of US occupation, American banks took over Haiti’s financial system. In 1918 the US wrote a constitution for Haiti that overturned a 100-year-old Haitian law preventing foreign ownership of land in the country, allowing American sugar, fruit, and other companies to buy land there. This led to the displacement of Haitian peasants engaged in subsistence agriculture (or turned them into wage laborers on land now owned by cash crop producing US-owned companies working in conjunction with a native Haitian elite), forcing many of them to decimate more (often marginal) forest land to grow crops and graze herds.

“Papa Doc” and “Baby Doc”

In the post-World War II period two dictators dominated Haiti’s politics: François “Papa Doc” and Jean-Claude “Baby Doc” Duvalier, father and son who ruled the country between 1957–86. The elder dictator died in 1971, passing leadership to his nineteen-year-old son. Both named themselves “president for life.” The Duvaliers ruled with the support of the US-trained (and infamously corrupt) Haitian Army and the Tonton Macoutes (a phrase that means “Uncle Boogeyman”), death squads who assassinated dissidents and political opponents of the regime. In 1986 a popular uprising overthrew “Baby Doc” Duvalier, who had reportedly amassed hundreds of millions of dollars by the time he fled Haiti on a US military aircraft. A period of chaos followed as opponents of the Duvaliers sought revenge against members of the Tonton Macoutes. Many were rounded up and “necklaced,” which entailed putting a tire full of gasoline around their body and setting it on fire. The late 1980s was a time of tremendous political instability in Haiti amid a succession of military coups as seven different military leaders ruled in just four years.

Several attempts at free elections were marred by violence but with the end of the Cold War the US increasingly pressured Haiti’s military leaders to hold democratic elections, which they finally did in 1990. The US strongly backed Marc Bazin, a former World Bank official educated in the US. The CIA and US businesses funneled millions of dollars into Bazin’s election campaign but much to everyone’s surprise Jean-Bertrand Aristide, a little-known priest and proponent of liberation theology, the belief that Christianity should be used as a tool of struggle for economic and social justice, won the elections. Aristide founded a political movement for the election campaign called

Lavalas, which means “a cleansing flood” or “tidal wave.” He mobilized the support of Haiti’s poor by calling for major economic reforms.

Aristide began a literacy campaign as Haiti had an illiteracy rate over 80%, the highest in the Western Hemisphere, and raised the country’s minimum wage for factory workers from thirty-three to fifty cents an hour. He also raised the minimum wage for farm workers to \$2 a day and equalized wages for men and women doing the same work. In September 1991 Aristide’s government fell to a military coup led by Raoul Cédras, who was trained in the US and had ties to the CIA, although there is no evidence of direct US involvement in his seizure of power. Cédras named Marc Bazin, the US-supported candidate who had lost the 1990 elections, Prime Minister. The Organization of American States (OAS) imposed sanctions and a trade embargo against Cédras’ new military regime. The US nominally supported the sanctions, but President Bush Sr. granted exemptions to US textile and manufacturing companies doing business in Haiti, which his successor President Clinton extended after his election in 1992. The US also granted Texaco permission to continue supplying oil to Haiti, so the impact of the sanctions was minimal. Cédras recruited former members of the Tonton Macoutes to intimidate political opponents and Aristide supporters and instigated a reign of terror in Haiti in the early 1990s.

In 1994 the US intervened militarily in Haiti to remove Cédras and return Aristide to power. Before undertaking the invasion, however, the US insisted that Aristide sign an agreement to abide by an economic program (“structural adjustment”) of free-market reform in accordance with IMF-imposed policies we have encountered elsewhere, including the privatization of state-owned enterprises, many of which were purchased by US-owned corporations, and restrictions on wage increases and social spending. As a result Aristide was unable to address the social and economic disparities in Haiti that won him support for his 1990 electoral victory in the first place. The economic situation in Haiti worsened under Aristide’s rule over the 1990s.

The reign of terror under Cédras ended with at least some semblance of a democratic political system restored. According to the agreement signed by Aristide with the US Clinton administration he was not allowed to run for re-election in 1996; he picked a successor within the *Lavalas* movement, René Préval, who won amid very low turnout, suggesting that Haitians were already disappointed in their “democracy.” Aristide was eligible to run again in 2002 and he won the election again amid low turnout. In 2004 protests erupted during the country’s celebration of 200 years of independence. Aristide was arrested and exiled in a coup, presumably carried out by his own army officers although he claimed that the US government, at the time under President George Bush Jr., was responsible. After an interim period of two years Aristide’s former ally turned rival, René Préval, was elected president for a second time in 2006. Economic woes continued to wreak havoc in Haiti and rising food costs led to massive riots in the summer of 2008, presaging still more political instability to come.

Haiti has suffered tremendously in this century from being hit by strong earthquakes and hurricanes, both of which it has been susceptible to throughout its history. In 2010 a 7.3 magnitude earthquake hit Haiti, believed to be the worst in over 200 years, leading to the deaths of an estimated 220,000 people and the displacement of an additional 1.5mn. UN soldiers arrived to help distribute aid and rebuild the devastated island nation, but in 2010 popular anger over the slow pace of reconstruction boiled over into massive protests after an outbreak of cholera that led to an estimated 6,000 deaths was traced to a camp for recently arrived UN soldiers.

Michel Martelly won the country's 2010 Presidential elections, but two years later large protests called for his removal owing to the high cost of living, government corruption, and the failure of Martelly's government to deliver on its promises to alleviate poverty. Street protests continued off and on for the next two years amid calls for new elections. Martelly stepped down in February 2016, about four months before Hurricane Matthew hit Haiti leading to hundreds of deaths and destroying thousands of homes. The following year the Provisional Electoral Council declared Jovenel Moïse the country's new President based on election results from the previous year. Haiti's woes continued, however, as two years later massive protests against Moïse's government erupted in Port-au-Prince.

In 2021 another massive (7.2 magnitude) earthquake hit western Haiti; although only slightly weaker than the earthquake that caused so much damage eleven years earlier, this one was not as bad because it was mainly in the relatively sparsely inhabited area of the island's west. However, it was soon followed by Tropical Storm Grace and the combination led to flooding and triggered landslides in the mountainous country that cut off and greatly hampered aid efforts for victims of the earthquake. Haiti's political situation, furthermore, is more unstable than ever because of the 2021 assassination of President Moïse by a suspected group of twenty-eight foreign mercenaries, most believed to be from Columbia. Haitian forces killed or captured most of them following the assassination. Prime Minister Ariel Henry assumed the presidency but amid continuing protests, large numbers of refugees fleeing the country, and increasing gang violence in Port-au-Prince and throughout the country he resigned in April 2024. A nine-member Presidential Transitional Council with full presidential powers took over and is slated to remain in power until elections in February 2026. Haiti is thus in the midst of a very different period of its history.

Cuba

Cuba, the largest of the Caribbean island nations with its capital at Havana and a population of almost 11mn as of 2025, is located ninety miles off the coast of the Florida Keys. Its proximity to the US has been a major theme in the country's history, both before and after Fidel Castro came to power there in 1959. On the island's southeastern corner is the controversial US Naval

Base at Guantanamo Bay, obtained at the end of the nineteenth century. Guantanamo has been a sticking point with the Cuban regime for over sixty years. Cuba's physical geography is a combination of mountains, hills, and coastal plains well suited for plantation-style cash crop production. The Bay of Pigs is located in the south. Castro and his forces hid in the Sierra Maestra mountains in the southeastern corner of the country during their guerrilla war in the 1950s; the mountains in south central Cuba were supposed to provide refuge to the invading force during the Bay of Pigs fiasco, which we discuss below, but the soldiers never got that far.

Beginning in the sixteenth century, the first wave of colonialism, Cuba became a Spanish colony and major producer of sugar and tobacco for the world market. As elsewhere in the Caribbean, the native (Taíno) population of Cuba was greatly reduced in the first 100–150 years of colonialism. Thus, the Spanish brought in a lot of African slaves to work the plantations, and many Europeans (mostly from Spain) settled in the colony as well, leading over the centuries to much racial intermixture. As of the 2012 census, a little over 64% of the country's population is White, meaning more purely of Spanish heritage, whereas about 26.6% are of mixed Spanish and Black ancestry and 9.3% Black. The majority of the island nation's people, about 59%, are Catholic, while 23.2% (as of 2020) claim no religious affiliation.

The US Role

A number of US presidents, including Thomas Jefferson, wanted to purchase Cuba from Spain and annex it, but the Spanish refused because Cuba was a very lucrative colony. In the early nineteenth century and after Cuban slaveowners were worried about the successful slave uprising in Haiti, fearing that it might set a precedent for them. Spain weakened as an imperial power over the course of the nineteenth century while nationalism among the Cuban elite of Spanish descent grew, leading to a war for independence in the late 1890s, over seven decades after most of Latin America had won its independence from Spain and Portugal. Pro-expansionist Americans at the time saw this as a prime opportunity to take over a profitable possession close to home. The US went to war on the side of the Cuban revolutionaries in 1898 in the Spanish-American War, which Spain lost. Cuba thus gained its independence from Spain, but it acquired a new patron state in the process—the US, which demanded trade and other concessions (for example, Guantanamo Bay) in exchange for its (decisive) role in the war.

In the Spanish-American War the US also obtained control over the Philippines, the only true US colony until its independence in 1946, and Puerto Rico (still a US territory) as well. The Cuban forces were in no position, militarily or otherwise, to deny US demands. Thus began a close colonial-like relationship between Cuba and the US at the very outset of the former's independence. As in the case of Haiti, US leaders and commentators displayed a

very paternalistic, racist attitude toward Cubans. US troops occupied Cuba for most of the period 1898–1933 when US President Franklin Roosevelt withdrew them as he was doing throughout the region in accordance with his new “Good Neighbor” policy toward Latin America. As US troops exited the country an army officer, Fulgencio Batista, took power in Cuba.

Batista’s long reign (1933–59) was characterized by dictatorship, corruption, and alliance between the Cuban elite and US business interests. He was a close US ally during the Cold War. Batista displayed the trappings of “democracy,” and even stepped aside for civilian rule for a while in the 1940s, though he certainly remained the country’s most powerful political actor. His rule was not based on popularity, and elections in Cuba were marred by intimidation and the repression of opposition. In 1952 he suspended the constitution and thereafter ruled with complete dictatorial power. Cuba under Batista was known for its mafia influence; gambling was legal and tourism was one of the island nation’s main industries. Havana was infamous for its lively underground culture and prostitution. Cuba’s economy under Batista was very dependent on the export of sugar to the US; in the 1950s, 80% of the country’s export earnings came from sugar and the US bought 50% of Cuba’s sugar exports. Cuba received more in US investments than any Latin American country and its economy grew rapidly. As a result, Cuba was one of the wealthiest Latin American countries in the 1950s, but there were wide disparities in wealth between a small elite (mostly of European descent) and an impoverished rural and urban working class. There was also a large urban middle class in Cuba.

In the early 1950s opposition to Batista grew. In July 1953, a small group of about 150 revolutionaries led by Fidel Castro attacked a Cuban Army barracks, hoping to spark a popular uprising against Batista’s regime. They were captured instead and put in jail. Castro was granted amnesty and released in 1955, after which he went to Mexico and began to regroup. In Mexico he met an Argentine doctor and professional revolutionary who had been in Guatemala during the Arbenz government of the early 1950s, Ernesto Che Guevara. The two formed the 26th of July Movement, named after the unsuccessful insurrection that had landed Castro in jail, and plotted the overthrow of Batista’s government. In 1956 Castro and Che landed ashore in Cuba with about eighty troops. They were met by Batista’s well-armed government forces and their ranks decimated. Castro and Guevara were two of only twelve survivors who made it to the Sierra Maestra mountains. From there they began to assemble an army of mostly poor and landless peasants for another attack on Batista’s government.

The Cuban Revolution

Castro and Guevara allied their movement with a growing anti-Batista coalition in the country as his government had become so corrupt and anti-democratic that it gradually lost support even among traditional allies—the

Cuban elite and, eventually, the US government. Peasants were calling for land reform, workers for better pay and living standards, and the urban middle class wanted democratic reform. Amid increasing pressure and unrest, Batista fled Cuba in December 1958. Castro entered Havana with a very small force of about 2,000 troops and began to assert his control; his was almost a victory by default. Castro's rise to power stemmed less from a groundswell of popular revolutionary fervor—as the event would later be portrayed—and more because of the deep apathy and resentment most Cubans felt toward the Batista regime. Learning a lesson from the 1954 US intervention in Guatemala, one of Castro's first moves was to purge the Cuban Army, primarily the officer corps, of Batista supporters and replace them with troops loyal to him. Castro and Guevara were determined that the events in Guatemala five years earlier would not be repeated in Cuba.

Castro's initial intentions were unclear and the US cautiously supported him. He studied in the US and the Eisenhower administration hoped he would continue the pro-US policies of Cuba's past, but with broader support among the population. He traveled to the US and met with Eisenhower in early 1959 not long after taking power. However, Castro's nationalist leanings led him to gradually challenge US hegemony in Cuba. In 1960 he signed a trade agreement with the Soviet Union. Later that year, the major US oil companies in Cuba—Texaco and Exxon (and also Shell, a British-Dutch company)—acting on instructions from the US State Department refused to refine oil shipped to Cuba from the USSR. Castro used their refusal as a pretext to nationalize the US- and European-owned oil refineries in Cuba. The US responded by cutting Cuba's sugar quota, and Castro responded to this by nationalizing other US-owned businesses in Cuba (including the four largest hotels in Havana, which had been an important part of the country's Mafia-dominated underground). Castro began a land-reform program that led to the expropriation of US-owned properties while also cracking down on political opponents and suspending elections indefinitely. The US responded by imposing a trade embargo on Cuba. Relations between the US and Cuba were so bad by the end of Eisenhower's presidency that he had the CIA plotting Castro's overthrow. The plan was to follow the model of the 1954 intervention in Guatemala that overthrew Arbenz. Cubans who fled Castro's revolution were recruited and trained in Guatemala in preparation for an attack on Cuba.

Bay of Pigs and Cuban Missile Crisis

US President John F. Kennedy inherited the plan and hesitantly approved it with the condition that the US role be kept secret. In April 1961, a force of 1,400 Cuban exiles (and some US advisors) landed in Cuba's Bay of Pigs. They hoped to spark an anti-Castro uprising, take over some territory, and proclaim a provisional government, which the US could then support. However,

the force was soundly defeated by the new Revolutionary Cuban Army, and Kennedy refused to allow direct US military intervention or provide air cover for the invading force (as Eisenhower had done for Castillo Armas' invasion of Guatemala in 1954). As a result, almost the entire invading force in Cuba was killed or captured. The US role in the events was exposed and the Bay of Pigs proved to be a complete fiasco for the Kennedy administration and a triumph for Castro. It led to an increased Soviet role in Cuba.

By increasing the Soviet role in Cuba as the country's protector against US aggression, the Bay of Pigs contributed to a major Cold War showdown over this Caribbean nation: the Cuban Missile Crisis. In 1962 US reconnaissance planes flying over Cuba detected the construction of a Soviet missile site for nuclear weapons. Kennedy's advisors presented him with two options in response: an immediate surprise attack on Cuba and the missile site, or a naval blockade around Cuba and negotiations. Kennedy opted for the latter choice because he felt it gave Soviet leader Khrushchev more flexibility and did not force a hostile response. For several days the world was on edge during this peak of Cold War tensions and the possibility of a major nuclear confrontation. In one particularly tense incident a Soviet ship approached the blockade—it looked like war was imminent. However, the Soviet ship backed down, and the two sides worked out a secretive and informal end to the conflict: the Soviets agreed to withdraw the missile site from Cuba while the US agreed never to invade Castro's Cuba and to withdraw nuclear missiles from Turkey along the Soviet border. Cuba, much to Castro's indignation, was largely left out of the negotiations, but at least nuclear annihilation was averted.

Castro was disappointed with the Soviets over the missile crisis, but Cuba remained a close Soviet ally and trading partner during the Cold War. The US never again invaded Cuba, but President Kennedy began "Operation Mongoose," a covert operation to assassinate Castro. According to a US Senate investigation in the 1970s there were at least eight separate CIA-planned attempts to kill Castro, one involving an exploding cigar, another a poison cigar, and still another a poison wet suit that Castro was supposed to wear on one of his many dives. None of the attempts worked. Cuba's close alliance with the USSR was the root of an eventual split between Castro and Guevara, who felt that the Soviets were gaining too much influence. Che resigned from his position in the Cuban government in 1965 and went to Bolivia to organize a guerrilla army there, but his efforts were unsuccessful and the Bolivian Army, with assistance from the CIA, killed Che in 1967.

Economically Cuba remained very dependent on the export of sugar. Over the first decades of his rule Castro tried several economic policies to develop and diversify the country's economy, but he was unable to break out of Cuba's dependency on the production and export of sugar. Just as was the case twenty years earlier under Batista, in the 1970s more than 80% of

Cuba's export income came from sugar, only now most of that sugar went to the USSR and its eastern bloc satellite countries instead of to the US.

Castro carried out a number of social reforms that made him popular among some segments of the Cuban population, including leveling the wide economic disparities of the Batista era to a significant degree. Cuba's socialized medical system became a model among developing countries—it has more doctors per capita than the US. Life expectancy under Castro increased from sixty-three years to seventy-three years (up now to almost eighty as of 2023), and infant mortality was reduced by two-thirds between 1959–79. Castro also emphasized housing construction and education. Cuba has a nearly 100% literacy rate, a rarity in Latin America. At the same time, however, Castro maintained dictatorial control over the Cuban government and press. In the late 1970s, there were over 20,000 political prisoners in Cuba, some of whom were released (along with common criminals) and exiled to the US in accordance with an agreement between Castro and President Jimmy Carter.

Beginning with Gorbachev's reforms in the Soviet Union in the late 1980s Cuba became increasingly isolated, especially after the collapse of the USSR in late 1991, which led to economic crisis in Cuba. Castro's response was to pursue a policy of "self-sufficiency" symbolized by the import of millions of bicycles from China, a move rooted in Cuba's rapidly decreasing oil supplies. The US tightened the embargo against Cuba in the 1990s, expecting economic pressure to lead to Castro's downfall. The 1996 Helms-Burton Act forbade any US company from doing business with any foreign company that profited from the nationalization of US property in Cuba. The impact of the Act was limited, however, and by the late 1990s Cuba's economic crisis eased somewhat. European countries continued to trade with Cuba, which became a favorite tourist destination for many Europeans, especially Germans.

There were signs off and on of a possible easing of relations between Cuba and the US, at least in economic terms. US human rights groups and business interests lobbied for an end to the embargo against Cuba, the latter because they saw the potential for lucrative investment there and feared that European competitors were getting an advantage owing to the embargo (this situation was similar to the debate that raged for years over whether or not the US should normalize relations with Vietnam, which it did in 1994). In February 1996 a team of US businessmen traveled to Cuba with the approval of the US government (the embargo included a travel ban that made it technically illegal for Americans to travel to Cuba) and filed a report calling for an end to the trade embargo. However, an anti-Castro Cuban lobby remained powerful in the US, and later that same month the Cuban government reportedly shot down a plane owned by the US-based group "Brothers to the Rescue," which flies over the Caribbean looking for rafts with people fleeing Cuba. The Cuban government claimed it was a provocation. US President Clinton responded angrily, promising, among other things, that he would never end the embargo as long as Castro remained in power.

In 1998 Pope John Paul II visited Cuba, a mostly Catholic country, for the first time under Castro's reign. He publicly criticized Castro for political oppression but he also called for an end to the US embargo because of the negative impact it was having on the Cuban economy and people. The Cuban government undertook limited reforms in the 1990s and 2000s to increase enterprise efficiency and alleviate serious shortages of food, consumer goods, and services. However, the standard of living for the average Cuban citizen remained at a lower level than before the severe economic depression of the early 1990s, which was due in large part to the loss of Soviet aid. In the late 2000s and early 2010s several factors negatively impacted Cuba's economy: high oil import prices; lower prices in key export markets, especially sugar (as a result of which Cuba increasingly turned away from sugar cultivation and began to grow avocados and other potentially high-dollar export crops); damage from several powerful hurricanes that hit the island nation; and a slump in tourist travel that occurred following September 11, 2001, and several other terrorist attacks around the world thereafter. These problems hampered Cuba's economic growth substantially.

Castro's grip on political power finally loosened because of health problems and in February 2008 at the age of eighty-one he resigned from Cuba's presidency, a position he had held since 1959, owing to an extended hospitalization. The Cuban Parliament elected his brother, Raúl Castro, five years younger than Fidel, as the country's president. Amid hopes for a possible political relaxation and economic improvements under Raúl few changes materialized. Fidel died in 2016. In a remarkable shift the US Obama administration greatly loosened the trade embargo on Cuba and the two countries exchanged ambassadors in 2015; however, in his first term in November 2017 US President Trump reversed course and reimposed the trade embargo on Cuba and once again ended diplomatic relations between the two countries. Several years later and days before the end of his first term in January 2021 Trump added Cuba to the US State Department's list of states supporting terrorism, which entails a heavier degree of sanctions. US President Joe Biden did not reverse course during his term in office.

In 2018 Raúl's fifty-eight-year-old handpicked successor, Miguel Díaz-Canel, replaced him as Cuba's President; three years later Raúl retired from public life and Díaz-Canel took over his position as head of Cuba's Communist Party as well. In March 2024 major protests against Díaz-Canel's government erupted in Cuba's second largest city, Santiago de Cuba, and spread from there to the capital Havana and elsewhere as Cubans took to the streets to express their disgust with power outages and food shortages amid the worst crisis in living standards in the country since the early 1990s. The Cuban government responded by cracking down on protesters and limiting access to the Internet in the country, leading the US Biden administration to further tighten sanctions on Cuba. Upon taking office for his second administration US President Trump in January 2025 initiated a "total

pressure” strategy against Cuba that entails reaffirming its status as a state that supports terrorism and re-activating elements of the old Helms-Burton Act that had not been implemented in recent years. Cuba has managed to overcome such pressure before in the years since Castro came to power there, but the noose on the country is tightening and the economic impact on the population promises to be very hard.

Conclusion

The colonial period shaped the primary global relationships that remain in place with the European colonial powers (Britain, France, Spain, Portugal, and Russia but also to a lesser degree Belgium, Germany, the Netherlands, and Italy) along now with a few other major countries like the US, Japan and, increasingly, China, benefiting from the extraction of resources, mainly cash crops and raw materials, from the former colonies, now independent countries. There were two “waves” of colonialism, the first from roughly 1500 to the early nineteenth century involving mostly Spanish and Portuguese conquest and rule of Latin America along with British, French, Spanish, and Dutch rule of North America (and gradual expansion elsewhere during part of that period, such as in India and the East Indies, i.e., Indonesia). This era of colonial rule became closely linked to the slave trade, the forcible enslavement of millions of Africans as laborers on cash crop-based plantations for an increasingly interlinked and ever-expanding global market economy. One consequence of this was the dramatic demographic impact of bringing in large numbers of Africans as well as the subjugation, conquest, and in some cases near total annihilation of entire Native American populations such as in the Caribbean. Most of the North and Latin American colonies achieved their independence through armed struggle in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, though a few of them, such as Cuba, did so later.

The second “wave” of colonial expansion involved the European powers moving into Asia and Africa to create vast overseas empires, although Russia is an exception as its colonial empire was contiguous and the conquest thereof gradual over several centuries, i.e., Ukraine in the mid-seventeenth century, eastern Poland in the late eighteenth century, Central Asia in the mid-nineteenth century, etc. Not all countries were colonized such as China, Japan, Iran, Afghanistan, Liberia and others, however even in those cases European expansion profoundly impacted their historical development and trajectories. There were different types of colonial rule. The British, on the one hand, who built the most extensive overseas empire (on which the sun never sets as the saying went) tended to rule their colonies indirectly, relying on

native elites to rule over the indigenous populations for them as in India, the jewel of the British Empire. France on the other hand ruled its colonies more directly, attempting to impose French culture upon its colonized peoples, as for example in Africa and Southeast Asia. This in turn determined the course of de-colonization, the achievement of independence by the former colonies; in cases of indirect colonial rule the colonized people often achieved independence through more peaceful and nonviolent means, whereas in cases of more direct rule they usually had to resort to armed struggle to do so. Armed struggle was particularly prominent, regardless of the colonial “mother country,” in the case of settler colonialism as in the Americas or Algeria, where in the 1950s the French faced a major armed conflict, or Kenya, where the British faced the violent Mau Mau uprising of the native Kikuyu (mostly) people.

Colonialism in all its various forms greatly altered the economies of the colonies as it almost always involved the introduction of cash crops such as cotton, sugar, coffee, tea, indigo, opium, cocoa, and rice, which opened the formerly subsistence-based agricultural economies of peasant villages in the colonized territories (to varying degrees) to the forces of a global market economy. The colonial powers extracted raw materials and valuable resources from the colonies ranging from oil, palm oil, rubber, and timber to minerals such as gold, silver, diamonds, copper, uranium, zinc, cobalt, platinum, bauxite and chrome (this now increasingly involves key minerals for electronics such as lithium and tantalum among others). This was done, as in the extraction of rubber from the Belgian Congo for example (only one of many), for the enrichment of the “mother country” and with little regard to the negative social or environmental impact of their mining practices in the colonies themselves, contributing greatly to the profound poverty of local populations around the world as well as to the destruction of the planet.

Colonialism also imposed artificial boundaries on the globe, creating borders that usually aligned with the whims and aspirations and power relations of the European states rather than with the interests or needs of the colonized peoples. As a result, diverse groups of people with regard to their racial, ethno-linguistic, and religious identities were often cobbled together as part of a single colony. Since de-colonization in (mostly) the 1950s–60s this has contributed to instability in many de-colonized independent countries owing to ethnic rivalries and power struggles, conflicts over the allocation of resources, the rise of dictatorial one-party states, and other related issues as well. The legacy of colonialism, in short, lives on in many ways.

A watershed in contemporary world history, World War II, a victory over Nazi Germany’s racist ideology on behalf of “democratic values,” led to the empowerment of disenfranchised groups around the world, including nonwhite colonized peoples (and also women). This led gradually to de-colonization in the years following the war, starting in India in 1947,

Indonesia and Palestine/Israel soon thereafter, Southeast Asia following the French defeat at the Battle of Dien Bien Phu in 1954, Ghana in Africa in 1957 and so on.

The Cold War, a political, economic, and ideological conflict between the US and USSR that encompassed most of the world, emerged as the dominant geopolitical paradigm over colonialism (the 1956 Suez Canal Crisis marked a clear shift in that direction). The Soviets promoted their version of “democracy,” a relative concept that means different things to different people; for the Soviets it meant “socialist democracy,” which theoretically entailed political as well as economic rights and thus from their perspective was superior to the West’s “capitalist” or “bourgeois democracy,” although in reality there was very little about the Soviet Union itself or its allies that was actually democratic. The Soviets occupied and controlled Eastern Europe throughout the Cold War, invading Hungary in 1956 and Czechoslovakia in 1968 (as well as Afghanistan in 1979) to impose its will, and courted the de-colonizing states, many of which allied with the USSR.

There were different ways of defining “communism” among countries on that side of the Cold War divide, with Mao Zedong’s emphasis on peasant support for communist revolutions being very different from what Marx himself had in mind, although that became the norm for (most) twentieth century communist movements from Vietnam to Nicaragua, etc. Khrushchev’s denunciation of Stalin in his 1956 secret speech and some of the policies Mao pursued after gaining power in China, especially the GLE, led to the Sino-Soviet split, another major geopolitical divide that overlapped with the Cold War and in some places, such as Southeast Asia after the end of the US-Vietnam War, became the dominant paradigm. On the other side of the Cold War divide, the US fought for and promoted its own version of “democracy,” one based on capitalism but often highly dictatorial and likewise not very democratic. US policymakers in the Cold War era of “containment” supported brutal dictators with terrible human rights records as long as they were anti-communist—that was all that mattered.

The Cold War ended with the collapse of communism in Eastern Europe and the Soviet Union in the late 1980s and early 1990s. Thereafter a period of neo-liberal market domination reigned (promoted through the policies of international lending agencies like the IMF and WB), albeit co-existing with a model of state interventionist market economics that emerged throughout much of East Asia (and elsewhere). Just as with communism there were different ways of defining “capitalism” in the global arena as well. The “Asian Flu” economic crisis of the late 1990s and the financial crisis of the late 2000s/early 2010s led to a greater emphasis on state interventionist measures in many parts of the world to control the whims of a neo-liberal free-market system susceptible to crises. In addition, while by no means new as a weapon of struggle among the world’s disempowered, terrorism, also a subjective concept defined differently by different people (“one person’s ‘terrorist’ is

another person's 'freedom fighter'”), emerged as an increasing threat in the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries, punctuated by the attacks on the US on September 11, 2001. It seems likely to remain a major issue going forward. Finally, the environmental degradation of the planet, a less prominent but nonetheless underlying theme of the book, may prove worse than any of the world's other challenges and problems today, threatening as it does the collective futures of everyone in it.

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